Glossary

The following glossary provides clear definitions of essential terms used in this book that are frequently misunderstood or potentially confusing.

Yeshua

The original Hebrew name of Jesus Christ, meaning "salvation" or "The Lord saves." Using the name Yeshua emphasizes Jesus' Jewish identity, context, and mission within the story of Israel.

Eternal

In *modern* English, "eternal" typically means endless, everlasting, infinite, or unending—used in phrases like "Eternal Conscious Torment." The modern definition is based on the Greek philosophical understanding and assumes infinite duration with no endpoint.

In biblical usage, however, "eternal" (Hebrew: *olam*; Greek: *aiōn / aiōnios*) does not mean endless time. Depending on the context, it can refer to an age, era, or an undefined period, or it can describe volume, kind, quality, and fullness rather than length—something whole, mature, or reflecting God's realm.

While some English translations use "age" to translate olam/aion, many popular versions overlook this nuance, opting for "eternal" instead.

Eternal Life

"Eternal life" is an ancient Jewish idiom contrasted with "fleeting life"—a life absorbed in the temporary, the material, and the non-spiritual. It refers not primarily to living forever, but to the quality and depth of life lived in alignment with God's will. Jesus defines eternal life relationally, not chronologically: *"This is **eternal life**: that they **know** You…"* (John 17:3).

Life

In *modern* English, life refers to the biological existence of an individual human being or animal.

In biblical usage, however, "life" usually means a rich, full existence marked by blessing, well-being, flourishing, and God's favor, rather than just physical survival. For instance: *"I have come that they may*

*have **life**, and have it to the full.*" (John 10:10). Qualitative rather than quantitative. Likewise, to "choose life" (Deuteronomy 30:19) is to live in alignment with God's covenantal purposes.

Gnosticism

An ancient movement taught that salvation—particularly with respect to the afterlife—came through special knowledge (*gnōsis*). It regarded the material world as inherently evil and believed that one must be reborn through spiritual (intellectual) enlightenment in order to escape judgement.

Dualism and Manichaeism

Dualism is a philosophical view that reality consists of two fundamental, distinct, and often opposing principles —mind/mental (good) and body/physical (evil). Manichaeism is a form of Gnostic dualism that teaches an unending cosmic conflict between Light (good) and Darkness (evil). Human souls are understood as fragments of divine light trapped within corrupt material bodies, and salvation is conceived as the soul's escape from

matter through special knowledge, strict ascetic discipline, and the eventual liberation of this imprisoned light from the physical world.

Augustine of Hippo

Considered a saint mainly in the Catholic and Calvinist traditions, is a fourth-century Christian theologian whose writings profoundly shaped Western Christianity—both Catholic and Protestant. His theology, heavily influenced by an earlier commitment to Manichaenism, Gnosticism, and dualistic thought, strongly impacted later doctrines of salvation, sin, grace, judgment, predestination, infant baptism, and hellfire within the Western church.

Eternal Conscious Torment

The Augustinian-Calvinist view of hell as a literal place of endless conscious torment of both body and soul, commonly referred to as the "hellfire" doctrine. This perspective has become dominant in Western Christianity

and remains especially prevalent among conservative Protestant and Catholic traditions.

Tikkun Olam

The earliest known appearance of the phrase Tikkun Olam is in the second century, in Mishnah Gittin 4:2–9. From its earliest usage, it expresses the Jewish hope for the repair and renewal of the world, not escape from it. This vision runs parallel to the biblical hope of the "restoration of all things" in Acts 3:21 and the prophetic promise of healing and renewal in Isaiah 35:1–6. In both Jewish and biblical imagination, redemption is cosmic, restorative, and this-world oriented, aimed at the healing of creation rather than its abandonment.

Preface

The Parable of the Forgotten Tongue

A rabbi once spoke to a village in the language of the soil beneath their feet. He spoke of *fire* as they knew fire

satisfaction of fury. Salvation was no longer rescue in this life, but escape from the flames in the afterlife. And eternity was no longer fullness, but endlessness—stretched thin like a road with no horizon.

In those lands, people read the rabbi's words, yet no longer heard his voice. He was no longer seen as a Jewish prophet walking the paths of Jerusalem, but was pictured as a Greek philosopher skilled in Roman categories. They spoke more of systems than stories, more of rules than relationships, more of intellect than love, more of measures than meaning. They argued over the temperature of fire instead of its purpose, over the duration and severity of judgment instead of its restorative purpose, over the distance of salvation instead of its nearness. They spoke of torment as though the rabbi had meant cruelty, though he had spoken of testing and refining—of metal proven true in the flame. Their view of God became fear-based, distant, and cold.

So the words were preserved—but through translations that carried new meanings, and the world that first gave them life slowly receded. The lamp was carefully guarded, yet the oil within it was quietly replaced. The people honored the language, recited it faithfully, defended it fiercely—while grieving, often without knowing why, the mercy it was always meant to reveal.

I use the phrase "Jewish perspective" in the book's title not merely because I am Jewish, or because this is how I, as a Jewish Bible scholar, read the text. I use it because I believe this perspective reflects how Jews in the time of Jesus—including those who believed in Him and became His disciples—would have naturally understood the language He used.

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This book is divided into six consecutive parts:

- **Part I:** When the Gospel Was Still Jewish
- **Part II:** #Blood #Atonement #Sacrifice
- **Part III:** A Hebrew Perspective on Christ's Atonement
- **Part IV:** Understanding Salvation
- **Part V:** Rethinking Hell
- **Part VI:** Your Life as an Audition

Introduction

When the original gospel struck a chord, it was first with the *Jewish people*, who embraced and believed it. From the start, the Gospels highlight that mostly *Jews* followed Jesus. We read that *Jews* came to Him all the way *"from Galilee, the Decapolis, Jerusalem, Judea, and beyond the Jordan"* (Matthew 4:25). This pattern continues throughout the Gospels (e.g., Matthew 4:25, 8:1, 14:13–14, 19:2, Mark 3:7–8, Luke 5:1, 9:11, John 6:2). Even after the resurrection, Scripture records that *"a great number of Jews"* believed (Acts 14:1; see also Acts 2:41, 4:4, 5:14, 6:7, 8:6, 13:44, 14:1, 17:4). The New Testament writers—mostly Jews themselves—go out of their

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these new believers came to realize that *Messianic Jews* are essentially Protestant Christian fundamentalists wearing a yarmulke, pretending to be Jewish.[3]

Over the years, we noticed a clear trend: more than 95% of Israeli Jews who embraced faith in Jesus eventually walked away from it. Within 6 to 12 months, most returned to traditional Judaism, moved toward secularism, or joined a traditional church like the Catholic Church. Yet, stories of their "conversion" continued to be used for fundraising among Christians, long after they had left. The pattern happened so consistently, it became impossible to overlook.

I discuss this in more detail in my book "Why Don't Jews Believe in Jesus," but after years of seeing this pattern, I came to realize that sending new Jewish believers into Messianic churches and ministries was counterproductive and ultimately caused more harm than good. Once I stopped funneling new believers and prospects into these systems, I noticed something striking: those who remained independent, outside the influence of Westernized theological structures, were far more likely to hold on to their faith despite isolation.

The lesson I've come to understand over the years is this: the Jewish people will continue to reject the *Western* version of the gospel—not because they are rejecting Yeshua Himself, but because they cannot embrace a distorted, foreign interpretation of His message. What's being rejected isn't Him, but the later theological framework—developed after the 4th century—that became attached to Him and, in doing so, turned into one of the biggest obstacles keeping Jews from believing.

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reading Jesus on His own terms to hear His words within the Jewish world that produced them. Understanding His teachings as His original audience would have understood them—before they were filtered through seventeen hundred years of non-Jewish, often antisemitic, reinterpretations.

Only then does the gospel recover its original power, coherence, and beauty.

What Should You Expect?

Thus, in this book, we will do what many today call "deconstruct"—not to destroy faith, but to strip away centuries of doctrinal traditions by returning to the very heart of the matter: the biblical text itself. Our journey will transport us back *before* the influence of Augustine of Hippo, Thomas Aquinas, Dante, John Calvin, Jonathan Edwards, and John MacArthur. While I engage deeply with those added theological layers in several of my other books,[4] in this volume we will look beyond them—peeling back centuries of interpretation—to encounter the raw, unfiltered voice of Scripture in its original context.

In this book, we'll explore—and try to answer—some of the big ancient questions: What really happened in Eden? What exactly has God saved us from? What did Jesus accomplish through His life, death, and

resurrection? How does His sacrifice complete the story told in Israel's Scriptures? How does blood bring atonement? How does the cross reveal and heal the brokenness of our world? What is the biblical meaning of salvation, justice, and wrath? What is the purpose of hell?

We will also wrestle seriously with Scripture's repeated and unmistakable claims: that God is "mighty to save" (Zephaniah 3:17; Isaiah 63:1); that He "wants everyone to be saved" (1 Timothy 2:4); that no purpose of His "can be thwarted" (Job 42:2); and that, in the end, "every knee will bow and every tongue will confess allegiance to Jesus Christ" in worship (Isaiah 45:23; Romans 14:11; Philippians 2:10–11).

Taken together, these declarations force us to ask whether God's will is merely aspirational—or truly effective; whether Christ's atonement is limited or unlimited in its power; whether divine love is hopeful but fragile—or victorious and unstoppable.

I invite you to set aside your preconceptions and to be both brave and honest in your search for truth. The path may feel unfamiliar—even uncomfortable—but that is often the sign of real growth. My challenge is simple: don't settle for secondhand answers. Dig deep. Ask hard questions. And have the courage to rediscover the living Word for yourself. The reward is a faith that is not only truer, but deeper, freer, and more transformative than anything one denomination alone could ever offer.

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Part I: When the Gospel Was Still Jewish

Chapter 1

Understanding The Biblical Concept of Time

The concept of time is understood very differently through the modern Western/Greek philosophical lens than it was in ancient biblical Jewish thought. Western theology, shaped heavily by Greek metaphysics, often imagines eternity as endless time stretching forward without limit. But the biblical writers did not think in those categories. Their language was more relational, experiential, and rooted in the cyclical rhythms of life rather than abstract philosophical speculation. When these ancient ideas are later filtered through Greek philosophical assumptions and then carried into modern languages, the original meaning can easily shift.

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readers often receive as "the Bible" is therefore not pure text, but text filtered through tradition, assumptions, and inherited theology.

One major reason there are so many Bible translations is that even scholars cannot agree on how best to convey the depth, nuance, and layered meaning of the original text. Translation is never merely linguistic; it is interpretive. On top of that, translators inevitably bring their own theological assumptions to the task.

For example, many Western translators—Catholic, Protestant, Evangelical—operate within a framework shaped by the doctrine of Eternal Conscious Torment, and that theology often seeps into how certain Hebrew and Greek words and passages are rendered in English.

A striking example is the Parable of the Sheep and the Goats in the Gospel of Matthew 25. In the popular evangelical translation, the New International Version (NIV), Jesus concludes by saying, *"They will go away to **eternal punishment**."* Yet in more academically rigorous translations—such as Prof. David Bentley Hart's The New Testament: A Translation, published by Yale University—the same line reads, *"These will go away into the **chastening of that Age**."*

The difference is not minor. It reflects radically different assumptions about language, time, judgment, and especially the meaning of the Greek word *aiōnios*.

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analytical Greek thought (particularly from Platonic [8] and Aristotelian [9] traditions). This philosophical tradition later influenced Christian theology, especially through figures like Augustine of Hippo, who integrated Greek metaphysics into biblical interpretation, [10] which then reshaped how Western Christianity came to understand biblical language and the concept of time. [11]

The Meaning of "Eternal" According to Top Christian Scholars

Even though I'm a native Hebrew speaker and learned Greek in seminary, I'd rather let the real experts do the talking so it doesn't come off as just my personal opinion.

According to the Interpreter's Dictionary of the Bible:

> **Time:** The Old Testament and the New Testament are not acquainted with the conception of eternity as timelessness. The Old Testament has not developed a special term for "eternity." The word *aion* originally meant "vital force," "life," then "age,"

"lifetime." [12]

(K.R. Crim, G.A. Buttrick)

The renowned theologian Charles Ellicott explains:

> **Everlasting punishment–life eternal:** The two adjectives represent the same Greek word, *aionios*—it must be admitted that the Greek word which is rendered "eternal" does not, in itself, involve endlessness, but rather, duration, whether through an age or succession of ages, and that it is therefore applied in the New Testament to periods of time that have had both a beginning and ending. [13]
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> **Eternal**: Greek: "*aeonion*," i.e., "of the ages." Etymologically this adjective, like others similarly formed, does not signify "during," but "belong to" the *aeons* or ages. [16]
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I could go on and on for an *olam*, but you get the point—the words so often translated as "forever," "everlasting," or "eternal" in English Bibles today were not originally about endless time. In the Second Temple Jewish mindset, when referring to time, they spoke of an *age* or an *era*. When paired with words like "life" or "punishment," the emphasis was not on duration but on depth—on volume, quality, weight, and purpose rather than on mathematical length.

In that sense, *eternal life* described a divine kind of life, not a stopwatch ticking into infinity. Jesus was offering a transformed way of living—a life of true depth and meaning, grounded in the life of God and available here and now.

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The Hebrew/Biblical Concept of Time—Cyclical Rather Than Linear

The Jewish and biblical understanding of time is cyclical rather than strictly linear. While Western theology often views time as a straight line with a clear beginning, middle, and end, the biblical mindset sees time unfolding in cycles, patterns, seasons, and ages. It's more like a spiral than a straight road, with each turn or age building on the last toward eventual restoration.

This is evident in the rhythms woven throughout Scripture—the weekly Shabbat, the moon's monthly cycle, the annual feasts, and the prophetic patterns where themes of judgment, exile, and redemption resound across generations. It's especially clear in the book of Revelation (consider my short book ***Revelation: A Jewish Perspective*** for more details).

These repeating cycles reveal a biblical understanding of time that is rhythmic rather than linear—an unfolding story rather than an endless countdown. These aren't one-time events but recurring themes that shape the journey of both individuals and communities.

In this framework, judgment is not the final word—it is a stage in a larger redemptive process. From this perspective, hell—if understood as a place of afterlife punishment—might be seen as a temporary, corrective stage within a broader cycle of return, renewal, and healing.

And indeed, in Jewish thought—both modern and ancient[21]—this present life is understood as an age, and so is hell. Hell is therefore not everlasting but another age beyond this life, serving a purpose rather than existing as endless punishment. It functions as a period of judgment, after which God's restorative purposes

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Let us look at several key examples of how *Olam* functions in Scripture:

> *To the roots of the mountains I sank down; the earth beneath barred me in* ***forever*** *[olam]. But you, LORD my God, brought my life up from the pit.*
>
> (Jonah 2:6)

Jonah was inside the great fish for only three days and three nights (Jonah 1:17), yet he describes his experience as lasting *olam*. This shows that *olam* can refer to a specific, limited time period.

> *The forts and towers will become lairs* ***forever*** *[olam], a joy of wild donkeys, a pasture of flocks—Until the Spirit is poured upon us from on high...*
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This prophecy of Babylonian captivity lasted seventy years, clearly demonstrating that *olam* spoke of an age as well as severity.

These examples confirm that the Hebrew *Olam* is not about infinite time.

The Greek Words "Aion" and "Aionios"

The New Testament sees this concept in much the same way as the Hebrew Scriptures.

Strong's Concordance explains:

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Conclusion

In conclusion, the evidence from Hebrew and Greek usage, as well as the testimony of respected scholars, makes clear that the words *olam*, *aion*, and *aionios* were never meant to convey the abstract idea of endless time. Instead, when referring to time, they point to ages, eras, or long but limited durations, often with qualitative significance rather than quantitative measure. The biblical worldview understood time as cyclical and restorative, woven into rhythms of covenant, judgment, and renewal, not as an infinite linear continuum. Later theological developments—especially under Greek philosophical influence and Augustine's metaphysical framework—reshaped these terms into doctrines of endless punishment and timelessness. Recovering their original meaning opens the way to a more hopeful vision of divine justice, one rooted in God's mercy and the promise of restoration rather than the terror of unending torment.

Chapter 2

The Plumb Line of Truth: How We Discern True Doctrine

For I am not ashamed of the gospel of Christ, for it is the power of God to salvation for everyone who believes, for the Jew first and also for the Greek.

(Romans 1:16)

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Michael S. Heiser, a beloved and renowned Old Testament scholar educated in ancient history, Semitic languages, and the Hebrew Bible, acknowledged with much wisdom:

> The proper context for interpreting the Bible is not Augustine or any other church father. It is not the Catholic Church. It is not the rabbinic movements of late antiquity and the Middle Ages. It is not the Reformation or the Puritans. It is not evangelicalism in any of its flavors. It is not the modern world at all or any period of its history. The proper context for interpreting the Bible is the context of the biblical writers—the context that produced the Bible. Every other context is alien to the biblical writers and, therefore, to the Bible. Yet there is a pervasive tendency in the believing Church to filter the Bible through creeds, confessions, and denominational preferences. [23]
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cross. We begin to imagine God as an angry, bloodthirsty deity demanding violence, instead of the caring, loving Father who guides and teaches, forgives and corrects, purifies and disciplines His people to nurture them and lead them toward wholeness.

In reality, we often read and interpret the Bible through the lens of our own culture—filtering its words through modern assumptions and values. But when we do this, we risk losing its original meaning and context, unintentionally replacing it with ideas that would have been foreign to its first readers.

Why a Jewish Perspective Matters?

I've often heard people argue that since "the Jews rejected Christ," any Jewish context or perspective on Scripture should be dismissed. But this idea is not only historically wrong—since His disciples were Jews—it's also logically weak and theologically risky.

Dismissing the Jewish context and perspective "because Jews rejected Christ" commits two logical fallacies. First, it's a *genetic fallacy*: rejecting an idea solely because it comes from a Jewish source, rather than evaluating whether the idea itself is true. In our case, it's not really a "Jewish idea" so much as an example of how the first

listeners—who were Jews—understood the biblical message, with the beliefs of Jews in the Second Temple period serving merely as context and support.

Second, it's a *faulty generalization*: not all Jews rejected Jesus—many followed Him. Christianity did not begin as a new religion detached from Judaism. Sure, some Jews rejected Christ, but in its earliest form, it was a movement within Judaism itself. Jesus was a Jew, as were most of His followers, the first churches, and nearly all the New Testament authors. The early Christians were not raised in evangelical, Catholic, or Baptist homes but were raised Jewish. For over a century, followers of Jesus—both Jewish and Gentile converts ("God-fearers")—understood themselves as part of Israel's covenant community. They saw Jesus not as the founder of a new religion, but as the fulfillment of Israel's messianic hope (e.g., Deuteronomy 18:15).

Even though most Jews today do not accept the modern-day concept of Jesus as the Messiah—and often for good reasons—the original Jewish culture, historical context, and linguistic framework of both the Hebrew Scriptures and the New Testament remain indispensable.

Both the Hebrew Bible and most of the New Testament were written by Jews, using Jewish idioms, addressing biblical law, Jewish tradition, and Hebrew prophecy. Without these foundations, the biblical message becomes distorted, disconnected from its roots, and vulnerable to layers of later interpretation that obscure its intended meaning. Without understanding the Jewish context, many biblical passages are bound to be misinterpreted.

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written and first understood. It's only by recovering and reconnecting with the original context—its language, culture, symbolism, worldview, and of course, the Hebrew Scriptures—that we can truly appreciate the depth, clarity, and coherence of the gospel as Jesus' earliest followers shared it.

If your time machine happens to be out of order and time travel isn't an option, there are still three other ways to discover how the Gospel was understood from the first to the second centuries. One is to examine the evangelistic sermons and gospel presentations preached by the Jewish apostles, as recorded in the **Book of Acts**. The second is to examine the **Didache**—often regarded as the earliest example of the Church Orders genre—which provides a rare window into how the first Jewish followers of Christ understood and practiced the Gospel. The third is by looking at the **Apostles' Creed**—a concise ancient declaration of Christian faith.

But no one begins a story in the middle. Before we turn to those three sources, we must return to the beginning—to the prologue.

Chapter 3

The Gospel According to the Garden of Eden

Movies, parables, and stories typically start with a *prologue*. If you misunderstand it, the entire plot inevitably starts to warp, because the prologue—the opening—is where the central problem is first introduced. Misread the beginning, and the rest of the story will feel pretty confusing. In the same way, when the Bible's own prologue—the account of Eden—is misunderstood, it skews everything that comes after, leading to inevitable misinterpretations of key parts of the Gospel. When you dive into a novel or a film, you're not just curious about

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The opening chapters of Genesis lay the groundwork for the entire biblical narrative. And the Eden story, with its two mysterious trees, sets the stage.

Now buckle up and hit the ignition button, because we're about to take a trip through time…

Between the Two Trees

> *And the Lord God planted a garden in Eden, in the east, and there he put the man whom he had formed. Out of the ground the Lord God made to grow every tree that is pleasant to the sight and good for food,* ***the tree of life*** *also in the midst of the garden, and* ***the tree of the knowledge of good and evil****.*
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Human beings cannot grow only through intellectual guidance but must also learn from the lessons they gain through real-life experiences.

You can warn a child a thousand times not to touch a hot stove, yet only the sting of heat makes the lesson sink in. In the same way that a physician must both study and practice before becoming truly competent, humanity—first embodied by Adam and Eve—was about to discover the real meaning of "good" and "evil," not as an abstract idea, but as something experienced firsthand.

So, it seems the biblical narrator makes the central human problem unmistakably clear: death.

The Knowledge of Good and Evil

Now, Adam and Eve already had a rough idea of the "good," at least in its most basic sense—Genesis repeats it again and again: *"God saw that it was **good**"* (Genesis 1:4,10,12,18,21,25,31). Goodness was woven into every fiber of creation. Evil was absent—still knocking on the door, but not yet entered.

By eating from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil, humanity opened the door to new understanding, choosing to gain expertise in good and evil through a lifetime of experience. And how is evil

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What God knew as "evil" in Eden was, for the first time, about to be learned by humans. Yet there's a brighter side—through darkness, light becomes cherished, and through evil, goodness is truly seen for its beauty, its importance, and its divine origin.

It's one thing to observe light or study it in a physics class; it's something else entirely to truly value it—after feeling its warmth for the first time following a year trapped in a cold, lightless underground tunnel.

However, eating from the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil also meant giving up access to the Tree of Life.

Losing Access to the Tree of Life

Life comes from God, the source of all creation. The closer we are to Him, the closer we are to life, while turning away from Him leads us toward death.

Humanity chose the hard path—learning firsthand what evil truly is—and we have been on that journey ever since. We see how it kills, corrupts, destroys, and enslaves. Yet God, in His goodness, set a limit to this deadly education. When Adam and Eve ate from the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil, they—and all their descendants—lost access to the other, perhaps more vital tree: the Tree of Life:

> *And the Lord God said, "The man has now become like one of us, knowing good and evil. He must not be allowed to reach out his hand and take also from the tree of life and eat, and live forever."*
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The exile from Eden itself proves two things. First, that on the very day they ate from the forbidden tree, humanity died—or at least began the biological process of dying. God was speaking the truth after all. Second, this wasn't an act of wrath but of mercy—God does not wish for humans to suffer forever. By removing access to the Tree of Life, He gave humanity an expiration date—a limit to our pain and suffering. If this was how God responded to sin in the beginning, it's hard to believe He would later choose to torture billions without end after death.

Death existed before the fall because Adam and Eve needed continual access to the Tree of Life. Mortality was built into humanity from the beginning. Yet death had not taken hold, because it was held in check by communion with the source of life. Genesis never says that Adam became mortal after sin. What it says is that

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The Climax of the Gospel—Death or Life?

Tragically, modern gospel portrayals have often reversed this entirely. Instead of seeing *resurrection* and *life* (John 11:25) as the solution to humanity's deadly condition, it has twisted the message so that a brutal, violent death becomes the supposed climax and solution to humanity's problem. The result is an unsettling, disturbing message disconnected from the Bible's own prologue and from the logic of redemption woven through Scripture.

For instance, according to David Platt, a well-known Calvinist preacher and former president of the Southern Baptist International Mission Board, the climax of the gospel is Christ's brutal death. In his view, Jesus absorbed the full force of divine wrath, satisfying God's fury through violent substitution:

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> Jesus bore divine wrath at the cross for our sake, and so protected us from it. This act implies that God hates humans since he would have poured wrath upon humans if not for the work of Christ's cross.[26]

In this strange take on the gospel—known as Penal Substitutionary Atonement—a god with a split personality ends up protecting us from himself. But this isn't really good news at all—it's a fear-fueled setup where divine justice feels more like revenge than compassion, and the focus shifts from life, healing and restoration to simply dodging a bullet from the boss's gun—where an enraged authority figure vents his violence by executing someone else in your place, splattering mercy across the floor while calling it justice, and demanding gratitude for the spectacle.

Why Modern Gospel Portrayals Don't Make Sense Biblically

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The God of our ancestors raised Jesus from the dead—whom you killed by hanging him on a cross.

(Acts 5:30)

The modern gospel often portrays the Father and the Son as being at odds by accusing God of killing His innocent Son. But according to the Gospel first preached in the Book of Acts, the opposite is true—it was humanity that rejected, tortured, and killed Christ, while all God did was undo our actions by raising Him from the dead. Blaming God for the way Christ was treated is nothing less than demonic.

Furthermore, the mutilated, blood-soaked body of Jesus does not portray divine rage redirected toward humanity's substitute. Scripture calls Christ *"the fullness of God in bodily form"* (Colossians 2:9). Therefore, the crucified Christ is not a reflection of God's fury in some cosmic act of self-flagellation and suicide—it is a reflection of *our* evil. The cross does not reveal what God hates; it reveals who God is: love, even when pierced.

Who tortured, mocked, and crucified the Son of God? Not God—we did. Humanity did. Do not allow modern theology to portray God as the sadist of Calvary. The sadism was on our part. The brutality was ours. The cross

is not a window into divine vengeance but into human depravity—a portrait of what we become when love stands before us undefended.

It was the hardened fists of Roman soldiers that ripped the flesh from His back and crushed thorns into His skull. It was the diseased imagination of fallen humanity—violent, fearful, demon-driven—that conceived the cross: a masterpiece of brutal cruelty, engineered to destroy body, soul, and dignity alike.

Do not dare to call this horror "God's justice." The crucifixion was not God's punishment of the world—it was the world's assault on God's love. The cross is not divine retribution; it is divine revelation.

We hate; God loves.

The modern Western gospel is too often a grotesque misrepresentation of the Good News, portraying it as a violent exchange of wrath instead of a narrative about restoration, resurrection, and redeeming love. Nowhere in Scripture does it say God attacked Jesus to avoid punishing you. That idea came from medieval Western thinkers like Anselm of Canterbury and John Calvin.

Besides, if the gospel is that God killed Jesus in our place so He wouldn't have to kill us, then why do believers still experience death? Why not continue living forever, or be taken directly into heaven like Enoch and Elijah?

Death is still a universal reality. Think about it. Humanity is already in a state of dying. From the moment we're born, the clock starts ticking—we age, we decay, and we die. That is the consequence of sin and the fall

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death. We did not choose the first act of disobedience, but we are all born into its aftermath. Sin is contagious in its consequences, not hereditary in its culpability.

This is the biblical logic: death is not a punitive sentence arbitrarily imposed on innocent descendants (Augustinian-Western theology); it is the natural result of stepping outside the source of life. Adam opened the door, and we all grow up in the same broken house. The story of Scripture, then, is not about an angry God assigning inherited guilt and violently exploding on His son—but about a loving God entering that house Himself to heal it from the inside out.

What Would a World Without Sin Be Like?

We need to consider: what might a world free from sin actually look like? Would such a world ever be feasible?

Take King David, for example. He didn't write psalms about God's grace and mercy before he sinned—but after. He first had to *experience evil*. Concepts like forgiveness and compassion aren't abstract ideas; they are deeply emotional realities that must be experienced to be fully understood. You can't truly forgive unless

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In biblical Hebrew, the word used in Genesis is *"tov"*—meaning beneficial, pleasing, operative, or fit for purpose. It doesn't mean flawless, morally perfect, or incapable of error. That word would be *"tamim,"* which speaks of perfection, moral innocence, or blamelessness and is used in different contexts throughout the Hebrew Scriptures (e.g.,"innocent *[tamim]* lamb"). The creation story doesn't use that word—and for good reason.

In a perfect world, there would have been no deceitful serpent in Eden. And if humanity were flawless, it would have known better than to fall for his lies. There also wouldn't have been a tree that could lead to death. Creation wasn't perfect, but it also wasn't broken—it was designed to be an experiential space of growth, relationship, and freedom—which requires risk, imperfection, and the possibility of failure.

God is perfect—all-knowing and understanding, all-powerful, all-loving, and unchanging. But neither Adam and Eve nor any of us were ever born reflecting that kind of perfection. We were made finite—restricted in knowledge, poor in emotional depth, and limited in moral understanding. We were made to learn. Like babies.

And in a world like that, "sin" isn't just rebellion—it's inevitable. It flows naturally from our limitations, our freedom, and our immaturity. Even qualities like self-focus or selfishness aren't inherently evil; they become harmful when they diminish or violate others. But in many cases—like putting on your own oxygen mask before helping others when flying—these so-called "selfish" instincts are actually basic survival mechanisms. They're

not inherently sinful; they help us exist, function, and endure in a world full of challenges. It's only when these instincts become distorted or misused that they turn sinful.

God didn't make a mistake in creating humans this way. He made a world where people grow through experience, through mistakes, through relationships. He created us not to be perfect (yet), but to be dependent —on Him and on each other. How else would we learn what love is? Imperfection isn't the real problem. The problem is forgetting that God called us good, even *with* our limitations. The journey of life isn't about achieving moral perfection—it's about becoming mature in love through the knowledge of good and evil. Moral refinement is a side effect of growth.

Conclusion

If *death* was the problem introduced in Eden, then *immortality* is the answer. God, whose not only the source of life but also of love, solved it by giving humanity the incredible gift of resurrection—life restored from death—the cure for evil's sting. Even in Eden, the story foreshadows this: humanity will encounter evil through death, but God will one day conquer death.

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Chapter 4

The Gospel in Light of the Book of Acts

One might ask, "How do you know you aren't the one misreading Eden and misunderstanding the gospel? After all, others read the story differently." If that is the case, then a deeper question presses itself upon us: by what standard do we decide who is right and who is wrong?

The easiest way to understand what the gospel was *before* institutional Christianity emerged is by looking at the Book of Acts. There we find how the message was spread and what it looked and sounded like in its original, living context—proclaimed by Jewish apostles, rooted in Hebrew Scriptures, and alive with the Spirit's power.

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The Kingdom of God

The kingdom of God is... righteousness, peace, and joy in the Holy Spirit.

(Romans 14:17)

Paul's teaching echoed the very same kingdom message Jesus had shared throughout His life and ministry. The Kingdom of God wasn't some far-off place in outer space; it was about living by the example Jesus set during His time on earth.

Here is the logic: if you are an ambassador of a foreign Kingdom, and your life—like the lives of others from that Kingdom—is marked by love, kindness, forgiveness, gentleness, generosity, justice, faithfulness, and compassion, people will notice. They will be drawn to you. They will sense that you belong to a different order of life—a Kingdom that offers what their hearts already long for.

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Kingdom of God was the central theme of Jesus' preaching from the outset. Jesus drew on Jewish expectations of God's reign but gave them a new urgency, presenting the Kingdom as a present reality breaking into the world through his ministry and a future hope to be fully realized. Thus, from the very start of His mission, Jesus' message was about God's Kingdom breaking into history, inviting both Jews and Gentiles to turn away from all other spiritual and moral paths and to put their trust in Him by following His way of life.

In other words—you participate in the kingdom of God when you love others sacrificially, when you show mercy to the undeserving, when you forgive your enemies, when you uphold justice, when you take care of the poor, when you welcome the stranger, when you comfort the brokenhearted, when you live in humility and truth. By being an active part of His kingdom, you not only experience God's blessings here on earth but also gain treasures in heaven.

This, rather than evading punishment in a cosmic torture chamber—was the focus of the Gospel message from the very beginning.

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Nothing about Original Sin, God punishing Jesus, or Eternal Conscious Torment in hellfire.

The Book of Acts ends with Paul—under house arrest in Rome—still *"proclaiming the kingdom of God and teaching about the Lord Jesus Christ with all boldness and without hindrance."* (Acts 28:23-31).

The kingdom gospel preached throughout the Book of Acts had nothing to do with how to escape from hellfire and everything to do with becoming an ambassador of God's kingdom—living it out here and now, following Christ's example as redeemed people who love, serve, and forgive others in Christ's name (e.g., Acts 3:6).

Overcoming Death: How the Early Jewish Church Understood the Gospel

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The answer is simple: The Gospel shared by Jesus's Jewish apostles for the first two centuries differs significantly from the gospel that is commonly advocated in many modern Western traditions today, especially the Reformed ones (Evangelical, Calvinist, Baptist, Pentecostal, etc.).

This changes everything. Because if death is the real enemy, then salvation isn't about getting pulled out of God's furnace—it's about being made alive again. In Christ. Through Christ. With Christ.

It's about being grafted back into the life we were cut off from. It's about re-entering the Garden. Eating from the Tree of Life. Living forever in communion with God—not because we earned it by works or intellect, but because Jesus conquered the thing that was keeping us from living forever—death.

Conclusion

If doctrines like hellfire torment were central to humanity's destiny and to Christ's mission, we would expect the apostles—Peter, Paul, Stephen, James, Philip—to have made them central to their preaching. After all, the Acts of the Apostles records the spread of the gospel across Israel and the Roman world. If avoiding Eternal Conscious Torment were the Good News, Acts should be saturated with warnings about it.

The answer is simple: The Gospel shared by Jesus's Jewish apostles for the first two centuries differs significantly from the gospel that is commonly advocated in many modern Western traditions today, especially the Reformed ones (Evangelical, Calvinist, Baptist, Pentecostal, etc.).

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It's about being grafted back into the life we were cut off from. It's about re-entering the Garden. Eating from the Tree of Life. Living forever in communion with God—not because we earned it by works or intellect, but because Jesus conquered the thing that was keeping us from living forever—death.

Conclusion

If doctrines like hellfire torment were central to humanity's destiny and to Christ's mission, we would expect the apostles—Peter, Paul, Stephen, James, Philip—to have made them central to their preaching. After all, the Acts of the Apostles records the spread of the gospel across Israel and the Roman world. If avoiding Eternal Conscious Torment were the Good News, Acts should be saturated with warnings about it.

Chapter 5

The Gospel in Light of the Didache

When we learn about the post-Acts Church from extra-biblical documents, such as 1 Clement, Epistle of Barnabas, Shepherd of Hermas, Ignatius' Letters, Epistle to Diognetus, and Justin Martyr's works—we never find them claiming that God punished His Son to satisfy divine wrath and avoid tormenting us. Nor do we see them warning about spending forever in flames; none of these ideas are presented.

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Instead, the Didache draws a sharp contrast between what it calls the "Way of Life" and the "Way of Death." These terms, however, aren't metaphysical labels for a future heaven or hell, but rather ethical and spiritual frameworks that guide how one chooses to live—whether to glorify God by living in line with the Kingdom of God or not.

In both biblical and Jewish thought, "life" was never primarily about the afterlife, but about life here and now—a way of living marked by covenant faithfulness, vitality, and communion with God (e.g., Deuteronomy 30:19–20; John 10:10; Romans 8:6).

The *Way of Life* is marked by love, generosity, humility, and moral integrity; **The *Way of Death***—a path of hatred and self-sabotage that ends in self-destruction—is marked by cruelty, greed, and lawlessness. It's a life turned inward, cut off from compassion, and blind to the beauty of God's ways.

While the Didache text certainly warns of consequences for evil and urges repentance and vigilance in light of the coming judgment, it never describes these consequences in terms of Eternal Conscious Torment. In fact, the eschatological section at the end of the Didache (chapter 16) reflects an early Jewish-Christian apocalyptic worldview. It speaks of the appearance of the deceiver, persecution, and the return of the Lord, but again, it's lacking any graphic depiction of everlasting punishment or fiery damnation. The emphasis is far more on perseverance, ethical living, and faithfulness than on the fear of hellfire. The good news wasn't understood as

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That entanglement came much later. Only after the influence of Augustine of Hippo in the fourth century did Western theology begin to recast judgment in terms of perpetual damnation. The Didache stands as a witness to a simpler, more grounded gospel—one concerned less with metaphysical terror and more with forming a people who walk the way of life.

Later portrayals like the medieval concept of hellfire—a cosmic unending fiery torture chamber—is a theological development far removed from the authentic apostolic preaching. The apostles' original Gospel was good news for all—not a horror story designed to terrify sinners into belief.

Conclusion

Salvation is not God rescuing us from an angry version of Himself. It's about God rescuing us from what we've become without Him. The good news is not that a few of us will receive a "get out of infinite jail" card. The good news is that the consequence of sin—*death*—has been overcome, and true, immortal, divine life is now within reach.

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Chapter 6

The Gospel in Light of the Apostles' Creed

The Apostles' Creed—whose earliest roots reach back to the late 2nd century, with forms developing through the 4th century onwards—stands as one of the earliest and most enduring summaries of Christian belief. Though not written by the apostles themselves, it reflects an earlier "Rule of Faith" that encapsulated the core teachings they passed on. For centuries, it served as a baptismal confession and a benchmark of orthodoxy across the Christian world.

However, after the Apostles' Creed took shape, various Christian traditions began producing their own creeds, confessions, and doctrinal statements. Over time, this resulted in additional layers of interpretation and dogma —many of which go beyond, and sometimes diverge from, the beliefs the apostles originally proclaimed.

Here's the English translation of the traditional form, with slight wording variations among translations shown in [brackets]:

> I believe in God, the Father almighty, creator of heaven and earth. I believe in Jesus Christ, his only Son, our Lord, who was conceived by the Holy Spirit, born of the Virgin Mary, suffered under Pontius Pilate, was crucified, died, and was buried; he descended to hell [to the dead]. On the third day he rose again; he ascended into heaven, he is seated at the right hand of the Father, and he will come again to judge the living and the dead. I believe in the Holy Spirit, the holy catholic [universal] Church, the communion of saints, the forgiveness of sins, the resurrection of the body, and the life everlasting. Amen.

Descended Where?!

The phrase *"he descended to hell [the dead]"* may sound confusing to modern ears.

The Greek version of the Apostles' Creed reads *"katelthonta eis ta katôtata."* Meaning, *"descended to lower ones,"* or *"descended to those below."* The Latin version reads *"descendit ad inferos,"* where "inferos" (not infernos with an "n"!) means *"those below,"* like the word "inferior." So, the Latin *inferos* corresponds pretty accurately with the Greek *katôtata*.

In the earliest centuries, when the Creed was forming, "hell" was understood in the sense of *Hades* (Greek) or *Sheol* (Hebrew)—the realm of the dead, the grave, the place where all dead rest, awaiting the resurrection. To say that Christ descended there was simply to affirm that he truly experienced death in full and entered the common fate of humanity in order to conquer it from within (through resurrection). It wasn't understood that Jesus entered a place of fiery punishment but that He fully shared in our human death and then triumphed over it.

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Saved from Death

In the first few centuries, no Christian would have imagined Jesus visiting the furnace of torment that modern infernalists/fundamentalists project onto the text. Eastern Christianity, for instance, never quite read the text this way, continuing to emphasize *Hades* as simply "the realm of the dead"—the grave that Christ broke open in victory.

The Creed was never meant to depict God's Son descending into a torture chamber, but to affirm that He entered fully into death—that He passed through the grave in order to shatter humanity's coffin.

When we read the Creed in the way it was intended, a far more hopeful vision emerges: Jesus truly died, truly shared humanity's common fate, and from within death itself truly broke open the path to resurrection and life everlasting:

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from an angry God who had to kill His own Son, or from infinite torment in hellfire—were not part of the original apostolic proclamation. These ideas emerged later, layered onto the gospel rather than flowing from it.

Who do you think understood the gospel more faithfully: first and second century Jews—many of whom personally knew Jesus, walked the same dusty roads, and spoke His language—or a fourth-century Gentile theologian named Augustine and a sixteenth-century Gentile European lawyer named John Calvin, seated in their studies and filtering Jesus' message through foreign translations and Western legal categories? Honestly, the very comparison should make us smile. On the one hand, Jewish eyewitnesses who actually lived the story; on the other, a lawyer half a world and fifteen centuries removed, trying to systematize it into a courtroom framework. It's up to you to decide which sounds closer to the heart of the Gospel…

So far, we have traced how the earliest believers understood the gospel. The remainder of this book will show why they understood it that way—biblically, theologically, and historically. We will also examine how, over the centuries, that original vision was gradually reshaped—at times subtly, at times radically—into the version many have inherited today. What follows is a return to the roots of the Good News, to recover its power, its beauty, and its original meaning.

Chapter 7

From a Jewish Movement to an Imperialistic Western Religion

It was a quiet morning on the shores of Galilee. The fire crackled softly. The scent of fish rose in the mist. And there stood Peter, still carrying the weight of his three denials like invisible chains. He had seen the risen Christ. He had witnessed the impossible. But restoration is not automatic—it must be spoken, received, and lived.

And Jesus, ever the Shepherd, asked him not for his statement of faith, not for penance, not for grand declarations of ministry vision. He simply asked, three times: *"Do you **love** me?"* (John 21:15-17).

I can picture Peter's first answer as a whisper, eyes fixed on his Master's feet; his second, spoken with a clearer voice and head held a bit higher; and his third, delivered with a loud, strong, confident tone and a smile spreading across his face.

Three times. Each time, Peter's wounded heart offered what it could. And each time, Jesus responded not with theological affirmation, but with a command of movement: *"Feed my lambs… Tend my sheep… Feed my sheep."*

And notice something critical: Jesus does not say, "Feed *your* sheep." He says, "Feed *my* sheep." They belong to Him. They are His beloved. And He has entrusted their care not to governments, not to systems, not to charities—but to His followers. Jesus' kingdom was never about control, coercion, or frightening the sheep into obedience. It was about love expressed through service.

Not an Institution but a Movement, Not a System but a Flock

Peter—like all of Jesus' Jewish disciples—was deeply familiar with the shepherd imagery woven throughout the Hebrew Scriptures. Israel is repeatedly called God's flock, and God Himself is portrayed as the Shepherd

who guides, protects, and restores His people (Genesis 48:15; 49:24; Psalm 23:1; 79:13; 95:7; 100:3; Isaiah 40:11; Jeremiah 50:6–7; Ezekiel 34:11–15, 31; Micah 7:14).

This time, though, something significant was changing. Jesus was appointing Peter—and the group of disciples with him—to take on the role of Israel's new "priestly" shepherds. Jesus had already warned the existing leaders that their stewardship would be taken away and given to others who would bear its fruit (see the Parable of the Two Sons, Matthew 21:43). And here, in Peter's restoration, that transfer of spiritual leadership begins to unfold.

Still Jewish. Still Israel. But now under new leadership—Jewish fishermen, tax collectors, and former outcasts—those whom God chose to lead His people not by pedigree or prestige, but by humility, self-giving, and devotion to the Way of Messiah.

It was not simply an ancient metaphor tucked away in mystery. It was an assignment. A calling. A shift from the disciples' inward shame to outward love. From silence to service. From belief to embodiment.

This is where we begin. Because before there was a religion called Christianity, before there was even a collection of letters called the New Testament, there was the nation of Israel. There were the Hebrew Scriptures. And there was Yeshua—Jewish, rooted, speaking in a language shaped by Torah and Prophets, calling back the people of God to what they had always been meant to be: shepherds who reflect the loving heart of the Shepherd.

But this time, they won't just shepherd Israel—they'll shepherd the entire world. God didn't abandon Israel; He ensured His Chosen People would indeed fulfill their mission and become a light to the nations. It was only Israel's *leadership* that He had to replace.

But much has changed since then. Christianity is no longer a Jewish movement; it has become a distinctly Western religion. And the way the gospel is commonly portrayed today is not how the biblical authors expressed it. It is a picture shaped by later, non-Jewish generations.

This shift emerged through a long chain of distortions: misunderstandings of biblical words and idioms, the loss of Jewish ways of thinking, the confusion of literary genres, and the flattening of rich ancient metaphors into rigid, literal, philosophical categories. Terms that once spoke of restoration, correction, purification, and covenantal consequence were slowly reinterpreted through foreign frameworks and severed from their original Jewish soil. What was once relational and redemptive became abstract, legal, and forensic—less the product of the biblical imagination and more the result of centuries of human reinterpretation.

"It All Started with Paul!"

I often hear people argue Paul founded Christianity. I find it absurd to claim that Paul invented a new religion called Christianity because Paul never understood himself that way, never spoke that way, and never acted that way.

Paul, like other first-century believers, never observed Christmas, Easter, Lent, Advent, or other later church traditions. Instead, he celebrated Israel's feasts of Tabernacles, Firstfruits, *Shavuot*, Passover, and *Yom Kippur*, continuing to keep the Jewish festivals (Acts 20:16; 1 Corinthians 16:8). Paul didn't confess sins in a booth, pray the rosary, or follow later church rituals. Rather, he took part in Jewish purification rites (Acts 21:23–26), arranged for Timothy's circumcision (Acts 16:3), and lived according to the Jewish religious rhythms of his time, following the practices that shaped Israel's covenant life.

Paul was a Second Temple Jew—trained as a Pharisee, steeped in the Hebrew Scriptures, and fiercely loyal to Israel's God. He labeled himself a *Hebrew* (Philippians 3:5), a *Jew* (Acts 22:3), and an *Israelite* (Romans 11:1).

He did not abandon Judaism; he embodied a new stream within it—the denomination of those who followed Rabbi Yeshua; Israel's Messiah.

Within Judaism, one measure of a rabbi's greatness is the number of non-Jewish disciples who come to follow Israel's God through him. The logic was: if you are truly a blessed rabbi, even gentiles will follow you. In that sense, Rabbi Jesus and, later, Rabbi Paul through Him, founded the largest Jewish denomination in history. That stream may later be called "Christianity," or any other name, but the reality remains: it is Jewish at its core, regardless of the labels attached to it.

Jews often study through debate. Paul argued with other Jews—often fiercely—that Israel's story had reached its climax in Jesus of Nazareth, Israel's Messiah (Acts 9:20; 13:5; 13:14; 14:1; 17:1–2; 17:10; 18:4). His later letters are saturated with the Hebrew Law and Prophets, and the Psalms; with Jewish language, Jewish temple imagery, and distinctly Jewish ethical categories. A man does not invent a "new religion" while relentlessly appealing to the authority of the old one.

Paul didn't introduce a new god, point to a new scripture, or establish a new moral vision. When he told Timothy that *"all Scripture is God-breathed"* (2 Timothy 3:16), the New Testament hadn't yet been canonized. He was referring to Israel's Scriptures, the Hebrew Bible. He preached that the God of Abraham had acted decisively through the risen Messiah to fulfill His promises and extend blessing to the nations. That is not

a new religious invention; it is an intra-Jewish proclamation. Disagreement within a tradition does not equal departure from it.

Nor did Paul invent "Christianity" as a system. He wrote occasional letters to real communities, addressing concrete problems—table fellowship, Torah observance, persecution, allowing non-Jews to join, and unity between Jews and Gentiles. Paul was not founding an institution; he was shepherding communities he believed were already living inside Israel's long-awaited redemption.

The Gentiles did not replace Israel; they became part of one of Israel's own movements—what later came to be called "Christianity." In fact, Jews who followed Yeshua as their Messiah were initially identified by other Jews as *Nazarenes* (e.g., Acts 24:5), alongside groups such as the Sadducees, Pharisees, Herodians, and Essenes. It was only later, in Antioch, that they were called Christians—likely as a label of mockery or derision (Acts 11:26).

The very idea of "Christianity" as a religion separate from Judaism is a later historical development, shaped by Gentile dominance, Roman categories, Greek spirituality (mostly Neoplatonism and Gnosticism), and post-Temple realities. Projecting that back onto Paul is an anachronism. It confuses later outcomes with original intent.

Paul did not invent a new religion. He proclaimed what he believed was the fulfillment of Israel's story—and argued that the nations were now being invited into it. For me—as a Jew—the vast number of Gentiles drawn

to Jesus does not undermine His Jewishness; it confirms it. It demonstrates that following Jesus is the most compelling stream of Judaism—the one that fulfilled Israel's calling to draw the nations. If anything deserves to be called the truest expression of Jewish faith, it is the path through which the God of Israel finally reached the world.

The Fourth Century: Where It All Began

A message born in the dust of Judea—fierce, earthy, and unmistakably Jewish—was carried into the halls of Greece and Rome, where foreign philosophies reshaped it into something fundamentally different. What emerged was a gospel refracted through pagan lenses, altered in both form and meaning. As time passed, this Greco-Roman reinterpretation was further Europeanized, producing the version of Christianity most familiar in the modern West.

As a result, the 21st-century Western gospel often sounds something like this:

> God the Father is utterly furious with you because you fail to match His perfection. Naturally, He must uphold His justice by tormenting your soul and torturing your body forever in everlasting hellfire. But you're fortunate: Christ stepped in to absorb the Father's rage, appease His wrath, and allow a select few to escape what would otherwise be their deserved fate.

This distorted portrayal began to take shape around the fourth century and continued to evolve from there. When Christianity emerged as an official, separate religion in that period, it did not merely drift from its Jewish roots—it became increasingly hostile toward them. Antisemitism, tragically, played a decisive role in reshaping how many Christians came to understand the gospel itself.

Once Christianity became intertwined with Neoplatonism, Gnosticism, and imperial power, distancing itself from its Jewish source was seen as both politically useful and theologically convenient. Over time, this hostility produced interpretations of Scripture that obscured the original context and Jewish identity of Jesus and His message, severed the Church from the Hebrew story that birthed it, and distorted the message of the gospel itself.

As the Church expanded across the Greco-Roman world, it absorbed the culture, categories, and philosophical assumptions of its new environment. The context changed. The language changed. The logic changed. The worldview changed. And with it—the gospel changed.

What was once a vibrant, embodied faith—rooted in living out God's will in every aspect of daily and communal life—was slowly reduced to a contest of correct ideas, individual confessions, and systematized creeds. Faith became an assent to abstract doctrines. Doctrines became tickets to heaven. The heart and body were exiled, and the mind enthroned.

The Birth of Western Christian Religion (313-325 A.D.)

The intentional historical separation of Jewish elements from Christianity and the disconnect of Jesus' teachings from the Hebrew Scriptures most visibly began with Emperor Constantine (4th century) who actively uprooted Christianity from its Jewish roots in his efforts to establish a distinct, "Jewish-free" identity: *"Let us then have nothing in common with the detestable Jewish crowd,"* [31] declared Constantine. Such efforts included removing Jewish-Christian priests from positions of leadership, [32] promoting new doctrines and local practices,

and introducing various pagan elements to make the faith feel more familiar and comfortable to Western converts.[33] Together, these shifts steadily eroded the Jewish character of the early church and pushed Jewish believers to the margins. Constantine legalized Christianity (Edict of Milan, 313) and initiated the fusion of imperial power and Christian authority. Within just a few decades, Christianity had been reshaped into an entirely new Western imperialistic religion—one that bore very little resemblance to its original, Hebrew foundations.

The First Council of Nicaea, held in 325 AD in Turkey (convened by Emperor Constantine), is arguably the most famous event in post-biblical Christian history. This event was pivotal in early Christianity, and while there were some positive aspects, bishops of Jewish heritage were not allowed to participate in the council.[34] This had notable, long-lasting repercussions not only for Christian-Jewish relations but also on Christian theology.

In an effort to "de-Judaize" the faith, the Council eliminated most biblical holidays and altered others, such as moving the celebration of the Resurrection from the Feast of First Fruits to the newly established Easter, intentionally creating distance from the "Jewish" calendar. Their reasoning was explicit: *"For it is unbecoming beyond measure that on this holiest of festivals, we should follow the customs of the Jews. Henceforth, let us have nothing in common with this odious people."*[35] It was also decided to replace the biblical Passover with Easter and the biblical Saturday Sabbath (Genesis 2:3) with Sunday.[36]

The persecution of the Quartodecimans signaled the start of a very dark era. The word "Quartodeciman," meaning "fourteeners" in Latin, referred mainly to Jews but also to many devoted Christians who observed the biblical Passover on the 14th of Nisan, [37] as stated in Leviticus 23:5.

Performing circumcision was outlawed, and violations were now fervently punishable by death. [38] Eventually, Jews were prohibited from holding public office or serving as officers in the military. Later, restrictions were put on where the Jewish people could live, with whom they could do business, and where they could travel. [39] By the end of the 4th century, Christianity had merged with imperial Roman power and become structurally and legally antisemitic, largely disconnected from its Hebraic roots. [40]

The Infusion of Paganism

When Christianity became the imperial religion, it did not emerge in a vacuum. It inherited, adapted, and repurposed many elements from the surrounding pagan Roman world. Pagan temples became churches, civic basilicas became Christian gathering spaces, and imperial festivals were recast as Christian holy days. [41] Ritual forms such as incense, processions, vestments, and the veneration of saints and relics—none characteristic of

early Jewish-Christian practice—became standard features of worship.[42] Christian theology and intellectual life drew heavily on Greco-Roman philosophy, especially Neoplatonism, which shaped emerging doctrines of God, the soul, salvation, hell, and the structure of the cosmos.[43] In effect, Christianity became the religious heir to the Roman Empire even as it condemned (other kinds of) pagan worship and distanced itself from Judaism.

The result was a new kind of Christianity: legally privileged, culturally dominant, philosophically Hellenized, and deeply intertwined with imperial power. It was no longer the small Jewish sect of the first century but the foundation of a Christian empire, carrying forward Roman forms even as it enforced a new religious order.

From the Faith of Scripture to the Religion of Empire

Theologically speaking, it comes as no surprise that Christianity has completely distanced itself from its Jewish context, profoundly reshaping Christian theology, causing it to lose sight of Jesus and Paul as Jewish rabbis and to neglect the need to interpret their teachings within their original Jewish context.

Christians today often emphasize that the New Covenant replaces the Old, yet they sometimes overlook an essential point: the Old Covenant commandments never spoke of the afterlife. They were about *this* life—how

to treat other humans (Leviticus 19), how to walk in God's favor (Deuteronomy 11), how to enjoy His blessings (Leviticus 18), and how to avoid the curses and consequences that come from disobedience (Deuteronomy 28).

When Jesus said He *came to fulfill the Law* (Matthew 5:17) and then delivered the Sermon on the Mount, He continued in the same trajectory. His teaching echoes the heart of the Torah: a way of life that leads to flourishing rather than destruction, blessing rather than curse. Jesus did not shift the focus to a different realm entirely but deepened and clarified the very same divine law and Hebrew logic of blessing that God revealed from the beginning.

Over time, the historical and theological gap turned into a distortion that still influences how the Bible is interpreted and translated today—often seen through a Westernized lens instead of being understood in its genuine Jewish context. By *Jewish*, I do not speak of the later Rabbinic tradition that eventually shaped much of post-Temple Judaism. Rather, I am referring to *biblical Judaism*—the faith of ancient Israel—including Moses, David, the Prophets, and, of course, Jesus and His disciples.

Conclusion—The Gospel *After* Christianity

The Gospel, once a vibrant and radical Jewish *way of living life*, was taken over by Greek philosophy—mainly Gnosticism and Neoplatonism—and reshaped into an *intellectual* formula to be mastered; a doctrinal system to mentally adhere to in order to avoid hellfire in the afterlife.

According to the Lausanne Movement, there are approximately *"49,000 Christian denominations/rites"* today.[44] Each Christian group claims that their *own* interpretation is the true key that unlocks salvation. The Catholic Church elevates transubstantiation and sacramental participation as essential. Pentecostal traditions imply that speaking in tongues is the evidence of genuine salvation. Calvary Chapel treats its particular rapture theory as indispensable. Reformed churches raise adherence to T.U.L.I.P.[45] to the level of orthodoxy. Lutherans insist that justification must be understood strictly within their confessional categories. Baptists often claim that their formula of "biblical baptism" validates true faith. Evangelicals demand a definable, often highly emotional, "born-again" experience as proof of salvation. Some holiness movements add sinless perfection or strict moral codes. Seventh-day Adventists insist on Sabbath observance. Messianic groups adhere to dietary

laws. Mennonites proclaim that head covering is required for salvation. Others demand adherence to a specific creation-narrative framework or the rejection of modern science altogether. Still others hinge salvation on allegiance to a particular saint, movement, Bible translation, or end-times chart—each confident that their gate is the narrow one, and that God has entrusted its key to them.

In all these cases, grace arrives only *after* you intellectually agree to a denomination's preferred theological framework. Salvation becomes conditional—not upon God's love or Christ's work, but upon the correct doctrinal password.

And from there, it often ceases to be a path of life and instead becomes a doctrine to debate—essentially a fear-based religion.

Regrettably, much of today's Western Christianity is haunted by this legacy. Immortal life is imagined as a reward for mental agreement with the "right" doctrinal formulas—a cosmic "escape room" challenge where only the intellectually correct avoid fiery punishment while most others burn forever. But for Jesus and his contemporaries, *faith* was not an intellectual answer to a theological exam for the sake of escapism; faith was a way of living, loving, and being present to God in every moment.

And so we are left with a quiet but unavoidable contrast: the faith that began around a charcoal fire in Galilee —Jewish, relational, embodied, and restorative—versus the religion that later arose in the halls of empire, abstracted, systematized, and severed from its roots. One asked only, *"Do you love me?"* The other learned

to ask, *"Do you agree?"* To recover the gospel, then, is not to invent something new, but to return—to the Shepherd's voice before it was filtered through power, philosophy, and fear.

Chapter 8

Life from the Dead

I'd like to wrap up the first part of the book with Zechariah's vision from chapter 14.

Why do you believe the Lord descends to the Mount of Olives in Zechariah's vision? Because from ancient times (at least as early as the 8th century BC) to this very day, the Mount of Olives has been a symbol of death.[46] It was—and still is—one of the most significant burial sites in the Land of Israel. In the worldview of a person living in biblical times, saying "Mount of Olives" was essentially like saying "the cemetery." This was

the place where the dead were laid to rest. It symbolized the threshold between the realm of the living and the dead.

There were no cemeteries in Los Angeles, Paris, or Sydney in antiquity. For the people of ancient Israel, the Mount of Olives served as a central and visible gateway to *Sheol*—the underworld of the dead. Zechariah's prophetic expectation that *"his feet will stand on the Mount of Olives, east of Jerusalem, and the Mount of Olives will be split in two"* (Zechariah 14:4) made perfect sense within Israel's geographic, cultural, and spiritual imagination: The graveyard would open wide and release the deceased—resurrection of the dead. This was Israel's hope and the mission Christ will fulfill upon His return.

The apostles proclaimed the same coherent story—a gospel not of terror, but of life. They announced that in Jesus, God had forgiven sin and defeated death. And death, in Scripture, is not merely biological; it fractures relationships, corrodes societies, and deforms the world itself. In Christ, God broke into history to heal what was broken—to restore persons, renew communities, and redeem creation.

The call to repent was never a threat. It was an invitation: to turn from destructive paths and step into God's life-giving work, His mission of *Tikkun Olam*—the restoration of His creation.

Restoring Individuals

Want to live a meaningful life? Want to see justice win, peace replace violence, and love shatter the chains of hate? Then the Gospel isn't just an optional path—it's *the* way. Jesus didn't call people to escape the world, but to redeem it through Him. The Gospel offers the power to subdue chaos, to live in right relationship with God and others, and to help build the kind of world we were created for—a world where love, truth, and justice reign. This was the apostolic message: that Christ's resurrection inaugurated a new creation, and those who follow Him become agents of that divine renewal and heavenly rewards.

Fear of Eternal Conscious Torment was never the engine of evangelism. Hope, renewal, and restoration were. The question is: will we take the path that leads to life and blessing, or will we keep repeating the same cycles of self-inflicted destruction?

Renewing Communities

While often interpreted through an individualistic perspective today, the Scriptures are fundamentally communal in nature. Every individual is viewed as part of a larger whole. Salvation isn't just about living again or changing your life alone; it's about transforming society as a whole.

While you are no longer doomed to remain under the curse of death—it is still up to us, not only as individuals but ultimately as entire societies, to decide how we live now. Historically, some societies chose to follow the way of Christ; many others did not, and the fruit of those choices is evident all around us.

Listen carefully to Acts 26:18:

> *I [Jesus] am sending you to them to open their eyes, so that they may turn from darkness to light and from the power of Satan to God, that they may receive forgiveness of sins and a place among those who are sanctified by faith in me.*

(Acts 26:18)

The Gospel is not merely about securing life after death; it is about transforming the world now. It is the spiritual conquest of darkness by light, of chaos by wholeness, of destruction by healing. It transfers individuals and societies into a new way of life—one marked by freedom, restoration, and the life God always intended.

The Gospel empowers people to live rightly today, and when whole communities begin to embody God's peace, mercy, and justice—when societies themselves join His kingdom and are reshaped by His love—we move toward the fulfillment of *Tikkun Olam*: the restoration of the world.

Conclusion

Let us summarize the first part of the book.

In the first centuries, the Jewish apostles consistently proclaimed victory over death and the resurrection as the decisive turning point in history. They declared Christ to be the fulfillment of the biblical story—found in

the Hebrew Scriptures, the Law and the Prophets—and invited all people to participate, not as an escape from afterlife torment in hellfire, but in transformation, forgiveness, reconciliation, and empowerment to share in the inauguration of His kingdom on earth: a kingdom marked by justice, peace, and the renewal of all things.

Every act of love, every word of truth, every glimpse of hope matters.

The Gospel isn't about escaping from a broken world.

It's about redeeming it—through the life of Christ flowing through us.

So, perhaps a clearer way to understand Romans 1:16 would be something like this:

> For I am not ashamed to live according to the way of Christ, for this way is the power of God to change and reform, to grow and restore, to heal and rescue, to save and renew all who trust it and walk in it—it is first relevant to the Jew, and also to the Gentile.
>
> (Romans 1:16, Eitan's paraphrase)

As we head into the next part of the book, make sure your time machine is working. Buckle up and fire up the ignition—it's time for another trip through history, this time to the fascinating world of ancient Israel!

Part II: #Blood #Atonement #Sacrifice

Introduction: Life is in the Blood

My grandmother survived the Holocaust and came to Israel from Transylvania, so whenever my mom goes heavy on the garlic in her cooking, the Dracula jokes inevitably start—an ongoing tradition in my Jewish mother's kitchen.

If you've never heard of the Western tale of Dracula, then let me tell you a tale about the windswept peaks and shadowed valleys of Transylvania, a story unlike any you've ever heard…

Once, in the deep forests of Transylvania, they whispered of a man who could not die.

He walked in shadows, cloaked in centuries of hunger. His name echoed through castles and candlelit tales: *Dracula*. The legend said he thirsted for blood—not for its taste, but for its power. For in the crimson current of life, he found the illusion of eternity.

He did not give. He took.

To live, he had to drain others. Night after night, victim after victim, he pressed his teeth to the necks of the innocent and drew *life* into his death-cursed body. His immortality was built on the sacrifice of strangers. The more blood he drank, the more he lived. The more he lived, the more he had to feed.

His curse was not just that he consumed blood—it was that he needed to. Desperately. Endlessly. Forever.

His life depended on blood.

And yet—behind the old myth, beneath the superstitions and garlic-laced jokes of grandmothers in Eastern Europe—there was a strange and hidden truth:

Life is in the blood.

Even the darkest fables know this. They know that blood is sacred. That to take it is to take something holy. That whoever controls blood, controls life itself.

But What if the Story Were Told in Reverse?

What if there was another Immortal—One who came from the east and beyond time, not cloaked in shadow, but clothed in light? (Psalm 104:2)

What if, instead of craving blood to live, He gave His blood so that others might live? (Romans 3:25)

What if He, too, stretched out His arms—not to seize a victim, but to embrace the whole world? (John 3:17)

What if He, too, hungered—but not for life to consume, rather for death to defeat? (Hebrews 2:14)

What if His blood, rather than being stolen drop by drop, was poured out willingly, cup overflowing, not to curse, but to cleanse? (Matthew 26:28)

This One, too, walked among mortals.

But He did not hide from the sun. He was the Sun.

He did not lurk in tombs. He emptied them.

He did not drain others to live. He let Himself be drained, so that life eternal might flow into the veins of the dying.

His blood—unlike Dracula's victims'—never runs dry. It's not weak but eternal.

His life is not prolonged by theft.

It is offered freely, joyfully, abundantly.

Where Dracula leaves bodies pale and breathless, this One breathes life into dry bones.

Where Dracula fears the cross, this One hung upon it—not as victim, but as Victor.

And so the Gospel is not about horror, but hope.

Not about a bloodthirsty god demanding death, but a life-giving God defeating it.

You are about to step into a story deeper than myth and older than legend.

A story of altars and lifeblood, of breath and dust, of temples and transfusions.

It's a story where blood doesn't signal vengeance, but life.

Where sacrifice is not punishment, but a gift.

Where atonement is not transaction, but transformation.

This is the story of a Messiah, whose blood speaks a better word.

This is the story of life conquering death.

If Jesus is the Christ who gives life, Dracula embodies the anti-Christ, seeking to drain and destroy it.

God is not like a vampire—He does not need blood to be satisfied or a victim to calm His nerves. God is like Jesus: not taking life to soothe Himself but giving His life so that others may live.

Dracula hides in the shadows; Jesus is the Light of the World.

Dracula feeds on death; Jesus conquered death.

Maybe that's why vampires fear the cross.

So, in my family's playful whispers about garlic and fangs, there's a hidden theology waiting to be named:

There is one who craved blood because he lacked life. And One who gave blood because He is life.

Let the legend of Dracula serve as a dark mirror—a reflection of flawed theology and a shadow of the antichrist.

And let Jesus shine as the radiant reversal.

The true Lord of Blood is not a monster. He is the Messiah. And His blood doesn't haunt. It heals.

Chapter 9

Blood in a World of Violence—Reclaiming a Sacred Symbol

We live in a world where the sight of blood rarely brings comfort. In fact, it's usually the opposite. News broadcasts spill it across our screens in stories of war and terrorism. Video games glorify it. Movies drench it across battlefields, back alleys, and broken bodies. Blood, in modern consciousness, is almost exclusively the currency of violence. It signals evil, danger, trauma, war. It is something to be wiped away, disinfected, hidden behind sterile gloves and hospital curtains.

But the Bible tells a different story.

In the Law given to Israel, blood isn't seen as horror but as life. It's not a symbol of terror, but of purification. It's not a mark of ruin, but of redemption. In ancient Israel, blood was not treated as a grotesque byproduct of suffering, but as the sacred element in the architecture of spiritual life. Blood was not a mark of violence but a medium of healing. It sanctified, purified, cleansed, and restored. More than anything, *blood meant life*.

That may sound foreign to modern ears, trained by centuries of secular thought to see religion through a forensic, even cynical, lens. But to step into the world of the Bible is to walk into a place where every drop of blood pulses with divine meaning. Leviticus 17:11 declares with bold, ancient clarity:

> *For the **life** of a creature is in the **blood**, and I have given it to you to make atonement for yourselves on the altar; it is the **blood** that makes atonement for one's **life**.*
>
> (Leviticus 17:11)

Here, blood is not a symbol of judgment—it is a vessel of grace. It is not the sign of God's anger, but the conduit of His mercy.

Blood was not understood to be the object of wrath, but a divine, "magical" potion that sterilizes the space so that a holy God can dwell among fragile people living in the shadows of sin and mortality.

We must learn to see blood as the ancient Hebrews saw it: not with fear or disgust, but with awe. It was never meant to stir up images of gore and torture. It was always meant to stir the soul toward wonder.

Reclaiming the Meaning of Blood

Blood, in biblical thought, is the tangible expression of life's most sacred energy—the divine breath made visible. It is life distilled into red. It is the story of a God who meets us in our mortality and offers a path not just through death, but beyond it.

To reclaim the meaning of blood is to recover a truth our modern world has forgotten: life is sacred, and life comes from God. And wherever God gives life, He also provides a way for that life to be restored, even after it has been fractured by sin, shame, or death.

In a pagan world obsessed with death, the Bible's use of blood was—and still is—a quiet rebellion. It does not glorify bloodshed; it glorifies the life within the blood. The life God breathed into Adam. The life poured out for Israel at the altar. The life offered to the world through the Messiah.

Before we can understand the cross, before we can grasp atonement, we must first purify our vision. We must allow Scripture to reframe our symbols. Only then can we truly grasp what the Gospel—and the reason Christ died—is all about.

"For the Life of the Flesh is in the Blood"—Leviticus 17:11 and the Heart of Atonement

The beating heart of the Hebrew Scriptures is not found in regulations or laws, but in a single, sacred truth whispered into the fabric of Israel's worship: life belongs to God—and that life, that pulse, that holy vitality, is found in the blood.

Leviticus 17:11 is not merely a law; it is a theological key. A portal. A holy lens through which the entire system of sacrifice, and later the meaning of Christ's death, can be rightly seen: *"it is the blood that makes atonement for one's life."* (Leviticus 17:11b).

Notice the careful wording: it is not *death* that makes atonement. It is the *blood*. And what is in the blood? ***Life***.

In other words, it is a somewhat mystic symbol of how life is transfused to redeem that of others.

Leviticus 17 does not speak of vengeance. It speaks of a gift. *"I have given it to you,"* God says—language not of retribution but of provision. God does not demand blood in anger. He provides it in compassion.

In the ancient world, many nations believed that their gods needed appeasement—pain, fear, death, even torture were sometimes required to bend the divine will.[47] But Israel's God was different. He was not a tyrant demanding satisfaction. He was a Father longing for restoration. His provision of blood was not to satisfy His own wrath but to heal the rupture between life and death, heaven and earth.

This is why blood is the agent of atonement. The Hebrew word for "atonement," *kippur*, carries not the sense of wrath but of covering, cleansing, restoration, and reconciliation.

If sin equals death, how can you take it away? How can you hide it and wash it clean? What reconciles us to God is not the suffering or death of an animal, but its life—its blood, its vitality, its sacred energy poured out for

the sake of another. It's the spiritual logic behind Jesus' famous statement: *"Greater love has no one than this: to lay down one's life for one's friends."* (John 15:13).

In this way, the altar becomes the meeting place between two worlds: death and life. Sin, which leads to death, is answered not by more death, but by a deeper life—life willing to be poured out in love. *Atonement*, then, is not about punishment or torture, as it's often portrayed in Western theology; it's about reunion.[48] It's about a space being cleansed or a torn relationship being stitched back together, not through violent punishment, but through the offering of life itself.

To the modern mind, this may sound mystical, even irrational. But in the ancient Hebrew imagination, it made perfect sense. Just as blood flows to every part of the body, bringing oxygen and vitality, so too did the sacrificial blood symbolically carry life into the center of Israel's spiritual body—into the very heart of the Tabernacle, into the Holy of Holies, into the soul of the nation. A divine transfusion.

Conclusion

Before we speak of crosses and thorns, we must sit before the altar in Leviticus and hear God say it clearly: *"I*

have given you the blood…because the life is in the blood."

Leviticus 17:11 is the axis upon which the whole system of sacrifice turns. Without it, the rituals become strange and archaic. With it, they pulse with divine logic. The blood is not brutality. It is the most tangible form of *life* the ancients had. And God, in His mercy, allowed that sacred symbol of life to stand in the gap between heaven and humanity.

From this foundation, everything else begins to make sense—not only the sacrifices of bulls and goats, but ultimately the offering of Jesus, the Messiah, whose blood—whose life—was poured out not to appease wrath, but to defeat death by the transfusion of life eternal.

Chapter 10

Understanding Biblical Offerings

One of the most harmful theological misunderstandings is thinking that *offerings* under the Mosaic Law were meant to appease divine wrath. In reality, there were *many* kinds of offerings—not one—and the vast majority had nothing to do with sin at all. Even the two that did—*Asham* (guilt) and *Hata'at* (purification or sin)—had nothing to do with wrath.

Most offerings were expressions of worship, gratitude, covenant loyalty, fellowship, and devotion. Only a small subset dealt specifically with sin or purification.

The offerings in the sacrificial system described in Leviticus include:

Burnt Offerings (Leviticus 1) – Voluntary acts of worship, expressing complete devotion and surrender.

Grain Offerings (Leviticus 2) – Non-bloody offerings of thanksgiving and recognition of God's provision.

Peace Offerings (Leviticus 3) – Shared meals between God, priest, and worshiper; symbols of restored fellowship.

Purification Offerings (Leviticus 4–5) – Addressing ritual impurity or inadvertent sins.

Reparation Offerings (Leviticus 5:14–6:7) – Acts of compensation when restitution was needed.

Of these, only two sub-categories (*Asham* and *Hata'at*) relate to moral or ritual fault. The rest are about communion, celebration, and gratitude. Sacrifice was more of a banquet than a bloodletting. And this tells us something crucial: in the Bible, the primary purpose of the offerings was relational, not retributive.

Even before the Law was given, there are early examples of such offerings, including the story of Cain and Abel. Abel's gift appears to be a burnt or peace offering of the highest quality (Genesis 4:4), while Cain's gift resembles a grain offering but lacks the Levitical emphasis on *quality*, which led to its rejection.

Those who reduce the entire system to *sin-punishment* mechanics are not only making a grave theological error—they are also dehumanizing Israel's worship.

The sacrificial system was never meant to substitute righteousness or justice. It was meant to accompany it. It was a tool for sacred order, not a loophole in moral obligation. The *God who desires mercy, not sacrifice* (Hosea 6:6), is the same God who instituted both.

Jesus Himself echoes this when He quotes Hosea and says to the Pharisees: *"Go and learn what this means: 'I desire mercy, not sacrifice'"* (Matthew 9:13). He is not abolishing the entire sacrificial vision—He is re-centering it. Mercy is the goal, not wrath. Life, not death, is the center. God desires a people shaped not by fear and shame but by grace and compassion.

Communal Atonement

When New Testament authors speak of Jesus in sacrificial terms, they do so against this background. Jesus is not offered as a penal substitute absorbing wrath. No. It's about His blood being poured out. He is the final purifier, the healer of the sanctuary, the One whose blood—not as punishment, but as holy life—cleanses the world and welcomes God's dwelling.

Hebrews speaks of Jesus entering the true heavenly sanctuary, not to suffer punishment, but to present His own blood as the final cleansing that restores communion between God and humanity (Hebrews 9:12–14). John wrote, *"The blood of Jesus... **purifies** us from all sin"* (1 John 1:7)—not that it satisfies wrath, but that it cleanses and purifies.

And Jesus, as the Lamb of God, does not abolish this system—He fulfills it by becoming the one who cleanses not just a temple, but universally atones for the whole of creation.

The Essence of Israel's Sacrificial System: Life, Cleansing, and Covenant Renewal

For ancient Israel, sacrifice was not merely a ritual—it was a language. It was the grammar of reconciliation, the poetry of devotion, and the architecture of communion.

The sacrificial system, as outlined in the Torah and especially the book of Leviticus, was multifaceted, symbolic, and liturgically rich. It was not a monolithic practice aimed solely at "dealing with sin," nor was it ever intended to function as a violent appeasement of divine wrath. Instead, the sacrifices formed the sacred

rhythm by which Israel realigned herself with God's presence and purposes. They were acts of gratitude, purification, covenant renewal, communal wholeness, and spiritual restoration.

Every sacrifice invited the worshiper to draw near—to approach God—with humility and reverence. Whether through burnt offerings, peace offerings, grain offerings, or purification rites, Israel's liturgical life pulsed with a single desire: to make space for the holy in the midst of human fragility.

The rich variety of sacrifices described in the Torah (the Pentateuch) reveals a far more beautiful and relational pattern—a way for humanity to draw near to God in gratitude, worship, restoration, and communion. Each category of sacrifice served a different purpose, and remarkably, each finds its ultimate fulfillment in the life, death, and ongoing ministry of Jesus.

Survey of Israel's Offerings

The **Peace Offering** (*Zevach Shelamim*) was about fellowship. It was a shared meal between God, the priest, and the worshiper—a symbol of restored relationship and joyful communion. In Jesus, this offering comes to life most vividly at the Last Supper and through the ongoing practice of the Lord's Table, where believers are

supposed to symbolically eat a meal and drink wine in fellowship with Christ, a feast (rather than a tiny piece of dry wafer and grape juice) joyfully celebrating reconciliation and peace through Him (as opposed to the often dull, quiet, and somber atmosphere commonly experienced when this practice is observed in most churches today).

The **Gift Offering** (*Minchah*)—typically grain, oil, or incense—was an expression of gratitude, devotion, and generosity. It acknowledged God as the provider of life's blessings. In Christ, we see this heart of gratitude embodied. His life was a constant offering of thanksgiving to the Father (John 17:4), and through Him, believers are called to offer not just gifts of grain but the very gift of their lives as a *"living sacrifice"* (Romans 12:1) pleasing to God. Living sacrifice isn't about itself, but about consistently choosing to love others.

The **Burnt Offering** (*Olah*) symbolized total surrender. The entire animal was consumed on the altar, representing complete dedication to God. Jesus fulfills this in the most profound way—giving not just part of Himself, but His whole life, holding nothing back, fully surrendered to the will of the Father even unto death on a cross (Philippians 2:8). In Him, we see the perfect *Olah*—a life wholly offered in service of others and for God's glory.

The **Purification or Sin Offering** (*Hata'at*) was not primarily about punishment but about cleansing impurity —removing from the altar anything that would defile God's dwelling among His people. Jesus fulfills this as the

one whose blood purifies *us*—the new temple—from all sin (1 John 1:7), not because God needed violence, but because humanity needed His blood to cleanse and purify, enabling us to dwell again in God's presence.

Finally, the **Guilt Offering** (*Asham*) dealt with reparations—restoring what was lost or broken, often accompanied by restitution to the offended party. Isaiah calls Messiah *asham* (Isaiah 53:10). In Christ, this finds fulfillment as He not only forgives sin but restores what sin has damaged—reconciling humanity to God and healing the wounds of a fractured creation. Christ's eternal blood, unknowingly offered by humanity and accepted by God, symbolizes the *Asham*.

Each offering in the Old Testament was a shadow—a symbol pointing forward. In Jesus, they are not discarded but fulfilled, elevated, and perfected. The cross is not only about covering sin—it is about peace, thanksgiving, surrender, cleansing, and restoration. In Christ, every category of sacrifice finds its true and final meaning—not in violence for violence's sake, but in life literally poured out to bring humanity home.

Now, let's examine the last two kinds of offerings in greater detail.

Purification or Sin Offering (*hata'at*)

Depending on the English Bible translation, the Hebrew word *Hata'at* may be rendered as "Sin Offering" in

some cases and "Purification Offering" in others. This can be misleading. Linguistically, *Hata'at* may derive from *het* (sin) or *hite* (to cleanse, purify). Many Christian commentators and Jewish scholars often prefer the translation "Purification Offering" because the primary focus of the *Hata'at* ritual was about purifying space—the sanctuary, the altar, and the people.

Even when a personal sin was involved, the focus of the *Hata'at* offering was not on the worshiper's guilt but on the impurity caused by sin's consequences. That impurity was seen as contaminating the sacred dwelling of God among His people. In other words, sin left behind a residue—a spiritual defilement that needed to be cleansed, not punished.

What purified that defilement? Not the death of the animal. Not the pain or the loss. It was the blood—life's sacred symbol—that was applied like holy antiseptic to the altar, veil, and sanctuary furniture (Leviticus 4:6; 4:7; 4:17–18; 4:25; 4:30; 4:34; 8:15; etc.). The blood made the space clean again. Only then could the divine presence continue to dwell in the midst of Israel.

This point becomes beautifully clear in Leviticus 14, during the ritual for cleansing a *metsora* (a person with a skin disease). Once healed, the individual was to be reintroduced into the camp only after a ritual that included the *Hata'at*. Here, moral sin is not the issue at all—there is no moral guilt. And yet, a sin offering is made. Why? Because the offering is not about moral fault—it is about removing symbolic death and restoring one to communal life and divine proximity.

Thus, the *Hata'at* does not speak of condemnation, but reunion. It is not an act of divine vengeance, but divine hospitality. Blood is not spilled to satisfy anger—it is life offered to cleanse what sin had darkened.

In the Bible, sin against God was seen as a relational issue, not a transactional one, unlike how it's often viewed in Western thought. When Scripture speaks of sin against God, such as in Genesis 39:9, Psalm 51:4, and 1 John 1:9, it points not to a violation of a legal system, but to a wound in covenantal intimacy. When David confesses, *"Against You, You only, have I sinned"* (Psalm 51:4), he is not denying the harm he did to Bathsheba and Uriah. Rather, he is overwhelmed by the personal rupture between himself and God. Since the Hebrew and Greek words for sin (*chata* and *hamartia*) both literally mean "missing the mark," this indicates distortion of trust within a covenant relationship, not a legal violation of an abstract law. Sin fractures shalom—peace and wholeness—damaging our relationship with God, ourselves, others, and creation.

Paul ascribes the *Hata'at* to Jesus:

> *He made the One who knew no sin to become a sin offering* [hamartia—same word used in LXX for Hata'at] *on our behalf...*
>
> (2 Corinthians 5:21)

The blood of the *Hata'at* washes away sin:

> *They have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb.*
>
> (Revelation 7:14)

The blood of Jesus, like the blood of the *Hata'at*, cleanses and purifies. It does not appease divine wrath, but it cleans stains like a detergent. It restores the soul and cleanses the sanctuary of the human heart. It does not absorb punishment—it removes the distance.

Guilt Offering (*asham*)

The second sacrifice associated with sin is the *Asham*, often translated "Guilt Offering." But this offering, too, is often misunderstood when viewed through a modern Western lens. It was not an act of retribution or substitution—it was a ritual of restitution.

The *Asham* was required when someone had wronged another person or unintentionally violated something sacred. It addressed not just the spiritual aspect of sin, but the social and economic implications. If a person cheated another, or mishandled something dedicated to God, the *Asham* offering was required—but so was repayment and often an additional twenty percent (Leviticus 5:14–6:7).

The emphasis was not on pain or death—it was on *restoration*.

Sin here was not a cosmic crime demanding bloodshed, but a breach of trust, a fracture in covenant fidelity. And the appropriate response was not suffering, but reconciliation. The Asham restored what had been taken. It mended what had been torn. This reveals something profound: atonement in Israel was relational, not transactional.

Isaiah 53 is a known prophecy about the Messiah dying for our sins (also quoted in the New Testament pointing to Jesus). Verse 10 uses *Asham* to describe Messiah's atonement: *"...his soul makes an offering for guilt (Asham)..."*.

Just as the guilty party in Israel brought forward their offering, the New Testament presents Jesus as the world's *asham*, the One through whom humanity is reconciled with God—not by absorbing divine fury, but by embodying divine mercy. As Paul writes:

God was in Christ reconciling the world to Himself, not counting their sins against them.

(2 Corinthians 5:19)

This is the Asham logic fulfilled—not punishment, but peace-making. Not abuse, but restitution. Not Christ reconciling God's anger, but Christ reconciling a chaotic world to God.

Notice that none of Israel's sacrifices were taken by God's hand—they were always offered by us. In the same way, it was us—sinners—who ended Jesus' life, and God who raised Him. This is exactly what the New Testament writers affirmed (Acts 2:23-24, 3:15. 4:10, 5:30).

Jesus: The One Who Cleanses, Restores, and Reunites

Just as ancient Israel offered animals in sacred rites of purification and restoration, the New Testament presents Jesus not as a condemned substitute absorbing wrath in our place, but as the one who gives His life to

cleanse the world, reconcile the broken, and restore the human temple.

He is the Lamb, but not the lamb upon whom God's rage is poured out. He is the Lamb whose life is poured out, so that death might be undone. He is the priest and the offering—not to placate the Father, but to bring humanity back into the presence of the Father.

His blood purifies/cleanses/sanitizes the altar of sin. His offering mends what was fractured.

This is why the New Testament writers speak of His blood, not His torment or punishment, as the agent of atonement. *"We have redemption through His **blood**"* (Ephesians 1:7). *"We are justified by His **blood**"* (Romans 5:9). *"The **blood** of Jesus… purifies us from all sin"* (1 John 1:7).

It's not His death that saves us, but His blood. The focus isn't on appeasement through death and violence—as in Anselm's and Calvin's atonement models—but rather on His blood cleansing, restoring, and giving us life.

Conclusion: Blood—Not Death—Atones

When we step back and behold the offerings through Hebrew eyes, the picture becomes clear: the offerings were never about abuse, wrath, or violence. They were about restoring what had been lost—the presence of

God in the midst of His people.

The whole system aimed not at satisfying divine anger but at preserving divine intimacy.

In the same way, Jesus' death wasn't some act of cosmic child abuse. It was the moment when human wickedness was laid bare, where the world's cruel, evil, and vengeful justice met God's forgiving and restorative justice, making God's presence available to everyone, and where blood—life itself—was poured out to cleanse the world from its downward spiral toward death.

Blood atones, not because God demands death, but because blood is the vehicle of life. Death was the costly and tragic means through which the blood could be provided. But as Christ demonstrated, even death is only temporary.

And so, the cross does not stand as a monument to divine rage, but as a testament to divine love—a love that purifies, heals, reconciles, and restores the world.

Chapter 11

Understanding Biblical Sacrifice

Like the biblical offerings, *sacrifice* is also one of the most misunderstood concepts in both religious and secular discourse. To many, it conjures up images of grim altars, primitive violence, virgins thrown into the fire, and pagan gods who thirst for blood. But in the Hebrew Scriptures, sacrifice is not about death—it is about offering life. It is the mysterious place where life and death meet—not as enemies, but as participants in a deeper, sacred drama.

When a worshiper in ancient Israel brought an animal to the altar, they were not simply killing it. They were offering something precious: a life. A creature—often an animal loved and known by name—that breathed, moved, and had blood flowing through it. The sacrificial act acknowledged a painful truth—we live in a world where death is inescapable, but through life, death can be overcome.

To sacrifice to someone simply means to give them a gift—to offer something freely, not to appease their anger or satisfy a violent demand.

To give someone *blood* was—and still is—to gift someone with *life*. And since life belongs to God, every offering was a return. *"All souls are Mine,"* says the Lord (Ezekiel 18:4). Sacrifice was not a transaction but a restoration.

The act of shedding blood was not divine punishment as to appease God—it was a precious gift. It was not retribution, but representation. Not wrath, but reunion.

The Divine Logic of Sacrifice—Where Life Met Death

There is a profound logic here—one that reaches beyond religion and into the rhythms of creation itself.

Nothing lives without something else dying. Whether we eat fish, beef, grain, or harvest fruit, we are living because something else has died. Animals eat one another not out of cruelty, but to survive. Even plants—life pulled from the soil—are consumed in order to sustain us and the animals. There is no life without death.

This truth is hard-wired into the created order: life begets life, and life requires life.

The sacrificial system made this visible, tangible, and sacred. It invited the Israelites to face the value of life and the consequence of sin without being crushed by guilt or fear. Instead, they were drawn into the mystery of grace. The blood of the animal symbolically cleansed sin, while the animal's death symbolically carried the sinner's guilt into the realm of death. The animal had given the worshiper the gift of life.

This is why sacrifices were offered on an altar—the place where heaven and earth touch. It was a threshold, a seam in the fabric of existence, where mortality and eternity embraced. And on that altar, blood was poured out not as evidence of divine cruelty, but as a holy gift. A reminder that even in the presence of death, life still has the last word.

Jesus in Light of Leviticus

Jesus' crucifixion must be re-read through this lens. He did not simply die—He offered His life. His blood, like the blood of the ancient sacrifices, became the meeting point between human sin and divine mercy. The cross was not merely a place of execution; it was an altar. And on that altar, the life that flowed from Jesus' veins was not a symbol of defeat, but of the victory of eternal life.

As we now turn to explore how science echoes this biblical truth, we carry this image with us: sacrifice is not violent death demanded by God. It is the gift of life offered. The place where mortality is swallowed up by something far more powerful: life that gives itself freely.

Scientific and Spiritual Echoes—Blood as the Giver of Life

Ancient Israel did not have microscopes or biology textbooks. Yet in their liturgies, their sacrifices, and their Scriptures, they intuitively grasped a truth that modern science now confirms: *life is in the blood*.

Today, we understand in precise medical terms what Leviticus 17:11 proclaimed millennia ago. Blood circulates oxygen. It delivers nutrients. It removes waste. It fights germs. It transports hormones. It guards against infection. It keeps our body temperature in balance. It is the internal river that keeps us alive every moment of every day. You can survive without certain organs, but not without blood. Strip away all the poetry and ritual, and the science remains: the life of the flesh is in the blood.

This is why we donate blood—not as a religious ritual to appease the wrath of an angry deity, but as an act of gifting that saves lives, because life is literally in the blood. When someone suffers trauma or undergoes surgery, their survival often depends on the blood of another. And we call it what it is: a transfusion, a gift, a life-saving donation. And there's another beautiful symbolism here—on the other side of the transfusion, they don't earn or buy the gift of life; it's simply given to them.

When we donate blood, we are not merely engaging in a modern medical act; we are unwitting participants in an ancient truth: blood is not merely a symbol of life. It *is* life itself.

When Jesus stood before a Jewish audience and said, *"Whoever drinks my blood has eternal life"* (John 6:54), it scandalized them—not because they misunderstood the symbolism, but because they understood it too well. Drinking blood, especially human blood, was forbidden by Torah (Leviticus 17:10). But Jesus was pointing not to the breaking of the Law, but to the fulfilling of a mystery. He was saying: "My blood is eternal, immortal life."

In this strange and holy claim, Jesus declared Himself the fulfillment of everything Leviticus could only hint at. His blood wasn't just symbolic—it was substantial. It wasn't just ritual—it was reality. He wasn't offering a sacrifice like the ones made at the Temple. He was the Temple, and the Priest, and the Sacrifice, all in one.

And He did not give a drop—He gave all. Poured out, not into sterile tubes, but onto wood and thorns and dirt. His eternal life coursed out of Him so that immortal life could be coursed into us.

This is not mythology. This is spiritual biology. Divine science. A sacred logic that pulses through the veins of both Testaments and into our very bodies: life must be given in order for life to be received.

In a world now filled with clinical language and antiseptic spirituality, we must not forget the raw, red truth at the center of the gospel. Jesus bled not to satisfy wrath, but to transmit life. His blood is not a symbol of divine rage, but the stream of divine life for us to drink from.

Purification, Sanctification, and the Ritual Power of Blood

To modern ears, the words "purify" and "sanctify" can sound abstract, even sterile. But in the Hebrew Scriptures, these were not cold theological terms—they described sacred processes of transformation, meant to bring a person, place, or object into proper standing before the living God.

In Hebrew, to purify (*taher*) means to cleanse something (e.g., a vessel) that has been contaminated—by death, decay, sin, or disorder. To sanctify (*qadash*) means to set something apart (e.g., a holy day), to make it holy, to dedicate it for divine use. And at the heart of both these acts—was blood.

But why blood?

Because blood was life. And only life could cleanse what death had touched.

This is the fundamental logic behind the entire Levitical system. The Israelites lived in a world saturated with reminders of mortality: disease, infertility, ritual impurity, physical deformities, corpses. These were not moral failings—they were signs that death had entered the camp.

And death, in biblical thought, was not merely a biological event. It was a spiritual force, a pollutant, a rupture in the divine order—the curse of Eden. Anything touched by death was considered unclean—not because it was morally evil, but because death carried the mark of what is the opposite of God, who is life—pure, unfiltered Life.

The Sacrifice Contained the Potion of Life

So how does one undo death's defilement? Not through punishment. Not through abuse. Not through shame. But through overcoming death with life—atonement.

That's why God gave Israel blood—not to frighten them, but to clean them. The blood of the sacrifice—*its life*—acted as a spiritual solvent, a divine bleach. Blood touched what was unclean and made it pure. Not because of a chemical effect, but because of what it stood for: a life offered to reverse the power of death by purifying it.

We see this principle again and again—purifying and cleansing with blood:

*Moses took the blood… and **purified** the altar.*

(Leviticus 8:15)

*You shall **purify** the altar… and anoint it to consecrate it.*

(Exodus 29:36)

*He shall sprinkle some of the blood… to **cleanse** it and consecrate it from the uncleanness of the Israelites.*

(Leviticus 16:18–19)

The blood did not make an angry God less angry. It made the space holy. It didn't remove moral guilt—it removed death's residue. It washed the soul. It re-opened the cosmic door to divine fellowship.

Likewise, Jesus' blood does not simply cover our sins like a rug hiding the dirt. It cleanses the stain. It sanctifies us, not just in theory, but in reality—transforming hearts, restoring consciences, and making even the most broken soul a sanctuary for the Spirit of God.

This is why the New Testament echoes the language of purification and sanctification by blood so often:

> *The **blood** of Jesus, His Son, **purifies** us from all sin.*
>
> (1 John 1:7)

> *...to make the people **holy** through His own **blood**.*
>
> (Hebrews 13:12)

> *...by His **blood**, He **cleanses** our consciences from dead works to serve the living God.*
>
> (Hebrews 9:14)

Conclusion

In ancient Israel, blood was poured on altars, sprinkled on priests' garments, and dashed upon the mercy seat. In Jesus, the blood is poured upon the human heart—not to mark us for death, but to mark us for life.

Blood was not regarded as disgusting or grotesque. It was understood as spiritual antiseptic—divine bleach—cleansing, consecrating, and restoring what had been defiled.

And so, we begin to see: blood was not the language of divine rage, but of divine welcome. It was God's way of saying, "Come closer. Be cleansed. Become pure. Become holy. Be mine."

Chapter 12

Understanding Biblical Atonement

Some Western models of atonement—such as *Satisfaction* theory (Anselm, 10th century) and *Penal Substitution* (Calvin, 16th century)—import foreign languages and categories of punishment, divine wrath, and legal transaction. By contrast, the Hebrew Scriptures portray atonement as something far more relational and restorative, woven deeply into the fabric of communal life in ways many have forgotten or never been taught.

Three Hebrew Terms that Shape Biblical Atonement

In Hebrew, three key words shape the Bible's vision of atonement:

GA'AL—to redeem, often in the context of family obligation, the kinsman-redeemer who steps in to rescue a relative from slavery, debt, or danger.

PADAH — to liberate or ransom, emphasizing freedom from oppression or captivity.

KAPHAR — to atone, to cover, to cleanse, to purify, or to remove.

While English translations often flatten these words into the same term—"redeem" or "atonement"—each Hebrew word carries a distinct flavor and context. The Hebrew imagination was rich with layered meanings, and these words offer us windows into God's redeeming heart.

GA'AL: The Family Rescuer

The Hebrew word *ga'al* evokes the image of the *go'el*—the kinsman-redeemer, the family protector. For instance, God "redeemed" Israel from slavery in Egypt by demonstrating His power and love (Exodus 6:6). The redeemer figure had the sacred duty to rescue a relative from slavery (Leviticus 25:47-49), to restore lost land (Leviticus 25:25), or even to execute a murderer (Numbers 35:19). Redemption here is deeply relational. It is not abstract or legal; it is about protection, loyalty, responsibility, and family love. It is about saying, "You belong to me, and I will care for you and protect you."

PADAH: The Liberator

Padah speaks of liberation from oppression. This word reminds us that redemption is about freedom, rescue, and deliverance. It is about breaking chains. In Deuteronomy 7:8, for instance, God *"redeemed (padah) you*

[Israel] from the house of slavery, from the hand of Pharaoh."

KAPHAR: The Purifier

Most relevant to our conversation about atonement is the verb *kaphar*, which appears over 100 times in the Hebrew Scriptures. It is also the root of *Yom Kippur*—the Day of Atonement. Linguistically, Hebrew scholars offer two main interpretations of the word *kaphar*:

1. To **remove**, **wipe away**, or **purge**.
2. To **cover** or **hide**.

Conceptionally, the Hebrew Bible speaks of sin using two complementary images: removal and covering.

In Zechariah 3:4, God declares, *"See, I have taken away your sin,"* portraying forgiveness as the lifting and removal of guilt. In Psalms 32:1, we read, *"Blessed is the one whose transgressions are forgiven, whose sins are covered,"* presenting forgiveness as concealment from judgment.

Together, these images reveal a rich biblical understanding of atonement: sin is not merely ignored, but dealt with—removed, covered, and no longer counted against the forgiven.

Rather than choosing one over the other, the biblical story holds both together. In Israel's sacrificial system, sins were *covered*—not ignored, but dealt with in a way that allowed God to dwell among His people despite their impurity. In Christ, they were *removed* altogether.

The Father Who Covers Sin

The Parable of the Prodigal Son provides a lovely illustration of the *KAPHAR* atonement.

> *Quick! Bring the best robe and put it on him...*
>
> (Luke 15:22)

Picture the Prodigal Son, utterly lost in his sins and just days from starving. He comes back filthy, smelling of pigs—a striking symbol of defilement to the Jewish audience of Jesus. Now imagine his dad wrapping him up—covering him—as they walk onto the family estate. It's a technical comparison, but for the Jewish audience, it carried a much deeper meaning. In that simple act, the father not only *covered* his son's sins, but he also *removed* his shame. Below is an excerpt from my book, *God as Father: Unveiling God's Love for Sinners, Outcasts, Legalists and Jerks Through the Prodigal Son:*

> The "best robe" belongs, of course, not to one of the servants but to the father and is saved for special events and celebrations. This wasn't just any robe; the word used (στολὴν) means a long robe. The upper class wore that kind of robe. It was a symbol of honor and status. By requesting this robe for his son, who had just returned after squandering his father's wealth, the father wasn't just covering his physical nakedness; he was reinstating his honor, his place in the family, and erasing the shame that came with his prior actions. This gesture, especially in front of the household servants, is a public proclamation that the son's past is forgiven, and his original status in the

family remains unchanged. The father didn't only show compassion by forgiving his past mistakes. He extended grace by reminding his son—and everyone else around—that he is still his beloved child.

The father achieves multiple symbolic purposes by putting the best robe on his returning son. First, he restores his son's position in the family, signifying that the son is not a mere servant but holds all the rights and privileges of being a family member. The robe also serves as a clear sign of acceptance, acting as a physical manifestation of the father's unconditional love and forgiveness for his wayward son. This gesture additionally reaffirms the son's identity as a beloved family member, tapping into biblical symbolism where clothing often relates to one's identity (e.g., Genesis 3:21, Isaiah 61:10).

The robe sets the tone for the following celebratory feast, emphasizing the immense joy surrounding the son's return. Furthermore, the robe stands in sharp contrast to what the son was likely wearing—probably filthy rags—which amplifies the transformative power of his father's acceptance and love.

> In the parable, the father's robe is not merely clothing—it was *kaphar* made visible. He covered the boy's filth before the son could wash himself, forgive himself, or even finish his confession. This is the heart of biblical atonement: God does not wait for us to fix our condition before He restores us; He meets us in our ruin and covers us with His own honor.

Just as *ga'al* rescues the family member and *padah* liberates the captive, *kaphar* wraps the sinner in a restoring embrace. The Prodigal Son is not a sentimental story—it is a living portrait of the atonement Jesus proclaimed: defilement covered, sin forgiven, shame removed, and identity restored.

Jesus Redeems, Covers and Removes Sin

In Jesus, the Lamb of God, we see the ultimate fulfillment: not only redeeming us from the devil (Hebrews 2:14–15, Colossians 1:13–14, Galatians 1:4, - 1 John 3:8) or covering sin (Romans 4:7, 1 John 2:2) but removing

it entirely (Hebrews 9:26). As John the Baptist declares, *"Behold, the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world!"* (John 1:29).

Notice that John declares that the Lamb of God *"takes away the sin of the **world**"*—not "the Lamb who removes the sins of the few who manage to achieve the right religious denomination, doctrinal formula, or theological precision." If he had said that, the burden of redeeming, atoning, and removing sin would fall on us—on our mental ability to understand and believe the right creeds or behave a certain way.

Sadly, much of the Western gospel does just that. Perhaps unintentionally, it shifts the power of salvation away from God and onto human effort—our intellect, our theological precision, our morality, our choices. But the true gospel doesn't attribute 99% of salvation to God and 1% to us. It gives Him all of it.

Conclusion

This is the God Jesus reveals—not a cosmic executioner, but the Kinsman-Redeemer who comes to rescue His family. Not a wrathful monarch demanding a kill, but the Liberator who sets captives free. Not a distant

medieval judge requiring torture as punishment before forgiving, but the Purifier who removes sin so that nothing can separate us from His love.

In the Old Testament, sins were covered. In the New Testament, sins are removed. And in both, God's heart beats with love, mercy, and restoration.

Chapter 13

Atonement as the Purification of Death

In religious lingo, "unclean" often conjures images of ethical filth, shame, or moral corruption. But in the Torah—particularly in Leviticus—uncleanliness had little to do with moral guilt and everything to do with death's nearness.

The Levitical system created a detailed map of life and death. On that map, anything touched by death—even potential death—was marked as unclean: ritually impure, ceremonially defiled. This didn't mean morally sinful. It meant in opposition to life. The God of Israel was unwilling to have death in His presence.

The logic of ritual impurity was not arbitrary—it was theological and deeply existential. Touch a corpse? You are unclean. Suffer a skin disease that eats the body like decay? You are unclean. Experience a loss of blood/life—menstruation, ejaculation, or childbirth? You are unclean. Eat an animal that feasts on carrion? You are unclean. Come into contact with mildew, bodily fluids, or physical disfigurement? You are unclean.

Not because these things are morally evil—but because they are profound reminders of life's adversary and death's intrusion into the world God created.

Purity Was About Death, Not Ethics

Take *tzara'at*, often mistranslated as "leprosy." It wasn't Hansen's disease. It was a skin condition—a visible sign of something dying while still alive. A living death. A symbol that life was unraveling. That person had to live outside the camp, not because they were bad, but because they carried an infectious sign of mortality too close to the sanctuary (Leviticus 13:46).

Consider also Leviticus 15, which deals with discharges of semen and menstrual blood. These are not morally sinful acts—they're natural! But they represent the loss of life-potential, the flow of what might have been life.

These, too, required purification. Not because sex or menstruation is wrong, but because they remind us that we bleed, and every drop lost is a shadow of death.

Childbirth, that miracle of creation, also brought impurity—not because it was sinful, but because it involved tearing, blood, and the thin veil between life and death. Even in birth, death was near.

The message of the Levitical system was not shame—it was truth: we live in a world where death contaminates everything. And God's presence won't dwell there unless death is addressed.

The impurity laws taught Israel to be painfully aware of death's reach. They cultivated a sense of the sacredness of life. They trained the heart to recognize that approaching God is no casual thing. He is holy (unique, distinct)—and to come near Him requires not moral perfection, but purification. And the only substance strong enough to cleanse death's touch was not soap but blood—life itself. Even when the High Priest entered God's presence after sprinkling himself with blood, he was not suddenly perfect—he was simply purified.

This is why the blood of Jesus is not about wrath appeasement. It is about death reversal.

We bruise. We break. We injure. We bleed. We spread disease. We kill.

God forgives. God heals. God purifies. God cures.

In Jesus, the forces that rendered us unclean are undone. He touches the leper—and instead of becoming unclean; He makes the leper clean. Christ is not defiled by death. He defeats it!

And so we see: the Levitical laws, far from being outdated or obscure, set the stage for the gospel. They diagnosed the world's great wound—our estrangement from life—and hinted at the only possible cure: life poured out to cleanse the realm of death. Not shame. Not punishment. But restoration. And what blood can cleanse and purify the entire creation if not that of our Healer Himself?

The Altar Must Be Sterilized—Blood as Spiritual Antiseptic

Modern Christians often think of *worship* in terms of loudspeakers, colorful lights, music and singing (praise), but ancient worship was more focused on hygiene. The rituals of the Tabernacle were strangely familiar in one regard: they were obsessed with cleanliness—the removal of defilement so that the presence of the living God could remain among His people.

In our post-pandemic world, the idea of sterilizing spaces resonates more than ever. We use bleach, alcohol gel, and disinfectants. A surgeon will not step into an operating room until it is spotless. Not because the doctor is angry at the sick person—but because the presence of contamination would endanger the patient's life.

The Tabernacle was no different. It, too, was a kind of mystical hospital—but not for bodies. For souls. And in this holy hospital, blood was the antiseptic. The priest, like a spiritual physician, would carry life in liquid form and apply it to sacred objects that had been touched by the impurity of a fallen world.

We read in Exodus:

> *You shall **purify** the altar when you make atonement for it, and you shall anoint it to consecrate it.*
>
> (Exodus 29:36)

In Leviticus:

> *Moses slaughtered it and took the blood, and with his finger put it on the horns of the altar around it and **purified** the altar.*
>
> (Leviticus 8:15)

And again on the holiest day of the year:

> *He shall take some of the bull's blood and some of the goat's blood and put it on all the horns of the altar… sprinkle some of the blood with his finger seven times to **cleanse** it and **consecrate** it from the uncleanness of the Israelites.*
>
> (Leviticus 16:18–19)

Why was blood applied to the altar? Had the altar sinned? No. But the altar dwelled in the midst of a death-saturated world, and every object in the Tabernacle needed to be ritually purified so it could remain a fitting home for the God of life.

The altar was God's operation table, where heaven and earth touched. For Him to draw near, death had to draw back. And that required more than moral effort or good intentions. It required a cleansing so deep, only life itself could accomplish it. The blood wasn't cleaning dirt—it was cleaning death.

In this way, figuratively, the blood acted as bleach, as detergent, as hospital-grade disinfectant—only infinitely more sacred and eternally more powerful. It symbolized the removal of every trace of decay, corruption, or separation, not just from the people, but from the very space where God and man would meet.

This helps us reframe the gospel.

Jesus' blood is not merely the price of our salvation—it is the purification of the Temple. But now the temple is not made of animal hides and stones. It is us. Our bodies. Our hearts. Our consciences. Our inner sanctuaries. *"For we are the temple of the living God"* (2 Corinthians 6:16). And we, too, must be sterilized—cleansed from death's residue so God's presence can dwell there.

Hebrews 9:14 draws this line perfectly:

> *How much more will the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered Himself without blemish to God, purify our consciences from dead works to serve the living God?*
>
> (Hebrews 9:14)

Dead works. Impure altars. Contaminated hearts. These are not criminal acts to be punished—they are death-sicknesses to be healed. And the cure is not torment, but transfusion.

Conclusion

The blood of Jesus is the divine antiseptic, applied not to furniture, but to human souls. It disinfects the stain of sin, not through punishment, but through presence—through life being poured into what was dying; divine resuscitation.

And the result? We become walking sanctuaries. Mobile temples. Sterilized spaces where the Spirit of God is pleased to dwell.

Chapter 14

Not Violent Death, But Lively Blood—Correcting the Atonement Lens

The Western Church has long carried the cross—but too often, it has misread the altar.

In the Catholic-Protestant tradition, atonement has often been preached as divine punishment, as the Son absorbing the wrath of the Father, as the execution of justice through violent substitution. In this twisted perspective, God's justice required a kill—a deadly act of revenge—as though God had slaughtered and killed Jesus to spare us.

Dr. Tim Mackie, the chief theologian and founder of the renowned *Bible Project* (YouTube videos) who graduated from the Hebrew University in Jerusalem, shared his view of the Western misunderstanding of atonement:

> Many of us have inherited a story about animal sacrifice, and it goes something like this:
>
> *"The gods are angry with me and are going to kill me. But maybe if I kill this animal and make sure the gods get their pound of flesh, they'll be appeased and happy. Maybe they won't kill me or send a plague on my family. Sure, it's barbaric, but so are the gods..."*
>
> Much of popular Christian belief has simply imported a pagan storyline into Leviticus and the stories about Jesus' death on the cross. The result is a tragic irony. What the Bible is portraying as an expression of God's love gets twisted into something dark. Our version goes like this:

"God is holy and perfect. You are not. Therefore, God is angry at you, and hates you even, so he has to kill you. But because he's merciful, he'll let you bring this animal to him and will have the animal killed instead of you. Thankfully, Jesus came to be the one who gets killed by God instead of me. Jesus rescues us from God, so now we can go forever to the happy place after we die and not the bad place."

Is this story recognizable to you? If so, you're not alone. The main problem with this story, to be a bit snarky, is the Bible. More specifically, the problem is that this story has enough biblical language in it that it can pass for what the Bible actually says about animal sacrifice and Jesus' death. However, when you step back and allow Leviticus and the New Testament to speak for themselves, you can recognize this story as an imposter.[49]

(Tim Mackie)

I'd also add that the view Mackie is critiquing is probably a big reason why so many people deconstruct their faith and leave, particularly from fundamentalist denominations.

But as Mackie pointed out, the Hebrew Scriptures never claimed that violence or death brought about atonement. They taught something far more mysterious, deeper, and more beautiful—that true atonement comes from life, from self-giving.

Let us be precise: death was the cost of obtaining the blood. But it was not the agent of atonement. The creature's blood—its life—was the point. Death was the tragic side-effect, the necessary means to access the life-giving blood that could cleanse, sanctify, and restore. Atonement wasn't received because someone was killed, but because their blood—their life—was given.

The Blood of Christ Cleanseth Us from Sin

In Jewish thought, to speak of someone's blood is to speak of their life force, their *"living Nefesh."* When the blood of a sacrifice was poured on the altar, it was not a violent spectacle of a bloodbath. It was a sacred tribute—life given to cover, cleanse, and reconnect what death had fractured.

To equate atonement with death is to flatten the gospel into an overly-simplistic pamphlet—where God is the judge and Jesus is the whipping boy sadistically punished to appease God so we can go free. But that is not

the biblical picture of atonement at all. In Scripture, atonement is a relational mystery, not a legal contract. It's not a transaction—it's a transfusion.

God is not a wrathful tyrant needing satisfaction for His anger. He is a holy God who longs to dwell among His people—but His holiness means He is the opposite of death and impurity. Blood, in the biblical vision, was the only thing powerful enough to undo death's contamination.

This is why Jesus' sacrifice matters—not because it satisfied an outraged god demanding a kill, but because it allowed His life—His blood—to be poured out. It allowed the world to be cleansed once and for all. It allowed the Temple veil to be torn and annulled. It allowed humanity to be reborn.

To say, "Christ died for us" is true—but it is incomplete, misleading, and misses context. The deeper truth is this:

"Christ gave His blood—His life—for us."

Thus, when the New Testament speaks of Jesus' atonement, it never elevates His death as an isolated, appeasing punishment. Instead, it constantly highlights the power of His **blood**:

> *We have **redemption** through His **blood**, the forgiveness of sins…*
>
> (Ephesians 1:7)

*…**justified** by His **blood**…*

(Romans 5:9)

*…the **blood** of Jesus, his Son, **purifies** us from all sin.*

(1 John 1:7)

Blood is the centerpiece, not because it was caused by death, but because it represents life.

That is the gospel—not a God pacified by even more violence, but a God stepping into death itself with His own life to resurrect ours.

While some Western doctrines will have you glorify death, the Bible will have you worship the One who conquered it—not through wrath, but through life poured out in love.

The Hebrew Logic of Blood—Life, Not Punishment

In a mind shaped by centuries of Roman law and Reformation-era courtroom metaphors, the atonement is often presented like this:

You sinned against the big boss, and now he is angry. Someone has to die. Jesus steps in to absorb the blow for you. You're off the hook.

But this story—common as it is—is not biblical. It's not how Torah speaks. It's not how Temple worship functioned. And it's certainly not how the ancient Israelites or Second Temple Jews understood the sacrificial system and atonement.

The ancient Hebrew and Jewish view of sacrifice never centered on punishment and death. It centered on life and restoration.

To sacrifice was not to satisfy divine rage. It was to restore divine relationship. Blood was not a payment extracted by a Dracula-like god. It was life offered by a faithful people to keep the dwelling place of God clean, open, and welcoming.

The animal was not a martyr abused and punished in your place. It was a living being whose blood (life) was used to clear away defilement—to purify the space between heaven and earth, so God's Spirit could continue to dwell among His people.

This is why the Leviticus verse *"life is in the blood"* is not theological poetry—it's the foundation of the entire system. And it's why Jesus, a Jewish Rabbi rooted in Torah, spoke in this same logic:

> *Unless you drink My blood, you have no life in you.*
>
> (John 6:53)

He was not inviting cannibalism or promoting draculaism. He was inviting union. He was saying: "My blood is eternal in power, and if you receive it, then you will have life everlasting."

This is the reversal of paganism.

Dracula consumes others to live. Jesus gave His blood so others may live. The gospel stands in direct contrast to the pagan concept of atonement—a system rooted in appeasing angry gods through violence and death.

Tragically, some aspects of this distorted logic were later adopted into many Christians' views of atonement in ways foreign to the biblical and Jewish context.

Conclusion

Blood is not punishment. Blood is life.

This is why the apostles never preached the cross as a courtroom sentence, but as a sacrificial altar:

> *Christ loved us and gave Himself up for us, a fragrant offering and sacrifice to God.*
>
> (Ephesians 5:2)

"A fragrant offering" refers to the "aroma" created when we sacrifice ourselves for the sake of others. In the biblical imagination, what pleases God is not violence or punishment, but self-giving love. It is when we give of ourselves for the good of others that our lives become a pleasing offering to Him.

That's Temple language. That's Torah logic. That's Hebraic theology.

So, when we say, "Jesus died for our sins," we must clarify what that means. Not that an offended god demanded a kill to be appeased. But that in Jesus, life was offered to undo death. His blood was poured—not to settle a score—but to cleanse the world and draw us near.

We are not pardoned because someone else was beaten up, tortured and abused in our place. We are forgiven because the blood of Life has washed away the death that separated us from Him.

Chapter 15

Biblical Repentance and the Day of Atonement

Every year in Israel, life comes to a complete halt for one day. Shops close. Roads empty. Even the noise of ordinary existence falls silent. For twenty-four hours, an entire nation stops—not as individuals in isolation, but together. Whether religious Jew or secular, citizen or outsider, everyone is caught up in the same collective pause. This is because *Yom Kippur* (*Yom*=day, *Kippur*=Atonement) was never meant to be a private spiritual exercise. It has always been a national day of repentance—a communal reckoning, shared in stillness, restraint, and return.

To truly understand *Yom Kippur*—Israel's national day of repentance and atonement—we must first grasp the biblical concept of *repentance*. That requires shedding the modern Western lens of hyper-individualism, which distorts the communal, covenantal, and restorative vision that permeates Scripture.

The ancient world—especially the Hebrew worldview of Scripture—was covenantal, communal, and collective. God did not call Moses out of Egypt; He called Israel. He did not redeem one family; He brought out an entire nation.

Likewise, repentance (*teshuvah*) was never a private or inward-only affair. Ancient Israel had no confession booths, no isolated rituals where individuals whispered sins in order to escape hell. Repentance was about a national return—people turning back to their original vocation, reorienting themselves toward God so they might be healed, restored, and blessed. It was a communal movement back into covenantal faithfulness, not an individual attempt to flee an afterlife incinerator.

Biblical Repentance—Communal in Essence

In the Torah, sin defiled not just the sinner, but the whole camp. One person's wrongdoing could impact the

nation's standing, while the representative repentance of one—the high priest—would ripple outward to bring blessing to the whole community. The priest did not enter the Holy of Holies just for himself or for a handful of pious saints, but for the nation as a whole. This is why the Day of Atonement—*Yom Kippur*—was not a private confession ritual, but a national day of repentance and purification; covering the sins of the entire nation of Israel.

In English, it can be difficult to know whether "you" refers to one person or several because the same word is used for both. In Hebrew, however, the verb for repentance—*teshuvah*—consistently uses the plural form (e.g., Ezekiel 18:30-31, Jeremiah 25:5, Joel 2:12-13, 2 Chronicles 7:14, Zechariah 1:3, Hosea 14:1-2). God wasn't saying, "You, the individual, must change your private beliefs." He was saying, *"Return, O Israel"* (the nation). Repentance was about God healing and preserving His people so His presence could remain among them.

The New Testament continues this collective emphasis, systematically using "repentance" in the plural form (e.g., Matthew 4:17; Luke 13:3, 5; Luke 17:3; Luke 15:7, 10), emphasizing a national call rather than merely individualistic. When John the Baptist declared, *"Repent, for the kingdom of heaven has come near"* (Matthew 3:2), he wasn't addressing isolated individuals concerned about their afterlife destinies—he was speaking to the nation of Israel about her moral and spiritual direction.

Jesus, as the long-awaited Jewish Messiah, likewise called Israel to repentance—not to save people from metaphysical torture, but to restore the nation to God and help it avoid the devastating consequences of

rejecting Him. He even warned Israel's leaders that rejecting Him is an unforgivable sin (Mark 3:29). That warning tragically came to pass with the destruction of Jerusalem in 70 CE.

The modern Western emphasis on individual salvation as a passport out of hell is alien to the biblical imagination. In Scripture, repentance was not about obsessing over internal guilt or earning forgiveness through sorrow. It was about reorientation—turning from destructive paths, false gods, and unjust systems, and returning to the God who desires mercy, not sacrifice. And just as with ancient Israel, the consequences of failing to repent were not framed as afterlife torment, but as national collapse, exile, and spiritual ruin (see Luke 19:41-44, Matthew 24:1-2).

Repentance, then, was less about individuals avoiding postmortem torment in hellfire and more about a national healing, restoration, and a return to the flourishing life God intended for His people together. To reduce it to a private transaction between "me and God" is not only theologically inaccurate—it flattens the depth of the biblical narrative which is communal in nature and focus.

Faith and repentance are not price tags for forgiveness, but awakenings to what already is. Faith doesn't unlock God's forgiveness—it opens our eyes to its presence. Repentance doesn't pacify God's wrath; it moves us from resistance and opposition to restoration and blessing.

Repentance is not us performing some act to make God change His mind about us; it is us changing our mind about God. It is the reorientation of our lives toward His will—not an attempt to manipulate Him into becoming something other than who He already is.

When Jesus prayed, *"Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they do"* (Luke 23:34), it was not because His executioners had suddenly offered repentance, confession, or faith. Yet Christ extended forgiveness anyway. This is not an exception but the very revelation of divine nature: forgiveness given before we even ask. Again and again throughout His ministry—healing the paralytic (Mark 2:5), rescuing the woman caught in adultery (John 8:11), redeeming Zacchaeus (Luke 19:9)—Jesus demonstrates that grace precedes faith and repentance. Transformation follows, but grace leads.

The cross, then, must not be seen as a cold legal exchange. It is the marriage bed of heaven and earth, the consummation of divine love. When Jesus whispered, *"It is finished"* (John 19:30), the perfect passive tense He used meant the action was completed, with ongoing effects forever. Faith does not complete what Christ began; faith is to participate in what Christ has done.

Thus, faith is not a transaction that triggers forgiveness; it is the joyous discovery of a love that was always there. Forgiveness is not unlocked by belief. It is believed because it is already true. We are called not to preach a conditional gospel—"if you repent, God might forgive you"—but to proclaim: "You were forgiven before you knew to ask. Now come home, live in the freedom of that truth, and let love transform your life."

With that in mind, let's discuss Israel's Day of Atonement.

Yom Kippur—Atonement as a Collective Reality

In the story of Israel, no day is more sacred, more intimately tied to sin, or more deeply woven into the national soul than *Yom Kippur*—Israel's national Day of Atonement. It is not only a ritual; it is theology enacted. It is not only remembrance; it is prophetic expectation.

This was the day when Israel came face-to-face with its deepest need: cleansing, restoration, and nearness to God. But one aspect often lost in Christian theology is the communal and collective nature of this atonement. *Yom Kippur* was not about the isolated individual securing forgiveness for their private sins; it was about the entire covenant community of Israel being covered, purified, and reconciled as one.

And this pattern continues powerfully in the New Testament. Just as *Yom Kippur*'s atonement covered *Israel* as a nation regardless of each individual's private faith level, so too Jesus's atonement is proclaimed universally in scope and coverage, taking away the sin of the *world* (John 1:29).

A Day of Purification, Not Punishment

In Leviticus 16, God established a yearly ceremony in which Israel's sins would be covered, cleansed, and removed. But there is nothing in the ritual of *Yom Kippur* that resembles the violent logic of Penal Substitution Atonement. There is no wrath being poured out on animals. There is no divine punishment. There is no anger directed at the innocent.

Instead, there is cleansing. There is purification. There is restoration.

The day began with the high priest atoning for himself. Just like a surgeon needs to sanitize before stepping into the operating room, the high priest had to atone—cleansing himself of his own impurity—before entering the holy of holies to mediate for Israel (Leviticus 16:6-11). Only after his own purification could he act on behalf of Israel. This reinforces the idea that atonement was not about punishment but a cleansing ritual in preparation for presence.

The Two Goats: A Symbol of God's Mercy

The climax—the very pinnacle—of *Yom Kippur* was the ritual of the two goats (Leviticus 16:7–22). One was sacrificed, and its blood was used to purify and cleanse the sanctuary, mercy seat, veil, and other sacred items, almost like a liquid detergent or sanitizer. The other, the *Azazel* goat, became the *scapegoat* dealing with Israel's sins. However, the scapegoat was not killed for the sins of Israel but carried the sins of the people into the wilderness—out of sight and far away. *Azazel* is often described as a wild, chaotic desert spirit, and later traditions—especially the Book of Enoch—interpreted that figure as demonic and even Satan himself.[50] It was as though, on a symbolic level, the Azazel spirit was being dismissed—its claim neutralized, its power cut off—in the act of sending the scapegoat into the wilderness.

Israel was not appeasing the wrath of God, but confronting the claim of Azazel. The ritual was never about calming divine anger; it was about breaking an accusatory power and sending it away. In this imagination, God is not the one who needs to be paid off. The demonic is.

This echoes the profound theological instinct behind C. S. Lewis's *The Chronicles of Narnia*, where the Witch—clearly a satanic figure—demands appeasement through Aslan's life. Lewis' genius shines in this: Aslan submits not to appease the Father's wrath, but Satan's, all while exposing and toppling the false logic of accusation and the power of death itself.

Yom Kippur was a stunning drama: one goat brought cleansing through its blood (life); the other symbolically carried away the sins of the nation.

God did not punish either goat with wrath. They were instruments of God's mercy—signs of His desire to remove sin, not destroy sinners.

The logic of *Yom Kippur* is restoration, not retribution. In Eden, humanity was exiled from the Garden. In Israel's communal life, individuals could be exiled from the camp for defiling acts. And Israel itself could be exiled from the Land for covenant unfaithfulness.

But *Yom Kippur* declares God's heart: I will draw you back!

Jesus Himself became the perfect fulfillment of this. He was both "exiled" from His people, rejected and crucified outside the city (Hebrews 13:12), bearing the sin and shame of not just Israel but the entire world. His blood purified Israel (and the world) like the first goat, and in His crucifixion outside the camp, He symbolically carried away the sins of Israel (and the world) as the ultimate scapegoat. Yet He did not bear them in a drama of divine wrath, but in a mission of divine love—willingly entering our exile to bring us home.

He bore our sins to remove them forever. He died not to appease divine fury but to cleanse and heal—not just one nation but the entire world.

No Wrath on the Animals, No Wrath on Christ

Notably absent from the *Yom Kippur* rituals is any description of wrath being poured out on the goats. The animals were not tortured. They were not abused. Their blood was used because it represented life (Leviticus 17:11). The first goat's death was necessary only to obtain the blood that purifies. The scapegoat didn't even die—it was sent alive into the wilderness, symbolically carrying away the sins of Israel.

Jesus' sacrifice, like *Yom Kippur*, was about cleansing, restoration, and reunion with God—not about God pouring out stored-up wrath on the innocent One.

Communal Atonement: The Pattern Continues

What is striking is that in *Yom Kippur*, atonement was granted to all Israel. The text does not demand that every individual must personally offer a sacrifice, hold to a specific doctrine, or understand every aspect of the ritual for it to be effective. The high priest's actions universally covered the nation. The ritual was for the nation as a whole. This was covenantal, communal atonement.

And this is precisely the pattern the New Testament sees fulfilled in Jesus. His life, death, and resurrection are presented not as a limited private transaction for individual believers alone but as a cosmic act of universal reconciliation:

> *For God was pleased to have all his fullness dwell in him, and **through him to reconcile to himself all things**, whether things on earth or things in heaven, by making peace through his blood, shed on the cross.*
>
> (Colossians 1:19-20)

Conclusion

The Day of Atonement in Israel's story is the Day of Hope, not the Day of Punishment. It looked backward, acknowledging sin and defilement. It looked inward, inviting repentance and reflection. And it looked forward, proclaiming God's promise to remove sin forever and dwell once again with His people.

Yom Kippur was not about fear of punishment but about confidence in restoration. And Jesus, our High Priest and perfect sacrifice, has fulfilled this ancient hope:

> *But now he has appeared once for all at the culmination of the ages to do away with sin by the sacrifice of himself.*
>
> (Hebrews 9:26)

This is the gospel: God is not against us. He is for us. His heart is always to cleanse, to restore, and to bring His people home.

The Day of Atonement was never about wrath. It was always about love. And Jesus is the living proof.

Chapter 16

The Biblical Understanding of Wrath, Vengeance, and Justice

Fundamentalists often point out, and with good reason, that human sin provokes God's wrath. Sin is no trivial matter in Scripture; it disrupts creation, fractures shalom—peace and wholeness—and wounds the relationship between humanity and God.

But when many Westerners hear the word "wrath," they picture a storming deity with clenched fists, ready to smite and cast into hellfire. For centuries, this image has haunted pulpits and darkened the gospel. But the

Hebrew Scriptures offer a very different vision—one far more tragic, far more loving, far more relational, and far more profound.

So, before we rush to imagine God's wrath as molten fury, violent punishment, or volcanic rage, we should pause and return to the very first moment humans sinned—back to the Garden of Eden.

Do you remember how God's alleged "wrath" manifested the moment Adam and Eve disobeyed?

Was there thunder, screaming, or a violent attack? Did God pull out his belt or sink them into lava?

None of the above.

Instead, the scene is marked by grief, divine sorrow, and a surprising tenderness: God covers their shame.

Back in the Garden

After Adam and Eve hid in fear, God did not strike them down. He did not drag them out of the bushes, whip them, or scorch them with fire. He called to them. He sought them. And He clothed them. God did not hide His face from them; they were the ones who hid.

In the ancient Near East, clothing was far more than a piece of garment—it was a statement, a symbol of identity, status, and vocation. Scripture consistently uses *garments* to mark a person's calling or position: the priestly garments (Exodus 28; 29:5–9), Jonathan giving David his robe as a sign of covenant and succession (1 Samuel 18:4), Elijah passing his mantle to Elisha (1 Kings 19:19), and the royal enthronement garments spread beneath Jehu (2 Kings 9:13).

So, when God clothes Adam and Eve with *"garments of skin"* in Genesis 3:21, He is doing far more than covering shame. He is reaffirming their priestly identity and mission to subdue and have dominion over creation (Genesis 1:28) and recommissioning them as His image-bearers—now within a fallen world. Instead of lashing out at them, He appoints them priests over all creation. [51]

This is not the action of an enraged deity but of a compassionate Creator who refuses to abandon His children. Even in judgment, He restores their dignity, equips them for life beyond Eden, and preserves their role as the ones through whom His redemptive story will unfold.

God, who knew exactly what they had done, moved toward them—not with rage, but with relational restoration.

So, where many claim the very first picture of divine wrath is, we see not a cosmic temper tantrum but a redemptive response. Yes, consequences follow—they are sent out of the garden—but even their exile is laced

with protection and promise. The narrative centers not on God abandoning humanity, but God accompanying them into a new experience.

I'm aware of the Calvinistic interpretation of Genesis 3 that claims God violently killed an animal to atone for Adam and Eve's sin. But that idea is not in the text. It is not exegesis—it is eisegesis, an attempt to read later theological assumptions back into the story. Genesis simply says God made garments of skin and clothed them; the text offers no description of a kill, sacrifice, wrath, violence, blood, or atonement.

If you want to dive deeper into this, we can look at the so-called "penal substitution" passages in the Bible, like Genesis 3, the binding of Isaac, Isaiah 53, and more. I explore these in detail in my book, ***The "Gospel" of Divine Abuse: Redeeming the Gospel from Gruesome Popular Preaching of an Abusive and Violent God***, where I show why these readings collapse under the weight of the biblical evidence itself.

God's Wrath is Restorative

The imagery of wrath used throughout Israel's Scriptures is intentionally severe. Hebrew terms such as *qetsef*, *chemah*, and *za'am* communicate intensity—anger, burning heat, divine indignation—in a language ancient

people could grasp. Yet the actions themselves are ultimately loving, because God's judgment is restorative by nature.

Israel repeatedly provoked God through injustice and the worship of other gods, yet His judgments were always temporary. Every exile came to an end. Israel, no matter how sinful, has never ceased to exist, and as God promised, never will cease to exist (e.g., Jeremiah 31:35–37)—a fact evident in its existence even today.

The idea that God's wrath is restorative is beautifully expressed in Isaiah 1:24–26:

> *Ah! I will vent my **wrath** on my foes... I will thoroughly purge away your dross... I will **restore** your leaders as in days of old... Afterward, you will be called the City of **Righteousness**.*

God's wrath led to purification. His wrath, in its truest biblical sense, is like a fire that refines, not a wildfire that destroys. It's discipline that purges away impurity. It is judgment that leads to redemption.

God's wrath, then, is not the wrath of a cruel despot—it is the holy ache of a Father whose love burns precisely because sin wounds the ones He cherishes. His wrath is not aimed at annihilation but at healing the fracture that sin has introduced.

The real question is not whether God has wrath, but what kind of wrath He has. Is it the fury of a vengeful tyrant, or the passionate flame of divine love, cleansing and renewing?

The first sin reveals much about God's justice, yet even more about His compassionate heart.

God's Wrath Isn't Human Rage, but Divine Withdrawal

In biblical terms, God's wrath is not divine fury but divine absence.

It's what happens when the Giver of life and protection steps aside; when God's presence—the force that holds everything together—is withdrawn. In the Bible, wrath is less about an act of violence and more about the quiet that follows after divine love has been ignored for too long.

This is the pattern woven throughout Israel's story. Again and again, when Israel chose idols over God, oppression over justice, and ignored His ways, God did not erupt in uncontrolled anger. Instead, He withdrew,

allowing them to have what they demanded—the experience of the prodigal walking a path defenseless and alone—and to face the consequences of that choice:

> *Surely the arm of the LORD is not too short to save, nor his ear too dull to hear. But your [Israel] iniquities have separated you from your God; your sins have hidden his face from you, so that he will not hear.*
>
> (Isaiah 59:1-2)

And that withdrawal, that vacuum, is what we call "wrath."

Wrath is the warmth of the sun being covered. The silence of the beloved no longer speaking. It is God saying, "If you will not have Me, then I will not force Myself upon you." It is not a tantrum—it is the ache of rejected love.

This is why the sacrificial system was so essential. It was not a way to "pay off" an angry God. It was a way to maintain the presence of the God who longed to dwell among His people. It was Israel's way of saying, "We

want you here!" The Tabernacle was not built to satisfy God's ego. It was built so that God's nearness—His Spirit—would remain.

When Israel rejected that closeness—when they defiled the sanctuary or pursued other gods—it wasn't that God lost it and struck them with lightning. It was that He was no longer welcome, no longer there to offer protection.

And into that vacancy rushed all the terrors of a fallen world: invading armies, plagues, famine, chaos, exile. Not because God struck—but because God stepped back and allowed Israel to suffer the consequences of their decisions.

The New Testament doesn't really change much. We see this clearly in Romans 1. Paul writes:

> *The **wrath** of God is being revealed…*
> *Therefore God **gave them over**…*
> *Because of this, God **gave them over**…*
> *So God **gave them over**…*
>
> (Romans 1:18, 24, 26, 28)

Wrath, according to Paul, is God giving people over to their own desires. It's not rocks falling down from the sky—it's more like the father in the parable of the Prodigal Son, letting his son walk away and suffer the consequences of his choices. It's not about seeking revenge, but about a sorrowful letting go—a step back that lets sin run its course and teach its own lesson.

The Greek word *orgē*, commonly translated "wrath," does not describe cold rage or sadistic anger; it comes from a root associated with intense inner movement or passion—the same linguistic family that later gives us orgasm, a word denoting swelling, excitement, overwhelming force, or surge. Both derive from the same Greek verbal root *ὀργ*, meaning "to swell, be excited, be in heat," and both ultimately trace back to the Proto-Indo-European root *wrog*, "to swell, grow, become strong." [52]

In Scripture, orgē points to God's burning passion in response to chaos and injustice—a deep, settled intensity that often results not in violent outbursts but in God withdrawing and allowing consequences to unfold. It is not about God losing control, but more about God's love reaching a boiling point where He steps back so disorder can be exposed, confronted, and ultimately healed.

Paul isn't introducing a new concept—he's echoing a consistent theme from the Old Testament. God's wrath, as seen throughout Scripture, is about allowing people to walk the path they've chosen and face the natural consequences. It's a pattern of divine discipline, not retaliation.

Psalm 78:49–50 literally combines "wrath" with "gave them over"—directly echoed by Romans 1.

Lamentations 4:11 describes wrath as destruction caused by God removing His protection and allowing Zion to fall, which mirrors the abandonment judgment concept in Romans 1.

In Isaiah 10:5–6, God uses a foreign nation as an instrument of wrath, allowing Israel's enemies to rise against her—not by unleashing random fury but by stepping back and no longer shielding her from the consequences of rebellion. Once again, wrath is interpreted not as explosive rage but as God stepping back and giving people over to the results of their own choices.

I know some might raise objections by pointing to exceptions such as the Flood or the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah. But those events belong to a different category altogether, involving fallen angels and the Nephilim—an entirely separate subject, and one addressed in another book.[53]

Rage Doesn't Appease Wrath

Think about it logically—you don't appease someone's fury with rage—you calm it with compassion, understanding, and peace. Meeting anger with more anger only fuels the fire; it's love and forgiveness that

break the cycle. This is divine logic: *"Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good."* (Romans 12:21; see also Matthew 5:39-44, Ephesians 4:31–32).

I'm not talking about pacifism. There are times when you must defend yourself and those you love. I'm talking about revenge for the sake of revenge—violence driven not by necessity or protection, but by the intoxicating desire to retaliate.

Likewise, you don't make peace with your angry neighbors by attacking them (nor by pouring out your anger on your innocent son instead). True reconciliation doesn't come through retaliation—it comes through forgiveness, mercy, humility, and love that breaks the cycle of vengeance.

In this light, we can understand the role of blood and sacrifice more deeply. The shedding of blood didn't "appease" wrath—it welcomed God to remain by symbolically cleansing and purifying His sacred "guestroom." It was a sign that the people of Israel still desired Him. Still welcomed Him. Still sought His nearness.

And when they didn't—when they abandoned the sacred rhythms of worship—it was as if they said, "We don't need You. We'll manage." And God, honoring their choice, let them walk without Him. His absence was His wrath.

This is why Israel's most severe judgment in the Bible was not divine violence, but divine withdrawal. God stepping back. Protection lifted. Exile imposed. Enemies invading—not because God turned violent, but

because His presence was no longer restraining the chaos. The terror was not that God hurled fire and lightning from the sky on Israel, but that He was no longer there to shield her.

And this makes Jesus's sacrifice all the more beautiful. He came not to endure His Father's rage but to bring the Father's presence back to a world that had pushed Him away. His blood is not the shield against divine anger—it is the welcome mat for divine return.

Jesus's blood restores what we lost in Eden. It reopens the door that was closed by our rejection. It brings back the Presence that once walked among us in the cool of the day.

Human Vengeance vs. Divine Justice

In our modern culture, the word *justice* often carries the sharp edge of vengeance, violent rage, and erratic retaliation. We imagine revenge through cinematic lenses—gritty anti-heroes, blood-stained justice, explosive battles for payback. To exact vengeance is to settle the score. It's emotional. Brutal. Personal. Yet when Scripture speaks of vengeance, particularly in Hebrew, it invites us into a very different image—one not driven by ego, pain, or rage, but by restoration and the long arc of divine mercy.

The Hebrew *Naqam* originates as a primitive root meaning "to avenge." In Scripture, however, it transcends human revenge and reflects God's covenantal justice—a divine act of restoring balance. God's justice defies the shallowness of human revenge fantasies. It means more than retaliation—it implies setting things right, a divine act rooted in restorative justice.

When humans seek vengeance, they are often led by bruised egos or unresolved pain. Revenge is rarely about justice—it's about feeling better. We lash out, not to restore wholeness, but to satisfy our wounded pride. Consider how nations go to war, families break apart, reputations are destroyed—all under the pretense of "justice," when in truth, it's pain begging to be seen.

God's vengeance is not like this.

Scripture is replete with a radically different vision of divine vengeance. The justice of God is not chaotic fury—it is focused, purposeful, and redemptive. It is justice that heals. Consider Isaiah 61:2:

> *To proclaim the year of the LORD's favor and the day of* ***vengeance*** *of our God, to* ***comfort*** *all who mourn…*

Did you catch that?

God's day of vengeance and comfort are spoken in the same breath. The vengeance of God isn't for entertainment or ego—it's to comfort the mourners. It's not to destroy sinners but to deliver the brokenhearted from what sin has done to the world. Vengeance is not God's wild rage—it's His passionate justice rushing in to rescue what evil tried to destroy.

True love doesn't compromise justice, but neither does it abandon mercy. Strip mercy from justice, and you're left with something harsh and cold: a rigid system that may demand what is "right," but offers no grace to the broken. Justice without mercy breeds fear, not freedom; anxiety, not peace; anger, not healing. It crushes the spirit instead of restoring it. Without mercy, justice becomes a weapon rather than a cure. But when justice is tempered by mercy, it becomes redemptive—it doesn't just expose what's wrong, it invites healing and transformation. That is the love we see in God, and that is the love we are called to reflect.

> Love is justice—is the fulfilling of the law, for God as well as for his children. This is the reason of punishment; this is why justice requires that the wicked shall not go unpunished—that they, through the eye-opening power of pain, may come to see and do justice, may be brought to desire and make all possible amends, and so become just. [54]

(George MacDonald)

If God truly never changes, then His merciful judgment, forgiving nature, and loving character must remain consistent—yesterday, today, and forever.

Let God Be the Judge

Paul echoes this divine logic in Romans 12:19:

> *Do not take revenge, my dear friends, but leave room for God's wrath, for it is written: "It is mine to avenge; I will repay," says the Lord.*

Why does Paul tell us to stand back and leave room for God? Not because God's payback will be harsher, but because His vengeance serves a purpose we can't accomplish—restoration.

Human vengeance only knows how to punish. Divine vengeance knows how to purify. We judge from pain. God judges out of love.

Renewal, Not Retaliation

The Hebrew prophets constantly remind us: God's judgment is aimed at renewal. Even His most dramatic acts of wrath—like the plagues in Egypt—were designed not for destruction but for repentance and redemption.

Yes, the Nile turned to blood. Yes, Egypt trembled under judgment. But through these signs, hearts were stirred. Egyptians (not just Israelites) joined the Exodus (Exodus 12:38). God's "vengeance" created the cracks in Pharaoh's empire so that the light of deliverance could break through.

Vengeance, then, was not an explosion of divine fury. It was an invitation to salvation.

Just as the plagues humbled Egypt and set both the Hebrews and many Egyptians free, the judgments in Revelation invite the nations to turn and be healed.

To Retaliate Is Carnal. To Forgive Is Divine.

When we try to take justice into our own hands, we only perpetuate the pain. The one who hits back only guarantees the next blow. But when we choose mercy, when we surrender vengeance, when we freely forgive, we create space for God to step in—not just to deal with the wrongdoer, but to transform both them and us. This is the divine logic:

> *Bless those who persecute you… Do not be overcome by evil, but overcome evil with good.*
> (Romans 12:14, 21)

We are not called to be agents of divine punishment. We are called to be agents of divine mercy. When we forgive those who hurt us, we mirror God's redemptive heart. Forgiveness is not pretending the wrong didn't

happen. It's saying: "I will not continue in this endless cycle. I will not let your sin turn me into something evil. I will protect myself."

Jesus, the true embodiment of divine justice, didn't demand cosmic revenge from the cross but instead called out for mercy, saying, *"Father, forgive them."*

Divine Judgment Seeks Restoration

A good judge in a morally healthy society doesn't hand out punishments to feel better. A good judge discerns truth, weighs circumstances, and seeks justice that leads to restoration. In God's economy, vengeance is never the final word. Redemption is:

> *I take no pleasure in the death of the wicked, but rather that they turn from their ways and live.*
>
> (Ezekiel 33:11)

Even divine wrath has this longing built into it—not to destroy, but to awaken. Not to shame, but to heal. God reveals the sin not to humiliate the sinner, but to expose the wound so it can finally be healed.

Every human heart will one day have to stand before, and give account to, Love Himself.

Divine judgment is God's purifying truth unveiled—every mask removed, every lie exposed, every wound healed in light.

For some, that light will feel like scorching torment because it burns away illusion; for others, it will feel like homecoming. But the fire is the same—it is the divine fire of God's love. His wrath is not the opposite of His love; it is love's refusal to tolerate what destroys its beloved.

When the church teaches about judgment, it should approach it with compassion, not with pride or a sense of triumph. To proclaim the gospel is to say: "The fire of God's love is coming—and it can heal you now, or it can burn away what you cling to later."

A Love That Judges

When people say, "God is love," they often mean it in a soft, harmless way. But "woke" love that never says

"No," never disciplines, never corrects—is not love at all. Love must judge. Love must speak. Love must protect.

Divine judgment is what happens when God's love collides with human injustice. It is not the opposite of grace—it is grace in action. And *naqam* is the justice of God flowing from a heart that refuses to let evil have the last word.

When Jesus cleared the temple courts, it wasn't judgment divorced from love. It was love that had reached its breaking point with injustice. He turned over tables not to destroy but to cleanse the Temple. His *naqam* wasn't an eruption of temper—it was a purification of sacred space.

And in the grandest expression of divine vengeance, Jesus bore injustice to give us mercy. He absorbed human wrath to unleash divine grace.

Conclusion

Wrath, then, is not God's emotional outburst of anger—it's Him drawing back from all that destroys love, justice, and life. It's not a divine tantrum, but a holy resistance to evil—the burning passion of a God who refuses to be indifferent to injustice, yet allows humanity to face the consequences of its choices.

God's wrath is more like that of a loving, heartbroken parent than a raging, cruel dictator throwing a divine tantrum. A good parent disciplines to guide and restore, not to harm or abuse. In the same way, God's justice is aimed at healing, not destruction.

To live in the spirit of God's justice is to resist retaliation and entrust justice to God. It means: Speaking the truth without becoming bitter. Seeking justice without losing mercy. Refusing to repay evil with evil. Trusting God to deal with those who hurt us—even when it takes longer than we'd like.

Most of all, it means living in such a way that our response to wrong doesn't mirror the world's instinct for vengeance but reflects God's instinct for redemption. *"Vengeance is mine,"* says the Lord. Not because He's angrier than us—but because He's wiser, purer, and more committed to saving the world than we'll ever be.

So when you're treated unfairly, don't seek revenge. Trust God and the authorities He has established to handle justice. If someone hurts your feelings, don't hit back—pray instead. Forgive, because they don't truly understand what they're doing. Leave the work of vengeance in God's hands.

Chapter 17

The Problem with the Two Western Models of Atonement

More than once, my Jewish-Israeli friends have confronted me with a painfully honest question—one that perfectly exposes how the gospel is so often presented to them by Messianic and evangelical missionaries and how deeply it is misrepresented by many Christians today. Below is one example of such a question I received (translated from Hebrew):

> If the Christian "good news" really comes from the Prince of Peace, why does it sound like a horror story whenever Messianic evangelists preach it? It sounds like a cosmic suicide where God sent Himself to kill Himself in order to save us from Himself but then only a few are actually saved from Him. Why does it come across as a gospel in which Jesus throws Himself under the bus to protect us from His abusive Father—an enraged deity supposedly marching toward humanity with a cosmic whip in His hand? Why does the path to "peace" look like a blood-soaked hostage exchange demanded by a wrathful God?

And they also point to how the whole performance is always held together by a handful of verses yanked violently out of context and stitched into a theological Frankenstein.

It's a brutally fair question—and it reveals just how grotesquely distorted the modern message has become from the original Gospel Jesus actually preached.

So Why Do Some Modern Gospel Depictions Often Sound So Different?

For many Christians today, particularly those shaped by the Reformed or Evangelical traditions, the answer to the question of why Jesus died on the cross has become fixed: *Penal Substitutionary Atonement* (PSA). This theory, which paints the crucifixion as God punishing His Son in our place, has dominated Christian thought for the last few centuries. But this was not always the case. In fact, the PSA model and its predecessor, the *Satisfaction* Theory, are relatively late inventions—born not from the soil of the Hebrew Scriptures, but from feudal Europe and Western legal imaginations.

Penal Substitutionary Atonement was systematized about 500 years ago by the reformer John Calvin. Raised and trained within Catholicism, Calvin essentially modified the Catholic atonement doctrine of Satisfaction (although today, many Catholics no longer believe in it), making it even more violent and transactional. In Calvin's model, God is portrayed as a wrathful judge—a moral monster—demanding a kill in order to forgive even the slightest offence.

It is no surprise that the PSA model almost always goes hand in hand with the doctrine of Eternal Conscious Torment hellfire (ECT).

When Calvinism Infected American Christianity

When preachers such as George Whitefield, John and Charles Wesley, and, perhaps most notably, Jonathan Edwards introduced the Calvinistic PSA and ECT to America, existential fear spread them quickly, particularly among Puritans and similar groups. On July 8, 1741, Edwards delivered his most renowned sermon, "Sinners in the Hands of an Angry God," which had a major influence on shaping the theology of American Christian fundamentalism. Below is a brief excerpt from his sermon:

> The God that holds you over the pit of hell, much as one holds a spider or some loathsome insect over the fire, abhors you, and is dreadfully provoked. His wrath towards you burns like fire; he looks upon you as worthy of nothing else but to be cast into the

fire. He is of purer eyes than to bear you in his sight; you are ten thousand times as abominable in his eyes as the most hateful, venomous serpent is in ours.

It would be dreadful to suffer this fierceness and wrath of Almighty God one moment; but you must suffer it to all eternity. There will be no end to this exquisite, horrible misery. When you look forward, you shall see along forever a boundless duration before you, which will swallow up your thoughts, and amaze your soul. And you will absolutely despair of ever having any deliverance, any end, any mitigation, any rest at all. You will know certainly that you must wear out long ages, millions of millions of ages in wrestling with this Almighty, merciless vengeance. And then, when you have so done, when so many ages have actually been spent by you in this manner, you will know that all is but a point to what remains. So that your punishment will indeed be infinite…

The world will probably be converted into a great lake or liquid globe of fire, in which the wicked shall be overwhelmed, which will always be in tempest, in which they shall be tossed to and fro, having no rest day and night, vast waves and billows of fire continually rolling over their heads, of which they shall forever be full of a quick sense within and

> without; their heads, their eyes, their tongues, their hands, their feet, their loins and their vitals, shall forever be full of a flowing, melting fire, fierce enough to melt the very rocks and elements; and also, they shall eternally be full of the most quick and lively sense to feel the torments; not for one minute, not for one day, not for one age, not for two ages, not for a hundred ages, nor for ten thousand millions of ages, one after another, but forever and ever, without any end at all, and never to be delivered.[55]

Today, Edwards' ideas, rooted in PSA and ECT, continue to have a strong influence in America, particularly among Baptists, Calvinists, Pentecostals, Calvary Chapel members, Brethren assemblies, Evangelicals, Messianics, certain Mormons (LDS), and other fundamentalist groups.

The Roots of PSA: Anselm's Satisfaction

If the PSA model represents the Protestant view of atonement, the Satisfaction model represents the Catholic

view—the root from which Protestantism emerged (though again, many Catholics have since moved away from it). That's also why these two models are so similar theologically. To better grasp the PSA model (16th century), it helps to first understand the Satisfaction model upon which it was built (10th century).

Anselm of Canterbury (1033–1109), an Italian Benedictine monk, lived during a time when society was governed by the *feudal* system. Honor, allegiance, and hierarchical submission were the foundations of Europian justice. A commoner who insulted a knight or king would not simply be forgiven. That would be seen as weakness. Honor had to be restored—and restoration meant punishment. Severe, often lethal punishment.

In that cultural framework, Anselm developed what became known as the *Satisfaction Model of Atonement*. He argued against the Church Fathers' historical atonement theories and claimed that sin was not just wrongdoing, but an offense against the *infinite honor* of God. Since humans had dishonored the divine King, someone had to make restitution. But no mere human could satisfy God's infinite honor. Only God could do that. So, in Anselm's view, God became human in Jesus so the Father could kill Him and restore His own honor. Jesus' punishment was the payment of an unpayable debt. Divine honor was satisfied, and humanity could be forgiven.

While it may sound noble, Satisfaction was soaked in the values of feudalism: honor, hierarchy, and vengeance. Rather than a loving Father in the context of a relationship, it cast God as a medieval angry king whose dignity required death to be appeased.

From Satisfaction to PSA: Logic of Violence

In the 16th century, John Calvin radicalized Anselm's vision. A trained lawyer, Calvin built upon the Satisfaction model and gave us what is now known as Penal Substitutionary Atonement (PSA). In PSA, the central claim is that not only God's honor but also His *justice* demand eternal conscious punishment for every sin, whether big or small. Yet, instead of punishing us, God places that punishment on Jesus, who takes our place. The full force of divine wrath falls on the innocent Son. In PSA, it is God who punishes—torturing and killing Jesus. This is at least how Calvinist and Evangelical preachers view it:

> We must remember, however, that sin did not kill Jesus; God did. The suffering servant's death was nothing less than a punishment administered by God for sins others had committed. [56]
>
> (John MacArthur)

> God's anger at sin and hatred of sinners causes him to pour out his wrath on Jesus.[57]
>
> (Mark Driscoll)

> Jesus was not swept away by the wrath of uncontrolled men. He was bruised by his Father. Why? To resolve the tension between the Father's love for his glory and his love for sinners.[58]
>
> (John Piper)

In this "cosmic suicide" perspective, it is not simply that Jesus paid our debt on our behalf by offering His precious eternal blood—He also had to endure God's violent sentence. Quoting verses out of context,[59] PSA casts Jesus as a divine whipping boy, absorbing the cosmic punishment humanity deserved. In this model, God's justice is satisfied not by forgiveness, but by violence. Divine love and divine wrath are pitted against one another in a grotesque transaction.

Here, God's love was no longer about self-sacrifice—absorbing and forgiving human sin—but had become a stage for divine cruelty and cosmic violence, with God portrayed as a fearsome grand torturer.

But let us ask honestly: what kind of love is this?

Would we call it love if a father punished his innocent son to spare his guilty brothers? Would we call it justice?

This theology resembles not the heart of a loving Father, but the profile of a sadistic abuser. It teaches us to see God as angry, explosive, and appeased only through killing. It turns God into a tyrant demanding nothing but perfection. As one famous Calvinist once put it, *"God only accepts absolute perfection."* (John MacArthur). [60]

Conclusion

What began as good news has, in too many mouths, curdled into a sanctified horror tale—a Father pacing heaven like a tyrant king, a Son crushed beneath a sentence He did not deserve, and salvation offered only through terror. A gospel born in biblical mercy was disfigured by foreign imaginations until love was recast as violence and justice as a divine abuse. The result is a theological monster stitched together from fear, power,

and misplaced zeal—one that repels the wounded and terrifies the faithful. Yet the grotesque mask is not the face of God. Strip it away, and the scandal reappears: not a whip, but open arms; not appeasement through cruelty, but victory through self-giving love. The true gospel does not coerce with nightmares—it heals, restores, and calls the world home.

Chapter 18

Misunderstanding Forgiveness: A Debt Forgiven Is Not Paid

If you punched me in the face and I chose to forgive you, it would not be because I punched you back—or punched someone else in your place. That would not be forgiveness; it would be retaliation. Forgiveness means I absorb the wrong done to me rather than pass it on.

If God had to torture and kill Jesus instead of us in order to forgive (PSA), then what we have is not forgiveness at all—it is violence redirected.

The Meaning of Forgiveness

Both the Satisfaction and the Penal Substitutionary Atonement theories rest on the assumption that, for forgiveness to occur, a debt to God—whether framed as lost honor or as violated justice—must first be paid. But that is not forgiveness; it is payment.

Forgiveness is about releasing someone from what they owe you, not taking your anger with them out on someone else. If you've paid off your debt to the bank, it's not forgiveness; when a debt is forgiven, it's not actually paid. These are two entirely different realities that should not be confused.

Forgiveness, in its truest and most beautiful form, is the act of releasing someone from what they rightfully owe—not because the debt was transferred to another, but because the offended party chose to absorb the loss out of love. This is exactly how Jesus taught us to understand forgiveness. He said, *"Forgive us our debts, as we forgive our debtors"* (Matthew 6:12), meaning that forgiveness is not a transactional exchange or substitution of penalty, but a free act of mercy.

If God had to be paid before He could forgive, then forgiveness is no longer a free gift nor is it grace—it becomes a transaction, a settlement, a business deal. But the gospel tells a different story. The cross was never about God being paid so He could forgive; it was about God showing us He already forgives—not because of an event but because that's His nature. Jesus didn't die to persuade God to forgive us; He died to show us God's forgiveness. True forgiveness comes without conditions. It's a gift of pure, unearned grace that flows from the heart of the forgiver, simply because they take joy in showing mercy (Micah 7:18).

This means that Jesus gave His life for *our* sake, not for the sake of appeasing His Father. Jesus' death without retaliation toward humanity was a display of divine grace, and His resurrection was a mighty demonstration of divine power.

The Reversed Gospel

To say that Jesus had to be tortured on a cross to convince the Father to forgive us is to reverse the Gospel into paganism and misrepresent the very character of God. The cross was not the price God demanded to change

His heart toward humanity; the cross was the price that human sin demanded to extinguish divine love—and even that failed.

God's forgiveness is free because it flows from His nature—not from a violent settlement He demanded. The cross *reveals* God's forgiveness much more than it enables it.

To say otherwise would be like saying:

"God is love... but only after being paid off."

That's not the gospel of Jesus. That's a reversal.

God Already Forgave Jesus's Enemies

On the cross, just moments before His death, Jesus prayed one final, often overlooked prayer:

> *Father, forgive them...*
>
> (Luke 23:34)

He wasn't asking for His friends. He wasn't interceding on behalf of the faithful.

Jesus asked God to forgive His accusers, His torturers, His murderers—His narcissist enemies.

These were the very people who mocked Him for years, then beat Him, humiliated Him, and nailed Him to a piece of wood. In that moment of unimaginable pain, Jesus didn't curse them to hellfire for their disbelief. He didn't seek fiery revenge. He asked for mercy. He pleaded for forgiveness.

The question is: Did the Father turn down the Son's plea? In much of Western Christian theology, the common answer is yes.

We are told that unless those individuals confessed their sin, repented, believed, and converted in the correct doctrinal formula, God refused to forgive them—even though His own Son explicitly asked Him to.

But what does that say about the heart of the Father? And what does it say about the unity between Father and Son—if one asked for mercy and the other stubbornly denied it? Was Jesus just saying empty words, offering a dramatic but ultimately meaningless request?

Or is it possible—no, likely—that the heart of the Son is also the heart of the Father, and that this prayer was answered in full?

Because if Jesus truly revealed the nature of God, then *"Father, forgive them"* was not just virtue signaling or wishful thinking on His part. It was a glimpse into divine love—a love that forgives before it's asked, that embraces before it's understood, and that opens the door of grace even while the hammer still strikes the nails.

Before the Gospel Was Reversed

None of what I'm presenting here is new. I'm simply echoing what Jesus' earliest disciples and the first generations of Church Fathers taught—those closest to the Apostles, those who inherited the faith before it became entangled in later philosophical systems. Not one of them taught the Protestant Penal Substitutionary Atonement or the Catholic Satisfaction theory; these are much later constructions, shaped by medieval assumptions rather than by the Jewish worldview of Jesus and His earliest followers.

In the first centuries of Christianity, the dominant vision of atonement was called the "ransom" view: humanity held in bondage (by Satan), Christ entering our captivity, and—through His death and resurrection—breaking the chains from the inside, not by satisfying a debt to God, but by setting the captives free from the evil one.

In this book, my aim isn't to completely dismantle the Protestant PSA or the Catholic Satisfaction models, nor to delve deeply into other atonement theories—that's something I've already done in a previous work, ***The "Gospel" of Divine Abuse: Redeeming the Gospel from Gruesome Popular Preaching of an Abusive and Violent***

God. Instead, here I will simply highlight a few essential points as to why I find these two Western perceptions of the atonement troubling.

Ethical and Theological Objections

Father-Son Schism: PSA fractures the unity between Father and Son. Pitting them one against the other, it paints a violent divide between the Father and Son, contradicting Jesus' words: *"I and the Father are one"* (John 10:30).

Forgiveness Reimagined: True forgiveness is letting go of debt, not redirecting anger or punishment to someone else. God doesn't need a transaction to forgive. Jesus didn't die to change God's mind about us. He came to change our minds about God.

Distorted Sense of Justice: Punishing the innocent—substituting the guiltless for the guilty violates the most basic sense of biblical justice (e.g., Ezekiel 18:20). We rightly recoil from a human judge who does this. Why would we think God's justice contradicts the Bible?

Love Undermined: The message that God "loves you so much He killed His Son for you" is deeply troubling. Love does not require violence to be genuine. As N.T. Wright notes, *"Simply adding the word 'love' to divine violence makes it worse, not better."*[61]

Disproportionate Justice: Eternal Conscious Torment for finite sins, as demanded by most proponents of Penal Substitutionary Atonement and Satisfaction theories, is morally incoherent. Even human courts recognize proportionality as a basic requirement of justice. Is God's justice truly less merciful—less rational—than the standard of justice He commands from us? (Exodus 21:24).

Traumatic and Triggering: The image of God as an abuser traumatizes those who have experienced violence. It replaces the Good Shepherd with a cosmic punisher, only further pushing people away from Him.

Violence as Sacred: I don't believe Jesus was a pacifist. But PSA and Satisfaction theories make violence not just necessary but holy. It elevates violence as salvific. This is a dangerous message that resembles Islamic beliefs more than ancient Jewish thought.

Distorted Gospel: The gospel is reduced to a legal transaction rather than revealed as a love story. It becomes a courtroom drama instead of a work of relational restoration—a bleak and hopeless narrative in which most of humanity is written off as doomed rather than healed.

Scriptural Misuse: Verses are cherry-picked to support PSA and Satisfaction, always out of context. Leviticus is read through Calvin, not Moses. The cross is interpreted through Roman law, not Hebrew sacrifice.

Fear-Based Religion: PSA and Satisfaction theories rely on fear as the main motivator for belief. But *"perfect love casts out fear"* (1 John 4:18). If your gospel is based on terror, it is not *the good news for all people* (Luke 2:10).

Pagan Echoes: The idea of appeasing an angry deity through sacrifice echoes pagan religions, not Israel's covenantal worship.

Historical Latecomer: PSA and Satisfaction theories were not believed by the early church. They are products of the Catholic church (10th century) and the Reformation (16th century), foreign to both biblical Judaism and the earliest Christians.

I do not care whether you call yourself Catholic or Protestant. I have dear friends who are both—Protestant pastors and theologians, as well as Catholic theologians, priests, and even a Cardinal. Call yourself whatever your conscience allows. What concerns me is the vision of God, Jesus, and the gospel that you actually hold in your heart.

Western theories of atonement not only misrepresent God's character but also subtly shift the burden of salvation back onto us, making it depend on our intellectual beliefs, moral conduct, or the strength of our trust. But that's shaky ground. It breeds anxiety, not assurance, because deep down, you're never quite sure if you believe enough, understand correctly enough, do enough good, or trust deeply enough. Over time, this leads to emotional stress, spiritual exhaustion, and in many cases, deep discouragement and depression.

The true gospel, by contrast, brings peace (Matthew 11:28, John 14:27), not pressure. It shifts the weight off us and onto God. That's why it brings genuine rest, lasting peace of mind, and freedom for the soul—not a demand to perform or the correct boxes to check, but an invitation to let go of fear and trust in what has already been accomplished.

A Better Way: Life, Not Death, at the Center

PSA/Satisfaction glorifies death and violence, portraying God as a bloodthirsty sadist who finds satisfaction in bloodshed and death. But the true gospel reveals a God who heals, restores, and gives life—not one who demands a kill to be appeased. Jesus did not come to absorb God's violent wrath. He came to reveal God's loving face.

The cross is not about divine abuse. It is about participation. It is not a transaction. It is a transfusion. Jesus enters into our sinful world not to judge it but to save it. He joins us in our suffering and death, not to appease the Father but to heal humanity. His blood (life) and resurrection, not His torture and death, are the turning point of history.

As Bible scholar Michael Heiser wrote:

> Death was a problem that needed solving—for everyone. This makes the focal point of God's plan the resurrection, not the violent death. In other words, it ultimately wasn't the death of Jesus that brought about redemption for lost humanity. It was the resurrection.[62]
>
> (Dr. Michael Heiser)

In the logic of love, Jesus is not a stand-in for punishment; He is the Wounded Healer. The Loving Priest. The One who shows us that God does not abandon us in our suffering—He joins us in it so we can be transformed from the inside out.

Conclusion

Jesus did not die to change God's mind about us—from anger to kindness—He died to change our minds about God—to reveal that the Father has always been ready to forgive, restore, and embrace His lost creation.

Believing the wrong model of atonement tragically distorts not only the Gospel but also the character of God revealed in Jesus—turning the gospel of love, mercy, and reconciliation into a courtroom drama of violence, retribution, and anxiety.

Yet when we turn to the Hebrew Scriptures, we find a very different picture: one not painted in retribution but in restoration; not focused on appeasing rage but on renewing life and communal wholeness.

To recover the essence of biblical sacrifice is to rediscover not only what atonement truly meant for Israel, but also what it means to say that Jesus is our atoning Lamb—not a lamb smashed under God's boot, but one who brings life where there was death, purity where there was decay, and union where there was distance.

The gospel does not require cosmic torture to be powerful. It does not need a wrathful Father killing His Son to be moving. That is not love. That is not justice. That is sadism.

The cross is where God, in Christ, drinks the cup of human wrath, takes in our violence, and still chooses to forgive us. That's beauty—and more than enough.

Chapter 19

The True Climax of the Gospel

As we near the close of this section, every true story reaches the moment when its deepest meaning is finally unveiled—when everything that came before is revealed as preparation. In the gospel, that moment is not merely the death of Jesus. A story grounded in restoration rather than revenge cannot end with a corpse, but with the power that overcame it: *resurrection*. His blood—His very life—proved unconquerable, for it is of an eternal quality.

Let's summarize what we've learned so far.

Death could not hold what was never subject to corruption. And in conquering death, Jesus unveils the central truth of the gospel: that life, not destruction, is God's final word.

It is not His death that redeems, resurrects, and saves us—it's His precious blood that holds eternal life that does.

Jesus' blood was not like the blood of bulls and goats, which had to be offered repeatedly. His was different. His was incorruptible, infused with divine vitality. His blood was not just symbolic—it was eternal substance: *"How much more will the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered himself…"* (Hebrews 9:14)

Jesus' blood holds eternal worth and impact because His life itself is eternal in worth and effect.

This changes everything. It reframes the gospel away from appeasement-through-torture and centers it on transfusion of life, triumph of the resurrection over death, and restoration of relationship. The climax is not wrath being vented through divine violence—but life being poured out, shared, and never running dry.

This is why Scripture doesn't say, "God killed Jesus so He can spare you." It says:

*"…you were redeemed… with the precious **blood** [life] of Christ…" (1 Peter 1:18–19)*

*"…justified by His **blood** [life]…" (Romans 5:9)*

*"…redeemed through His **blood** [life]…" (Ephesians 1:7)*

*"…made holy through His **blood** [life]…" (Hebrews 13:12)*

*"…peace made through His **blood** [life]…" (Colossians 1:20)*

*"...freed us from our sins by His **blood** [life]..." (Revelation 1:5)*

Not one of these verses suggests Christ was God's punching bag.

Not one celebrates the violence done to Him.

All of them focus on His blood—because His blood held His life, and His life was divine.

Jesus's blood is not about the Father's anger. It is about death finally being defeated on our behalf.

The climax of the gospel is that God infused humanity with His own indestructible life to rescue it from perishing in the decay of sin and death.

The gospel is not death appeasing God. That's how pagans used to appease their gods. The gospel is not God demanding bloodshed like a mafia boss seeking satisfaction. The gospel is the God of life giving us eternal life through divine blood transfusion.

> *You have been brought near by the **blood** of Christ.*
>
> (Ephesians 2:13)

And this blood is not running out. It is not drying up. It is not locked in the past. It flows. Even now.

Life-Transferred—The Divine Blood Transfusion

Imagine this: a person is dying. Their organs are failing. Their face pale. Their breath shallow. The doctors rush in, not with anger, but with a gift—a blood bag, a lifeline. The needle pierces skin, and slowly, cell by cell, oxygen and life begin to flow back into their body.

They live—not because someone was punished, but because someone gave their blood.

This is the logic of the Gospel. Not a judge's gavel—a transfusion. A heart pouring its life into another. A loving parent giving their life for their children's sake.

And what is blood, if not life made visible? It carries breath, immunity, healing, energy. Blood flows to the body's wounds with an army of restoration. It knows where to go. It remembers where the pain is. It rushes to heal.

Jesus' blood does the same. God didn't kill Christ *instead* of killing us. Christ died *for* us—so He could cover us with His blood—give us His life.

Now, read it together:

"Drink from it, all of you. This is My blood" (Matthew 26:27-28). ***"Unless you drink the blood, you have no life in you."*** (John 6:53).

These words once scandalized His listeners. And rightly so. But Jesus was not inviting cannibalism. He was unveiling the mystery of union. To drink His blood is to receive His life-force—His divine vitality—eternal life into our own mortal bodies. It is to become, as Paul says, *"a new creation"* (2 Corinthians 5:17). Mystically. Truly.

The blood of Christ flows to the wound of the world—death. And it fills that wound with eternal life that cannot die.

This is not theology for the mind alone. This is medicine for the soul.

The old sacrifices offered temporary healing and purification because animals are mortal. But Christ is immortal, and His blood, once for all, reaches deeper. It does not just clean the outer man. It cleanses the conscience (Hebrews 9:14). It does not merely forgive—it renews.

Now, read it together:

"The life is in the blood..." (Leviticus 17:11) ***"...and the blood of Jesus, His Son, purifies us from all sin."*** (1 John 1:7).

The logic is ancient. The Spirit is eternal. The effect is immediate.

His blood received; our life renewed (Romans 6:4).

The Final Cleansing — Why Life in the Blood Conquers Death Forever

If the story of humanity is the story of exile from life, then the story of redemption is the story of returning to it. But how does one return to life while still surrounded by death?

The Hebrew Scriptures offer a radical answer: life is stronger than death—when it's divine.

This is why blood was always the chosen symbol. Not because it was grotesque, but because it was the most intimate, most vital, most sacred part of living existence. It spoke of lineage and covenant. It signified the unseen miracle that made dust live. It carried oxygen and power—it carried life!

And that is why, in the Tabernacle and later in the Temple, blood became the purifier. It was the great cleanser—not of dirt, but of death's stain. Just as we instinctively reached for sanitizer during the pandemic after shaking a hand or touching a doorknob, so Israel instinctively turned to blood as the deep spiritual solvent:

> *In fact, the law requires that nearly everything be cleansed with blood, and without the shedding of blood there is no remission.*
>
> (Hebrews 9:22)

It's not because God seeks death and violence, but because without the giving of life, there is no reversal of death.

Unlike the pagans, Israel's sacrificial system was never about vengeance. It was about life and relationship.

It allowed the people to draw near again. It restored the relationship. It cleaned the sanctuary—first the Tabernacle, then the Temple, and finally the human heart.

And now, through Jesus—the true Lamb, the eternal High Priest, the indestructible Tabernacle—the final cleansing has come.

His blood did what no sacrifice before could do. It cleansed not only for a period, but for infinity. Not only space, but conscience. Not just impurity, but identity. Not just the physical altar, but the inner soul.

Jesus' blood didn't just cover sin—it removed it. It didn't just postpone death—it defeated it:

The sting of death is sin, and the power of sin is the law. But thanks be to God! He gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ.

(1 Corinthians 15:56–57)

This is the triumph at the center of the gospel—not wrath satisfied, but death swallowed up.

Not torment glorified, but life resurrected. Not condemnation declared, but creation restored.

Jesus didn't come to be tortured for us. He came to donate His life—His blood—for us. He came to transfuse us with eternal breath.

In the end, blood was not the symbol of how angry God was about sin. It was the symbol of how far God would go to reclaim the world He loves.

So, we end where we began:

*The **life** is in the **blood**... and I have given it to you.*

(Leviticus 17:11)

He has given it. Freely. Fully. Forever. And it is enough.

Amen.

Part III: A Hebrew Perspective on Christ's Atonement

Many Christians focus so narrowly on sin that they miss the larger horizon of the cross. Yes—sins were forgiven, cleansed, and removed. Yes—the resurrection of the dead was secured through Jesus' victory. But forgiveness, as central as it is, was not the whole story. What else was accomplished on that cross? What ancient drama reached its climax in that moment? And how did a single event in history reframe the entire trajectory of humanity's shared story?

Throughout history, the Church has proposed multiple theories to explain Christ's death, some of which overlap—even if imperfectly—with the Bible's own theology of atonement. When the cross is read within its original Hebrew and biblical framework, it emerges as far more than merely a mechanism for dealing with "our sins." It stands as the climactic convergence of covenantal, cosmic, and restorative themes that are too often overlooked.

With that in mind, I invite us to examine the cross within its Hebraic context, highlighting five frequently neglected dimensions of Christ's atonement:

1. Christ Died Because He Was Our Perfect **King-Redeemer**
2. Christ Died Because He Was Our Perfect **Chief Rabbi**
3. Christ Died Because He Was Our Perfect **Scapegoat**
4. Christ Died Because He Was Our Perfect **High Priest**
5. Christ Died Because He Was Our Perfect **Life-Giving Healer**

Chapter 20

Jesus Died Because He Was Our Perfect King-Redeemer

To understand the heart of the King of Israel, start here: He's not only a warrior, not only just, not only powerful—He's a Redeemer.

Throughout countless movies, legends, and fantasy epics, kings are portrayed as power-hungry rulers—enthroned in towering castles, surrounded by elite soldiers, insulated from the pain and cries of ordinary people, and feared more than loved. Their strength is measured by the size of their armies, their wealth by the

walls that hide them, and their authority by how easily they can crush those beneath them. But this is not the kind of king Jesus is—not even close.

The heartbeat of the Torah is the God who saves—tangibly and literally. The God who sees His people in bondage and moves heaven and earth to set them free.

Consider how God first introduced Himself to Israel:

> *I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of Egypt, out of the land of slavery.*
>
> (Exodus 20:2)

This is the same God who, just days earlier, had instructed the Israelites to offer something precious—a lamb (Exodus 12:3-7). In a slave economy, where every possession carried immense value, letting go of a lamb was not a small gesture; it was a profound act of sacrificial faith. Yet what they were about to receive in return was infinitely greater: redemption.

The Act of Redemption

The way for an Israelite to redeem something in the Torah was simple: You gave something in return.

If you wanted to redeem land or property, you paid its price (Leviticus 25:25).

If a poor family member sold themselves into slavery, a *GOEL*— a kinsman-redeemer—could buy them back, paying whatever was necessary to restore them (Leviticus 25:47-49).

Redemption always cost the Israelite something.

And there is no greater love than redeeming someone at the highest cost of all—by giving your life for them:

> *Greater love has no one than this: to lay down one's life for one's friends.*
>
> (John 15:13)

Indeed, in the ancient world, a great king was often also a mighty warrior. Israel knew this. Their greatest hope was for a King Messiah who would set Israel free from Roman occupation. But God's wisdom far surpassed the logic of human warfare. The occupation He came to dismantle was far greater than Rome alone—a domination deeper than legions and banners, aimed not merely at an empire, but at the enslaving powers behind every empire.

So, Jesus was a King, but with strategies no human general could fathom. He conquered not by taking life—but by giving His own.

He staged the ultimate rescue mission in history. He came to overthrow the ancient serpent of Genesis 3. He came to drive out the ruler of this world. He came to break the chains of death and liberate humanity from its slavery to sin and fear.

Jesus: The Perfect King-Redeemer

Jesus was not merely another redeemer—one more heroic figure rescuing an individual or even a nation, as history has seen many times before. He is the perfect, final, and ultimate King-Redeemer, who came to save

not a fragment of humanity but the whole world. He is the God who is truly Mighty to Save—the Lion of Judah. And yet, He is the divine warrior-King who conquers without crushing, who saves without domination, who triumphs not through force but through self-giving sacrifice.

Few have captured this paradox more vividly than C. S. Lewis in *The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe*. Edmund, seduced and enslaved by the White Witch—a clear satanic figure—becomes a traitor, bound by the Law of Narnia, which demands his life as payment. The Witch insists on her "right" to Edmund, not because Aslan—the Christ figure—demands blood for sin, but because evil feeds on accusation, fear, and legalistic condemnation. The demand does not originate in goodness; it originates in the logic of the Accuser.

Aslan steps forward, not to appease a wrathful God, but to rescue Edmund from the enemy's grasp. He offers His life in Edmund's place—not out of legal necessity, but out of love. This is substitution reframed: not a divine demand for a kill, but a deliberate act of liberation.

Here Lewis stands in sharp contrast to Penal Substitutionary Atonement. In The Chronicles of Narnia, the sacrifice is not offered to placate God, but to free the captive. It is not God who kills the Son; it is Satan who overreaches. The Father does not require death to forgive—the Accuser demands death to maintain control. And in pressing his claim, he unwittingly engineers his own defeat.

The Witch accepts the bargain, convinced she has won. But she does not understand what Lewis describes as "the deep magic" of love—the divine logic written before accusation, before violence, before death itself.

Aslan rises. Death is undone. The Witch's power collapses. Edmund is redeemed—not from God, but from the dominion of evil.

Picture it like this:

A child is lured away from safety by a stranger's lies. Despite every warning, the child follows, deceived and captured. The parent does not stop loving the child. The parent does not want to kill the child or torture them forever because they rebelled and didn't follow instructions. The parent does not leave them enslaved. No—the parent goes after them, confronts the captor, and offers themselves as a ransom to set the child free.

This is what Jesus did for us and why He is our perfect King-Redeemer.

In this way, Lewis gives narrative flesh to a profoundly biblical truth: Jesus, the Lion of Judah, does not save us from His wrathful Father, but from the grip of Satan. He conquers not by killing His enemies, but by absorbing their violence and nullifying their claims. His greatest weapon is not domination, but sacrificial love—and that love proves unstoppable.

The Ransom Motif: A Biblical Pattern of Liberation

The New Testament speaks powerfully of Jesus' death as a *ransom*—a price paid to liberate captives from bondage:

> *For even the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a* ***ransom*** *for many.*
>
> (Mark 10:45)

> *For there is one God and one mediator between God and mankind, the man Christ Jesus, who gave himself as a* ***ransom*** *for all people.*
>
> (1 Timothy 2:5-6)

Much like the witch-deceiver who lures Edmund in the Narnia story, humanity's fall in Genesis 3 led to a catastrophic spiritual captivity. We exchanged the voice of God for the lie of the serpent—and in doing so, came under the dominion of Satan: the accuser, the deceiver, the one who holds the power of death (Hebrews 2:14). From that moment, the human story was marked by exile, bondage, and the desperate need for rescue.

But God, the King of redemption, did not abandon His creation:

> *Since the children have flesh and blood, he too shared in their humanity so that by his death he might break the power of him who holds the power of death—that is, the devil—and free those who all their lives were held in slavery by their fear of death.*
>
> (Hebrews 2:14-15)

The Cosmic Drama: Jesus vs. Satan

The cross was not only a sacrifice—it was a battlefield. It was a cosmic confrontation between the forces of

darkness and our perfect King-Redeemer. Satan thought he could destroy Jesus through death—but God used Satan's own weapons against him.

Paul describes it like this:

> *When you were dead in your sins... God made you alive with Christ... having disarmed the powers and authorities, he made a public spectacle of them, triumphing over them by the cross.*
>
> (Colossians 2:13-15)

Imagine it: the cross as a divine trap. Satan, blind with pride, rage and greed, reached out to seize Jesus—not realizing that the very act of killing Him would be his own defeat:

> *None of the rulers of this age understood it, for if they had, they would not have crucified the Lord of glory.*
>
> (1 Corinthians 2:8)

God outmaneuvered Satan entirely. He did not answer violence with greater violence, but unveiled a superior wisdom: love. Self-sacrificial love became the ultimate strategy—the true antidote to sin and its consequence, death itself.

This is why Jesus spoke of coming to *"plunder the house of the strong man"* (Luke 11:21-22).

This is why John says Jesus came *"to destroy the works of the devil"* (1 John 3:8).

This is why Jesus proclaimed: *"Now the ruler of this world will be driven out"* (John 12:31).

Our King-Redeemer has defeated the ruler of this world.

Chapter 21

Jesus Died Because He Was Our Perfect Chief Rabbi

In the world of ancient Israel, a rabbi was far more than a schoolteacher or lecturer. A rabbi was not someone who merely stood in front of a classroom with a board and notes. No—a rabbi embodied truth. A Rabbi lived the lesson. A Rabbi taught with flesh and blood.

Gurus often retreat into mountains with their disciples, far from anything that might provoke or disturb them. A rabbi, however, walks the same soil as everyone else—shouldering the same dust, breathing the same air, sharing the same struggles.

To follow a rabbi in the Jewish world was to imitate his entire way of life—not merely to memorize his teachings, but to walk in his footsteps. It meant learning how to speak as he spoke, act as he acted, and respond to the world as he responded.

This is why the Gospels portray Jesus repeatedly saying, "Follow me." It was not an invitation to a classroom, but a summons to a radically new way of being human. It was a call to wash the feet of sinners, to forgive one's enemies, and to extend mercy to those who do not deserve it.

The Rabbi Who Became a Servant

Rabbi Yeshua, then, is not merely the world's greatest spiritual teacher—He is the embodiment of God's wisdom lived out in real life. And while He taught using parables (Matthew 13:34), His greatest lesson was not with a sermon—but with His own life and death.

Rabbi Yeshua taught love not in theory, but in scars.

His death revealed that true love is sacrificial, but also exposed the moral bankruptcy of this world. Humanity, left to itself, crucified its only Righteous One. That is the ultimate commentary on human systems, politics, religion, and power—we murdered Love when He walked among us:

> *This is the verdict: Light has come into the world, but people loved darkness instead of light because their deeds were evil.*
>
> (John 3:19)

His death reflects our injustice, but it also reflects God's merciful justice—instead of retaliating with violence, Jesus answered with self-sacrifice. Instead of calling down legions of angels to avenge His blood, He forgave His enemies. Instead of condemning the world, He laid down His life to save it. What a spectacular lesson our rabbi taught us about God's love!

This is what separates Rabbi Yeshua from every other teacher in history. He did not only teach about sacrificial love—He fully incarnated it.

And this is what the early Church came to understand. Christ's death was not about God dying in some metaphysical sense (since God cannot cease to exist). Rather, it was about God demonstrating, within time and space, the highest form of love imaginable—a love willing to enter suffering, a love willing to die with us and for us.

Now We Know How to Love

> *We love because He first loved us.*
>
> (1 John 4:19)

Rabbi Yeshua didn't just teach us *what* love is; he showed us *how* to love. His death became the ultimate moral lesson. A lesson designed not to satisfy divine anger—but to awaken lifeless hearts, for such an act can soften even the hardest ones.

Before Jesus, humanity understood love through instinct or self-interest. But at the cross, we learned a new definition: Love is self-giving and all-inclusive (yes, even for His enemies).

Love is the willingness to lose so another may gain. To lower oneself so another may rise. To forgo life so another may live.

This is why Jesus is different from Muhammad; he draws us not through intimidation or terror, but through love.

This is the Rabbi we follow. He doesn't win us over by force; he wins us with his kindness.

He does not demand our obedience out of fear. He awakens our hearts by grace.

Mary Magdalene became a living example of this. Having experienced the redeeming love of her Rabbi, she devoted her life to Him—not out of guilt, not out of fear, but out of love awakened by love.

Similarly, Jesus' disciples weren't defined by doctrine or creed—which they knew nothing about—but by love:

> *By this everyone will know that you are my disciples, if you* ***love*** *one another.*
>
> (John 13:35)

This understanding of the cross tells us that Jesus' death was meant not to appease divine rage but to spark a moral awakening—to shatter our selfishness, to melt our hardened hearts, to provoke us to turn from darkness to light. Only love has this power.

Love heals wounds no argument can heal.

Love restores relationships no punishment can restore.

Love reconciles enemies no sword can reconcile.

Yeshua is not only the Lord of lords but also the Rabbi of rabbis. He died to teach God's love in a way that would never fade into a distant memory of history, but remain a vivid, unforgettable demonstration—an everlasting reminder—of just how far God's love will go to redeem and restore His creation.

This is why He died. So that we, watching Love lay down its life, would be forever changed—and then go and do likewise—lay down our lives for those we love, and even for the sake of those who do not love us back.

Chapter 22

Jesus Died Because He Was Our Perfect Scapegoat

Human beings are imitators by nature. We do not desire in isolation; we learn what to desire by watching others. When everyone in a community reaches for the same things—status, power, approval—desire intensifies into rivalry. Rivalry becomes conflict, and conflict threatens to tear a society apart. When communal tension reaches its breaking point, history shows us what fearful humans instinctively do: they turn to a scapegoat. A single individual or group—often the Jews—absorbs the blame, the anxiety, the rage of the

community. Violence is redirected onto the chosen victim, and—at least temporarily—the community feels appeased, cleansed, relieved, restored. The feeling of peace is real, but the mechanism is dark.

Throughout history—in tribes, in nations, in religions—societies have found temporary peace by placing collective blame on a single individual or group. From the early Christian persecutions in the Roman Empire to the brutal targeting of Jewish communities during the Black Death, the hysteria-driven trials of the Salem "witches" in the 1690s, and even the conviction of Sacco and Vanzetti in 1920s Boston. This "scapegoat" is rarely guilty of the crime. Their guilt is constructed. Their "otherness" is magnified. Their removal or death becomes the false solution to the community's crisis. A collective catharsis.

The violence poured out on them is not justice—it is survival disguised as justice.

We can see an aspect of this pattern in the *Yom Kippur* scapegoat, not as divine endorsement of violence, but as a sacred exposure of a human impulse. The scapegoat did not appease God's wrath; it symbolically carried the accumulated sins, failures, and communal burdens *away* from the people, into the wilderness, where they no longer defined the community. In doing so, the ritual acknowledged a deep truth about human psychology: our tendency to externalize guilt and seek relief by transferring blame onto another. The biblical ritual restrains that instinct, ritualizes it, and empties it of bloodshed. The scapegoat reveals how easily humans reduce redemption to removal, justice to expulsion, and righteousness to mere relief—an error later generations repeated by transforming symbolic, corrective rituals into literal systems of punishment and everlasting blame.

The Cross that Exposes Our Violence

Jesus is the ultimate scapegoat. He is the innocent One. The blameless One. The One who embodied truth, love, and purity—and yet was hated, rejected, accused, tortured, and executed.

Why? Because His very presence revealed the brokenness of human systems.

When Jesus stood before the religious leaders, before Pilate, before the angry mob, it was not divine justice that demanded His death—it was human rage, envy, fear, and hate.

The religious leaders coveted His influence. The political powers feared His kingship. The crowd, whipped into a mimetic frenzy, cried out for blood: *"Crucify Him!"* (Mark 15:13)

But unlike all previous scapegoats in history—whose death maintained the illusion of justice—Jesus shattered the mechanism forever. Because God raised Him from the dead.

The resurrection was not only the defeat of death—it was the public vindication of the Victim.

It declared once and for all: This Man was innocent. This violence was unjust. This system is corrupt.

In this view, the power of the cross lies here—in exposing humanity's darkest habit: the need to blame, exclude, and destroy those we fear or envy, even if they are good and righteous.

The cross is both salvation and indictment. It exposes how far we are willing to go to defend our illusions of righteousness and our distorted sense of justice—especially when those impulses are baptized in religious language. When unnecessary violence is justified in the name of divine law, what is being served is not God's justice but humanity's desire to sanctify murder by dressing it in holiness.[63] And yet, the cross also saves us. It absorbs our violence without returning it, receives our hatred without retaliation. This is the depth of God's love for us—a love that confronts us truthfully without abandoning us to despair.

The cross and resurrection together form the loudest call to a new kind of humanity. A life free from rivalry. A life free from violence. A life rooted in forgiveness, compassion, and reconciliation.

Here, Jesus did not die to satisfy God's wrath and anger. He died to expose humanity's.

He died as the perfect Scapegoat—willingly (John 10:17–18) entering into our violence, bearing it, and then rising to offer life instead of revenge.

He died to teach us that the way forward is not through exclusion, but embrace. Not through retaliation, but reconciliation.

This is the kingdom Jesus inaugurated. This is the path He walked. And this is the way He calls us to follow. To stop participating in the most ancient game of blame (Genesis 3:12-13). To stop scapegoating others to

secure our fragile sense of worth. To become, like Him, people of mercy—people of forgiveness. Individuals who embody radical love, even in the face of injustice. Jesus not only preached this, but He also exemplified it at the very peak of His unjust suffering (Luke 23:34).

Golgotha—Human Corruption Meets Divine Love

Golgotha stands as the summit of humanity's darkest crimes—pride, rivalry, vengeance, scapegoating, and the lust for power and domination—all laid bare and brought under judgment.

It was the moment when human civilization, with all its claims of order and justice, was unmasked for what it truly is: a power struggle maintained by violence so corrupt that it did not hesitate to crucify the Son of God Himself in the name of "truth," "justice," and "righteousness."

Yet Golgotha is not only the site of humanity's greatest sin—it is also the place where we encounter the greatest revelation of divine grace. There, in the suffering of Christ, we see sacrificial love in its purest and most powerful form: a love that absorbs violence without returning it, that forgives while being pierced, and that conquers not by killing, but by dying.

Thus, to gaze at the cross is to see more than wood and nails. It is to see every twisted impulse of the human heart exposed—and every wound answered by grace.

He took the lies we believed, carried the shame we bear, and absorbed the judgment meant for His accusers. But that's not where it ends. The cross isn't just a mirror—it's a window. Through it, we see God as He truly is: not proud or vengeful, but forgiving and full of self-giving love. A God who walks through our poison to bring healing. A God who takes the very image of the curse and turns it into salvation.

And so the pattern breaks: the Victim rises. Other societies silenced their fears by casting blame on the innocent, but Jesus unmasks the lie and rewrites the script.

The cross shows us who we are; the resurrection shows us who God is.

In Him, the scapegoat does not stay dead—He becomes the cornerstone of a new humanity—a Kingdom no longer built on rivalry, fear, and violence, but on forgiveness, mercy, and reconciling love. This is the path He opens. This is the life He calls us to step into.

Chapter 23

Jesus Died Because He Was Our Perfect High Priest

While Scripture names only one person—Jesus—as a mediator, Moses, Israel, and the Church were all called to function in a priestly role (Exodus 19:6; 1 Peter 2:9). In ancient Israel, the priest stood at the intersection between heaven and earth. A priest was not simply a religious official performing rituals—a priest was a representative. The priest bore the name, identity, and hopes of Israel before the living God. He was Israel's bridge.

But Israel's priests were only shadows—limited, temporary, flawed. No priest could truly represent Israel perfectly before God. Their sacrifices had to be repeated. Their own sins had to be atoned for before they could intercede for others.

This is why the apostle John, in his heavenly vision, broke down in tears when he saw the scroll of God's ultimate purposes sealed shut—because no one in heaven or on earth was found worthy to open it (Revelation 5:1-4). Creation longed for a priest—a true mediator—but none could be found.

Until Jesus:

> *See, the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has triumphed. He is able to open the scroll and its seven seals!*
>
> (Revelation 5:5)

Jesus is the Great High Priest that Israel—and the world—had been waiting for. But He was not a priest like the others.

Israel's priests entered the Holy of Holies with the blood of bulls and goats. But Jesus entered the true heavenly sanctuary with His own blood—His own life—offered willingly on behalf of the world:

> *But when Christ came as high priest... he entered the Most Holy Place once for all by his own blood, thus obtaining* ***eternal*** *redemption.*
>
> (Hebrews 9:11-12)

Here, "eternal" does not refer to time in the later Greek-philosophical sense—it refers to *quality* rather than duration.

When Hebrews' mysterious author[64] wrote that Christ *"obtained eternal redemption,"* he is not saying Jesus' blood lasts longer than time. Rather, he is saying that Christ's blood is of a different order—a heavenly, incorruptible, divine kind. Thus *eternal*, not by quantity but by *quality*.

The Perfect Priest, The Perfect Representative

To be a priest is to represent your people (Exodus 28:1, Leviticus 9:22, and Numbers 6:22–27). But how could Jesus represent us—the human race—unless He became one of us Himself?

This is why the New Testament emphasizes that Jesus lived the full human story. He did not skip childhood. He did not bypass hunger, exhaustion, or loneliness. He even died. Christ entered fully into the human experience—but unlike Adam, who can be seen as humanity's first priest, Christ responded with perfect obedience.

Christ's obedience was infinitely more demanding. Adam fell in a paradisiacal garden surrounded by beauty, with only one restriction to keep. Jesus, by contrast, obeyed in the garden of Gethsemane—a garden not of delight but of anguish. In that wilderness of suffering, under the crushing weight of the Law, abandoned by friends, surrounded by enemies, and staring straight into the cup of death, He did not flinch.

Where Adam failed in ease, Jesus was faithful in agony.

Adam listened to the voice of the serpent. Jesus crushed the serpent's head by listening to the voice of His Father.

Christ as Our Patriarch

In ancient Israel, the patriarch—in a sense the family's priest—carried the destiny of his entire household. His choices shaped the fate of everyone under his authority. If he sinned, the family suffered the consequences; if he triumphed, the family shared in the blessing. This is why we read that Achan's household faced judgment alongside him (Joshua 7:1–26), and why Korah and his household were swallowed up together (Numbers 16:1–35). Their stories reflect an ancient communal worldview: the head represents the body, and the body participates in the outcome of its representative.

When the first priest—Adam—sinned, humanity inherited *death*.

When the perfect priest—Christ—obeyed, humanity inherited *life*.

This is why Paul calls Jesus the "Second Adam"—the New Patriarch-Priest of a New Humanity.

And since Adam's decision brought death upon humanity. Christ's faithfulness brought life:

> *For since death came through a man, the resurrection of the dead comes also through a man. For as in Adam **all** die, so in Christ **all** will be made alive.*
>
> (1 Corinthians 15:21-22)

Just as David fought Goliath not merely for himself but on behalf of all Israel—so Jesus fought against sin, death, and Satan on behalf of humanity.

This is not merely symbolic. It is covenantal. This is why Scripture says:

> *Just as sin entered the world through one man, and death through sin, and in this way death came to all people...For just as through the disobedience of the one man the many were made sinners, so also through the obedience of the one man the many will be made righteous.*
>
> (Romans 5:12, 19)

Our Living Priest Intercedes for Us

Jesus' priesthood didn't end at the cross. His life on earth was the offering, and upon ascending, He continues His ongoing priesthood. Right now, at this very moment, Jesus stands at the right hand of God, representing us, interceding for us, advocating for us as our perfect High Priest:

> *Christ Jesus who died—more than that, who was raised to life—is at the right hand of God and is also interceding for us.*
>
> (Romans 8:34)

Jesus' intercession does not mean He is persuading a reluctant Father to forgive us—as if God were still angry after the cross. Rather, to intercede means to represent, advocate, and continually mediate God's grace to

humanity—**God is on our side** (1 John 2:1, Hebrews 7:25)! His work on the cross accomplished forgiveness once and for all, but His ongoing intercession means that the risen Christ remains our living High Priest, constantly bringing humanity into reconciliation with God. It is not about changing God's mind, but about applying and sustaining the healing and restoration that the cross already accomplished.

No earthly priest could do this. No Levitical sacrifice could achieve this. Only Jesus—our High Priest—could stand before God and represent humanity with nail-scarred hands.

This is the beauty of priestly atonement in the Hebrew Scriptures. Not wrath-appeasement. Not divine sadism. But covenant representation. Sacrificial love.

This is why He died. This is why He lives. And this is why we can approach the throne of God with confidence. He is our Perfect Priest. Forever.

> *Therefore, brothers and sisters, since we have confidence to enter the Most Holy Place by the blood of Jesus... let us draw near to God with a sincere heart and with the full assurance that faith brings.*
>
> (Hebrews 10:19, 22)

We are redeemed because He was faithful, not because we are.

Chapter 24

Jesus Died Because He Was Our Perfect Life-Giving Healer

If God could die—truly die—He would cease to be God. This is a fundamental truth that sits at the very heart of biblical theology. God is, by definition, life itself. God is uncreated, unkillable, eternal, everlasting, and overflowing with being. Mortality belongs to creation, not to the Creator.

This is why when we speak of Jesus' death, we are not talking about God ceasing to exist—but about God, in Christ, entering into human death so that He might conquer it from within—like a cure, a secret potion, a

divine antidote to a deadly illness. For humanity to overcome death, we needed something greater than fragile human life—we needed divine, eternal life.

"O Death, Where Is Your Victory?"

All of us are subject to the curse of death. Even those whom Christ graciously resurrected—like Lazarus—died again. Their life was restored temporarily. It was a gift—but it was not yet victory over death. Why? Because death can always reclaim what is merely human. But death has no claim over what is divine.

This is why Jesus is not merely another prophet. Not merely another martyr. Not merely another holy man who died for a good cause. Jesus is the life-giving Healer because He carries within Himself the life of God—eternal, incorruptible, deathless life. This is the logic underlying Jesus's mystical statement: *"For the bread of God is the bread that comes down from heaven and gives life to the world"* (John 6:33), and why he later declared, *"I am the living bread that came down from heaven"* (John 6:51).

Jesus is not only the one who teaches the way to life—He is the source of life. Jesus feeds us with His own divine life. To eat of His flesh and drink of His blood is to mystically participate in the life of God Himself—a life stronger than death.

If Jesus were merely human, then His death would have been heroic, tragic, but powerless. Like every righteous sufferer before Him, He might have been vindicated, remembered, or even resurrected temporarily—but His blood would not have the power to give life.

But Jesus is the divinity who *"made himself nothing by taking the very nature of a servant, being made in human likeness"* (Philippians 2:7). Thus, death could not hold Him because death has no true power over divinity. This is why Jesus could say with unshakable confidence:

> *I give them eternal life, and they shall never perish; no one will snatch them out of my hand.*
>
> (John 10:28)

Notice: not, "I will *show* them eternal life." Not, "I will *teach* them about eternal life." But simply, "I *give* them eternal life."

And Jesus wasn't thinking of just a select few. Later, He explains:

> *And I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw* ***all people*** *to myself.*
>
> (John 12:32)

This is why the entire New Testament—from the Gospels to the letters of Paul to the book of Revelation—insists that eternal life—the kind that resurrects—is not found in a holy place, religious system, or even a set of creeds and doctrines. It is found in the Creator revealed to us through Christ. He's not just our priest, He's the one who gives us life.

Life is relational. Life is connection. Life flows from God—through Christ—to us.

Just as a branch withers and dies when separated from the vine, so humanity was withering under the curse of exile and death because it was cut off from the Tree of Life.

Jesus came to graft humanity back in; to reconnect us to the very life of God, and to heal us with eternal life.

Jesus Did Not Die to Suffer Divine Wrath—
He Died to Pour Out His Life

For I am the LORD who heals you.

(Exodus 15:26)

His death was not a defeat. His death was a doorway. He entered death willingly—so that He could destroy it from within. Christ can be imagined as a divine Physician who enters a quarantined city ravaged by plague—not to be overcome by the disease, but to cure it with His own incorruptible life. The inhabitants, already transformed into something less than human, fail to recognize the Healer and kill Him instead. Yet His blood—saturated with the antidote—spills into the streets, spreads through the city, and reverses the infection of death itself, restoring life where decay once ruled.

Jesus, as the life-giving healer, absorbed the full weight of human death—and then reversed it.

If *"the wages of sin is death"* (Romans 6:23), then death itself is the visible consequence and power of sin. That's why Paul can later say, *"The last enemy to be destroyed is death"* (1 Corinthians 15:26). Once death is gone—out of the equation—the very wage of sin is gone. Meaning sin/death has been fully overcome. In other words, God's final victory isn't just forgiving sins—it's erasing their ultimate consequence: death itself!

This is why Paul can declare in triumph:

> *Death has been swallowed up in victory! Where, O death, is your victory? Where, O death, is your sting?*
>
> (1 Corinthians 15:54-55)

If *eternal life* has been flowing into the world since and through the life of Christ our Healer, then death has truly lost its power.

But if eternal life is reduced to an escape plan—an afterlife destination earned through intellectual assent or moral performance—then death was never truly defeated, nor was it the final enemy at all.

You Already Have Eternal Life

Throughout his gospel, John repeatedly emphasizes that the believer already *"**has** eternal life"* (e.g., John 6:47; 5:24). And in his letter:

> *I write these things to you who believe in the name of the Son of God so that you may know that you **have** eternal life.*
>
> (1 John 5:13)

Notice the verb tense: has/have, not "will have someday after death" and not "will receive only at the resurrection." If *"eternal life"* were primarily about the quantity of days—about unending time—then believers wouldn't die at all. But they do.

This reveals something crucial: *eternal life* is first and foremost about quality, not duration. It is a *kind* of life—God's life—breaking into the present. A life one can begin to experience now through union with Christ, long before the resurrection completes it.

John isn't merely promising immortality later; he is declaring a transformed life now—a participation in God's own eternal reality that reshapes how we live, love, and understand the world even in this moment.

We do not follow a dead teacher. We do not follow a fallen martyr. We follow the living Lord—the Great Healer—whose life *now* flows in us like living water.

> *I have come that they may have life, and have it abundantly.*
>
> (John 10:10)

We needed eternal, divine life. And through Jesus, we have it. Not life after death only—but life stronger than death. Eternal life is a vivid, divine, and powerful life that begins now.

Jesus's death was far greater than handing out "get to heaven" tickets to those who recite a specific prayer or subscribe to the right doctrinal formula. He came to redeem the entire human story. He came to shed His

life-giving blood into the world. His mission was to restore creation, heal what was broken, and reconcile all things to God (Colossians 1:20). The cross wasn't the end of a transaction—it was a life transfusion that began a cosmic transformation.

Final Conclusion—Why Jesus Died

As our **King-Redeemer**, He didn't seize power; He surrendered it. He ransomed us not with armies or threats, but with His own life, breaking the grip of evil through self-giving love. As our **chief Rabbi**, He didn't just instruct us with words, but taught us with wounds. His death was His greatest sermon—a living parable of divine sacrificial love that melts hardened hearts and calls us to live by that same love. As the **ultimate Scapegoat**, Jesus absorbed humanity's blame and exposed our systems of violence for what they truly are: unjust, broken, and in need of healing. By bearing our rejection and rising again, He didn't validate our wrath—He dismantled it.

He is also the **High Priest** who didn't just stand in for us—He stepped into our full humanity, carried it, and redeemed it. In Him, the barrier between heaven and earth was torn, and we now stand welcomed. But even

more than that, He is the **divine Healer** who didn't avoid death—He walked straight into it to destroy it from the inside out. He gave us not just forgiveness, but eternal life—His life—a life stronger than death, pulsing now through all who believe.

Jesus didn't die to satisfy vengeance. He died to infuse the dying world with indestructible life. And because of that, the world is not just saved—it is slowly made new.

In the chapters ahead, we'll dive into the question—what are we really saved from, and what does salvation actually mean.

Part IV: Understanding Salvation

Introduction: Salvation—Not What You've Been Taught

Every Christmas, Christians across the world gather to worship, singing songs of deliverance and celebrating a Savior who came to save the world. Yet few ever stop to ask the most basic and unsettling questions: Save *what*? Save *from* what? Save *whom*? Save *how*? And save for what *purpose*?

Soteriology—salvation—is among the most debated and most misunderstood doctrines in modern Christianity, both in what it claims to mean and in the questions it dares—or refuses—to ask.

In this section of the book, we will not approach salvation through the inherited lenses of evangelical revivalism, Baptist preaching, Calvinist systems, or Catholic scholasticism. Instead, we will return to the original scene—to the soil, language, and worldview in which the gospel was first proclaimed. We must set aside medieval categories and Western philosophical abstractions and listen again to the heartbeat of the biblical story itself. But before we can do that, we must first understand how we arrived at our current assumptions—and how far they have carried us from the original vision.

Chapter 25

When Greek Dualism Hijacked the Christian Faith

As Christianity moved westward, it absorbed the dualisms of Greek philosophy and Gnostic speculation. In these systems, the world is a battleground—spirit versus matter, light versus darkness, soul versus body. The material world is often viewed with suspicion, even contempt. The ultimate goal becomes escape—"going to heaven" and leaving the "evil" world behind to burst in flames.

This dualism finds echoes in modern Christian debates, especially where salvation is framed as individual and intellectual, and the world is seen as disposable. The Greek mind, focused on individualism, knowledge *(gnosis)*, intellectual truth and escapism, replaced the biblical and Jewish emphasis on relationship, action, and community restoration.

When Christians adopt the belief that matter is worthless, corrupt, or ultimately doomed, the consequences are devastating. The world becomes disposable (despite our calling in Genesis 1:28). Care for creation is sidelined. The body is neglected. The poor and the suffering are reduced to "spiritual problems" to be explained away, rather than brothers and sisters to be loved, fed, and clothed.

But Jesus—and the ancient Jewish tradition He stood within—insist on the opposite: the world is worth saving (John 3:17). Judaism called this *tikkun olam*—the restoration of the world. This vision shifts the gospel away from the Greek fantasy of the soul escaping the body and toward the biblical hope of bodily resurrection. It declares that the physical world matters, that it is redeemable, and therefore worth loving. Every act of kindness, every work of justice, every moment of beauty becomes a place where God's *salvation* can break into the present.

Ironically, the resurrection is the most anti-dualistic doctrine in all of Scripture. It proclaims that we are not souls trapped in bodies waiting to escape, but embodied beings—soul and body inseparably woven together as

a homogenized whole. You cannot fully live without your body, because God never created you as a fragment. From the beginning, you were meant to be whole.

This is why, in the earliest proclamation of the gospel, salvation did not mean fleeing the physical world. It meant redeeming it.

We Are Not Ghosts Seeking Escape from the Evil Body

The Gnostic distinction between body and soul is not supported by the Bible. According to biblical teachings, the dead do not ascend to a different place known as "heaven" or "hell." Instead, they are merely dead, or, using biblical terminology, "asleep."

Jesus, speaking about Lazarus, said, *"Our friend Lazarus has fallen asleep; but I am going there to wake him up."* (John 11:11). Jesus did not ascend to heaven (or hell) to pull Lazarus back to life in our world. He simply raised him—saved him from death.

Likewise, when Paul wrote to encourage the Thessalonians, he wrote: *"But we do not want you to be uninformed, brothers and sisters, about those who have fallen asleep...through Jesus, God will bring with him those who have fallen asleep."* (1 Thessalonians 4:13-14).

The dead are not alive somewhere else. They are simply *asleep*.

But Didn't Jesus Say the Criminal Would Be in Paradise 'Today'? (Luke 23:43)

No, Jesus did not say the criminal would be in Paradise with him "Today." People often point to Luke 23:43, where Jesus speaks to the repentant criminal on the cross. Some English translations suggest that Jesus told the man, *"Today you will be with me in paradise."* However, a closer examination of the Greek text and other biblical passages suggests a different reading of Luke 23:43.

Ancient Greek manuscripts had no punctuation—no commas or periods. This means that the placement of the comma in some English translations is a matter of interpretation rather than direct textual evidence.

Other translations of Luke 23:43 support an alternative reading, a few examples below:

"Verily I say unto thee this day: With me shalt thou be in Paradise."[65]

"Verily, to you am I saying today, with Me shall you be in paradise."[66]

"I tell you this today; you will be with me in Paradise."[67]

"Verily, to thee I say this day, with Me shalt thou be in the Paradise." [68]

These renderings show that the phrase "this day" could be referring to when Jesus was making the statement, rather than when the event of going to paradise would occur.

In Greek, adverbs like "today" *(sémeron)* typically modify the verb that they are closest to. In Luke 23:43, "today" is placed immediately after "I say to you," making it natural for it to modify "I say" rather than "you will be with me in paradise."

"I Tell You This Today"?

The biblical phrase "this day" often functions as an emphasis marker rather than a reference to a literal 24-hour period. A more natural modern rendering could be:

"Today I tell you,"

"I assure you today,"

"Today, I make you this promise,"

"Mark my words today."

Jesus was a Jew, and in His Bible, "this day" or "today" often serves to highlight the urgency and certainty of a statement. For example:

> *See, I have set before you **today** life and good, death and evil.*
>
> (Deuteronomy 30:15)

Or,

> *I testify against you **this day** that you shall surely perish.*
>
> (Deuteronomy 8:19)

Thus, in Luke 23:43, when Jesus tells the criminal, *"I tell you today, you will be with me in paradise,"* He is emphasizing the certainty of His promise, not the timing of when it will be fulfilled.

Jesus Didn't Go to Paradise That Day

If Jesus was telling the criminal that both of them would meet in paradise later that day, it contradicts other clear biblical teachings:

1. Jesus Was Not in Paradise But in the Grave for Three Days

Matthew 12:40: *"...so will the Son of Man be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth."*

Jesus did not go directly to heaven but was in the grave for three days. This aligns with the Apostles' Creed, which states: "He descended to the underworld."

2. First Resurrected, Then Descended

1 Peter 3:19: *"After being made alive, he went and made proclamation to the imprisoned spirits."*

This passage indicates that Jesus descended into the realm of the dead, not ascended to heaven.

3. Jesus Had Not Yet Ascended After His Resurrection

John 20:17: After His resurrection, Jesus tells Mary Magdalene, *"Do not cling to me, for I have not yet ascended to the Father."*

If Jesus had already visited heaven on the day of His crucifixion, He would not have said this.

Under Construction

Paradise wasn't ready yet: Jesus said, *"I go and prepare a place for you… I will come back and take you to be with me that you also may be where I am"* (John 14:3). However you interpret this, one thing is clear: the place isn't ready yet—which means it wasn't yet prepared for the criminal either.

In summary, Jesus was making a promise, not a time statement. Rather than saying the criminal would be in paradise that very day, Jesus was making a solemn declaration: "I tell you today, you will be with me in paradise." This promise assured the criminal that he would ultimately be with Jesus, but not necessarily on that exact day.

Conclusion

In the end, the gospel does not point us away from the world but deeper into it. It does not teach us to despise the body, abandon the earth, or spiritualize suffering into abstraction. It announces that God has chosen to heal what is broken, to raise what has fallen asleep, and to restore what has been wounded—flesh and soil, memory and hope. Resurrection is not an escape plan but a promise: that nothing God has made is disposable, that love enacted here and now matters eternally; and that the world, though scarred, is still the place where God insists on dwelling, redeeming, and making all things whole again.

Lazarus of Bethany (John 11:38–44), Jairus' daughter (Mark 5:21–43), the widow of Nain's son (Luke 7:11–17), Tabitha (Acts 9:36–42), Eutychus (Acts 20:7–12), and many saints in Jerusalem (Matthew 27:52–53) weren't spirits brought back down from heaven, but were truly raised from the dead—"awakened" from being "asleep"—in their own bodies. Likewise, we too will awaken with new bodies (1 Corinthians 15:51–52, 2 Corinthians 5:1–2, Philippians 3:20–21, Romans 8:23).

The Gospel is not about escapism of the spirit, but about restoring both body and soul.

Chapter 26

Western Salvation: How the Gospel Was Reduced to a Doctrinal Quiz

Clearly, the popular pulpit slogan that salvation is "a free gift of grace" does not hold up under the weight of Western theology. At best, it works only on the surface level.

If salvation ultimately depends on our understanding—on our finite minds and limited perception—then it becomes contingent on the correctness of our intellectual grasp. But what exactly must that understanding include? Is it simply professing belief in a historical figure named Jesus, a Jewish rabbi who lived in Israel

2,000 years ago, who was the Son of God that was sacrificed for our sins? If so, then what are we to make of the 49,000 Christian groups, movements, and sub-denominations that all profess this in some form? Are they all "saved"? Or is there some additional knowledge required—some doctrinal precision like the Trinity—that determines salvation?

For instance, Catholics and Protestants both profess faith in Christ and His divinity, in His sacrificial atonement, in the Trinity, and more—yet for centuries they have condemned one another to hellfire over various other doctrines. So, where does this intellectual mind game end? Must salvation really hinge on subscribing to a precise set of doctrinal formulas?

How well-developed and precise must your Christology, Hamartiology, Bibliology, Soteriology, Eschatology, Pneumatology, and Ecclesiology be to be "saved"? And if humanity is really as foolish and dumb as it sometimes appears to be, then why would a God—who created us with very limited wisdom and restricted understanding—base His willingness to spare us from His cosmic incinerator on passing such a confusing intellectual test? Would a *loving* Creator really design a system where escaping Eternal Conscious Torment hinges on our ability to comprehend complex theology? It makes no sense. It would be a sick game and a setup for failure, not an act of grace.

If salvation depends on our intellectual understanding, then we're left with confusion, fragmentation, and endless debate. It becomes chaotic, uncertain, and ultimately doomed to fail. That's why 49,000 Christian

groups vehemently argue over every single aspect of faith. And it's why salvation can't depend on us. It must be up to God. All of it. Salvation is His work, not ours. As Scripture declares, He—not we—is Mighty to Save (Isaiah 63:1; Zephaniah 3:17).

God is Greater Than Systematic Theology

Imagine a father buying his son a birthday gift—even after the son has rebelled, offended him, and broken his trust. If the father gives the gift anyway, not because the son earned it but because love compels him, that is genuine, unmerited grace.

But if the father makes the gift conditional—"I'll give it to you only if you do X, believe Y, or apologize first"—then it is no longer a free gift. It becomes something to be earned, a transaction rather than grace.

So it is with God. If His *salvation*—whatever that word means—depends on human understanding, virtue, or performance, it is no longer a gift but a reward. True grace—unconditional, inclusive, universal, and flowing from the very heart of God—does not wait for worthiness; it creates it.

It is simple logic: a gift ceases to be free the moment it must be earned.

If salvation rests on passing a theological exam in intellectual correctness, then how is that grace? No one can ever be secure. Fear becomes the engine of faith: fear of being wrong, fear of missing one obscure truth, fear of belonging to the wrong denomination. And history has shown what that produces—endless divisions, schisms, accusations, and even bloodshed. In the end, salvation by "right doctrine" is not good news at all, but a life driven by suspicion, fear, and despair.

Take, for instance, the great Catholic-Protestant conflicts in Europe; historians estimate that as many as 15 million people died.[69] And over what? Salvation theories and theology. How ironic! And if that is the bitter harvest of Western theology, then surely some serious questions must be asked.

Good News for All?

If nearly all of humanity—except for a small few—were to be tortured forever in hell, calling that "good news" would be morally absurd.

If we discovered that an extinction-level meteor was on its way and would incinerate 95% of the human race, no sane person would frame that as hope. It would be a catastrophe. To celebrate it as God's goodness because you happened to survive would be morally grotesque.

The *"**Good news** that will cause great joy for **all** the people"* (Luke 2:10), by definition, must be good for *all*.

But if 95% of humanity is doomed to Eternal Conscious Torment, and you happen to be among the elect and get to escape it, calling that reality "good news" and celebrating your own rescue does not make you faithful—it makes you narcissistic.

The God Who Is Truly Mighty to Save

> *The LORD your God is...the Mighty One who saves.*
>
> (Zephaniah 3:17)

If salvation does not rest on *our* intellectual precision or theological understanding, then it rests on God alone—and that changes everything. It means we can finally stop striving, stop proving, stop fearing that we might think or believe the wrong thing. We can rest. Peace becomes possible, not because we understand perfectly, but because God is faithful, patient, and good—and our lives are held, not by our certainty, but by His love.

This is not the god of MacArthur and Edwards who "holds you over the Pit of Hell, much as one holds a Spider, or some loathsome Insect, over the Fire, abhors you, and is dreadfully provoked."

It is the loving Father of Jesus Christ, who runs toward the sinner while he is still far off, who interrupts confession with embrace, who restores before explanation, and who celebrates return rather than threatening exile—a Father whose justice is mercy in motion, whose holiness is love unashamed, and whose arms are already open long before repentance finds its words.

The Father Who Understands

God's knowledge and understanding are far beyond our own, surpassing the limits of human reasoning. To suggest that our salvation hinges on our intellectual grasp of doctrines is not only unrealistic—it's morally

troubling. The gospel is not a test of doctrine that most of humanity is destined to fail, but a free gift of grace. If redemption were based on human understanding, which is not only severely flawed, limited, and lacking but often also shaped by trauma, indoctrination, culture, and other external factors, it would imply that we are the ones saving ourselves. But that is the opposite of grace.

Yes, some people actively reject God—but the real question is whether they are rejecting Jesus Himself or a distorted caricature of Him, filtered through two thousand years of theological overlays. From my experience, it's pretty much always the latter. People are not turning away from Christ; they are recoiling from a version of God they cannot recognize, cannot trust, or cannot love—a fractured, contradictory, and often abhorrent portrayal, such as that found in the theology of Jonathan Edwards, which bears little resemblance to the face of God revealed in Jesus.

I've personally debated Jesus with thousands of religious and secular Jews alike. And here's the conclusion I've come to: even the most aggressive atheists aren't truly attacking God; they're attacking a distorted version of a hateful God. Likewise, even the most zealous religious Jews aren't actually rejecting Jesus—they're rejecting a paganized and often antisemitic portrayal of Him.

In both cases, people are responding not to the God of Scripture or the Jewish Messiah, but to a false image —usually the caricature handed to them by the fundamentalist voices I've highlighted throughout this book.

What they reject is not the God of Scripture, but the God invented by those who speak the loudest and love the least.

They are not pushing back against the Creator of heaven and earth, or the Father revealed in Jesus the Messiah—they're pushing back against a twisted portrayal shaped by fear, shame, manipulation, and bad theology.

And honestly? I don't blame them. If the "god" they were shown were truly like that, I would reject him, too.

What Would Jesus' Father Do?

So what does the *real* God do with that? Does He look at a wounded human being—someone rejecting a cruel caricature of Him—and say, *"You should have loved that idol anyway"*? Or does He see the pain, the confusion, the manipulation that distorted their vision of Him, and judge them according to the light they actually had—saving them despite their inability to recognize Him clearly?

The God of Scripture is not careless with context. He knows the difference between rebellion against truth and resistance to abuse done in His name. Like the good judge that He is, He weighs intention, formation,

trauma, and honesty of heart. He knows when someone is only turning away from a distorted mask that others forced onto His face.

Which brings the question into sharp focus: would a God who is perfectly just and perfectly loving hold people accountable for a limited, distorted understanding of Him? Or would it be far more cruel—far more unlike the God of Abraham and the Father revealed in Jesus—to condemn people for refusing to worship a false god who was never truly Him at all?

I was once in touch with a Hasidic Jew who came to faith in Jesus and was then discipled by Calvinists in the Israeli Messianic movement. They told him that God had predestined him to believe and escape hell. "So that means God also predestined my parents, grandparents, and sisters to eternity in hellfire?" he asked. Their response devastated him. Unable to reconcile such a view of God, he left the faith entirely and returned to Judaism.

No human turns away from loving-kindness unless something deeply wrong, like trauma, indoctrination or bad theology, has warped their perception of it. Our human understanding is limited because we see only dimly. But one day, all will stand before God, see Him clearly, understand Him fully, and will no longer have a reason to reject His grace.

Conclusion

Salvation can only be a one-sided act of God—unearned, unprovoked, and untouched by human contribution. It does not rest on even the smallest percentage of us, on our limited understanding or fractured abilities, but wholly and completely on Him alone.

Chapter 27

"Salvation" in the Hebrew Bible and New Testament

When read through biblical eyes, *salvation* is not about escaping a cosmic furnace or avoiding unending torment in God's so-called torture chamber. Nor is it a ticket out of this world in some mystical sense. In the biblical imagination, *salvation* is deeply practical and profoundly holistic.

Jesus' resurrection sets the pattern—His body isn't discarded but transformed and glorified. The ultimate hope is not to leave earth for heaven, but for heaven and earth to embrace once more (Revelation 21:1-5).

God's salvation isn't about burning the world to ashes but freeing it from corruption and restoring it to its fullest potential. God doesn't throw away what's broken. He heals, restores, and makes all things whole again. Salvation is not about relocation—it's about renewal.

Salvation: Holistic Restoration, Not Soul Escape

Before we can fully grasp how Jesus used the term "salvation," we first need to consider how the Bible—especially the Hebrew Scriptures, which were the only sacred texts available to believers in His time—uses the word "salvation." Spoiler alert: it's not about your soul going to heaven when your body dies. It's not about escaping hellfire, either. In the Bible's original context, salvation meant something far more grounded, more communal, and more urgent—deliverance from danger, restoration from exile, winning a battle, healing sickness, and the return to God's presence and blessing.

Take the Exodus story—the most foundational salvation story in the Jewish imagination. Israel wasn't saved from an afterlife incinerator. They were saved from slavery. From oppression. From Pharaoh's chokehold:

*That day the LORD **saved** Israel from the hands of the Egyptians…*

(Exodus 14:30)

God didn't save them by snatching them into heaven. He came down into their suffering and led them out. That's salvation. Not an escape from the world, but liberation. Exodus. Homecoming.

The Hebrew word for salvation—*yeshuah*—is deeply connected to this theme. It carries the meaning of deliverance, rescue, healing, and restoration. And if the Hebrew word sounds familiar, that's because it shares the same root as the name *Yeshua*—Jesus.

Every time someone in the Hebrew Bible cries out for salvation, they're asking God to intervene in real life. To heal, to protect, to redeem. It's never about a cosmic courtroom or an abstract afterlife. It's always relational, communal, and earthy.

For example, in **Deuteronomy 33:29**, Moses says, *"Blessed are you, Israel! Who is like you, a people **saved** by the Lord?"* Here, salvation is about national identity. God saved the people from Egypt, led them through the

wilderness, and promised them a land, a future, and His presence. Salvation was the ongoing story of God's faithfulness to His people, not a moment of personal belief or a private spiritual contract.

Similarly, **Psalm 34** says, *"The Lord is close to the brokenhearted and **saves** those who are crushed in spirit."* That's not talking about the afterlife. That's talking about struggling right here, right now.

Psalm 18 likewise opens with a cry for salvation from enemies and a declaration, *"I have been **saved**!"* (Psalm 18:3). King David was not speaking about being saved from hellfire in a distant afterlife. The context makes this unmistakably clear: salvation meant deliverance from concrete threats—military enemies, violence, chaos, spears at his throat. In Psalm 18, God appears as a storm-riding warrior, tearing open the heavens to intervene and rescue His beloved. That is salvation in the biblical imagination.

Even the prophets—Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel—when they speak of salvation, they're pointing to return from exile, to national renewal, to protection from harm, to the healing of the land and the people.

*"In returning and rest you shall be **saved**,"* (Isaiah 30:15) **Isaiah** says. This verse wasn't directed at individuals in the 21st century to warn about afterlife punishment, but rather to the nation of Israel, emphasizing trust in God's covenant promises to her.

Thus, in the Hebrew Scriptures, salvation means *blessing* (Genesis 49:18), *protection* from harm and enemies (Exodus 14:13–14; Psalm 18:2), *healing* (Isaiah 53:5; Mark 5:34), *justice* (Isaiah 45:21; Luke 18:7–8), *winning* a

war (1 Samuel 14:23; 2 Chronicles 20:17), *restoration* (Jeremiah 30:17; Acts 3:21), and ultimately, *the renewal of all creation* (Isaiah 65:17; Romans 8:21; Revelation 21:1–5).

Salvation in the New Testament—Still the Same Story

The words most often translated as "salvation" or "saved" in the New Testament do not mean "rescued from afterlife divine punishment in hell." Rather, "*sózó*" carries the deeper sense of being rescued, healed, made whole, restored, and delivered from real danger—mostly physically.

In **Matthew** 8:25, when the disciples feared for their lives in the storm on the Sea of Galilee, they cried out, *"Lord, **save** us!"*. They didn't ask Jesus to forgive their sins and rescue them from afterlife hellfire torment but to deliver them from physical danger by calming the storm.

In **Mark** 5:23, when Jairus pleaded with Jesus, *"My little daughter is at the point of death; please come, that by coming, You may lay Your hands on her, so that she will be **saved**,"* he was begging for his child's physical healing.

In **Luke** 8:48, the woman who touched Jesus' cloak was told, *"Daughter, your faith has **saved** you; go in peace."* Jesus wasn't referring to her faith saving her from a torturous afterlife, but rather to healing her physical disease (see verse 43) in that very moment.

In each case, "salvation" is not about paperwork in heaven, but about real healing, rescue, and transformation in this life.

Jesus Saves

Jesus came to save people: to cure their illnesses, to heal their wounds, to set them free from whatever oppresses them—whether demonic, emotional, physical, or societal—and to restore them to their true identity as God's image-bearers. His salvation is a present reality: the healing of our brokenness, the liberation from our sin, and the renewal of our hearts and relationships.

The Gospel is not a message of fear and legal bookkeeping, but of deep healing and transformation (and no, the Book of Life in Revelation isn't about bookkeeping—learn more in my book on Hell). Jesus' salvation

reaches into every part of our existence, calling us to live now as fully renewed children of God, reflecting His love, wholeness, and compassion into the world.

But somewhere along the way, Christianity lost the plot. The Jewish message of the Jewish Messiah was ripped from its Hebrew roots, filtered through Greek philosophical categories, and eventually rewritten with the language of Roman courts, contracts, and cosmic punishments soaked in paganism. But if you go back to the New Testament itself—and read it like a Jew living in the first century—you'll find that its understanding of salvation is still the same story told in the Hebrew Bible: rescue, restoration, healing, protection, deliverance, blessing, homecoming.

When Jesus said He came to *"seek and **save** the lost"* (Luke 19:10), He wasn't talking about plucking disembodied souls from the fires of Eternal Conscious Torment. In fact, when saying this, He had just finished restoring a man named Zacchaeus—a Jewish tax collector hated by his community. Jesus dined with him, welcomed him, called him a "son of Abraham." That's salvation. A broken man, estranged from his people, restored to dignity, identity, and belonging.

Jesus wasn't creating a new religion where salvation suddenly meant an escape from some cosmic furnace. He was fulfilling an old promise—that God would gather the scattered, heal the sick, bring the outcast home, raise the dead, renew the mind, give hope and a new way of living. That's what His salvation was. That's what Yeshua-Jesus was named for.

Later, when Paul writes about salvation, he echoes the same theme. In **Romans 10**, he prays for Israel to be *"saved"*—not because he's worried she'll burn forever (nations don't burn in hell, do they?!) but because Israel is missing the fulfillment of her own story and calling. He's heartbroken that they're cut off from the blessing, the restoration, the Messiah they've waited for. And in **Ephesians 2**, he says, *"It is by grace you have been saved..."* but he's talking collectively to Gentiles—and he doesn't mean escape from hell. He means the inclusion of the Gentiles into the people of God, into the covenant, into the blessing.

The New Testament consistently uses *sōzō*—"to save"—in tangible, earthly contexts: healing the sick, raising the dead, restoring the broken. The blind man? *"Go, your faith has **saved** you."* He wasn't saved from hell but from blindness. The leper? *"Your faith has **saved** you."* He wasn't saved from hell either but from leprosy. Salvation wasn't a doctrine to be mastered for the sake of afterlife escapism. It was a lived experience. It was tangible and immediate.

In summary, the New Testament didn't alter the biblical meaning of *salvation*—Western theologians did. Jesus simply deepened its Hebrew roots and broadened its reach. He came not only to free Israel from exile but to rescue the whole world from every kind of exile—sin, shame, sickness, and death. His mission was to pave the way for *tikkun olam*—heal what's broken, restore what's lost, and unite all creation with God.

So How Did We Get To Salvation from Hellfire?

Walk through almost any city in America long enough and you'll eventually hear it—the familiar question shouted on street corners and spoken in revival tents: *"Are you saved?"* And almost without pause comes its shadow twin: *"If you died tonight, do you know where you'd go?"*

This version of the gospel, drilled into the minds of millions, presents salvation as an urgent escape plan—a spiritual insurance policy to avoid hellfire and secure entry into heaven. And the whole deal, they insist, can be yours instantly—just recite a scripted prayer from a folded pamphlet, and voilà, salvation delivered on the spot!

But what if the question itself is based on a huge misunderstanding?

Ask the average Baptist, Calvinist, Pentecostal, or Evangelical, and the answer to what we are saved from usually comes quickly—"We are saved from Eternal Conscious Torment in Hell!" But the Bible never actually says that in any straightforward way.

The version of salvation most Christians inherit today does not arise organically from the Bible itself, but from centuries of theological development shaped by Greek philosophy, Roman legal categories, and the fiery

imagination of medieval Catholicism—later refined and systematized by Protestant reformers. Within this framework, the doctrine commonly called Eternal Conscious Torment assumes that humanity's default state is damnation, and that Jesus came primarily to save us from His own Father by absorbing the blows of divine wrath in our place, thereby allowing a small minority to escape everlasting punishment.

But from Genesis to Revelation, the biblical warning is strikingly consistent. It is not about afterlife torture, but about separation from life itself. From the very beginning, humanity's deepest obsession has been to defeat death—to transcend it, outwit it, or overcome it by any means necessary. Death is the tyrant. Death is the curse. Death is the final enemy. And death—not Eternal Conscious Torment—is what we ultimately need to be saved from.

As you remember, in the Bible's prologue—Genesis 2:17 specifically—God's initial warning wasn't about Eternal Conscious Torment, but rather about death: *"In the day you eat of it, you will surely **die**."* Thus, the enemy is not torment—it's death. Consequently, the good news of the gospel is that Jesus came to conquer death, not to rescue us from a medieval idea born of poor translations and misinterpreted metaphors and parables.

The day Adam and Eve sinned, they didn't fall into a burning pit. They began to die. Literally. Not in some esoteric, hidden, mystical way, but physically. And that curse of death—that unraveling of life—has defined the human experience ever since.

In Romans 5:12, Paul says, *"Through one man sin entered the world, and **death** through sin, and in this way **death** came to all people."* And this is why he says in 1 Corinthians 15:26 that *"the last enemy to be destroyed is **death**."*

Now think about it logically: if hellfire—something dreadful that awaits *after* death—were the ultimate threat, Paul would not say that the last enemy to be destroyed is death, but hellfire.

Clearly, for Paul, salvation was not rescue from afterlife hellfire—it was deliverance from Death itself.

Death, in Scripture, is not just biological expiration. It is sickness. Brokenness. Alienation. Fear. Emptiness. Destruction. Oppression. Shame. Guilt. The decay of everything we were made to be. The breakdown of relationship—with God, with others, with ourselves. It's the slow suffocation of joy, meaning, connection, and purpose. That's why people often say they're dying inside. The salvation they crave is real and immediate, not something to wait for until after death.

Jesus ultimately came to save us from death—but walking in His way also saves us from its effects, whether physical, emotional, or relational. This is precisely why the Gospels portray Him moving through the world not only raising the dead but reversing death's reach: healing the sick, restoring the broken, casting out demons, feeding the hungry, cleansing lepers, welcoming outcasts, and forgiving sinners.

For the Hebrews, "salvation" was never about escaping to another realm in the afterlife. It was, first and foremost, about the restoration of life here and now—renewal, healing, deliverance, and wholeness—the repair of the world, *tikkun olam*.

Jesus doesn't say, "I am the escape hatch from hell." He says, *"I am the **resurrection** and the **life**"* (John 11:25).

In other words, Jesus saves by undoing the effects of death wherever He finds them. His ministry reveals God's intention from the beginning—not to abandon creation, but to restore it. Not escapism, but renewal.

Jesus Holds the Keys to the Cosmic Graveyard

When Jesus rises from the grave, He doesn't return battered and proclaim that He settled some cosmic legal debt to God by taking on His wrath. Instead, He appears with the holes left by human nails in His hands, declaring victory over death. He says, *"I was dead, and now look—I am alive forever and ever! And I hold the keys of death and Hades"* (Revelation 1:18). Hades—often translated "hell"—is the ancient Greek word used to describe the grave—not a specific graveyard or geographic location, but a symbolic realm where the dead are imagined being at rest, asleep. It's not a place of Eternal Conscious Torment, but of waiting. And the good

news? Jesus holds the key to unlocking humanity's cosmic graveyard. That means He can—and will—unlock its gates. He has the authority to call the dead to life, to empty the grave, and to bring resurrection to all. That is what His salvation is all about. The healing of all that death has fractured.

Humanly speaking, you can't destroy what's already dead—you can only bring it back. Dead people aren't further destroyed because they already are, but they can be raised again. So when Scripture says, *"Death and the grave are thrown into the lake of fire"* (Revelation 20:14), it means the grave itself is no more and death is ultimately dismantled.

Throwing death and Hades—the grave—into the Lake of Fire (also known in Judaism as the River of Fire—a symbol of cosmic refinement and divine purification) signifies their ultimate defeat and removal from the human story. It's not about perpetual torment; it's about the cleansing of death itself and the final purging of all that stands against God (Revelation 19:20;20:10;20:14-15;21:8).

It's the final undoing of the curse from Eden. Resurrection replaces the grave. Or in Paul's words, *"Death has been swallowed up in victory."* (1 Corinthians 15:54).

And look how the Bible ends—with the solution to the very problem it began with:

> *He will wipe every tear from their eyes.* ***There will be no more death.***

(Revelation 21:4)

The biblical story concludes not with a negative declaration, "Most of you will spend forever being broiled," but with a positive promise, *"There will be no more death."*

Again, the New Testament introduced nothing that the Hebrew Scriptures hadn't already taught:

> *He will swallow up death forever. The Sovereign Lord will wipe away the tears from all faces.*
>
> (Isaiah 25:8)

That's biblical salvation—overcoming death.

Not hell. Not God's wrath. Not Satan. Death. And how does God destroy it? Through resurrection.

This is why, until Augustine of Hippo in the fourth century, the earliest Christians were not fixated on an afterlife hell. Their proclamation was resurrection. They did not tremble before visions of perpetual flames; they rejoiced in the decisive victory of Jesus over the grave.

They didn't preach a comfy afterlife for the lucky few who passed a theological test. They preached the good news of the Kingdom of God.

So if you're still thinking of salvation as a cosmic fire insurance policy, you've missed the beating heart of the Gospel.

Conclusion

The biblical story of salvation—from Genesis to Revelation—is the story of God's cosmic redemption; saving humanity from death and restoring life.

Salvation is being rescued from slavery in Egypt. Salvation is being brought back from exile. Salvation is God delivering His people from enemies, from oppression, from famine, from fear. Salvation is healing the sick, restoring the outcast, feeding the hungry. Salvation is about life—people restored, relationships reconciled, lives protected, wounds healed, and death itself defeated.

The Good News is not that a select few might narrowly escape unending punishment. It is that *all* will be raised to life (and judgement)—not because of anything we have done, nor because of knowledge we have

acquired, but because our God is truly Mighty to Save. And this is not merely a future promise. It is a kind of divine life that can be entered into now—not by reciting a formulaic prayer, but by walking the way Jesus walked and living as He lived.

Chapter 28

Understanding Salvation Redefines Life's Purpose

There's a much more meaningful and beautiful way to see our purpose than treating it like some cosmic "escape room" designed to dodge endless torment. Life's meaning is about growing in the knowledge of who we are, who God is, and what it means to love. That journey inevitably involves failure, struggle, and sin—not as goals, but as part of the learning process.

Grace, compassion, forgiveness—these aren't just theories. They must be experienced to be understood. Without sin, Adam and Eve would never have grasped the depth of God's mercy. Without failure, we'd never taste the sweetness of redemption. Like light is only fully appreciated after darkness, love is most powerful when it's shown to the undeserving.

Most Christians treat Genesis 3 as a tragic detour—a "Plan B" because humans messed up. But what if God knew that free beings would fall? What if this world was never supposed to be a flawless paradise, but a space for learning and transformation?

The Bible never says Adam and Eve were created perfect (*tamim*). They were created *tov* (good/functional)—with the ability to grow. Perfection doesn't need to grow. Imperfect humans do. And growth requires space for error, experience, and transformation. That's not a design flaw. That's divine wisdom.

Life's Meaning When Death Is Only Temporary

Sin brings pain—that's undeniable. Sin causes suffering, injustice, betrayal, loss. But through that very pain, we grow. We gain wisdom. We develop empathy. We learn to forgive, to hope, to fight for justice. It's the hardness

of life that carves out our character.

We're not AI robots. We're not Divine either. We're human. And being human means learning through imperfection.

Sin is harmful—but it's also a mirror. It shows us who we are, what we're capable of, and how desperately we need grace. It is meant to lead humanity to repentance, reconciliation, creativity, healing, and maturity. Societies and individuals alike often improve only after facing the consequences of wrongdoing.

According to clinical psychologist Jordan Peterson, sin may be the most significant catalyst for growth, wisdom, and creativity:

> The thing that people don't understand about creativity is that there's no reason to be creative unless you have a problem to solve. If someone dies on you young and you're forced to fend your way in the world and deal with that kind of trauma, you have to put yourself together in a creative manner, and it's no joke. And so, early negative experiences allied with high intelligence and this kind of temperament that we were talking about are one of the things that foster creative production. Parents are misinformed about this sort of thing because they think that if they just do laissez

> faire things with their children, you know, "you can do anything you want", they'll automatically be creative. That's the stupidest thing you could possibly imagine because that isn't how creativity works. Creativity emerges when you put serious constraints on things.[70]
>
> (Jordan Peterson)

Peterson's logic is simple: *No pain, no gain*. It's not a spiritual excuse—it's a hard truth. Life shapes us through struggle. And God, rather than condemning us for it, meets us there—not with wrath and fury, but with grace and healing.

Even our poor decisions, even those who do evil—and even evil itself—end up serving a purpose within God's larger story. Not because God desires wickedness, but because its very existence creates contrast. It sharpens our moral vision. It helps us discern the difference between good and evil, light and darkness, what builds up and what tears down. Without contrast, goodness becomes invisible; without opposition, virtue cannot be recognized for what it is.

In God's providence, even the darkest acts become unwilling teachers. They reveal what kind of world we don't want, what kind of people we must not become, and what kind of Kingdom God intends to establish—a Kingdom defined not by destruction, but by healing, justice, and love.

The Divine Intent Behind Human Limitations

God could have "downloaded" all truth into our minds from birth—but He didn't. Instead, He gave us only the basics: instincts, curiosity, and a hunger to learn. The rest comes through experience—and often through painful ones.

God is perfect—all-knowing, all-loving, unchanging. But when He created us, He didn't make us perfect like Him. He made us human. And humanity, by design, is limited—in knowledge, understanding, and emotional capacity. Our limitations also mean we act out of impulse. We judge poorly. We make mistakes. We err.

But these limitations are not a flaw—they are part of the design. And if we were created this way, then it would be profoundly unjust to condemn us to Eternal Conscious Torment for the very limitations God Himself built into us. And if He won't, then it means life's purpose has nothing to do with escaping hellfire.

The other day, I came across a discussion in a Messianic WhatsApp group run by the Messianic Bible College in Israel. People—mostly its own Bible college students—were debating which members of the Jewish Bibas family—the children and their mother kidnapped by Hamas and murdered in Gaza—were old enough to burn in hell.

Let that sink in.

Imagine theology students arguing over whether a ten-year-old deserves Eternal Conscious Torment because they weren't "saved" by a certain age—as if God, who created that child with limited understanding, would then punish them—forever—for not being morally perfect or for lacking theological precision. That's like burning a zebra for failing a math test or being unable to climb a tree.

This isn't just bad soteriology. It's a distortion of God's character and a grotesque misunderstanding of the Gospel.

Perfect People Don't Need Help

The truth is, our imperfections are not accidents, nor do they pose a threat to God. They are purposeful. God

created us with physical, mental, and emotional limitations not to shame us, but to invite us into something deeper—growth and relationship.

If we had perfect knowledge, unlimited emotional wisdom, and flawless moral instincts, we wouldn't need each other—and we wouldn't truly need God either. But in our vulnerability, we're drawn into community. We learn love, humility, forgiveness, patience, sacrifice—not by being self-sufficient, but by depending on one another.

This interdependence is not a weakness. It's sacred. It's how we grow. It's why we need God. It's how we experience and practice love.

Even more, our limitations create the space where free will can exist. Without the ability to choose—even wrongly—love would not be real but robotic, and faithfulness would be meaningless. God didn't create a world of hand puppets. He created people who could choose, learn, grow, fail, and try again.

It's through these struggles, questions, and moral challenges that real character is formed. And in those moments when we face our own weakness, we often become most aware of our need for others, and for God's guidance, strength, and grace.

Fundamentalists like John MacArthur claim that *"God only accepts absolute perfection."*[71] But this claim is not only theologically flawed, but emotionally damaging. These ideas portray God as a distant, cold, and harsh

tyrant rather than the loving Father revealed in Christ. This view of God breeds anxiety, not peace. Depression, not joy.

To suggest that infinite torment is a fitting punishment for the very limitations we were born with—for being human—is not only illogical, but it is also morally indefensible. It twists the gospel from being rooted in love to being driven by fear.

The biblical story, at its heart, is not about achieving perfection—it's about growth and restoration. It's not about measuring up—it's about being lifted up. God is not standing at a distance with folded arms and a whip. He's the Father who runs to meet the prodigal, the healer who touches the unclean, the Shepherd who leaves the ninety-nine to rescue just the one.

To be human is to be flawed—and to be deeply loved nonetheless. That is the true good news.

We Learn From (Painful) Experiences

Yes, sin causes suffering. Much like you—I've lived it, been shaped by it, and contributed to it. But without experiencing pain and failure, we would never grow in wisdom or character. It's life's pain and struggles that

shape us the most.

Artificial Intelligence can process data, but it can't feel sorrow, regret, or relief. That's what makes us human—our ability to feel, to fail, to hurt, and to learn and grow from it. If we never sin, we'd never need forgiveness. And without forgiveness, we'd never grasp the depths of grace or the richness of love.

As Jesus said, *"Whoever has been forgiven little, loves little"* (Luke 7:47). Those who've fallen and been lifted know something that no textbook can teach. The emotional, spiritual, and relational weight of grace can't be understood abstractly—it has to be lived.

Yes, sin destroys. But it's only temporary because God promises restoration—a resurrection, a new body, a new earth, a renewed world (Philippians 3:21; 2 Corinthians 5:1–10; Revelation 21:1–5). That hope is the foundation of forgiveness. Even if someone wounds you beyond repair—even if they take your life—God will make all things new. No pain will be wasted. That's the good news.

Conclusion

The hopelessness exposed by sin drives us toward something greater than ourselves. It teaches us that what we

need is not just self-improvement, but healing. And that healing does not flow from existential fear or religious intimidation, but from encountering a God who understands us—a God who does not cancel us when we fail. A God who draws nearer, not farther away, in our brokenness.

Contrary to what many have been taught, sin does not threaten God. It does not intimidate Him or diminish His holiness. Jesus, our healer, never recoiled from the sick or the sinful. He touched them. He restored them. He forgave them. He loved them.

Jesus is what God is like.

So no—sin is not the end of the story. More often, it is the beginning of a deeper one: the story of grace, transformation, redemption, and a love greater than anything we could ever produce on our own.

No matter how far you fall or how deeply you fail—rise. Stand upright. Walk in grace. God loves you, and there is always more than enough grace for you!

Chapter 29

The Communal Aspect of Salvation

In today's hyper-individualistic culture, salvation is often presented as a private transaction between the sinner and God—a personal decision, a solitary prayer, a moment that "secures" one's afterlife destiny. While personal transformation is certainly crucial, it's far from the whole picture.

In the Bible, salvation is primarily communal. It's not just about me being saved. It's about a collective restoration of the family, the people, the nation, and ultimately—the world.

Consider the Exodus once more: God saved an entire nation—many of whom were doubters, complainers, half-committed worshipers of Egyptian gods, and spiritually immature. Why? Because God rescues communities, not just a few isolated "deserving" individuals.

The Individual—Always a Thread in the Greater Tapestry

Salvation in Scripture is communal as much as it is personal. God liberates a people, shapes a people, carries a people—not merely a handful of spiritual elites.

The same theme echoes through the prophets. When Israel sins, it's the nation that is exiled. When they repent, it's the nation that is restored. As God says through Jeremiah, *"I will surely **save** you out of a distant place… Jacob will again have peace and security"* (Jeremiah 30:10). Not Jacob the individual—but Jacob the people, the tribe, the nation (Israel).

This collective mindset continues into the New Testament. When Paul told the Ephesians that *"it is by grace you have been saved"* (Ephesians 2:5), he wasn't addressing isolated individuals worried about hell. He was speaking to a *community* of Gentile believers who were once outsiders but who have now been brought near.

They were "dead" not in the sense of personal moral guilt, but because they, Gentiles, were cut off from God's covenant family. And salvation means being welcomed in. Reunited. Included.

So when Paul tells the Ephesians (2:8–9), the Galatians (2:16), and the Romans (3:28; 5:1) that they were saved by faith alone, faith means *trust*. We walk by faith, not by sight, which means we live in trust. But it's not a passive trust; we get up, move, change direction, and align our lives. It means entrusting oneself to the God of Israel. The Gentiles were welcomed into the covenant family simply by trusting God's promises—to keep them, to bless them, and to make them part of His redemptive plan. They were saved—joined into the covenant—by trusting God.

But they were not saved from hellfire torment—that idea is nowhere in the text. They were saved from a life of waste, meaninglessness, idol worship, perishing, and estrangement from the covenant. That is what Paul tells Gentile believers they have been rescued from. Salvation, for Paul, is deliverance from a broken way of life and incorporation into a healed one. He wrote with entire communities in mind, not specific individuals.

They "switched teams" not because they earned it through effort, moral achievement, or religious performance, but because salvation is God's gift. They did not pay for it. They did not merit it. They simply recognized—or were in the process of recognizing—what God had already done in Christ and stepped into it by trust.

This is why the *"you"* in most (if not all) biblical passages about *salvation* and *repentance* is plural—more like "y'all" than "you." It is a national call to Israel (e.g., Ezekiel 18:30-31, Jeremiah 25:5, Joel 2:12-13, 2 Chronicles 7:14, Zechariah 1:3, Hosea 14:1-2, Matthew 3:2; 4:17, Luke 13:3, 5; 15:7, 10; 17:3) that expanded to the gentiles. Salvation was never meant to be limited to the individual or confined to a private confession in one's heart; it's something we step into together. A new community. A new family. A new humanity.

The Bible Speaks in *We*, Not *Me*

Many people today struggle to understand why collective punishment appears in parts of the Hebrew Bible. But we must remember that the ancient worldview saw the individual as inseparable from the community. A person's sin was rarely viewed as an isolated moral failure but as a rupture in the communal fabric. The whole household, clan, and sometimes the entire nation bore responsibility for the environment that shaped the individual.

This is why the Torah contains examples where the consequences of sin fall upon more than just the perpetrator. Consider Achan in Joshua 7: his secret act of disobedience brought defeat upon all Israel in

battle, and his entire household faced judgment alongside him. To modern Western readers, raised in a highly individualistic society, this feels shocking and unfair. But in the ancient Near Eastern mindset, the family and clan were the soil in which a person's character grew; they shared both honor and shame, blessing and curse.

The individual was always understood as emerging from—and shaped by—the collective.

Today, psychology actually confirms what the biblical world assumed all along: individuals do not form in a vacuum. The vast majority of murderers, serial abusers, rapists, and violent offenders come from profoundly dysfunctional environments—homes marked by neglect, trauma, addiction, or generational violence. In other words, the fault is not solely personal but collective. The community, the system, and the family all participate —actively or passively—in shaping the very conditions that produced the offender.

This ancient insight is largely absent from today's "me, myself, and I" culture—and from much of modern Western theology, with its hyper-individualistic focus on *my* personal salvation, *my* personal sin, and *my* personal relationship with God. Scripture, however, presents a far more communal worldview. The actions of one can harm many (Adam) or bless many (Jesus). God engages humanity not merely as isolated individuals, but as interconnected members of families, tribes, and entire nations.

Salvation Is Communal Because Repentance Is Communal

We touched on this earlier, but it deserves deeper attention: repentance—so often reduced today to a private, emotional, inward moment—was, in Scripture, fundamentally a communal act.

Hebrew prophets like Joel and Isaiah called the nation to repent: *"Return to me with all your heart… Gather the people, sanctify the congregation."* (Joel 2:12-13). The Hebrew words used for "repent" and "re/turn" are spoken in the **plural**. "Return, y'all." Not "you personally." The call was always collective.

In the New Testament, too, when John the Baptist declared, *"Repent, for the kingdom of heaven has come near"* (Matthew 3:2), and when Jesus echoed these exact same words (Matthew 4:17), who were they addressing? Random individuals passing by? Not at all. The Greek word *Metanoeite* ("Repent") is in the **plural** form.

John and Jesus spoke as Israel's prophets to their nation, collectively urging her to repent, just as the prophets before them had done. This wasn't a private call to personal salvation from hell; it was a national summons to return to God, to turn from corruption, injustice, and spiritual complacency, and to prepare for the

arrival of God's kingdom. Not adhering to this did not condemn Israel to a lifetime in hell, but rather brought devastation upon it, as demonstrated by the destruction of Jerusalem and the Temple, along with the exile of Jews in the year 70AD.

This has massive implications. It means the Gospel is not about saving a few individuals from a fiery, torturous future. It's about redeeming whole communities, whole cultures, whole systems. It's about healing the world—*tikkun olam*.

That's why the early Christians *"were together and shared everything. They would sell their land and the things they owned and then divide the money and give it to anyone who needed it"* (Acts 2:44-45). That's why they cared for widows, welcomed outcasts, and built new social structures rooted in love and justice. They weren't individuals waiting to be raptured from Earth. They were a community participating in its restoration. They understood that salvation had begun, and they had a key part in it.

Thus, biblical salvation is never just "me and Jesus." It's *Immanuel*—"God with *us*." It's a new covenant family —Jew and Gentile, male and female, slave and free—brought together under one Head, one Body, one Spirit.

Biblical Collectivism vs. Western Individualism

In both the Old and New Testaments, identity was deeply corporate. But Greco-Roman philosophy, particularly Stoicism and Epicureanism, had emphasized the individual pursuit of the good life, marking a departure from the communal orientation of Hebrew thought.[72] This trajectory deepened in the 2nd and 3rd centuries with the rise of Gnosticism, which stressed secret personal knowledge (gnosis) as the individual's path to salvation. In Gnostic teaching, redemption was not communal but centered on the individual's inner awakening, who had to be mystically reborn, standing in sharp contrast to the biblical emphasis on shared faith, sacraments, and community.[73] The movement toward individualism gained further momentum in the 4th and 5th centuries with Augustine, whose introspective writings, most notably *Confessions*, highlighted the inner self and the "personal relationship" with God, representing a decisive step in the development of individualism within Western theology.

Once Christianity became institutionalized in the 4th century, the communal aspect was gradually buried under layers of philosophical interpretation. The infusion of Gnosticism and Neoplatonism by Augustine[74]

reshaped the gospel message into something foreign to its Jewish roots. Over time, the Western gospel evolved into a maze of personal confessions, doctrinal debates, and theological examinations—far removed from the communal, relational, life-giving message Jesus actually taught.

What began as a call to embody divine love became, in many circles, an intellectual system to be mastered, argued, and defended. The heart was replaced with propositions and creeds. And the simplicity and beauty of the original gospel were overshadowed by centuries of philosophical and theological reinterpretation.

Ultimately, the world's salvation is not about what we do, but about what God has done for us. Jesus didn't lay down His life so we would grovel like condemned criminals. He gave His life to show us our true worth, proving we are all beloved children—even the prodigals—of a Father who would go to any length to bring us home. And just like earthly children don't have to earn their parents' love, we don't have to earn God's. But we do get to choose how we live in response—whether we walk in that love or turn away from it—and the face consequences (like filling our belly with the pods meant for the pigs; Luke 15:16).

Conclusion

Salvation has always been aimed at the communal level and expressed through love, justice, mercy, wholeness, and restored relationships—with God and with one another. In the teaching of Jesus, salvation is not a spiritual loophole or a legal transaction. It is an invitation into God's blessings and into a way of life—a way defined by healing the sick, restoring the broken, lifting up the poor, and loving neighbors and enemies alike (Matthew 10:8).

This is exactly how the apostles understood Jesus' message. They didn't go around frightening people with threats of fire that would burn their skin forever. They preached about lifting the lowly, feeding the hungry, honoring widows, and practicing radical generosity: *"Share with the Lord's people who are in need. Practice hospitality"* (Romans 12:13). *"Give proper recognition to widows who are really in need"* (1 Timothy 5:3). *"Don't look to your own interests, but each of you to the interests of others"* (Philippians 2:4). This is salvation in action. That's what a saved community looks like.

So maybe it's time to retire the word "saved"—or at least save it from the hellfire narrative that's corrupted its meaning. And instead, return to the original biblical language: deliverance, healing, liberation, redemption. These words speak of being set free. And we're not saved *from* God, but *by* Him—from everything that keeps you apart from Him. And it's not just about individuals, but whole communities too.

This is salvation: not abandonment but restoration. Not escape, but resurrection. Not fear, but freedom. Not somewhere above and someday in the future, but here and now.

My parents' generation repaired what was broken. Ours tend to discard and replace. But I do not believe God treats His creation that way. God does not throw away what is broken, wounded, or flawed. His intention is not to burn the world to ashes, but to liberate it, heal it, and bring it to its intended fullness (Revelation 21:5).

Chapter 30

The Universal Aspect of Salvation

The greatest act of heroism in the human experience is self-sacrifice—when a hero gives their life to save the lives of others. And the very definition of a superhero is precisely this: someone whose sacrifice saves many, many lives, not just a few. The more lives rescued, delivered, or protected through that sacrifice, the greater the heroism becomes.

If this is true on a human level—where we honor those who save dozens or hundreds—how much more does it hold from a divine perspective?

If Jesus's sacrifice touched only some lives but not all, it would still be a good sacrifice, yet one that could be surpassed. And if a greater sacrifice were possible, then logically, there could be a greater Christ and an even greater God. Therefore, it logically follows that God's salvation through Christ must be universal in nature.

Now let's explore this idea in depth…

The Superhero Who Saved the World

> *For I did not come to judge the world, but to save the world.*
>
> (John 12:47)

If you were to rescue a great ship from sinking—thus saving every passenger from certain death—not all would respond with gratitude. Some would go on living as if nothing had happened: resentful, unkind, even hostile toward the very one who saved them and toward others as well. In that sense, though they were

genuinely saved, they would still choose to live in darkness, inwardly untouched by the grace that spared their lives.

The fact of their salvation from death remains unchanged. But how they live in response—and the consequences of that way of life—certainly does.

> *I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw **all** people to myself…*
>
> (John 12:32)

What a breathtaking metaphor: Jesus, lifted up—resurrected, exalted, and ascended—will draw ~~a few preelected~~ **all people** to Himself. Just as He triumphed over death, all of humanity will be swept up into that same victory. Not everyone will appreciate it—at least not right away—but all will be drawn by Jesus's work.

Yet throughout much of Christian history, especially since the 4th century, the gospel has often been reduced—limited to a select few. Calvinism, for instance, formalized this in the doctrine of "Limited Atonement," teaching that Jesus' sacrifice was not truly for everyone, but limited—only for the pre-chosen elect. According to this view, Christ did not die for the world but only for a few—the elect. Calvinists argue that if Jesus died for

all yet not all are saved, His atonement would somehow be a failure. Therefore, they insist, He must have died only for those predestined to be saved.

But this doctrine faces serious challenges—not only morally, but biblically. Not only is the invitation universal, but so is the application. Christ's blood is not merely offered to all and applied to a few. It is poured out for the world and effective for the world. Anything less reduces the cross to a sincere gesture that ultimately fails, rather than the decisive, victorious act of God to reconcile all things to Himself.

A careful look at Scripture reveals an overwhelming, undeniable pattern: God's plan of salvation is not partial nor exclusive, but universal. Scripture consistently uses words like *"the world," "all,"* and *"every"* when describing Christ's mission and work. Far from presenting salvation as an exclusive club, the Bible thunders with the message that God's grace is a free gift extended to everyone, with no exclusions or conditions, and without exception.

The Universe Doesn't Orbit You

Nowhere in the New Testament are we instructed to "pray and ask Jesus into your heart." That phrase is a later

evangelical invention. The idea is also theologically confused, since the New Testament repeatedly teaches that Jesus is at the right hand of the Father while the Holy Spirit is the one sent to dwell within believers.

When we speak of salvation, we often make it small. We reduce it to individual choices, moments at an altar, or formulas and prayers to "get to heaven." But the Bible paints a much bigger picture. It speaks of a cosmic battle, not just for human souls, but for the triumph of God's will over everything that opposes it—evil, sin, rebellion, death, and the spiritual powers and principalities that seek to enslave creation. If God is truly God, then His salvation must ultimately include all parts of His creation.

As we saw in previous chapters, the Hebrew Scriptures' redemption was never a narrow, one-dimensional, individualistic concept limited to the afterlife of an individual. It was holistic and about restoring not just people but entire communities, nations, and even land. The scope and vision were always grand:

> *For God did not send his Son into the world to condemn the world, but to **save the world** through him.*
>
> (John 3:17)

Christ's death—His atonement—was not a limited transaction fulfilling a single requirement. Rather, it was the culmination of the biblical narrative—a story that always pointed to a cosmic healing, universal restoration, and the salvation of the world.

Preachers often say, "If you were the only person on earth, Jesus would still have come and died just for you." While the sentiment behind that statement is heartfelt, it subtly narrows the scope of the New Covenant. It reframes the cross as primarily individualized, rather than recognizing its vast, cosmic reach.

The New Covenant is not merely personal—it is universal. It is no longer confined to one individual, one people, or one nation, but embraces the whole world and, indeed, all creation. Jesus did not come only for you in isolation; He came to reconcile *all* things to God and to restore the entire created order. The cross is not diminished by personal love—but it is expanded by its universal purpose.

God's Universal Scope of Salvation Is Not a New Testament Invention

> *The Lord is good to **all**, and his mercy is over **all** that he has made.*
>
> (Psalm 145:9)

God's mercy is not limited. His kindness embraces all of creation.

> *He will swallow up death forever; and the Lord God will wipe away tears from **all** faces.*
>
> (Isaiah 25:8)

God's victory over death is not partial. It will touch every face, not just a chosen few.

> *To me **every** knee shall bow, **every** tongue shall swear allegiance.*
>
> (Isaiah 45:22-23)

The future God promises is one of universal recognition and worship, not partial allegiance.

> *All we like sheep have gone astray… and the Lord has laid on him the iniquity of us **all**.*
>
> (Isaiah 53:6)

All have gone astray. All are included in the redemptive work laid upon Christ.

> ***All** flesh shall come to worship before me, declares the Lord.*

(Isaiah 66:23)

A day will come when worship is universal, when every heart turns toward its Creator.

This means even hell—however one understands it—must be temporary; a corrective justice for the sake of restoration.

Divine discipline—that of a loving Father—must always aim toward repentance and restoration. Its purpose isn't to crush or abuse, but to correct, restore, and bring about transformation. God does nothing as a judge that he wouldn't do as a father. Only a temporary punishment can have a true and positive purpose, thus:

> *For **no one** is cast off by the Lord forever.*
>
> (Lamentations 3:31)

Without the hope of redemption, punishment becomes mere sadism—but when guided by love, it becomes a temporary path to healing and renewal.

Even those who suffered the death penalty, the loss of the privilege of life in this age, are not beyond God's redemptive reach. They too will be raised, brought into judgment, and held accountable. That judgment involves real consequences, corrective and purifying in nature, but it is not endless torture. Resurrection leads to reckoning, not to eternal torment. God's justice restores order and heals what is broken; it does not perpetuate suffering without end.

God's Universal Scope of Salvation According to the New Testament

> *I bring you good news of great joy that will be for **all** the people.*
>
> (Luke 2:10)

The good news was not for a few, but for *all* the people.

*And **all humanity** will see God's salvation.*

(Luke 3:6)

God's salvation will be witnessed by all flesh—not hidden, not restricted to time or place.

*The true light, which gives light to **everyone**, was coming into the world.*

(John 1:9)

Jesus' light is universal, shining upon every human heart.

*And I, when I am lifted up from the earth, will draw **all** people to myself.*

(John 12:32)

If Jesus draws all, then no one can permanently remain outside His pull. His love is stronger than human misunderstanding and rebellion, stronger than Satan's deception.

> *For **all** have sinned… and **all** are justified by his grace as a gift.*
>
> (Romans 3:23-24)

All are justified because His grace is a free gift.

> *One trespass led to condemnation for **all**… so one act of righteousness leads to justification and life for **all**.*
>
> (Romans 5:18-19)

Adam's fall affected everyone; Christ's righteousness restores everyone.

*For God has consigned **all** to disobedience, that he may have mercy on **all**.*

(Romans 11:32)

God's mercy matches the reach of human disobedience—completely.

*As in Adam **all** die, so in Christ shall **all** be made alive.*

(1 Corinthians 15:22)

There is no death Adam caused that Christ will not undo.

*One has died for **all**...*

(2 Corinthians 5:14)

Christ's death embraces all people in its scope.

> *At the name of Jesus **every** knee should bow… and **every** tongue confess that Jesus Christ is Lord.*
>
> (Philippians 2:9-11)

The future will see a universal confession of Christ's lordship—not through coercion, but through adoration.

> *Through him to reconcile to himself **all** things, whether on earth or in heaven.*
>
> (Colossians 1:19-20)

God's plan is nothing less than the reconciliation of everything.

*God our savior, who wills **everyone** to be saved.*

(1 Timothy 2:3-4)

If this is God's desire, what could ever stand in the way of His triumphant will?

*We have hoped in a living God who is the Savior of **all** human beings.*

(1 Timothy 4:10)

Not the Savior of some—the Savior of *all*.

*The grace of God has appeared, bringing salvation for **all** people.*

(Titus 2:11)

God's grace doesn't discriminate. It brought salvation to *all*.

> *Jesus… so that by the grace of God he might taste death for* ***everyone****.*
>
> (Hebrews 2:9)

Jesus didn't taste death for the sake of only an elect few—but for *everyone*.

> *The Lord… is patient toward you, not wishing that any should perish, but that* ***all*** *should reach repentance.*
>
> (2 Peter 3:9)

God's patience reveals His heart: He desires *all* to find repentance. Can anything resist His will forever?

> *He is the propitiation for our sins, and not for ours only but also for the sins of the **whole world**.*
>
> (1 John 2:2)

The sacrifice of Jesus extends to the *whole world*—not a corner left untouched.

> *I heard **every** creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth… saying, "To him who sits on the throne be glory and honor!"*
>
> (Revelation 5:13)

Every creature—dead or alive—will join in worship. Every voice will rise in adoration.

> *Behold, I am making **all** things new.*
>
> (Revelation 21:5)

God's final act is the renewal of *all* things—not the abandonment of most.

Everyone Will Be Brought Back to Life

The universal aspect of salvation means that everyone will be brought back to life:

> *Do not be amazed at this, for a time is coming when **all** who are in their graves will hear his voice and come out—those who have done what is good will rise to live, and those who have done what is evil will rise to be condemned.*

(John 5:28–29)

This may sound confusing to the modern ear: what is the point of resurrecting everyone with a new body if, moments later, most are supposedly "condemned"? The confusion dissolves once we examine what Scripture actually means by *condemnation* versus *life*.

A Western reader tends to equate "life" with mere biological existence or physical survival. But Jesus was not a twenty-first-century biologist or a modern philosopher. He was a first-century Jewish rabbi. In His world, *life* did not mean simply continuing to breathe. It meant blessing and joy, wholeness and peace, purpose, flourishing, and harmony with God. To *live* was to participate in the fullness of divine life—not merely to exist. Life wasn't about quantity (duration) but about quality:

> *The thief comes only to steal and kill and destroy; I have come that they may have* ***life, and have it to the full.***
>
> (John 10:10)

That meaning remains in Judaism even today.

For instance, at Bar Mitzvahs, weddings, and every Shabbat, Jews around the world raise a glass of wine and toast *"L'CHAIM!"—"To life!"*—meaning, to joy, blessing, and flourishing.

So, some will rise to enjoy God's highest blessings—sharing in the intimate nearness of His Kingdom, joining the great feast, the celebration prepared for those who lived faithfully. Others, though resurrected, will experience loss, judgment, and condemnation. They will stand before God not as enemies to be tortured, but as souls whose lives bear the consequences of what they chose, neglected, or rejected. They will not be like refined gold, but like alloyed gold that still needs to be refined and purified in fire.

In other words—someone can be condemned for their wrongdoing without being sentenced to everlasting torment. They may not be "great in the Kingdom," they may gnash their teeth in regret, feeling the weight of missed opportunities. But this does not mean God will throw them into a burning pit and torment them forever in lava.

Conclusion—God's Salvation is Universal

From Genesis to Revelation, the Bible tells a beautiful story of God's boundless love and His plan to redeem the world. Again and again, we encounter the language of inclusion: *all, every, the whole world.* The gospel is not a restricted offer to a select few but an unstoppable river of grace that will eventually engulf and restore the entire cosmos.

If all have fallen short—and Scripture declares that they have—then all are equally included in Christ's work of redemption. Salvation is not limited by human stubbornness, religious systems, or doctrinal precision. It flows from the heart of a God whose love is boundless, whose power is unmatched, and whose will is sure.

The good news is bigger, wider, and more beautiful than we ever dared hope: In Christ, all things will be made new. *All.*

Chapter 31

The Grace That Offends the Religious Mind

Let's be honest: deep down, many Christians struggle with the idea that "bad people"—murderers, abusers, even sworn enemies—might also be forgiven and restored. Grace sounds wonderful until it's extended to those we hate. Jonah hated it. So did the older brother in the prodigal son story. Grace offends our sense of fairness—until the day we realize we need it just as much.

As a Jewish person who lost family members in the Holocaust, I would rather see Hitler—yes, even Hitler—repent and bow before Jesus Christ than burn forever. God's restorative justice must triumph over human emotional vengeance, or else justice itself becomes another form of violence.

The Scandal of Grace

The notion that eventually everyone will be saved is a hard pill to swallow. Perhaps there are even exceptions—few who became so wicked that they effectively lost the image of God within them and are ultimately annihilated. Yet the idea that most—if not all—will be restored presents a view of God as supremely powerful, wise, loving, and inclusive.

God's power is not measured by how many He can destroy in a single blow, but by how many He can save, rescue from evil, and heal from their own brokenness.

This perspective suggests that God's love and redemptive power are so immense (Romans 8:38-39) that even in the afterlife—no soul is beyond His reach, illustrating a God who fulfills His desire that none should perish but that all should come to repentance (2 Peter 3:9). It implies a God whose plans are unstoppable and whose

purposes are so grand that they encapsulate the entirety of creation within His redemptive embrace. This view acknowledges the ultimate victory of good over evil, and of love over hatred, showcasing God's infinite wisdom in designing a creation where every part has a place in the world to come.

Conversely, the idea that only a few are eventually saved limits God's power and effectiveness. It suggests that despite His desire to save all, He either chooses not to (Calvinism) or is unable to achieve this outcome. This could imply that God's capabilities are thwarted by human stubbornness or by the powers of evil. Such a viewpoint might portray God as less capable of achieving His will or that His wisdom is restricted to only a subset of His creation, leading to a partial victory over evil, which questions the omnipotence attributed to Him.

God: Greater Than We Dare to Believe

Many Christians have been raised to see salvation as a kind of exclusive club—a reward for behaving a certain way, believing the right creeds, or belonging to the right group. The idea that "everyone eventually gets in"

feels, to some, like it cheapens the value of their own faith or group. But God's love is not finite. Grace is not diluted by being extended for all; it is magnified. Mercy doesn't run out. It multiplies.

Fear can pressure a person into short-term compliance, but it cannot produce long-term transformation. Fear may stop a behavior for a moment, but it cannot change the heart that desires it. That's why fear-based religion so often collapses into cycles of guilt, shame, and exhaustion: people obey only as long as the threat feels close. Once the door is shut, the behavior returns—because nothing inward has been healed. Fear suppresses; it does not renew. It coerces the will, but it cannot set the mind free.

Love, on the other hand, transforms from the inside out. Love awakens desire, restores dignity, and draws the heart toward goodness freely, not by force. The New Testament is unambiguous: *"Perfect love casts out fear"* (1 John 4:18), not the other way around. Jesus never said, "Fear me so you will obey me," but rather, "Follow Me," "Abide in My love," "I call you friends." Love produces faithfulness that is joyful, durable, and wholehearted. Someone who follows out of love will stay committed long after someone who follows out of fear has given up. Fear may raise a flag or start a journey, but only love can sustain it—and only love can make it beautiful.

Sadly, highly religious people often cling to fear because it provides a sense of control, certainty, superiority, and psychological safety in a world that feels unpredictable without it. Let's unpack some of these reasons.

Religion Flourishes on Fear

Religion, in many of its institutional forms, is structured around fear because fear is the glue that keeps the system intact. If a community can convince you that your afterlife hinges on adhering to its doctrines, submitting to its authority, and maintaining membership through your time, energy, tithing and donations, then the system becomes self-sustaining. No religion can sustain itself without selling something—an idea powerful enough to persuade you to fund it and keep it alive. And nothing sells more effectively than fear.

The promise is safety: Stay with us, believe as we tell you, follow our rules, and you will be secure in the afterlife. Otherwise, our God will barbecue you forever. The threat is exclusion: Stray from us, and you risk everything. This dynamic—fear paired with promised protection—ensures loyalty, preserves institutional power, and keeps the machinery running by collecting financial support.

But if, as Paul wrote, *"God was in Christ reconciling the world to Himself"* (2 Cor. 5:19), then the church's role is not to control access but to announce freedom. Not to judge but to heal. Grace always threatens systems built on exclusivity, fear, and control.

The Weight of Tradition

For over 1,500 years, Western Christianity—especially post-Augustine—has taught that unbelievers—as well as many believers—face Eternal Conscious Torment. This doctrine was passed down like family heirlooms: inherited, familiar, and rarely questioned. When challenged, verses taken out of context are used to shut people down. So when the church proclaims, "Christ died for us," it often adds an invisible footnote: "...but only if you do X or believe Y." That's not good news to all. That's a boundary on God's grace. And it misses the scope of the Cross.

Justice, Misunderstood

Too often, the religious mind equates justice with payback—someone must suffer, someone must burn. So if

God eventually forgives all, is He still "just"?

It was almost comical—if it hadn't been so morally disturbing—how fundamentalists accused Kirk Cameron of "misunderstanding justice" simply because he rejected Eternal Conscious Torment. As if true justice required God to operate like a psychopath, compelled to satisfy a sadist's craving by torturing people forever. That wasn't a defense of justice; it was a projection of cruelty onto God and a sanctification of moral insanity. If someone fundamentally misunderstood justice, it certainly wasn't Cameron—it was those who mistook sadism for righteousness and dared to call it holy.

Biblical justice isn't retribution—it's restoration. The Cross doesn't appease God's wrath like a transaction or payment. It conquers evil, absorbs violence, forgives enemies, and restores humanity. God's justice is not about settling cosmic scores, but about healing the wound.

Imagine This for Just One Moment

Let go of what you think is "orthodoxy."

Put aside human creeds and religious doctrines.

Don't be defensive.

Don't be apologetic with yourself.

Now, with your God-given imagination, picture this:

What would it look like if every single soul—across time, culture, and history—worshiped God simultaneously?

No more suffering and pain.

No more division and fear.

No more confusion and condemnation.

No more death.

Just pure, unified awe rising from every heart and filling the entire universe.

Every knee ever created bowing in honor. Every tongue ever made confessing the name of Christ in loud praise.

Breathe in. And hold on to that image for five seconds.

Now ask yourself—how did that make you feel?

Did it bring sadness or joy? Depression or hope?

Did it make you think less or more of God?

Did it make you feel distressed, or did it awaken something deep in you—a longing to celebrate God's unimaginable power and grace?

Did it feel like the end of something…

Or the resurrection and restoration of everything?

Conclusion

Ultimately, a belief that embraces the salvation of all is a celebration of God's absolute sovereignty and unbounded grace, presenting a God who is not only powerful enough to create the universe but also loving enough to ensure that every part of it is, eventually, reconciled to Him. This magnifies His glory and demonstrates His profound wisdom in orchestrating a plan where His love and justice triumph absolutely.

Chapter 32

"Eternal Life" and John 3:16

*For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not **perish** but have **eternal life**.*

(John 3:16)

John 3:16 is one of the most quoted Bible verses—often seen on soda cups and burger wrappers—but it's also among the most misunderstood and taken out of context. Two key phrases, in particular, are often misinterpreted by modern readers.

The first phrase is *"**perish**."* While some assume it means being tormented forever in hell, the original hearers would not have understood the word "perish" in that way. In its original context, "perish" refers to waste, ruin, destruction, or the tragic loss of what could have been—not Eternal Conscious Torment.

The second phrase is *"**eternal life**"*—a rich and meaningful Jewish phrase that doesn't point to quantity, like living forever, but to quality or kind—a way of life fully rooted, and deeply aligned with God's will. It represents the highest expression of spiritual living.

Let's dig deeper…

"Perish"—Lost Rather Than Perpetually Tormented

The Greek word "perish" *(Apollymi)* does not mean "to be tortured forever," but speaks about *this* life and means to be ruined, lost, waste, or broken—like saying "her life is ruined," "he is a broken person," "such a waste

of life," or "they are a lost soul." It's a metaphor for a life that has gone astray.

Jesus Himself defines the word through His three parables in Luke 15—the *lost* sheep, the *lost* coin, and the *lost* son. In each story, the thing that was *"apollymi"* was not tormented in hell forever; it was simply missing, lost, out of place, or estranged. And in every case, what was lost was eventually found, restored, and brought home again! That is the biblical meaning of "perish": not endless torment, but a temporary state of being lost—always within the reach of a God who seeks until He finds.

The first-century followers of Jesus understood this metaphor from the Hebrew Scriptures—like Jeremiah 50:6—where Israel is described as having "perished" (or "been lost," depending on the translation) in exile, yet was ultimately restored.

They recognized that in Jesus's stories what's "lost" or "perished" is something valuable to God—something He searches for, longs for, and ultimately restores. So, to "perish" doesn't mean being tortured, tormented, or wiped out—it's about a life that's drifted off course, lost its way, squandered, and left to waste....

You Can't Have It Both Ways

If "eternal life" were nothing more than unending existence, then the logic collapses. If some people are said to suffer forever in hell, then they too would possess "eternal life"—just a version defined by endless torment. But Scripture does not speak in contradictions. If eternal life were merely a span of infinite time, then eternal punishment would qualify as eternal life as well.

The conclusion is unavoidable: *eternal life* must mean something else. It is not about duration, but about kind. It is a quality of life—life aligned with God, shaped by His teaching, animated by His Spirit, and rooted in communion with Him.

Eternal Life Now, Not After Death

Throughout his writings, John repeatedly insists that the believer already *has* eternal life (John 6:47; 5:24; 1 John 5:13). Notice the tense: *has*, not 'will have someday after death,' and not 'will receive only at the resurrection.' Eternal life, according to John, is a present possession.

If "having eternal life" were primarily about quantity—about endless duration—then believers would likely not die at all. But they do. The fact that death still occurs exposes the category mistake. Eternal life is not defined first by how long it lasts, but by what kind of life it is.

This makes John's theology unmistakably clear: eternal life is, first and foremost, about nature, not duration—a divine kind of life already at work in the present, long before the grave is emptied.

“Eternal Life” in Biblical Judaism

A striking insight emerges when we examine how the Jewish phrase eternal life—*chayei olam* in Hebrew—was understood in the time of Jesus and in later Jewish thought.[75] *Chayei olam* was considered an honorary term and was often set in contrast with *chayei sha'ah*—literally, “superficial life”, “fleeting life,” or “perishing life.”

Chayei sha'ah describes superficial kind of life consumed by mere survival: working, earning, eating, sleeping—endlessly managing the necessities of existence without ever touching its purpose. It is life reduced to maintenance. By contrast, *chayei olam* refers not to infinite duration, but to a depth and quality of life rooted in God—life infused with meaning, blessing, and participation in the eternal purposes of heaven, even while lived on earth.

In contrast, *chayei olam* referred to a spiritually charged way of life—one lived in alignment with divine values. It described a blessed existence shaped by righteousness, purpose, and enduring significance. While it did carry implications beyond death, its primary emphasis was never escapist or otherworldly. It was about

living now in harmony with God's will—participating in eternal life in the present, not postponing it to the afterlife.

This understanding sheds light on Jesus' words in John 17:3:

> *Now this is **eternal life**: that they **know you**, the only true God, and Jesus Christ, whom you have sent.*
>
> (John 17:3)

Here, "eternal life" is not described in terms of time or location, but in terms of essence, quality, substance. *Eternal life* is a unique kind of spiritual understanding. It isn't about physics (time and space) but about union. To "know" someone means to be close and intimate with them (e.g., Genesis 4:1). *Eternal life*—knowing God—begins now, not after death.

To "know God" in this sense is not merely cognitive or intellectual. It is relational, experiential, and transformative—it's to live *chayei olam* here and now.

Therefore, "eternal life"—in the Hebrew mindset—wasn't about time, duration, or going to a far-off place after death. It was about a kind of life—a life rooted in God, rich in meaning, filled with love, peace, justice, and divine presence. It was the kingdom of God—breaking into the present.

Furthermore, since Jesus hadn't yet died, the phrase *"whoever believes in Him shall have eternal life"* (John 3:16) couldn't have been referring to a guaranteed ticket to heaven based on belief in His sacrificial death. Instead, it was an invitation to enter a new way of living. To believe in Him meant following His way. To move from carnal desires into true, blessed, abundant life by walking His path.

Eternal Life Is To Know God

According to Jesus, eternal life wasn't about floating in the clouds forever—it was about truly knowing God, His will, His character, and His ways. And knowing God isn't some magical download of facts or memorizing doctrinal lines; it's something lived out in real relationships—through loving others.

To *know God* means learning what He loves and what grieves Him, understanding what He desires from us, and discovering how to walk with Him in trust and obedience. It's knowing what brings Him joy, how to align our hearts with His, and how to live a life that reflects His character.

Knowing God isn't abstract like a seminary degree—it's personal, practical, and deeply transformative. It's not just about intellectually believing God exists and that Jesus is the Messiah; it's about becoming one with Him, one with His will—living the very life we were created for. Eternal life wasn't about endless time, but about the honor of experiencing the *highest kind* of spiritual life. Quality, not quantity.

Why the West Thinks as It Does

Since Jews in biblical times did not understand "eternal life" as an everlasting, never-ending duration, we shouldn't interpret it that way either. This interpretation did not come from the Hebrew Scriptures or from the Jewish worldview held by Jesus and His disciples. Instead, it arose later, shaped by Greek philosophical categories—an obsession with quantifying time, metaphysical permanence, abstract timelessness, and mathematical measurement.

Greek philosophical influence, combined with later Christian misunderstandings of Jewish idioms, disconnected the phrase from its original context and transformed it into a statement about duration and the afterlife rather than divine quality and participation in God's life.

The Hebrew mind was not concerned with time in the abstract. The concept of time was never debated. For the ancient Israelites, the focus was on relationships, covenant faithfulness, divine presence, and blessing. It was about the *quality* of life, not the number of years.

Yes, many Jews believed in immortality—not as infinite linear time, but as life so strong that it can't be extinguished.

This perspective also clarifies the meaning of the *"narrow road that leads to life"* (Matthew 7:14). It is not a biological or literal statement about the afterlife, but a spiritual one—a narrow way that leads to a rich, blessed, abundant kind of life: a life aligned with God.

When Jesus spoke about eternal life, small gates, and narrow roads, He had not yet gone to the cross. No one listening to Him imagined that He was about to die for their sins so they could go to heaven.

Whoever Believes = Whoever Follows

> *Whoever **hears** my word and **believes** him who sent me **has eternal life** and will not be judged but **has** crossed over from death to life.*
>
> (John 5:24)

Whatever *"whoever hears my word and believes"* meant in that moment, it could not have meant "believe that I will one day die for your sins." Reading it that way imports a later theological system back into an earlier teaching—a textbook case of anachronism.

Instead, Jesus was calling His hearers not to a future transaction, but to a present way of life. The narrow road leads to life now—a life of faithfulness, blessing, and alignment with God's reign—long before the grave.

Jesus was a Jewish rabbi. In that world, to hear a rabbi's word did not mean passive listening or intellectual agreement—it meant obedience, imitation, alignment. To hear was to follow. To believe was to entrust one's

life to the teacher's wisdom and way. People did not seek out rabbis for abstract doctrines, but for a path. They believed a true teacher carried the wisdom—the secret, so to speak—to a life of blessing, meaning, and harmony with God.

To believe Jesus, then, was to entrust oneself to His way of life and to begin walking it. Hearing and believing are inseparable from following. Living by His teachings is living eternal life—a blessed, God-aligned life—here and now, liberated from perishing life and condemnation, and crossing over from judgment to life.

So when Jesus says, "Follow me," "Believe me," or "Hear my word," He is doing something radically subversive. He is placing Himself above every competing voice—religious authorities, political powers, social expectations—and calling people to trust *His* way as the supreme path to life. Eternal life, in this sense, is not postponed until after death; it is entered the moment one crosses from death into life by walking in His way.

If I were to paraphrase John 3:16 for someone unfamiliar with the Jewish worldview and context, it might sound something like this:

"For God so loved the world that He gave up His one and only Son, that whoever follows His ways shall not waste their lives but have a blessed life because it's aligned with God's will."

Case Study: Why "Eternal Life" Couldn't Be About Escaping Eternal Conscious Torment in Hellfire

> *Teacher, what good thing must I do to **inherit eternal life**?*
>
> (Matthew 19:16)

Jesus responds, *"If you want to **enter life**, keep the commandments"* (Matthew 19:17). Notice the language: *eternal life* and *entering life* are treated as interchangeable. Not as an escape from hell, but as participation in the fullness of God's kingdom blessings.

"Eternal life," "entering life," "entering through the narrow gate," "entering the kingdom," "walking the narrow path," and "inheriting the kingdom"—these are not metaphors for an afterlife destination, but for a *kind* of life—already available to us in the present.

Jesus is not offering a transactional shortcut to heaven for those who merely agree with Him intellectually. He was inviting the rich man into a transformed existence aligned with God's reign—here and now, in embodied faithfulness, not deferred salvation.

Then, Jesus also added, *"If you want to be perfect, go, sell your possessions and give to the poor..."* (v.21). Here, perfection isn't moral flawlessness—it's becoming one with God's will. It's sacrificing for His kingdom to enjoy His blessings.

If "eternal life" or "entering life" meant escaping hell by adhering to doctrine, obeying commandments and performing good deeds, then Jesus would have been teaching salvation by works. But Jesus wasn't offering an escape route from divine torture; He was simply inviting the man—and us—into life with God. A life of divine abundance, a life aligned with God's nature, a life of deep, spiritual intimacy with glorious rewards in the age to come.

The rich man's wealth was the obstacle, not because money damns, but because it dulled his soul to the *kind* of life Jesus was offering. The man wanted to be blessed by God—yet wasn't willing to let go of earthly wealth to receive heavenly treasure.

Paul's "Inherit" is Jesus' "Inherit"

The word *"inherit"* is key. In both Jesus' conversation with the rich man and Paul's writings (e.g., 1 Corinthians 6:9–10), ***inheriting** the kingdom* is not about escaping never-ending torment—it's about receiving one's portion or reward in the present age and in the age of Messianic restoration.

When the rich man asks what he must do to inherit eternal life, he's not talking about avoiding hell, but about receiving heavenly reward—gaining a share in God's kingdom. Jesus responds by inviting him into a life of sacrificial discipleship—but the rich man turns away, unwilling to let go of his wealth. The rich man had to give up his wealth to gain an even greater reward—becoming a disciple of Jesus Christ. Literally.

In the same way, Paul warns that *"neither thieves nor the greedy nor drunkards nor slanderers nor swindlers will inherit the kingdom of God"* (1 Corinthians 6:9–10). This isn't about an afterlife of Eternal Conscious Torment; it's about forfeiting the rewards and blessings of God's kingdom, both now and in the age to come.

"Eternal Judgment"

In biblical language, "eternal judgment" does not mean an endlessly ongoing process of judging, but symbolizes a complete, decisive, and irreversible judgment—one whose results are permanent, not one that is endlessly administered.

A clear example is Sodom and Gomorrah. Jude 7 speaks of them undergoing *"the punishment of eternal fire,"* yet the cities are not still burning today. The fire was not infinite but decisive and total—it accomplished its purpose. Again—quality rather than quantity.

Likewise, Scripture says Edom's fire *"will not be quenched night or day"* (Isaiah 34:9–10), yet Edom is not presently aflame. The imagery communicates finality and completeness, not infinite duration of time.

To summarize, in the Bible, *eternal life* describes the quality, value, or kind of life, not its length in measurable time. Likewise, *eternal judgment* means a judgment that is thorough, conclusive, and beyond appeal—not one that perpetuates punishment forever:

> For the wicked there are punishments, not perpetual, however, lest the immortality prepared for them should be a disadvantage. But they are to be purified for a brief period according to the amount of malice in their works. They shall therefore suffer punishment for a short space, but immortal blessedness having no end awaits them...the penalties to be inflicted for their many and grave sins are very far surpassed by the magnitude of the mercy to be showed to them. [76]
>
> (St. Diodore of Tarsus 320—394 AD)

In short:

Eternal judgment (or eternal fire) = A judgment that's total. Complete. Accomplished. Not endless torment, but an irrevocable act whose consequences fully stand.

Eternal life = intimacy with and knowledge of God, blessings, reward, spiritual fulfillment.

Conclusion—The World Was Perishing Until God Sent His Son

In the Hebrew imagination, eternal spoke less of duration and more of depth—of quality, weight, fullness. Eternal life was a divine kind of life: intimacy with God, spiritual vitality, meaning, and blessing. It stood in stark contrast to perishing—not as endless conscious misery, but as a life drained of purpose and communion. This is not the Western obsession with infinite timelines or mathematical duration, but a profoundly Jewish vision of life infused with God. When Jesus spoke of "eternal life," He was not offering an endless clock. He was offering a transformed way of living—a life finally aligned with its Creator.

The all-encompassing scope of John 3:16 is impossible to escape. *God so loved the world*—not a fraction, not a select group within it, but the world in its entirety. And the very next verse removes all ambiguity:

> *For God did not send His Son into the world to condemn the world, but to save the world through Him.*

(John 3:17)

So we must ask the unavoidable question: did Christ fail? Did the Son sent to save the world succeed only marginally—five percent, ten percent, a lucky remnant—while the rest slip beyond redemption?

If God's intent were merely to rescue a small subset of humanity from infinite torment, the text would speak the language of exclusion, not the sweeping, world-embracing vocabulary of divine love. What makes God truly Mighty to Save is not merely that He desires salvation, but that He accomplishes it. His will is not a fragile wish contingent on human comprehension or performance. When God purposes redemption, He does not merely offer the possibility of salvation—He brings salvation to its intended completion.

The world was perishing. God sent His Son. And God does not fail. Yet you are invited to step into this kind of life—eternal life—not through mental assent or theological agreement, but through becoming a true disciple of Jesus Christ. Eternal life is entered by walking in His ways, embodying His teachings, and allowing His life to take shape in yours here and now.

Chapter 33

The Gnostic Shadow Behind Today's Gospel

In the ages to come He might show the immeasurable riches of His grace.

(Ephesians 2:7)

There is a persistent religious arrogance in the West—the assumption that we have God neatly figured out, *the sin of certainty*. But that illusion will eventually give way to something far richer: the joy of becoming lifelong students of divine mystery.

If God is boundless in nature, inexhaustible in wisdom, and eternal in knowledge, then His knowing is not static or finite. It is infinite, living, and endlessly unfolding—and so must be our posture before Him.

Logically, this resonates with the nature of infinity itself. You cannot exhaust an infinite source. And if we are created in the image of God, then our souls are not satisfied by stasis. We long to grow, expand, and uncover what is hidden. That longing is not a flaw—it is evidence of design.

In other words, we know very little, so we should always remain humble and teachable.

That means neither I, nor your pastor, nor a seminary professor knows everything—no matter how authoritative we may appear standing behind a pulpit, dressed in a suit and tie, speaking with confident certainty. Appearance and confidence are not the same as omniscience, and no human voice can exhaust the mystery of God.

This also means paradise won't be boring. It's not a frozen place of singing the same songs over and over again. It is a never-ending exploration of beauty, love, wisdom, and relationships. Imagine learning new dimensions of grace every day. Imagine meeting love in deeper ways every hour.

Morally, this calls us to embrace a lifelong openness to learning. It rebukes spiritual pride and reminds us: if we are to learn forever, then we must stay humble forever. And if there is no ceiling to what God can show us, then every person we meet may carry a glimpse of His truth we've yet to see.

This is why I regard *Systematic Theology* as a well-intentioned but ultimately flawed human attempt to force God into a box. It offers the illusion that God has been figured out, neatly organized, and resolved—when in reality it is an effort to confine the Infinite within tidy categories He never agreed to inhabit.

What I've Learned From Teaching Systematic Theology

I spent about 20 years serving in fundamentalist Messianic ministries and academia. These schools and ministries were heavily influenced by fundamentalist Christian groups, primarily grounded in Calvinistic and Pentecostal doctrine.

Theologically, the Messianic scene in Israel is overwhelmingly Reformed (Calvinist)—especially among the wealthiest and most influential ministries. And while the term Systematic Theology doesn't have a single inventor, over time it developed into the central pillar of Reformed theology.

We were sent to study fundamentalist Calvinistic theology at American institutions. Then we returned and taught it rigorously at our "messianic" Bible college, indoctrinating a new generation as if our theology represented the singular and final truth of God. In our human—and often arrogant—attempt to dissect and categorize the Infinite like a laboratory specimen, we routinely tore verses from their context and forced them into neatly constructed, man-made systems. In doing so, we became architects of a rigid box, attempting to contain the very Spirit we claimed to serve.

And the irony persists. To this day, there is only one Systematic Theology available to the Messianic movement in Hebrew—a Calvinistic volume first published in 1986 and only recently translated and promoted by One For Israel Ministry. A single Reformed framework, imported, elevated, and treated as definitive—offered to a people whose Scriptures were never meant to be imprisoned in such a system.

The Failed Attempt to Systematize God

Back then, the more systematic and polished our messianic doctrine became, the narrower and more exclusive our spiritual tolerance grew. As our theology hardened, our capacity to live with disagreement collapsed. The

explosion of boycotts within such a tiny movement was not accidental—it was inevitable. I could already see where that road ended: the walls of our beliefs closing in tighter and tighter until, eventually, the path would be wide enough for only one person to walk it.

That trajectory explains much of the dehumanization I witnessed—and still witness—within the Messianic movement. Jews, Catholics, and even fellow Protestants dismissed as "merely nominal" Christians are casually condemned to Eternal Conscious Torment. When theology becomes a weapon of certainty, compassion is the first casualty. What remains is not faithfulness, but fear disguised as conviction.

And this is the framework that I—like many other ex-fundamentalists—eventually had to dismantle, piece by piece, in order to recover a vision of God that is actually faithful to our Jewish Scriptures, grounded in the Jewish roots of our faith, and aligned with the Spirit and teachings of our Jewish Rabbi. Of course, I'm not talking about today's rabbinic form of Judaism, but rather the version found in the Bible and associated with Jesus (e.g., Luke 2:21-41).

Why am I telling you all this? Because it's helpful in understanding where I came from and the theological DNA that shaped Israel's modern Messianic movement and its ministries (all originally founded by Westerners) —a lens that absorbed, rather than questioned, Western/Augustinian assumptions about God, atonement, salvation, hell, and even the very heart of the gospel. Global donations didn't just fund the movement; they defined its theology.

And what I came to witness during my time in the movement is that wealth mixed with doctrine and dogma often serve as tools to divide, turning anyone who disagrees with you into an "other." They strip people of their humanity and dignity, elevating their own doctrinal statement to something idolized and worshipped, believing salvation depends on doctrinal precision.

The Gnostic shadow is unmistakable in the assumption that salvation is achieved through mastering intellectual knowledge.

Fundamentalism often comes across as overconfident, speaking as if it holds the ultimate truth. Wisdom, on the other hand, walks with humility, aware it can never grasp the entire picture (1 Corinthians 13:12).

For We Walk By Faith, Not By Sight

Belief doesn't require knowing everything. Faith was never meant to be total comprehension. Scripture itself affirms belief without sight, trust without full understanding, and hope rooted in what is still unseen (Hebrews 11:1; John 20:29; 2 Corinthians 5:7; Romans 8:24–25; 1 Peter 1:8–9). And that's perfectly fine, because then you won't insist on forcing everyone into a "you-shaped" theology.

If you were blind, you would not be guilty of sin; but now that you claim you can see, your guilt remains.

(John 9:41)

God extends compassion and mercy to the humble and teachable, but He confronts—and judges—the intellectually proud and spiritually arrogant. Blindness is not the greatest danger; the claim of perfect sight is.

Humility is not a weakness—it is a gift. When faith no longer depends on having all the answers, it stops feeling threatened by questions and loses the urge to coerce others into the narrow confines of its own dogma. Humility makes room for strength without cruelty, conviction without domination, and truth without fear. It allows us to believe deeply without dehumanizing those who believe differently, to walk confidently without trampling dignity.

Imagine what Christianity might look like to the outside world if Protestants did not damn Catholics to hell, and Catholics returned the favor—if disagreement did not require mutual condemnation. Imagine a faith mature enough to disagree without anathematizing, to hold convictions without weaponizing them.

I say this as someone who believes the entire Western—both Catholic and Protestant—framework of the gospel is deeply distorted. And yet, I also believe that every person within those systems is fully loved, fully seen, and fully embraced by God. Truth does not require contempt, and love does not require uniformity.

To Be "Born Again" Into Modern-Day Gnosticism

"If you agree, you can be born again right now by simply repeating this short prayer after me," we would tell people on streets and university campuses—handing out tracts, dressed in matching evangelistic T-shirts.

The phrase "born again" in John 3:3 couldn't have originally meant believing in Jesus' death for the forgiveness of sins, since at that point he hadn't died yet, and his death wasn't anticipated. This implies that, originally, the term carried an entirely different meaning. [77]

The belief that the faith God is after is intellectual agreement with the right doctrine or creed—and that it can "save" someone from Eternal Conscious Torment in hell is, at its heart, the essence of Gnosticism—an ancient heresy that was absorbed into Western Christianity in the 4th century. [78], [79], [80]

Scholars argue that this was caused mainly by Augustine of Hippo,[81] who was influenced by Gnostic thought primarily because he spent nearly a decade as an auditor within Manichaeism, a late-antique religious movement widely recognized by historians as a major expression of Gnostic cosmology. Although Augustine rejected Manichaean doctrine at one point, researchers note that his mature theology—like his views on evil, the will, and interiority—retains conceptual marks shaped by his earlier immersion in a dualistic, knowledge-centered system. Modern studies of Augustine's intellectual development emphasize that his writings, his doctrine of the bound will, and his intense introspective method in *Confessions* all reflect a mind formed in dialogue with Gnostic categories even as he reworked them into Christian orthodoxy. As Johannes van Oort observes, Augustine's long engagement with Manichaean teachers and texts left *"a permanent imprint on his theological imagination,"* even after his conversion to Nicene Christianity.[82]

The Gnostics believed salvation came through *gnosis*—special, hidden from the world knowledge that "enlightened" the soul and enabled rebirth. In a disturbingly similar way, many modern Western gospel presentations reduce salvation to what a person can mentally grasp or intellectually affirm in order "to be born again." The result is a gospel transformed into a cerebral Gnostic exam, where eternal destiny hinges not on healing, transformation, or participation in divine life, but on passing a test of correct beliefs.

Whatever way Christianity may have been infiltrated by Gnosticism in the past, what truly matters is that today Gnosticism still undermines the core message of the gospel in the West—just under a different guise. It's

an ancient heresy that's all around us, and it reduces salvation to a private theory—an esoteric knowledge one must intellectually affirm to be born again and escape Eternal Conscious Torment in hellfire. In this distorted view, the gospel became a mental transaction: believe the right idea, pray a prayer, check the right mental box, and you're off the hook.

You can even test yourself to see how much Gnosticism has influenced your thinking.

Consider a simple example: someone believes in Christ, prays, and is told they are "saved." Later in life, however, they intellectually begin to question or disagree with a doctrine such as the Trinity, or have theologically shifted from one denomination to another. Are they still saved?

Many Christians instinctively answer 'no.' But that response reveals something important. It shifts salvation from what God has done in Christ toward correct knowledge of doctrinal formulas. In other words, salvation becomes dependent on your mind's ability to possess the right information.

It's a repackaged Gnosticism disguised as Christianity.

Biblical faith, however, was not about mastering intellectual formulas but about hearts transformed to better love others.

Theology is crucial because what creed you affirm or the doctrine you follow will shape how clearly you see God and represent (or misrepresent) Christ to the world. Knowing what you believe matters—but above knowledge, Scripture tells us that *love* is what matters most (1 Peter 4:8; 1 Corinthians 13:13).

True theology gives birth to true faith—not to sterile intellectualism, but to a faith embodied in love. Love is not a feeling to be admired or a concept to be debated; it is something practiced. It moves toward others. It acts. It gives. It sacrifices itself for the sake of another.

At the end of the day, everyone is a theologian of sorts, because everyone holds beliefs about the Divine. The difference is that some are simply bad theologians—and that truth applies to Christian theologians as much as anyone else.

Understanding Biblical Faith

In biblical times, belief wasn't an abstract idea or a formula you mentally signed off on. Belief was a living force—so potent, so embodied, that Jesus said it could move mountains (Matthew 17:20), or in modern language—make the impossible possible. Faith wasn't mere assent; it was an active trust that reshaped how a person lived and loved, and what kind of path they walked. Following the right way of faith—Jesus' way—meant living a blessed life that showed God's will in action.

Genesis 15:6 says, *"Abram believed the Lord, and He credited it to him as righteousness."* This verse is often referenced as support for the doctrine of salvation by faith alone—particularly in Protestant theology—but interpreting it this way removes it from its original ancient context.

In Genesis 15, Abraham's faith is not abstract or merely intellectual. It follows a dramatic covenantal promise in which God tells a childless, aging man that his descendants will outnumber the stars that he could see. Abraham's belief is not just mental agreement—it is trust that manifests in action: leaving his land (Genesis 12); building altars; preparing sacrificial animals (Genesis 15:9-10); and later even being willing to offer up his son (Genesis 22). His faith is embodied faith—faith that does something:

> *Was not our father Abraham considered righteous for what he did when he offered his son Isaac on the altar? You see that his faith and his actions were working together, and his faith was made complete by what he did.*
>
> (James 2:21-22)

James' point was not that Abraham was "saved" by works. His faith had nothing to do with escaping hellfire or securing paradise after death—none of that is in the text. Nor are we "saved" by what we do or by what we believe. We are saved—forgiven and will be raised—not from ourselves, for it is the gift of God. Humanity doesn't save itself; He alone is the Savior of the world.

Abraham's faith was not an abstract belief but a lived obedience. It meant leaving Ur of the Chaldeans (Genesis 11:31) and walking roughly 2,500 kilometers—about 1,500 miles—leaving safety, familiarity, and certainty behind, and stepping into a promised unknown. And Abraham's faith brought him a different kind of salvation—the biblical kind, filled with divine blessings and protection.

My point, and I think James would agree, is this: in biblical terms, *faith* was something you did, not merely something you assented to intellectually. In Abraham's case, faith meant trusting God enough to move, to obey, and to stake his life on God's promise.

James presents Abraham as the definitive proof that genuine faith is never passive or merely theoretical. True faith reveals its authenticity through action. Whether in his willingness to cross the earth or to offer Isaac, Abraham demonstrated that trust in God is completed, matured, and made visible through obedience. Biblical faith, therefore, is not a slogan to memorize or a confession to recite, but a lived reality—faith embodied in costly, concrete movement.

The God of Israel does not begin with rage. He begins with covenant. He begins with love. There is no threat of Eternal Conscious Torment anywhere in Genesis—or anywhere in the Hebrew Scriptures, for that matter. What we find instead is promise.

Abraham's faith is not fear-driven but promise-shaped. It is trust in God's intention to bless him, to work through him, and to make him a blessing to the nations (Genesis 12:2–3; 15:5–6). Faith here is covenantal loyalty—alignment with God's redemptive plan for the healing of the world. It is not an escape hatch from postmortem torture, but a commitment to participate in God's work of restoration here and now.

Saving Faith Is Lived, Not Merely Believed

If you believe—as I once did—that "salvation" means rescue from hellfire and is secured by "[intellectual] faith alone," then what you are really saying is that your intellectual understanding saves you from hell while the beliefs of others damn them to it. That posture almost inevitably breeds condescension and spiritual arrogance. You "figured it out." Or worse, God uniquely "chose you." Salvation quietly becomes a badge of superiority.

Once you believe that it is your faith that moves God's hand, the weight of salvation subtly shifts from God to the individual. Salvation becomes something you must mentally grasp, correctly interpret, and personally execute. It is no longer something God has decisively done for you, but something you must successfully perform—intellectually, doctrinally, and psychologically.

But truth be told, "saving faith" never had anything to do with escaping Eternal Conscious Torment in the first place. Saving faith is the kind of faith that actually saves. It saves the starving by feeding them. It saves the homeless by sheltering them on cold winter nights. It steps out of the boat—and out of the cozy seat in the church building—into storm-tossed waters. It chooses sacrificial love, even toward an enemy. It stands courageously for justice, but also for the oppressed, even when it costs something.

This is the faith Jesus embodied. Not passive intellectual assent, but living fidelity to God expressed through love, mercy, and courage.

Jesus was not a Greek philosopher constructing abstract theories. He was a Jewish rabbi, teaching through truth *and* action how to live in a way that glorifies God.

This is also the faith God recognized in Abram: a heart willing to trust, to leave certainty behind, to venture into the unknown, and to stake everything on unseen promises. The question, then, is not which faith produces fruit—every faith does. The real question is: what *kind* of fruit does your faith produce? Because the fruit always reveals the root.

Good fruit is not merely maintaining religious traditions, attending church every Sunday, or reading the Bible every morning. These practices can be good and meaningful, but they are not what the New Testament means by "the fruit of the Spirit."

When faith is genuine and biblical, its fruit is unmistakable: love, joy, peace, righteousness, patience, kindness, gentleness, humility, compassion.

But when the fruit is rotten—arrogance, pride, harshness, selfishness, impatience, cruelty, corruption, aggression, ostracization—then something is profoundly wrong with the faith itself, regardless of how many seminary degrees one holds or how eloquently one preaches from a pulpit. And this is not only true of individuals, but of entire churches, movements, and denominations.

Faith that saves will always look like love in motion. Anything else is just theology pretending to be faith.

Jesus' Own Saving Faith

Think about it: Jesus never roamed the countryside terrorizing people with questions like, "If you died tonight, would you go to heaven or hell?" Instead, He healed lepers. He fed the hungry. He spoke blessing over the poor.

He announced that the kingdom of God was at hand.

In Jesus' vocabulary, faith and salvation were never an afterlife lottery. They were the in-breaking of God's reign into real time. They were the good news that what was broken is being restored, what was lost is being found, and what was dead is rising to life.

That is the saving faith Scripture calls us to embrace. It is about restoration, healing, liberation, return, and life. And it begins here—now—by unlearning what we have inherited and rediscovering what the Scriptures actually proclaim. It begins by dismantling man-made gods and allowing our vision to be re-formed by the incomprehensible yet revealed God—the God of Abraham, Moses, and Jesus.

The Incomprehensible God

Acts records Paul preaching to the Athenians at the Areopagus and pointing out the altar to the *"unknown God"* (Acts 17:23). This is a poor translation. *Agnostos Theos* is the *incomprehensible God*, the one beyond human understanding and wisdom. That's exactly why Paul chose that altar. But when people today try to put

that God in a box and define every aspect of Him "systematically," they end up placing themselves above the Almighty, creating a god in their own image.

The study of *biblical* theology is deeply valuable, and as a theologian, I wholeheartedly affirm its significance—after all, it's exactly what we're engaging in throughout this book. However, I must also point out how greatly the gospel message has been skewed by the *Systematic* theology taught in so many seminaries today.

Faith and salvation were never meant to hinge on intellectual mastery, as though paradise could be earned by holding the correct ideas about God. The moment human intellect or "special enlightenment" becomes the key to salvation, we drift into Gnosticism and distort the very heart of the Gospel—shrinking it from a message meant to transform lives, societies, and the world into a system obsessed with being right to avoid Eternal Conscious Torment.

Modern gospel presentations often dilute the power of grace by shifting the focus from what God has decisively done to what *we* must figure out, comprehend, or get right so He does not torture or burn us in some cosmic incinerator. In doing so, the gospel is reduced to a fear-driven theology exam rather than proclaimed as what it truly is: a bold announcement of God's loving, redemptive action in the world—an invitation to have our lives transformed and to participate in the healing of everything around us.

Conclusion

Release the heavy burden of needing to "be right," and step into the freedom of being loved. Lay down the urge to win theological debates, and let it be replaced by a deeper desire to love others well. Your faith is not a fortress to be defended, but a garden to be tended—a quiet, courageous trust that blossoms in the dirt of everyday life through every act of kindness and every pursuit of justice. Trust that the Incomprehensible God is not waiting for you to solve a theological puzzle, but is already walking beside you, inviting you to be the hands that heal and the heart that reflects His infinite grace in this world.

In the end, faith is not about intellectually mastering God in seminary, but about being mastered by love. The moment we release the illusion that we must have everything figured out, we become free to learn, to grow, and to be transformed. God is not threatened by our questions, nor confined by our systems; He invites us into an endless journey of trust, humility, and discovery. And in that posture—not of certainty, but of openness—we finally find rest, because our hope was never meant to stand on knowledge or perception, but on a God who is infinitely patient, endlessly gracious, and faithful far beyond our understanding.

Chapter 34

Is God Truly Mighty to Save?

What makes God *God*, by definition, is that He is the absolute best conceivable being—not just great but perfect in every possible way and lacking nothing in anything that can be. And if God is truly God—perfect in power, wisdom, and love—then His *will* must ultimately prevail.

The Hebrew Scriptures are unshakably clear: *"Our God is in the heavens; He does whatever pleases Him"* (Psalm 115:3). *"Is anything too difficult for the LORD?"* God asks Abraham (Genesis 18:14). Through the

prophet Isaiah, He declares, *"My word… will not return to me empty, but will accomplish what I desire and achieve the purpose for which I sent it"* (Isaiah 55:11).

God isn't just a reflection of our best ideas, but far greater than anything we can imagine. God's omnipotence means He is not just stronger than every created being—He is infinitely stronger. His omniscience means He is not just wiser than any angel, human, or beast—He perfectly knows every thought, every detail, every outcome, every possibility. And His omnibenevolence means He is not just better than others—He is pure good. He doesn't merely want good things for the world—He is good.

If this is true—if God is truly as powerful, wise, and loving as Scripture proclaims, then the most important question in all of theology is this: **will His will ultimately be done?**

Can God Fail? Can We Trust His Word?

The Apostle Paul gives us the heart of God's will in plain words: *"God our Savior, who wants all people to be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth"* (1 Timothy 2:3–4). Not some. Not a chosen few. *All*.

This verse is not controversial in what it says—but it becomes deeply controversial in how many Christians try to explain it away. Some theologians, particularly in the Calvinist **T.U.L.I.P.** tradition,[83] argue that in practice, God only chooses to save a few ("Unconditional election"). And that Jesus died for them only, not for all, rendering His love limited ("Limited atonement").

But if God truly wills the salvation of all, and yet only a few end up saved, a disturbing dilemma emerges. Either God lacks the *power* to accomplish His will—rendering Him weak—or His *love* is somehow deficient (wanting to save only a few), implying that a greater love is possible, a world in which He saves more than He does here.

Either option strips God of what makes Him God. Worse still, it portrays Him as ultimately surrendering to fragile human will, distorted understanding, and the very forces of evil that shape them—rather than reigning over them, overcoming them, and bringing His purposes to completion.

It is utterly absurd to imagine that the stubbornness of a finite, limited, and often confused creature could exert greater influence than the will of God Himself.

But the God of Scripture doesn't fail. *"No purpose of Yours can be thwarted,"* says Job (Job 42:2). *"He works all things according to the counsel of His will"* (Ephesians 1:11), confirms Paul. If God wants something—and He is God—then He eventually gets it.

Which means this: if God truly *wants all people to be saved*—to come to the knowledge of Him—then that is precisely what will ultimately happen. Anything less would render Him less than God.

The Cosmic Battle—What's at Stake?

Imagine a cosmic battle between God and the forces of evil, each vying for control over human souls. If most of humanity ends in destruction—or if the enemy claims even one soul that God loves—can we truly say God has won? What kind of victory would that be? An end in which the enemy drags billions into Eternal Conscious Torment, while God watches powerlessly from the sidelines? If that's the story, then Satan isn't defeated. He's extremely successful.

But the biblical authors disagree. The Hebrew prophet Isaiah declares that *"every knee will bow, and every tongue will swear allegiance"* (45:23). Paul echoes this in Philippians 2:10 and Romans 14:11: *"Every knee will bow… every tongue will confess."* These aren't the desperate confessions of the doomed in their final moments before the axe falls, but the *willing* surrender of hearts that have *finally* seen the truth. The truth that God is not a tyrant, but a Father. Not a monster, but a Healer. Not a torturer, but a Redeemer.

If God is truly *"mighty to save"* (Zephaniah 3:17), then Christ's mission *"to save the world"* (John 3:17; John 12:47) is not a hopeful wish—it is a certainty. He will not lose the war. Not to evil. Not to sin. Not to death. Not to human stubbornness. Not to demonic powers.

He came to rescue the world, and He will accomplish exactly what He came to do—all of it.

The Weak god of Calvinism

One of the most tragic missteps in Christian history was the rise of a theology that, in the name of honoring God's sovereignty, ended up diminishing His love. Calvinism's doctrine of *Unconditional Election* teaches that God has pre-elected only a tiny portion of humanity to be saved, predestining the rest to burn forever by divine decree. Jesus, in this view, died only for "the elect," while the rest were excluded from the start. This is called *Limited Atonement* in Calvinistic theology.

But let's be honest about what these "unconditional election" and "limited atonement" doctrines really mean: These doctrines show that His love is limited and conditional, His grace is diminished, and His will to save

all people and the world is either partially effective or an outright lie. The god of Calvinism couldn't be the God of Jesus, even when he tries his best.

Calvinism stands in stark contrast to the New Testament. Jesus healed the crowds. He fed the multitudes. He forgave sinners freely and extended His mercy to Gentiles, Samaritans, prostitutes, and tax collectors. His life was an embodiment of inclusion and universal love. How, then, can we imagine His death was only for a limited few?

If God only chose some to be saved, and left the rest to damnation, we are no longer dealing with a Father who *"so loved the world"* (John 3:16), but with a sovereign who plays favorites and lets most of His image bearers burn.

But that's not what the Gospel says. It says that God *"wants **all** people to be saved"* (1 Timothy 2:4). That *"God is the Savior of **all** people"* (1 Timothy 4:10). That Christ died for *"the sins of the **whole** world"* (1 John 2:2). That *"God was in Christ reconciling the **world** to Himself"* (2 Corinthians 5:19). That *"as in Adam all die, so in Christ **all** will be made alive"* (1 Corinthians 15:22). The picture is not narrow or selective—it's universal and inclusive.

According to Romans 5:12, *"sin entered the world through one man, and death through sin, and in this way death came to all people."* If Adam's sin truly condemned all humanity (to death, not to hell), but Christ's work saves only a few, then Adam's failure proves stronger than Jesus' victory. Yet Scripture says the opposite: *"As in Adam all die, so also in Christ **all** will be made alive"* (1 Corinthians 15:22), and *"one act of righteousness leads to*

*justification and life for **all**"* (Romans 5:18). A gospel where Adam affects everyone but Christ rescues only some diminishes Christ and contradicts Paul's logic that grace must abound more than sin (Romans 5:15–21).

Limited Atonement is a weak atonement. A partial victory is not a real victory. And a god who can't—or won't—save what He loves is not the Father of my Rabbi. If Jesus came to destroy the works of the devil (1 John 3:8), then His success will be total. If He promised to draw *all* people to Himself (John 12:32), then He will. If He is the Good Shepherd who leaves the 99 to find the one that perished into the wilderness, then eventually, every last one will be brought home.

God does not lose. Not even one.

The Power of a Perfect Will

> *And when all things shall be subdued unto him, then shall the Son also himself be subject unto him that put **all** things under him, **that God may be all in all**.*
>
> (1 Corinthians 15:28)

If you believe that God is all-powerful, all-knowing, and most loving, then the only logical conclusion is that He *will* save all and that He will be all in all.

Now, let me explain…

The question we must all wrestle with is not "Does God *want* to save everyone?"—Scripture already answers that (1 Timothy 2:4). The real question is, will He succeed?

Is God truly wise enough, loving enough, and powerful enough to accomplish His will—the salvation of all people? Or is He ultimately thwarted by fragile human will? By Satan? By sin? Does He merely wish for all to be saved, only to stand powerless when they resist?

If God is the wisest of all, will He not eventually persuade? If He is love itself, will He abandon His own purpose? And if He cannot accomplish what He wills, then is He really the God revealed in Scripture?

God is not a hopeful optimist, crossing His fingers that at least some humans will choose wisely. He is not reactive. If His will is that ultimately all be saved, then that's precisely what will happen. If it is not done—then it wasn't really His will. Or worse—He is not strong enough nor wise enough to accomplish what He desires, and thus we should look for a better god elsewhere.

The Church Fathers' Understanding of God's Will

This is where the logic of the early Church Fathers kicks in. If God is truly omniscient (all-wise), omnipotent (all-powerful), and omnibenevolent (most-loving), and if He truly desires that all be saved—then the only conclusion that makes any logical or theological sense is that all will be saved. This isn't just my own logic, but the way many Church Fathers—long before MacArthur, Edwards, Calvin, or Augustine—understood the Gospel:

> Let us reflect how free from wrath he is towards *all* his creatures. God does good to all, but most abundantly to us who have fled for refuge to his compassions. God is the all-merciful and beneficent Father.[84]
>
> (Clement of Rome; 35-99 AD)

For as one who has been thought worthy of a divine and desirable name, in those bonds which I bear about, I commend the Churches, in which I pray for a union both of the flesh and spirit of Jesus Christ, who is the Saviour of *all* men, but specially of them that believe; by whose blood ye were redeemed; by whom ye have known God, or rather have been known by Him.[85]

(Ignatius of Antioch; Died 108 AD)

We can set no limits to the agency of the Redeemer to redeem, to rescue, to discipline in his work, and so will he continue to operate after this life.[86] ...*All* men are Christ's, some by knowing Him, the rest not yet. He is the Savior not of some and the rest not. For how is He Savior and Lord, if not the Savior and Lord of *all*?[87]

(Clement of Alexandria; 150-215 AD)

There is a resurrection of the dead, and there is **punishment, but not everlasting**. For when the body is punished the soul is gradually purified, and so is restored to its ancient rank. For all wicked men, and for demons, too, shall be restored to their former rank.... So then, when the end has been restored to the beginning, and the termination of things compared with their commencement, that condition of things will be re-established in which rational nature was placed, when it had no need to eat of the tree of the knowledge of good and evil; so that when all feeling of wickedness has been removed, and the individual has been purified and cleansed, He who alone is the one good God becomes to him 'all,' and that not in the case of a few individuals, or of a considerable number, but He Himself is "all in all." And when death shall no longer anywhere exist, nor the sting of death, nor any evil at all, then verily God will be "all in all." [88]

(Origen of Alexandria; 185-254 AD)

The Son "breaking in pieces" His enemies is for the sake of remolding them, as a potter his own work; as Jeremiah 18:6 says: i.e., to restore them once again to their former state.[89]

(Eusebius of Caesarea; 260-340 AD)

Christ has become the body of the whole of humanity, that, through the body that he was kind enough to assume, the whole of humanity might be hidden in him.[90]

(Hilary of Poitiers; 310–367 AD)

Flesh was taken up by the Logos to liberate *all* humans and resurrect *all* of them from the dead and ransom *all* of them from sin.[91]

(Athanasius of Alexandria; 296-373 AD)

The Word seems to me to lie down the doctrine of the perfect obliteration of wickedness, for if God shall be in all things that are, obviously wickedness shall no longer be in them. For it is necessary that at some time evil should be removed utterly and entirely from the realm of being. [92]

(St. Macrina the Younger; 327-379 AD)

For it is evident that God will in truth be "in all' when there shall be no evil in existence, when every created being is at harmony with itself, and every tongue shall confess that Jesus Christ is Lord; when every creature shall have been made one body. Now the body of Christ, as I have often said, is the whole of humanity. [93]

(Gregory of Nyssa; 335-395 AD)

Mankind, being reclaimed from their sins, are to be subjected to Christ in the fullness of the dispensation instituted for the salvation of *all*. [94]

(Didymus the Blind; 313-398 AD)

> While the devil imagined that he got a hold of Christ, he really lost *all* of those he was keeping.[95]
>
> (St. Chrysostom; 347-407 AD)

Clearly, some of the early Church Fathers had a far more Jewish view of Christ's atonement than most medieval Western theologians and Reformers.

Conclusion

If God is truly God, then love is not a gamble and mercy is not a risk. What He wills, He completes; what He begins, He brings home. The story does not end with loss, but with fullness—every shadow healed, every

fracture mended, every wandering heart found. In the end, God will be all in all, and *love* will have the final word.

Chapter 35

Every Knee, Every Tongue

In the grand narrative of Christian theology, Satan is portrayed as the principal adversary—the deceiver, the accuser, the one who works relentlessly to lead humanity away from God. From the start, knowing the limitations of human understanding, his greatest weapon has been persuasion. From the beginning, in the Garden of Eden, Satan's strategy was not brute force, but cunning—tricking Adam and Eve to believe that God's word could not be fully trusted. This ancient lie still echoes today. Yet if we truly accept that God's attributes—His wisdom, power, and goodness—surpass those of all, including Satan, then the devil's capacity

to deceive and corrupt is ultimately temporary, limited, and doomed to failure. His influence, however real and devastating for now, can never outlast God's power to save and restore His creation.

Let's revisit Paul's bold citation of the prophet Isaiah:

> *As surely as I live, says the Lord, every knee shall bow to me, and every tongue shall give praise to God.*
>
> (Romans 14:11)

Notice the force of that declaration. God anchors the promise to His own existence: *"As surely as I live."* To claim that anything could ultimately prevent this from happening is to suggest that some power exists capable of frustrating God's omnipotence—placing limits on the limitless, binding the infinite. It would mean that God's own life could somehow fail. And that is not theology; it is absurdity.

No lie of Satan, no confusion of humanity, no stubbornness of the heart will ultimately stand against the loving, redeeming will of God. Not because God will overrule our free will, but because we will finally know Him *face to face*. Satan's strategy has always been to obscure God's love, twisting it into something petty, fearful,

conditional, or transactional. In this way, he corrupts human hearts, not by forcing them into rebellion, but by feeding them a distorted image of the One who created them for love. Sadly, Satan often uses the Church to do exactly that. As one theologian admitted, *"Theologians have done more to hide the gospel of Christ than any of its adversaries."* [96]

The Battle Over Human Understanding

The deepest spiritual battle is fought over human understanding. If Satan's war is not over territory but over hearts, then the battlefield is the human mind—and his primary weapon is misrepresentation. The biblical vision of God is not that of a petty tyrant demanding obedience through fear, but of a Father whose love ultimately conquers every heart. His victory is not achieved through domination, but through transformation.

At this stage, God permits momentary bewilderment, *"until the time comes for God to restore everything, as he promised long ago through his holy prophets."* (Acts 3:21).

This is the bedrock of the prophetic vision—that every mind will eventually see clearly, and every heart will awaken to the truth of who God really is. This is not a naïve dream or wishful thinking but God's own promise:

> *Then I heard **every creature** in heaven and on earth and under the earth and in the sea and all that is in them, singing, "To the one seated on the throne and to the Lamb be blessing and honor and glory and might forever and ever!"*
>
> (Revelation 5:13)

Not some. Not most. But *every creature*—everywhere—will worship the Lamb.

Every Knee Will Bow

The phrase *"every knee will bow"* paints a vivid and powerful future scene, but it's often misunderstood. Some imagine it through the lens of fear—as if God will humiliate and forcibly crush people into submission, like a tyrannical medieval king demanding loyalty:

> Either by choice or by force, every knee will bow...Some by God's grace have been enabled to bow by choice and others will bow by force.[97]
>
> (John MacArthur)

John MacArthur's portrayal of God imagines a cosmic tyrant—more akin to Ali Khamenei or Kim Jong Un—who forces worship at sword point, brutally driving the majority of humanity into submission and compelling them to mouth praises they do not mean. It is a vision disturbingly closer to the dictatorships of North Korea or the Islamic Republic of Iran than to the Father revealed by Jesus. This is not the God who wins hearts through self-giving love, but a god who secures obedience through terror—an image utterly foreign to the gospel and unrecognizable in Christ.

But that's a misunderstanding of the world of the Bible.

In the ancient world, to bow the knee before someone was an act of profound respect and allegiance, a gesture reserved for a select few, like kings and deities. It signaled trust, honor, and devotion. We see it in the

story of Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego (Daniel 3), where refusing to bow to a false king was a declaration that only the true God deserves such homage.

The biblical picture is far more beautiful than that of MacArthur's: it's about a universal recognition of God's goodness, love, and rightful authority—not forced humiliation, but willing awe and joyful surrender. A bow not out of terror, but out of wonder and recognition.

Even those *"under the earth"*—meaning even the dead—will ultimately give honor to Jesus in the end.

Thus, when Scripture declares that every knee shall bow—including those of the dead—it is envisioning a universal moment of joyful surrender, not forced submission in God's dungeon. It pictures a day when all creation will, in awe and love, willingly kneel before the goodness, wisdom, and majesty of God, singing His praises.

Every Tongue Will Confess

Confession with the tongue carries a similar significance. In Hebrew, the word *"tishaba"* used in Isaiah 45:23 conveys the idea of taking an oath—publicly declaring allegiance. When a subject swore loyalty to a king, it

meant pledging heart, soul, and life to that sovereign. Thus, the confession described here is not the forced admission of a humiliated enemy, but the joyful declaration of one who has come to trust and love the true King.

Certain Islamic groups have been known to force captives onto their knees and into making ideological declarations to Islam and Allah before executing them.

But the Bible paints a completely different picture. Bowed knees and confessing tongues are not signs of cosmic terrorism, sadism, humiliation, domination and degradation. They are signs of cosmic healing. They represent humanity, finally and fully, falling in love with its Creator.

When every knee bows and every tongue confesses, it won't be because God has crushed their heads to the floor with His boot or forced them down in humiliation against their will. It will be because He has healed and purified them. It will be because their eyes have finally been opened to see what they could not see before—the unimaginable beauty, mercy, and overwhelming love of God. Their surrender will not be squeezed out by violence, but drawn out by awe.

So we are left with only two possible conclusions. Everyone—living and dead—will ultimately recognize Jesus as the Messiah and confess Him as such. From there, the paths diverge sharply. Either that universal confession leads to universal restoration, or God proceeds to endlessly torment the vast majority—pouring out

unceasing lava, never permitting release from a cosmic torture chamber, while looking on with sadistic, grim satisfaction.

If that sounds extreme, understand this: it is not a caricature. It is the logical outcome of how fundamentalists explicitly frame the doctrine. In that vision, God's final victory is not the healing of creation, but the eternal preservation of suffering as a monument to His power.

That god may inspire fear. He may command silence. But he bears no resemblance to the Father revealed by Jesus Christ.

A chilling—and tragically revealing—expression of this theology comes from one of Calvinism's most prominent voices, Paul Washer, who declares:

> The moment when you take your first step through the gates of hell, the only thing you will hear is all of creation standing to its feet and applauding and praising God because God has rid the earth of you. [98]
>
> (Paul Washer)

The god of Calvinism couldn't possibly be the same as the God of Israel and Jesus Christ.

If Any Are Lost Forever, God's Attributes Are in Question

The logic becomes unavoidable:

If even one soul were to remain in permanent rebellion forever, if even one heart could persistently resist the love and wisdom of God, it would mean that God's will had been thwarted, His wisdom bested, His love overcome. It would imply that Satan had scored a permanent, even if small, victory. It would place a limit where Scripture places none.

Again, I can imagine a rare exception in which someone so persistently and permanently refuses repentance—even in the age to come—that God may ultimately harden their hearts (Exodus 7:3-4) and remove them from existence rather than restore them. In such a case, annihilation would serve as a final judgment rather than endless torment.

But as a general rule, I believe the trajectory of Scripture points toward cosmic restoration. God's mercy is expansive, persistent, and restorative. The biblical story repeatedly portrays Him as a pursuing lover, a

correcting father, and a mighty redeemer, seeking to bring all back into fellowship rather than abandoning them to destruction.

For how could the love of the God who declared that *"love never fails"* (1 Corinthians 13:8) ever fail to accomplish what it truly desires?

It is not sentimentalism to believe in the universal restoration of all things—it is fidelity to the character of God. If we take seriously the biblical declarations about God's nature—His omnipotence, omniscience, and omni-benevolence—then we must also take seriously the logical conclusion of the inevitable and complete triumph of His redemptive love.

Restoration Is Not Wishful Thinking—It's Divine Necessity

The restoration of all things is not only a comforting idea; it is a theological necessity. It is the logical and inevitable conclusion of God's nature as revealed in Scripture.

If God's power is truly perfect, no creature can forever resist Him.

If God's wisdom is truly perfect, no deception can forever blind.

If God's love truly never fails, no heart can remain forever closed.

Thus, the universal restoration of the world—*"Tikkun Olam"*—is not simply one interpretive option among many. It is the only outcome consistent with the fullness of who God is.

Anything less would mean that sin, Satan, or human stubbornness could ultimately place a limit on the will of God. It would mean that rebellion could outlast redemption, that death could outshine life, that hatred could defeat love.

But Scripture, thank God, says otherwise:

> *Then comes the end, when he delivers the kingdom to God the Father after destroying every rule and every authority and power. For he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. The last enemy to be destroyed is death.*
>
> (1 Corinthians 15:24-26)

The final enemy is death itself, not people. Ending death is like eradicating a disease—through curing and healing. Overcoming death is about restoring everything to its intended wholeness.

Christ reigns, not until He has crushed and humiliated all people, but until He has crushed all forces that destroy people.

In the end, when time gives way to infinity, the name of Jesus will be spoken by every tongue not by force nor out of terror, but out of wonder. Every knee will bend, not under compulsion, but in awe. Every heart will be drawn not by threat, but by the unstoppable, undeniable magnetism of divine love.

Because, when the Truth is fully revealed, and the scales fall from every eye, there is only one possible response: worship freely given.

This is the true final victory of Christ—not partial, not hesitant, but full, complete, radiant, and everlasting.

This is the God of the Gospel. This is the Gospel of Life. And in this Gospel, death, sin, and darkness have no final word. Love does.

All Means All

Some will insist, "But God gave us free will—and He won't override it!"

That's true. He doesn't override it—He *transforms* it. He knows every heart, every wound, every lie we've believed, every trauma that keeps us from trusting Him. He doesn't control us; He convinces us, persuades us, pursues us, softens us. He leads us to repentance with kindness upon kindness, mercy upon mercy, until even the hardest heart melts—even if that melting comes only after experiencing the "fires" of His love in the afterlife.

Everyone means *everyone*. All means *all*.

This is not coercion. It is not submission through fear. It is the outcome of divine goodness and irresistible grace.

The Logic of Victory

Let's be honest. If God ends up saving only a few, then the enemy wins. If Christ's blood is shed for all but effectively atones only for some, then we are left with a gospel of failure. A gospel where the powers of evil and human stubbornness outsmart divine grace. A gospel where sin, death, and hell get the last word.

But that's not what the Jewish authors of the New Testament taught.

The early Christians understood Jesus' death and resurrection not as a partial fix, but as a cosmic breakthrough. They didn't go around asking people, "Are you saved?"—they went around proclaiming, "God has acted! The world has changed. A new creation has begun. Death has been defeated. Love has conquered."

This is the core logic of the Gospel:

Premise 1: God is *"the mighty one who saves"* (Zephaniah 3:17).

Premise 2: *"God loves the world"* (John 3:16).

Premise 3: His love means He *"wants to save all"* (1 Timothy 2:3–4).

Premise 4: *"Love never fails"* (1 Corinthians 13:8).

Premise 5: God's purposes cannot be thwarted (Job 42:2; Ephesians 1:11).

Conclusion: If God loves all, wills to save all, and His love and purposes cannot fail, then God will ultimately save all. Guaranteed.

This is pure logic rooted in Scripture, God's character, and covenant. To say otherwise is to imply that God's plan was fragile from the start. That His love was not persuasive enough. That Christ's sacrifice was not sufficient enough. That death and sin and rebellion will still claim their victory at the end of time.

But if God truly is who He claims to be—the wisest, the strongest, and the most loving—then the salvation and restoration of all things isn't merely possible; it's the natural result, both from a biblical and logical standpoint.

Conclusion

God's will cannot be thwarted. His love cannot fail. And His salvation cannot be partial or unfinished. God does not lose. He is not engaged in a cosmic tug-of-war in which Satan walks away with ninety-three percent of humanity while God settles for a small remnant of survivors. That vision is not victory—it is defeat dressed up as sovereignty.

No—God is *Mighty to Save*. And in the end, He will do precisely what He set out to do: save all.

This is not merely the internal logic of my theology. It is the logic of God's own love. And love—Scripture insists—*never fails*.

Chapter 36

How Will the Story End?

Conclusion

Christians have told the story of how everything ends in two main—and profoundly different—ways. The first is a Westernized version that dominates much of modern Christian thought. The second, rooted in the biblical Jewish worldview, was embraced by many of the earliest Church Fathers.

Version One: The Western Ending

In the first telling, the story of the end begins with Jesus returning in glory. At last, everyone sees the truth and acknowledges Him as Lord. The moment is radiant: rebellion is purged, every lie exposed, sin no longer holds sway. It feels like the perfect, long-awaited resolution.

But then the story takes a dark, jarring, brutal turn.

In this version, Jesus suddenly casts most of humanity into a fiery pit where they will suffer endless torment—because they believed the wrong thing, belonged to the wrong denomination, or failed to live up to a moral standard during their few fleeting decades on earth. Here, divine love reveals itself as limited and conditional. Victory is only minimal. Salvation feels like a bait-and-switch, something most people never truly had a fair shot at receiving.

Version Two: The Ancient and Biblical Ending

The second version tells an entirely different story.

Here too, Jesus returns in glory, and every eye recognizes Him. But now the ending is not a reversal—it is the fulfillment of everything the Scriptures have been pointing toward.

Sin—not sinners—is purged (Hebrews 9:26).

Every tear is wiped away (Revelation 21:4).

Death itself is destroyed (1 Corinthians 15:26).

Creation is liberated and restored (Romans 8:21).

God becomes *"all in all"* (1 Corinthians 15:28).

In this vision, love does not fail. Victory is not partial—it is complete. Salvation is not a prize for a small remnant but the healing of the whole world. Heaven is not imagined as a VIP club or a gated community for the spiritually elite but as a great family table where no chair is left empty.

Two Sources, Two Visions

These distinct endings emerge from two very different sources.

The vision of universal restoration flows from the ancient prophetic worldview and the biblical Jewish theology of *Tikkun Olam*—of a God who searches until every lost sheep is found, who refuses to abandon even the most wounded soul, who lovingly restores the broken world through justice, mercy, and truth.

The harsher ending is shaped largely by Greek philosophical categories, ruthless Roman law, and imperial domination—Western ideas more concerned with punishment, hierarchy, and exclusion than with healing and community.

The Character of God Determines the True Ending

Scripture tells us plainly:

"If your enemy is hungry, feed him; if he is thirsty, give him something to drink" (Romans 12:20).

And: *"Love your enemies"* (Matthew 5:44).

And: *"For the Lord will not reject forever"* (Lamentations 3:31).

God does not command us to show mercy while He will show none. He doesn't tell us to love and forgive our enemies while planning forever to abuse and torment His own.

In the end, the story closes in a way that reflects the heart of its Author. The God revealed in Jesus is not defeated by human failure, nor satisfied with partial victory, but faithful to the end—until love has done all it came to do. The final word is not exclusion but restoration, not endless torment but healing, not a world divided forever but one made whole. This is the hope the Scriptures dare us to imagine and trust: that mercy outlasts judgment, that love *never* gives up, and that when God is finally "all in all," nothing He has made will be missing from the joy of His renewed creation.

Conclusion

Later Western thinkers such as Augustine of Hippo, Thomas Aquinas, and John Calvin produced impressive and sometimes brilliant theological constructions. Engaging with their ideas can be stimulating and even beneficial. But we must be clear about what they were and what they were not. They were regular human beings attempting to reason about God from within severe limitations. None were native speakers of Hebrew or Greek. None were Jews. None lived inside the biblical world they were interpreting. Their linguistic access was partial, their cultural distance enormous, and their philosophical categories often foreign to Scripture itself. Not to mention their ignorance of native idioms (e.g., "Lake of Fire," "Book of Life," "Gnashing of Teeth," and more) that even professional translators often misinterpret.

We should therefore expect them to be wrong about many things. Their writings may be insightful, but they carry no intrinsic authority. Respect for their intellect must never harden into submission to their conclusions. Theology belongs to Scripture, not to later interpreters, no matter how influential or revered.

Even those whom I would consider heretical still have something to teach us. We can learn from their theological errors. Engaging critically with their writings can sharpen our thinking, expose our blind spots, and compel us to clarify what we truly believe. Sometimes we grow not only through agreement, but through serious disagreement.

Part V: Rethinking Hell

Introduction: Let's Talk About Hell

There is far more to say about hell than can responsibly fit into a few chapters. That is precisely why I devoted an entire separate volume to the subject— ***Hell: A Jewish Perspective on a Christian Doctrine.*** In that book, I engage in a thorough, text-by-text examination of every major passage typically cited in discussions of hell: "unquenchable fire" (Matthew 3:12), "weeping and gnashing of teeth" (Matthew 8:12), "the worm that never dies" (Mark 9:48), the parable of Lazarus and the rich man (Luke 16), "the furnace of fire" (Matthew 13:42),

"outer darkness" (Matthew 22:13), "the lake of fire" (Revelation 20:14–15), "fire and brimstone" (Revelation 21:8), and many others.

Rather than skimming these texts or relying on inherited assumptions, the book traces their Jewish background, literary genre, historical context, and theological intent—unpacking what they meant then, before importing later doctrines into them. I highly recommend checking out that volume for a thorough and thoughtful look at the doctrine of hell and its foundations, explored with depth, clarity, and faithfulness to Scripture.

In this book, however, we'll limit ourselves to a focused overview of the most essential aspects of hell.

Chapter 37

The Biblical Meaning of the Word "Hell"

Language is never static; it evolves, and meanings shift over time. Words often drift far from their original sense. For example, *awful* once meant "full of awe" or "worthy of reverence," whereas today it means "very bad." The word *gay* once meant joyful or lighthearted; now it primarily refers to sexual orientation.

The same goes for words like "eternal" and "hell" that we come across in English translations of the Bible. Historically, *hell* referred to the realm of the dead—the grave, the underworld—not a place of everlasting torture. This view is also widely acknowledged and accepted in both Christian and secular

academia.[99][100][101][102][103] It was only later, through cultural, philosophical, and theological developments, that *hell* came to be viewed as an afterlife of either temporary punishment, as in Judaism, the early church fathers, and several Eastern Christian denominations, or Eternal Conscious Torment, as in Islam and in traditions shaped by Augustine of Hippo, like Protestantism and Catholicism. Understanding this linguistic shift is crucial, because reading modern meanings back into ancient texts and translations inevitably distorts what the biblical authors were actually saying.

Where the English "Hell" Came From

The English word "hell" originates from the Old English "Hel" or "Helle," which was derived from the Proto-Germanic term "haljō."[104] This term generally referred to the underworld (the graveyard), or a mystical hidden place. "Haljō" is also related to the Old Norse word "Hel," which referred both to the underworld—a realm of the dead—and the goddess who ruled over it in Norse mythology. In Norse belief, this underworld was where souls who did not die in battle would go.

As Christianity spread through Europe, hell was adopted and adapted within Christian theology to describe a place of punishment for the wicked, further shifting its meaning from a concept of cosmic graveyard to the more specific notion of hell as a place of punishment.

The evolution of the word *hell*:

- **Proto-Germanic:** "haljō" first referred to a concealed or hidden place and was used to describe the underworld—realm of the dead.
- - **Old Norse:** "Hel" was both the name of the underworld and the deity presiding over it.
- - - **Old English:** "hel" or "helle" referred to an afterlife place of punishment.
- - - - **Modern English:** "hell" refers to a place of punishment after death, sometimes excruciating and perpetual.

Four Words Translated "Hell"

English translations frequently employ the term "hell" as a replacement for four distinct Hebrew/Greek words: "Géenna," "Sheol," "Tartarus," and "Hades." However, these words are not exactly interchangeable synonyms,

and each carries its unique connotations and meanings. Let's see some examples.

Sheol:

> For thou wilt not leave my soul in ***hell*** *[sheol]*; neither wilt thou suffer thine Holy One to see corruption.
>
> (Psalm 16:10, KJV)

Hades:

> And death and ***hell*** *[hades]* were cast into the lake of fire. This is the second death.
>
> (Revelation 20:14, KJV)

Géenna:

> And if thy right eye offend thee, pluck it out, and cast it from thee: for it is profitable for thee that one of thy members should perish, and not that thy whole body should be cast into ***hell*** *[Géenna]*.
>
> (Matthew 5:29, KJV)

Tartarus:

> For if God spared not the angels that sinned, but cast them down to ***hell*** *[tartarus]*, and delivered them into chains of darkness, to be reserved unto judgment.
>
> (2 Peter 2:4, KJV)

Clearly, translating these four distinct biblical concepts with the single English word "hell" collapses their meanings and badly distorts the text. The problem is not the Hebrew Bible or the New Testament, but the word

itself. Historically, hell referred to death or the grave. Over time, it absorbed later afterlife imagery that the biblical authors did not share.

None of these four original terms describes a realm of eternal fiery torture. That idea is imported, not derived. By retrofitting later meanings onto ancient words, translators and theologians have replaced careful exegesis with theological anachronism, turning texts about death, judgment, and restoration into something they were never meant to say.

Sheol, Hades, Géenna, Tartarus

Sheol is a Hebrew word used in the Old Testament to describe the realm of the dead (e.g., Genesis 37:35, Job 14:13, Psalm 16:10, Ecclesiastes 9:10), often translated as "the grave" or "the pit." It is portrayed as a shadowy place where the dead are asleep, regardless of their beliefs or moral choices during life. Sheol is not associated with punishment or reward but is simply the state of being dead and hidden from the living.[105]
In English translations of the Bible, the term is frequently rendered as "hell."

Hades is the Greek word equivalent of *Sheol*,[106] representing the underworld or the realm of the dead. In Greek mythology, Hades is both the name of the god ruling this domain and the place itself. In the New Testament, Hades similarly stands for the unseen place where souls metaphorically go after death, awaiting resurrection. Like *Sheol* (Hebrew), *Hades* (Greek) is not inherently a place of torment or bliss but a temporary holding place for the dead.[107]

In English translations of the Bible, the term is frequently rendered as "hell."

***Géenna* (or *Gehenna*)** originates from the Hebrew word "*Gehinnom*," meaning the *Valley of Hinnom*, which is located in Jerusalem, running along the southern and western edges of the Old City. Historically, it was associated with much death, from the worship of Moloch and the burning sacrifice of children to the city's garbage dump, where trash was constantly burned and bodies were discarded. In Second Temple Judaism, the *Valley of Hinnom* became associated with *shameful* death and disgrace.[108] It could represent the ostracization or death of an individual, or the downfall and destruction of a city or nation.

In the New Testament, Jesus refers to Gehenna as a symbol of dishonorable death. In some Rabbinic literature, "*Gehinnom*" became associated with an afterlife disciplinary process, a destination for the wicked where they get to atone for their sins.[109]

In English translations of the Bible, the term is frequently rendered as "hell."

Tartarus, in Greek mythology, is a deep abyss used to imprison the Titans far beneath Hades. It signifies the lowest part of the underworld, a jail-like place. In the New Testament, particularly in 2 Peter 2:4, Tartarus is used metaphorically to describe the gloomy, dark place where rebellious angels are held, awaiting judgment. Tartarus appears in the Septuagint translation of Job (40:20 and 41:24) and in Hellenistic Jewish literature, such as the Greek text of the ancient Book of Enoch. In Enoch, God places the archangel Uriel "*in charge of the world and of Tartarus*" (20:2), understood as the prison for 200 fallen Watchers (angels). [110]
In English translations of the Bible, the term is frequently rendered as "Hell."

Clearly, none of these terms suggest a place of Eternal Conscious Torment ("Hellfire"), so translating them all as "hell" should be reconsidered in future English Bible versions. For now, the term "hell" will likely keep causing confusion for readers of translations that apply it to some or all of the Hebrew and Greek concepts mentioned.

In the Concordant Expositions, [111] Bible scholar James Coram explains:

> The Old English "hell," denoted that which is covered (hidden or unseen). Consequently, it once served as a suitable translation of the Greek *hades*, which means "imperceptible" or "unseen." In modern English, however, due to the corrupting influence of human

tradition, "hell" has come to mean "the abode of the dead; the place of punishment after death [in which the dead are alive]." Consequently, since in modern English the notion represented by the term "hell" constitutes, to say the least, interpretation, not translation, it is unconscionable for modern translators to render either the Hebrew *sheol* or the Greek *hades* by this expression.

Yet it is worse still, whether in old English or modern English, to render the Greek *tartarosas* and especially the Greek *geenna*, also as "hell." Such "translations" are not translations at all; they are but the product of circular reasoning and hoary tradition. Whatever one's understanding may be concerning the matters to which these words make reference, as a translation of the Original, the rendering "hell," in all cases, is wholly unjustifiable. Yet it is this very rendering, the single term, "hell," for all these distinct words in the Original, which has spawned all the familiar talk concerning "hell" which prevails among "Bible-believing Christians" today.

(James Coram)

Jesus Never Spoke of Hell—He Spoke of Gehenna

Now, let's poke a stick at one of fundamentalism's most untouchable sacred cows…

> Jesus spoke more about hell than anybody else in the Bible. In fact, He spoke more about hell than everybody else in the Bible combined.[112]
>
> (John MacArthur)

John MacArthur is completely wrong. Jesus never spoke of the Augustinian–Calvinist vision of hell as Eternal Conscious Torment, so common in Western theology. He spoke of *Gehenna*—a term no first-century Jew would have understood in that way.

Gehenna (short for *Gey Ben Hinnom*—the Valley of Hinnom) was a real, physical place just outside Jerusalem. It appears repeatedly in the Hebrew Scriptures as a site associated with death, great shame, judgment, and destruction (e.g., Jeremiah 7:31–33; 19:2–7; 2 Kings 23:10). In ancient Israel, the valley served as the city's dump—a spot where trash was constantly burned, where dead animals and the bodies of the disgraced were tossed, giving worms a steady supply of food that never ends. It was also where the poorest and most marginalized scavenged the refuse for scraps to survive.

Jesus described *Gehenna* as the place *"where the worms that eat them do not die, and the fire is not quenched"* (Mark 9:47-48) since the worms always had food to consume and the flames constantly burned the trash.

Thus, in the Jewish vocabulary, *Gehenna* symbolized a shameful or deadly outcome, not an afterlife incinerator. It represented death, loss, exclusion, destruction, and the collapse of a meaningful life. A fate worse than honorable death—either living as an outcast (socially dead), or dead entirely.

When Jesus spoke about Gehenna (e.g., Matthew 5:22, 29–30; 10:28; Mark 9:43–48), He was drawing on a familiar Jewish image to convey real historical judgment, social breakdown, disgrace, and devastating consequences—not otherworldly unending torment after death.

We must remember, Yeshua wasn't a 21st-century Bible Belt preacher in a suit and tie, but a first-century Prophet of Israel and Jewish rabbi living and teaching in Jewish Israel, ministering among His own people. His

words were directed first and foremost at His Jewish audience in their specific context, while also prophetically calling the entire nation of Israel to repentance, justice, mercy, and faithfulness to the covenant.

Tragically, as a nation, Israel rejected that call. And within a generation, the warning became reality. In 70 AD, Jerusalem was destroyed by Rome, the Temple was burned, and according to ancient sources, over a million Jews were killed.[113] This was *eternal judgment* in the most biblical sense—not endless, but total, decisive, and irreversible for that generation and system. It's likely that many of these bodies ended up being thrown into the Valley of Hinnom.

In short, Jesus' use of Gehenna was a prophetic warning about the consequences of injustice, violence, moral decay and covenant rebellion—not a blueprint for an afterlife furnace.

Case Study: To Be Thrown Into Gehenna (Matthew 5:27-29)

Let's examine Matthew 5:27-29 as a case study:

> *You have heard that it was said, "You shall not commit adultery." But I tell you that anyone who looks at a woman lustfully has already committed adultery with her in his heart. If your right eye causes you to stumble, gouge it out and throw it away. It is better for you to lose one part of your body than for your whole body to be thrown into Gehenna.*
>
> (Matthew 5:27-29)

No, Jesus was not advocating self-mutilation. It strains all credibility to imagine that the same Jesus who had just said, *"Do not think that I have come to abolish the Law or the Prophets"* (Matthew 5:17), would immediately contradict both Moses and Himself by implying everlasting fiery torment for inward desire alone—a concept entirely absent from the Hebrew Scriptures and foreign to Israel's Law.

I also find it deeply ironic that many who insist on taking the threat of being *"thrown into hell [Gehenna]"* with wooden literalism suddenly abandon that approach when Jesus says, *"gouge it out and throw it away."* If they were consistent, we would be surrounded by fundamentalists missing an eye—or two. Yet, curiously, the violent threat is treated as literal while the self-mutilation command is quietly spiritualized. One half of the

metaphor is pressed to its harshest extreme, while the other is safely neutralized. That inconsistency reveals not faithfulness to Scripture, but selective literalism driven by theology rather than context.

In any case, if Jesus were speaking literally about tearing out eyes to avoid hellfire, the logic collapses on its own terms. He would have known perfectly well that sight is not required for imagination or desire; even the blind can still experience lust and inner fantasy. Losing an eye doesn't change what's in your heart or on your mind.

His words are not anatomical instructions pulled from a modern medical textbook. They are prophetic hyperbole—an established rabbinic teaching device—intentionally shocking, intentionally exaggerated, meant to awaken moral seriousness. Jesus is exposing the gravity of sin, not prescribing salvation by self-mutilation, and certainly not introducing a new doctrine of never-ending afterlife torture.

So what was the point Jesus was trying to make?

Understanding that lust is a natural part of human nature, His point was that it's the gateway to adultery—before someone commits the act, they first imagine it. In 1st-century Jewish society, getting caught in adultery could mean becoming an outcast scavenging in Gehenna, or worse, being stoned to death (Leviticus 20:10) and tossed there.

Jesus simply taught that every action begins in the heart—you don't commit murder unless hatred has taken root there first. You don't steal unless you've first coveted something that isn't yours. This was His point and warning to His young disciples, and to us as well.

Sadly, when Western theology turned antisemitic, it severed itself from its Jewish roots. And when context is stripped away, misunderstanding is inevitable. Detached from the Jewish world in which Jesus lived and taught, His words are easily distorted—and the result is tragic: the God of Scripture is reimagined as a cruel, sadistic, volatile tyrant rather than the faithful, compassionate, loving Father revealed in Christ.

Conclusion

Few topics make Christians shift uncomfortably in their seats like hell. Yet it remains one of the most influential—and most misunderstood—teachings in Christian theology. Much of the confusion persists because the passages associated with hell are rarely studied in their original context, their metaphors are flattened into literal threats, Hebrew and Greek terms are mistranslated or oversimplified, and alternative readings are dismissed before they are even considered.

Because this doctrine profoundly shapes how we view God, humanity, justice, and salvation itself, it cannot be treated casually or inherited uncritically. For that reason, I strongly encourage you to read my book ***Hell: A Jewish Perspective on a Christian Doctrine***, where these texts are examined carefully, historically, and faithfully—allowing Scripture to speak on its own terms rather than through the fears and assumptions we have been taught to project onto it.

Chapter 38

Hell—A Short Historical Overview

Before we can meaningfully discuss hell, we must first clear away centuries of inherited assumptions and return to the world in which Jesus actually lived and taught. Hell, as imagined by many modern Christians —a place of endless conscious torture—did not drop fully formed from the pages of Scripture. It emerged gradually, shaped by cultural, philosophical, and theological developments far removed from first-century Judaism. To read Jesus rightly, we must step back into His Jewish context, where images of fire, judgment, and Gehenna were not weapons of terror but familiar metaphors for purification, correction, and restoration. This

chapter traces that original landscape—Jewish, biblical, and early Christian—to show how the language of hell was first understood, how it later shifted, and why recovering its original meaning radically transforms our understanding of God, judgment, and salvation.

Hell in First Century Judaism

Ideas of the afterlife—whether imagined as a shadowy underworld or as a purifying fire—existed in many ancient cultures long before Christianity. These early notions were largely symbolic, primitive, and undeveloped. Even within ancient Israel, *Gehinnom* was not originally the fully formed "hell" of later Jewish theology. It developed over time, often understood as a temporary place where wrongdoing is confronted and dealt with—not as an Eternal Conscious Torment.

Origen (185-253 AD) was an early Christian scholar, ascetic, theologian, and a prolific writer who wrote roughly 2,000 treatises. He has been described as *"the greatest genius the early church ever produced."*[114]

Origen wrote extensively about the Jewish context of the gospels and concluded:

> Now as we found that Gehenna was mentioned in the Gospel as a place of punishment, we searched to see whether it is mentioned anywhere in the ancient Scriptures, and especially because the Jews too use the word… We find a certain confirmation of what is said regarding the place of punishment, intended for the purification of such souls as are to be purified by torments, agreeably to the saying: *"The Lord comes like a refiner's fire, and like fullers' soap: and He shall sit as a refiner and purifier of silver and of gold."*
>
> Origen, Against Celsus, VI, 25.

In other words, even Jews who associated Gehenna or hell with afterlife punishment saw it as *temporary* rather than everlasting. Refining and purifying, rather than tormenting or destroying.

At its core, the imagery Jesus employed was concrete, familiar, and unmistakably Jewish: the refining of precious metals by fire. Scripture returns to this metaphor again and again. The Hebrew Bible speaks of God refining His people like silver and testing—even *"tormenting"*—them like gold in a furnace (Malachi 3:2–3; Zechariah 13:9; Psalm 66:10). Fire is not the enemy of the metal; it is the means by which the metal is purified.

The New Testament carries this same imagery forward without interruption. Human works are examined and tested *"as through fire"* (1 Corinthians 3:13–15), and trials are said to refine faith the way fire refines gold (1 Peter 1:7). The metaphor never changes. Fire does not exist to destroy what is precious, but to burn away what is false—until what remains is genuine, resilient, and fit for glory.

Thus, in 1st-century Judaism, the metaphor of fire was associated not with Eternal Conscious Torment, but with testing, cleansing, and purification.

According to HELPS Word-studies, the Greek word *basanizó*, often translated as "torment," can also mean "to test" or "to examine." Therefore, "tormented in fire" can be understood as "tested or refined in fire."

Jesus drew from this same vocabulary. To His original Jewish audience, fire symbolized a painful yet purposeful process—refining, reshaping, and restoring. Fire burns away dross so that what remains is clean, perfected, refined, and truly valuable. This is likely how His disciples understood it: not as never-ending sadism, but as a refining fire that ultimately serves a redemptive purpose.

Of course, some people accumulate far more "impurity" over a lifetime—hatred, cruelty, selfishness, violence. For them, the refining process may indeed be long and painful. But prolonged purification is not the same as everlasting despair. Fire was never meant to destroy the gold, only the dross—until what God always intended finally emerges in clarity and beauty.

Since God hates sin, not the sinner, He will destroy the sin, not the person. This was—and still largely remains—the Jewish understanding of hell.

Hell in Early Christian Schools

In the first centuries of the Church, theology was taught primarily through six major catechetical schools, and their views on hell varied. These schools—much like modern seminaries—were the intellectual and spiritual centers of Christian formation in their day, each representing a distinct theological tradition rather than a single, uniform doctrine. Let's take a quick look at these ancient schools and what they taught about hell.

Alexandria: The Catechetical School of Alexandria (2nd century) was one of the most influential theological centers in early Christianity. It gained fame for its allegorical reading of Scripture and distinctive approach to theology. Alexandria's teachings, known as *"apokatastasis"* (the ultimate restoration of all things) proposed that hell served as a corrective and purifying phase, ultimately leading all souls to salvation through God's love and mercy.[115]

Antioch: The School of Antioch (3rd century) was known for its emphasis on the literal and historical interpretation of Scripture. This school also taught that hell was a temporary state designed to purify and ultimately restore all souls to God. This approach emphasized God's ultimate plan for the reconciliation and salvation of all creation.[116]

Cesarea: The theological school in Caesarea (3rd century), influenced by Origen (who first studied under Clement in Alexandria) and other prominent theologians, also believed and taught that God's judgment was not endless but rather a process through which souls would be purified and eventually restored to their original, sinless state.[117]

Eastern Syria: The Eastern Syrian school (4th century), part of the broader Syriac Christian tradition, taught that divine punishment was temporary and aimed at bringing about repentance and healing, emphasizing the compassionate nature of God.[118]

Asia Minor (Turkey): The theological school in Asia Minor (3rd century) took a different approach, teaching annihilationism. This view held that the wicked would ultimately be eliminated—cease to exist—rather than being restored or subjected to unending torment.[119]

Hippo: The school in Hippo (late 4th–early 5th century), named after Augustine of Hippo, was located in northwestern Africa and was the only one that taught Eternal Conscious Torment. This school viewed afterlife punishment as "hellfire"—a place of never-ending torturous punishment and suffering for the unbeliever. It

emphasized the severity of sin over grace and what was believed to be the absolute and punitive nature of divine wrath and judgment.[120]

Ironically, what was once seen as a rare and minority belief about hell in the early centuries has now become the dominant view in the West, largely due to the adaptation of Augustinian theology by both Catholicism and Protestantism.

The Three Main Views of Hell Today

After studying the doctrine of hell for several years, I've come to see that Christian (and broader religious) beliefs about final judgment generally fall into three major categories:

1. Eternal Conscious Torment (ECT / Hellfire)

Today, the Augustinian view is the prevailing perspective among fundamentalist Protestant and Catholic

groups, and it's also the view of hell held in Islam. It sees hell as everlasting, unending torture—a punishment that serves no purpose beyond retribution. There is no healing, no restoration, no transformation—just an infinite continuation of pain and suffering.

To me, this portrays God as sadistic, cruel, merciless, vengeful, and unrelentingly punitive—a picture I find to be completely at odds with the God of Yeshua revealed in Scripture.

2. Annihilationism (Conditional Immortality)

This view—held by several Christian traditions—teaches that certain people are ultimately destroyed rather than tormented forever. Depending on the specific version, those who face this fate may be described as the *wicked*, the *unbelieving*, or those who persistently *reject* God even in the afterlife. After the final judgment, their existence simply comes to an end. Morally, this position is far less severe than Eternal Conscious Torment. Yet depending on how it is framed, it can still leave most of humanity facing ultimate extinction rather than restoration.

Though I believe a case can be made for some form of annihilationism, it still introduces a serious logical problem. Scripture repeatedly affirms the resurrection of all the dead (John 5:28–29; Acts 24:15; Revelation 20:12–13). If that is the case, if God were to marvelously bring unbelievers back from the dead only to wipe them out again moments later, resurrection would seem like nothing more than a fleeting moment of life granted just to stage another death—something that feels unnecessary, cruel, morally dubious, and theologically confusing. In this scenario, the resurrection feels like a brief, meaningless interruption that downplays the significance of Christ's triumph over death.

This then raises an unavoidable question: what is the purpose of resurrection if it simply returns most people to the same state as before—nonexistence? Would God truly summon the dead back to life only to extinguish them again, as though resurrection was a cruel formality rather than a redemptive act? Such a notion sits uneasily with Scripture's own testimony, where God declares,

> *I take no pleasure in the death of the wicked, but rather that they turn from their ways and live.*
>
> (Ezekiel 33:11)

3. Restorative Judgment (Universalism / *Apokatastasis*)

This view, embraced by many early Church Fathers and deeply influenced by Jewish thought, is still most clearly upheld in Oriental and Eastern Orthodox traditions and by few Catholic thinkers. It sees judgment not as retributive punishment but as a disciplinary process. Fire isn't meant only to condemn but to refine—purifying, healing, and restoring. In this understanding, hell exists, but it's not the ultimate end.

A common misconception—and frequent criticism—of Christian Universalism is the claim that it teaches "all roads lead to God" and that actions carry no consequences. This is a strawman that misrepresents the position entirely. Universalism holds that salvation is found in Christ alone, but that His atonement covers *all* humanity, and that *eventually* everyone will come to understand and believe.

In this view, God's justice—even in the afterlife—aims at setting things right, not inflicting unending suffering for its own sadistic sake. If God is truly omnipresent, present everywhere without exception, then He must also be present in hell, whether understood as the grave or as punishment. As Psalm 139:8 unequivocally proclaims:

*If I ascend up into heaven, thou art there: if I make my bed in **hell**, behold, thou art there.*

(Psalm 139:8)

There is no realm where God simply is not. That means hell cannot be the absence of God (as some Christians claim), but the presence of God experienced differently.

In that light, hell is not God withdrawing in hatred, but God remaining in faithfulness. It is His holy, purifying love encountered by those not yet healed by it. The same fire that warms and gives life also burns away what is false. What changes is not God, but the condition of the one who encounters Him.

There are various versions of universalism, annihilationism, and ECT, with some positions even blending elements of more than one view. For example, certain universalists argue that annihilation may apply to a small number of individuals who became so radically evil that they effectively lost the image of God.

I am not here to tell you what you must believe. And while I generally try to avoid theological labels, I personally find that some form of universalism best aligns with the biblical vision of God: a God who judges not in order to destroy, but in order to save, a God who is *"reconciling all things to Himself"* (Colossians 1:20),

and whose mercy ultimately triumphs over mere retribution. I believe Jesus came to save the *world*, and Christ's atonement truly affects *all*, with the goal of universal restoration of creation.

Conclusion

In the end, the fire does not exist to annihilate hope, but to rescue it. What God judges, He judges in order to heal; what He exposes, He exposes in order to restore. The last word is not torment, but transformation—not exile, but homecoming. The God revealed in Scripture is not a destroyer of souls, but a refiner of hearts; not a tyrant who delights in suffering, but a Father who refuses to abandon His children to their brokenness. This vision does not weaken justice—it fulfills it. It does not cheapen grace—it magnifies it. And it does not diminish God's holiness—it reveals it as love, blazing and unstoppable. So take courage. Whatever darkness remains is not final. Whatever fire awaits is not purposeless. The story is still moving toward life, and God will finish what He began—until all that was lost is found, all that was broken is healed, and all creation finally rests in the wholeness it was always meant to know.

Chapter 39

The Augustinian Fallacy

Much of the confusion surrounding the mistranslation and misunderstanding of *olam* and *aiōn* as "endless" or "everlasting" time can be traced directly to the influence of Augustine of Hippo (354–430 A.D.). Deeply shaped by Neoplatonic philosophy,[121] Augustine reasoned that because God is infinite and timeless, all divine actions —including judgment and punishment—must also be infinite, timeless, and without end. This reasoning is most evident in The City of God, Book XXI, where he argues for the idea of Eternal Conscious Torment.

But his conclusion did not emerge from the Hebrew Scriptures, nor from the Jewish worldview of Jesus and the apostles. It was a philosophical assumption imposed upon the text. In one decisive move, the biblical notion of age—purposeful, qualitative, and God-directed—was collapsed into the Greek abstraction of timeless eternity. The result was a radical reinterpretation of judgment, one that permanently reshaped Western theology and transformed corrective, age-bound judgment into endless metaphysical punishment.

Neoplatonism

Neoplatonism is a philosophical and mystical development of Plato's thought that arose in the 3rd century CE, primarily through the work of Plotinus. It teaches that the human soul can ascend back to divine unity through contemplation and purification.[122] Unlike Plato's conversational style, Neoplatonism systematized his ideas into a structured metaphysical hierarchy, merging Greek philosophy with spiritual thought.

Augustine encountered Plotinus' ideas through Latin translations of Plotinus' works. Modern scholarship emphasizes how deeply Augustine was shaped by Plotinus' Neoplatonism. For example, the Brill monograph describes Plotinus as Augustine's *"most important non-biblical source."*[123]

Thus, it is widely agreed that Neoplatonism profoundly shaped early Western Christian theology through the work of Augustine of Hippo.[124]

Augustine of Hippo

Here is something most Christians are never told: Augustine of Hippo, the single most influential theologian in Western Christianity, was one of the few major Church Fathers who was functionally illiterate in both Hebrew and Greek.[125] He relied almost entirely on Latin translations—translations that often flattened Hebrew imagery and altered Greek nuance. As a result, key metaphors, idioms, and cultural assumptions that would have been obvious to Jews of the biblical world were lost to him.

Because of his limited facility with Hebrew and Greek, Augustine famously misread several key biblical texts. One of the most consequential examples is Romans 5:12—specifically the phrase that was rendered in Old Latin as "in whom all sinned."

Augustine relied on a Latin translation that implied humanity sinned in Adam, as though all humans literally participated in Adam's transgression. From that mistranslation he constructed the doctrine of inherited guilt:

the idea that every human being is born legally culpable for Adam's sin. This single interpretive error became the theological cornerstone of Original Sin as later developed in both Catholic and Protestant traditions.

But the Greek text says nothing of the sort.

> *Therefore, just as sin entered the world through one man, and death through sin, and in this way death came to all people,* ***because all sinned****.*
>
> (Romans 5:12)

Paul does not say "in whom all sinned." He says, *"because all sinned."* The difference is enormous. Paul's argument is about the universality of human sin—what humans actually do—not about an inherited legal guilt passed down biologically from Adam. Death spreads because all sin, not because all once sinned as Adam.

As native Greek speakers, Eastern Christian theologians and Church Fathers never accepted Augustine's reading precisely because it did not align with the Greek text. And modern scholars across denominational lines now agree: the Latin wording misled Augustine, and an entire theological system was built on that mistake.

What began as a translation error hardened into dogma—and reshaped Western Christianity's understanding of sin, guilt, and salvation ever since.

Augustine's decade-long immersion in Manichaeism—a dualistic religion obsessed with cosmic conflict, inherent corruption, and punitive justice—left deep psychological and theological scars that later resurfaced in his fixation on inherited guilt, divine wrath, and a God who saves by condemning most.

Augustine's theological legacy rests on an extraordinarily dark—and deeply controversial—view of the human condition. Augustine's doctrine of Original Sin goes far beyond the early church's teaching (all sin, thus all die, thus all need grace). He redefined Adam's sin as *inherited moral guilt*, meaning every human—including infants from the moment of birth—is born already condemned and deserving of Eternal Conscious Torment judgment.

Ken Wilson, who earned his doctorate in theology with a thesis on Augustine's life and teachings from the University of Oxford, summed it up perfectly:

> Because infants have no personal sin, Augustine deduced their baptisms for forgiveness of sin must be based upon their inherited guilt (reatus) from Adam's first sin. [126]
>
> (Ken Wilson)

In Augustine's framework, infants enter the world condemned, not because of anything they have done, but because guilt itself is inherited. But *inherited guilt* clearly contradicts the biblical message: *"The child will not share the guilt of the parent, nor will the parent share the guilt of the child."* (Ezekiel 18:20).

To explain why some are "rescued" from this cosmic indictment while others are not, Augustine adopted the doctrine of predestination/election.[127] Not an election for a role and mission (e.g., Romans 9:10–16) but for being saved from Eternal Conscious Torment. And not predestination as in everything eventually serving God's plan, but rather about preselecting who would be saved from hell before they were even born. Many ancient pagan religions embraced some form of predestination that overrides human agency and free will, including the Greco-Roman world, where the Fates controlled every life; Mesopotamian religion, with destinies inscribed on the Tablets of Destiny; Egyptian belief, where gods like Shai assigned each person's fate; and Norse mythology, where the Norns fixed the destinies of gods and humans. But predestination was an unfamiliar idea to the Israelites, as the Bible placed a strong focus on human choice and responsibility.[128] The only form of "election" found in Scripture is election for a role, a vocation, or a mission—not election to personal salvation from hellfire. As Romans 9 makes clear, God chooses people *for* something, not over others for eternal destinies.

Augustine broke from the biblical tradition and leaned toward pagan ideas, claiming that God had already chosen a set number of people to receive saving grace while intentionally denying it to most others[129]—who

were then severely punished for a condition they were born with and powerless to change. This isn't mercy in limited form; it's cruelty dressed up as Systematic Theology.

To defend his views, Augustine famously appealed to Psalm 51:5 as proof of Original Sin—reading it as a metaphysical claim that guilt is inherited from conception. But when the verse is read carefully, on its own terms, within the biblical context and its linguistic structure, it teaches nothing of the sort. David is not making a universal statement about human nature, nor is he claiming that infants are born morally culpable before God. He is speaking autobiographically, describing the brokenness that marked the story of his life from its very beginning.

> *Behold, I was shapen in iniquity; and in sin did my mother conceive me.*
>
> (Psalm 51:5)

The Hebrew grammar is decisive. The preposition translated "in" does not denote a legal status of guilt; it typically marks sphere, context, or circumstance—"within the situation of." The verbs are passive and biographical: *"I was brought forth."* Then the focus sharpens explicitly to the maternal act: *"in sin my mother*

conceived me." Grammatically, David is not the subject of the sin; his mother is the subject of the conceiving. The phrase locates the event within a sinful or tragic situation, not within David as an object of inherited blame. The parallelism of Hebrew poetry reinforces this: the two lines restate and intensify the same idea—that from the very beginning of his life story, sin and brokenness surrounded him.

We know David felt rejected and forsaken by his parents (Psalm 27:10) and brothers (1 Samuel 17:28). Ancient Jewish tradition[130] fills in the gap. David's mother, Nitzevet, endured years of silent suffering and social disgrace to protect her son. After Jesse separated from her due to doubts about his own lineage, he sought to conceive a child through a maidservant. Unbeknownst to him, Nitzevet and the maidservant secretly switched places, resulting in David's conception. Because Nitzevet never exposed the truth, her pregnancy appeared illicit. She bore the shame alone, while David grew up treated as an illegitimate outcast within his own family (1 Samuel 16:11). His earliest years were shaped not by divine condemnation, but by human suspicion, injustice, and exclusion because his mother conceived him in sin—literally.

Read in this light, Psalm 51:5 becomes what it plainly is: a confession that David's life began amid sin, scandal, and suffering—not a doctrinal treatise on inherited guilt. To extract from this verse a universal theory of Original Sin as Augustine did is to impose a later theological framework onto a lament that was never meant to carry such metaphysical weight. It is not exegesis; it is retrojection.

Furthermore, the logic drove Augustine to one of his most disturbing conclusions: infant baptism was not merely important, but absolutely essential. Unbaptized babies who died, he insisted, were excluded from heaven and consigned to hell—understood not metaphorically, but as a place of literal, physical fire that forever torments both body and soul without ever destroying them. In Augustine's system, God creates babies knowing most of them will suffer forever, calls it justice, and demands gratitude for sparing a few.

If this theology sounds familiar, it's because Augustine's pessimism about humanity and theological fixation on inherited guilt profoundly shaped Western Christianity—later softened in places within Catholicism, but radicalized in Protestantism—leaving a legacy in which fear eclipses love, grace becomes selective, and God increasingly resembles a cosmic prosecutor rather than the Father revealed by Jesus.

How Augustine's Formative Years Shaped His Theological Vision

Having spent most of his life in North Africa—primarily in what is now Algeria and Tunisia—Augustine was largely unfamiliar with the Jewish worldview, its symbols, metaphors, and modes of thought that shaped

both the Hebrew Scriptures and the teaching of Jesus and the New Testament. Yet his interpretations, filtered through the Latin language and Neoplatonic philosophy, would go on to define Western theology for centuries.

This is not a small detail. Imagine a thinker in Ecuador reading a Spanish translation of Sophocles' Antigone and then building an entire philosophical system on misunderstood metaphors and mistranslated words. Now imagine that these misinterpretations become, a thousand years later, the doctrinal foundation for major branches of a world religion.

That is precisely what happened with Augustine. His belief about "hell" as Eternal Conscious Torment —a concept foreign to Second Temple Judaism and to all other ancient Christian schools of theology— shaped the early Catholic understanding of hell. Centuries later (16th century), ECT was picked up by two towering Reformers: John Calvin and Martin Luther. Catholics themselves, they continued to embrace most of Augustine's theological beliefs—even after the Reformation—without returning to the Jewish worldview, likely because they were both highly anti-Semitic as well.[131] (You're invited to learn more about the deep antisemitism of both Calvin and especially Luther in my book, ***"Why Don't Jews Believe in Jesus."***)

Augustine's Logical Fallacies

Building on linguistic misunderstandings and theological fallacies—largely imported from Neoplatonism—Augustine concluded that because God is infinite, hell, which he imagined as a very literal place of fire,[132] must be infinite as well: without end, without mercy, and without any corrective or redemptive purpose. In his framework, punishment was not meant to heal or restore, but simply to punish—again and again—forever.

This marked a decisive break from the older, more Jewish understanding of divine justice, grace, and judgment, in which correction and restoration were integral to God's dealings with humanity. That earlier vision dominated Christianity for its first three centuries, long before Augustine's synthesis took hold. Yet Augustine's doctrine of hellfire as Eternal Conscious Torment went on to cast a long shadow over Western theology, haunting both Catholic and Protestant traditions ever since.

However, Augustine's argument commits several errors in reasoning known as "logical fallacies."[133]

First, **the fallacy of equivocation**: Augustine collapses God's infinite nature into the finite reality of creation, treating human sin and historical judgment as though they must share the same ontological properties as God Himself.

Second, **the fallacy of false analogy**: Augustine assumes that because God's love—as a divine *attribute*—is infinite, His punishments—as divine *actions*—must also be infinite in the same way. But attributes and actions are not identical, and Scripture never treats them as such.

Even in his own lifetime, Augustine's interpretation was far from universally accepted. What later became dominant in the West was not the settled consensus of the early Church, but one theological trajectory among several—and a controversial one at that.

To this day, it is the Eastern and Oriental Orthodox traditions that have most faithfully preserved the pre-Augustinian vision of judgment and hell: a far more nuanced understanding of time, correction, and divine mercy—one that refused to collapse biblical language into abstract metaphysics or infinite retribution. That distinction has never disappeared. As one well-known Orthodox theologian succinctly puts it:

Hell appears in the shadow of the cross as what has always already been conquered, as what Easter leaves in ruins, to which we may flee from the transfiguring light of God if we so wish, but where we can never finally come to rest—for, being only a shadow, it provides nothing to cling to (as Gregory of Nyssa so acutely observes). Hell exists, so long as it exists, only as the last terrible residue of a fallen creation's enmity to God, the lingering effects of a condition of slavery that God has conquered universally in Christ and will ultimately conquer individually in every soul. This age has passed away already, however long it lingers on in its own aftermath, and thus in the Age to come, and beyond all ages, all shall come home to the Kingdom prepared for them from before the foundation of the world.[134]

(David Bentley Hart)

What Augustine Got Wrong About God's Nature

Augustine is regarded as a saint in some traditions, but even "saints" often get things wrong. In his case, it was his understanding—or misunderstanding—of God's nature.

Before God created time and space, there was no time at all. God's life, therefore, is not *quantitative* but *qualitative.* He does not exist for an infinite number of days along some endless timeline, because time itself did not exist prior to creation.

God cannot die not because He has accumulated unlimited time, but because He is immortal by nature—unaffected by sin or death, perfect, self-sufficient, and unchanging in who He is. His immortality flows from His very being, not from the length of His existence.

Likewise, in the resurrection, we will receive a new body that is immortal and life that is imperishable. We will no longer be vulnerable to sickness, aging, or death. We will become like God in the sense that nothing can destroy us:

> *When the perishable has been clothed with the imperishable... then the saying that is written will come true: "Death has been swallowed up in victory."*
>
> (1 Corinthians 15:54)

Eternal life, then, is not about living endless days. That is only a byproduct—a side effect. In its truest sense, eternal life is about sharing in a kind of life like God's own: a life that is untouchable by death, incorruptible by sin, and ultimately indestructible.

Conclusion: Think Like a Hebrew, Not a Greek

In conclusion, Augustine's Neoplatonically shaped interpretation of *olam* and *aion* introduced a rigid, endless view of divine punishment into Western Christianity that departed sharply from the restorative justice envisioned in Jewish thought and preserved in many of the Eastern/Orthodox traditions. By equating God's

infinite nature with infinite retribution, Augustine committed logical and linguistic errors that gave rise to the Western doctrine of Eternal Conscious Torment. Yet the biblical and Jewish tradition reminds us that eternity is not about endless duration but about the quality of incorruptible life in God—a life that conquers death, restores creation, and embodies the victory of resurrection rather than the permanence of punishment.

To understand *eternal life* is to stop thinking like a Greek philosopher or a modern engineer and start thinking more like a Hebrew prophet and a Jewish rabbi. The Bible's vision of life is not primarily concerned with endless time but with blessedness, wholeness, closeness to God, and victory over death—**immortality**.

Chapter 40

Eternal Conscious Torment Fails the Test of God's Character

If an alien spent five minutes scrolling through Christian posts and videos on social media today, it would quickly become obvious why there are 49,000 Christian groups and sects worldwide. Christians can barely agree on anything—least of all on salvation itself. And if one's afterlife destiny truly depends on solving a theological puzzle that even Christians cannot agree on, then salvation begins to look less like a free gift of grace and more like a cruel game of cosmic Russian roulette.

Such a vision does not reveal a loving Father. It depicts something far darker: a deity presiding over confusion, disproportionately punishing creatures for failing to decipher competing doctrines He allowed to fracture endlessly. That is not grace—it is perilously close to an abusive experiment masquerading as justice.

With that in mind, I will now present three moral and theological arguments against the doctrine of Eternal Conscious Torment.

Eternal Conscious Torment Fails the Test of Divine Guardianship

God is our guardian because He created us, knows us, and sustains our every breath. We are all His offspring (Acts 17:28). We are under His responsibility. Like a faithful shepherd, He watches over what is His own—not from obligation, but from love. We are not self-made or forgotten; we are held, protected, and guided by the One who gave us life.

When evangelizing unbelievers, Christians often reach for the analogy of God as a loving Father who loves them deeply—because it resonates, because it draws people in. But let's stop and actually test that analogy, rather than invoking it rhetorically and exempting it from scrutiny.

A good parent/guardian teaches, nurtures, and corrects their children/wards. Even if they rebel, a loving guardian does not abuse them by burning them in the fire or casting them into a torture chamber to suffer forever. If God is truly a better father than any human parent (Matthew 7:11), why would He operate by standards we would find abusive in any human relationship?

If we, as imperfect human beings, would never burn our own children alive for disobedience (unless we are psychopaths), how can we believe that a God of infinite love and mercy would commit something infinitely worse?

Even earthly parents know that when children misbehave, correction should be measured, temporary and purposeful—aimed at growth. But punishment designed only to inflict endless suffering? That is not justice. That is cruelty. If hell truly meant infinite torment with no chance of healing or change, then it would serve no purpose except to gratify divine sadism. However, Scripture teaches that God's justice is restorative, not vengeful; His love corrects, heals, forgives enemies, and seeks reconciliation. Unending torture accomplishes none of this.

This is the big difference between a religion driven by fear and the true Gospel of a God who is completely kind, forgiving, and loving. If the primary purpose of human life is simply to avoid Eternal Conscious Torment, then something is profoundly wrong with how we have imagined both God and ourselves. Life becomes a fearful Escape Room contest, not a meaningful journey; faith becomes anxiety, not transformation.

For what kind of loving God would torment most of humanity forever with no redemptive goal? Why would the One who commands us to forgive without limit (Matthew 5:44; Luke 17:4) refuse to forgive His own offspring and image bearers? And how could infinite punishment be fair for finite beings—fragile minds shaped by trauma, culture, fear, misinformation, and distortion?

If God is a loving Father, then His justice must look like love. And if He created us with limited understanding, why assume that once we stand before Him—seeing clearly for the first time—we would not see, understand, repent, and turn to Him freely?

A theology built on fear collapses under its own contradictions. A theology built on love, restoration, and the character of Christ is the only one that makes sense of Scripture—and the human heart.

Eternal Conscious Torment Fails the Test of Redemptive Grace

We love to sing about the sweetness of God's amazing grace—but do we truly grasp what grace actually means?

Human ideas of "justice" are often fueled by emotion, wounded pride, and a thirst for revenge. That is precisely why so many find a dark comfort—and even a perverse satisfaction—in the image of a monstrous god who tortures their enemies forever. The doctrine of Eternal Conscious Torment does not reveal divine grace; it mirrors human vindictiveness. It gratifies something ugly within us: not the longing for restoration, but the craving for payback. Hell becomes a theological permission slip to say, "They may have hurt me here, but one day my God will make them suffer far worse—forever!"

But pause and test this vision against reality. If your child came to you and said they had converted to Buddhism or Judaism, would you burn them at the stake? Of course not. And if you—with all your limitations, fears, and moral failures—would never commit such an atrocity, why imagine that God, whose love infinitely surpasses yours, would do exactly that simply because someone died unconvinced?

Grace that ends in endless torture is not grace at all. It is revenge wearing religious language.

[Trigger warning: sensitive content ahead]

Picture this: your unbelieving child, who had converted to Buddhism or Judaism, suffers a horrific tragedy—kidnapped, assaulted, tortured, and ultimately murdered by a true monster. The perpetrator is caught, tried, their crimes laid bare before the world, and sentenced to unending torment.

You attend the first session of their punishment. Red-hot irons sear their flesh. Teeth ripped from their mouth. Fingernails torn out. Skin flayed. You watch in silence, and for a moment, you feel something like relief—vindication, a dark echo of justice.

A month passes. You return. The torment hasn't stopped. Kneecaps shattered. Joints pulled from their sockets. Their tongue severed. Face burned. What was once screaming is now only hoarse, animal whimpering. You leave feeling justice is being served.

But in time, the fire of revenge cools, and bitterness returns, hollow and cold. So you come back again. Years later. Skin peeled away to show raw muscle. Scalp torn off. Empty sockets where eyes once were. Suspended

in place, the burning flames slowly melt the skin. The spectacle is endless, grotesque. A decade passes—yet somehow the body still clings to life. The creature still feels everything. Acid hisses as it eats through what remains of its limbs. Bones are splintered, mangled beyond recognition. There is no release, no death—only unending conscious suffering.

It's terrifying to read this, I know. But this is the picture many hold of hell: Eternal Conscious Torment, pain inflicted forever, without healing or redemption.

But let's be honest, in the common Christian view, it's not just monsters but all unbelievers who are doomed to endure Eternal Conscious Torment in hellfire. In this awful scenario, that means your "unsaved" child would be likewise suffering in hell forever, too.

It is easy to imagine monsters like Hitler suffering forever. That thought feels emotionally satisfying. But the reality of Eternal Conscious Torment is far darker. Most who hold to it do not consign only Hitler to endless suffering—they consign most of humanity, including the millions Hitler tortured, starved, and burned alive, to the same fate of unending torment in hellfire.

This is the quiet horror of the doctrine. It does not merely punish perpetrators of extraordinary evil; it sweeps up victims alongside them. Under ECT, the grandma and her grandchild in the concentration camps and the architect of the camps share the same fate—not because of justice, but because they failed to pass a particular theological threshold. That is not moral clarity. It is a moral collapse.

According to Charles Spurgeon, a foundational and towering figure in many Protestant traditions, including the Baptist and evangelical:

> When thou diest, thy soul will be tormented alone; that will be a hell for it: but at the day of judgment thy body will join thy soul, and then thou wilt have twin hells, thy body sweating drops of error, and thy soul suffocating in a sea of fire.... There is a real fire in hell, as truly as you have a real body—a fire which shall burn the body, but yet not consume it; it shall melt the iron, but the metal shall not pass away; it shall burn the skin, but the skin shall never be consumed. Every nerve shall be a highway for the hot chariot of pain to travel on; every vein shall be a canal for the river of fire to roll through; and every bone shall be a scorched pillar of agony. [135]

Likewise, according to John MacArthur:

> Agony, banishment, brimstone, curse, darkness, deprivation, destruction, distress, fire, teeth grinding, guilt, hopelessness, loneliness, pain, suffering, pressure, prison, punishment, ruin, separation, shame, contempt, smoke, sulfur, torment, trouble, trash heap, weeping—all forever. [136]
>
> (John MacArthur)

But this isn't divine justice. It's the "justice" of tyrants—the fear-mongering of regimes like the Islamic Republic of Iran or North Korea, where pain and torment are mistaken for righteousness and justice.

Endless torment doesn't fix anything; it doesn't restore what was lost. It doesn't bring a dead child back to life. It only feeds vengeance, never reconciles.

The gospel offers something profoundly different and better. Not endless torment for criminals and unbelievers, but restoration of all. The promise that one day, every broken thing, every murdered child, every shattered life will be made whole again. That even the worst of sinners will bow their knees and confess that Jesus Christ is Lord—not because they're crushed, but because they finally see and understand.

That's hope—not revenge. That's the good news of the gospel.

Punishing the wicked doesn't bring back the innocent whose lives were lost. No matter how severe the consequences, they cannot restore what the wrongdoers have taken away. How would torturing a million Germans bring my lost Jewish family members back to me? Only the true Gospel offers genuine hope—not endless retribution, but the hope in the restoration of all things—I will get to see them again!

Truth be told, Eternal Conscious Torment offers nothing more than a counterfeit emotional release—a revenge fantasy dressed up in religious language. It gives people permission to cling to bitterness while calling it righteousness. Rather than doing the difficult, transformative work of forgiveness, healing, and grace, ECT hands them a theology that baptizes resentment and declares infinite suffering to be "justice" for those who caused them pain. It does not heal the wound; it sanctifies it.

But this is not the heart of God revealed in Jesus. It is the projection of our pain onto the divine, creating a god in our own broken image.

No amount of revenge will ever bring back a lost loved one. The eternal torment of others cannot undo *your* grief or heal *your* broken heart. Only Christ offers something truly redemptive: resurrection of those you've lost! He will raise everyone to life again. Every tear will be wiped away. No more death. No more trauma. No pain will last forever.

The deepest wounds of history will not be ignored—they will be healed and made new. (Revelation 21:5). That's God's grace to us.

Eternal Conscious Torment Fails the Test of Corrective Justice

A punishment born of love is meant to guide and correct—to heal, not to break; to restore, not to destroy. God's discipline does not erupt from rage, but flows from love. It is a refining fire, not an inferno of vengeance. Like a good Father, God disciplines His children in order to bring them back—whole, humbled, healed, and transformed.

Eternal Conscious Torment, by contrast, serves no redemptive purpose whatsoever. It does not teach. It does not restore. It does not reconcile. It does not heal. It is not justice. It is cruelty for cruelty's sake. In this doctrine, punishment is emptied of meaning and inflated into endless sadism. The Augustinian-Calvinistic god it portrays is not a healer but a sadist and tormentor—one who delights in unending suffering with no goal beyond inflicting pain. Unsurprisingly, this vision steadily deadens compassion and erodes moral sensitivity in those who defend it.

Consider the reality of the human condition. Most people are shaped from birth by culture, fear, trauma, ignorance, survival instincts, mental illness, distorted beliefs, and inherited wounds. Much of what we call "sin" flows from brokenness—not malice. What needs to be destroyed is sin itself, not the human being caught in its grip. What humanity needs is healing, not more pain and punishment.

A genuinely Christian heart should recoil at the idea of God eternally tormenting the majority of humanity. It should grieve, not defend it. Yet many in the West passionately protect this grotesque doctrine, propped up by a Romanized, retributive vision of justice that owes more to empire than to Christ. Test your own heart honestly: if the idea of endless suffering strikes you as "righteous," then something has gone deeply wrong—not with God's justice, but with how you have been taught to imagine it.

In the Hebrew Scriptures, "fire" is often used to describe God's justice[137]—not as a tool of sadism, but as a force of refinement and purification. Fire refines gold, burns away impurities, and prepares something to be made new. In this context, divine fire isn't about perpetual abuse—it's about healing what's broken, cleansing what's defiled, and restoring what's been lost:

I will put them into the fire; I will refine them like silver and test them like gold. They will call on my name, and I will answer them; I will say, "They are my people," and they will say, "The LORD is our God."

(Zechariah 13:9)

Infinite punishment for finite sins is neither just nor merciful. A crime committed in a human lifespan cannot deserve infinite, unending torture—that is not justice; it is sadism. The Augustinian-Calvinist hellfire overrides not only redemptive justice but also grace and mercy entirely—for they mean the offering of redemption, restoration, and forgiveness to the *undeserving*. Apparently, in the fundamentalist imagination, God's mercy has an expiration date. It lasts only until the moment of death, after which grace is abruptly replaced by endless vengeance. Such a view not only shrinks mercy to a temporary feature of God rather than an everlasting expression of who He is, but also contradicts the Bible: *"O give thanks unto the God of heaven: for his mercy endureth forever."* (Psalm 136:26)

On the other hand, a *temporary* judgment serves a purpose. And if that purpose is not sadistic but loving—then, by simple logic, it must be *restorative*. Any punishment that comes to an end implies that something has been accomplished: purification, repentance, healing, or transformation. Therefore, even those who undergo judgment will ultimately be restored, because a finite correction can only make sense if it leads to a greater good. That's true, restorative justice.

This is not sentimentality—it's biblical logic grounded in the nature of God:

> *His anger lasts only a moment, but His favor lasts a lifetime.*
>
> (Psalm 30:5)

And in Lamentations:

> *For no one is cast off by the Lord forever. Though he brings grief, he will show compassion, so great is his unfailing love.*
>
> (Lamentations 3:31-32)

The doctrine of Eternal Conscious Torment has nothing to do with God's justice. God's discipline is not unending, and His justice is always intertwined with His love. If hell has an end, its purpose is not to indulge a psychopath's sadistic desire for revenge, but to bring about redemptive justice. Torturing someone forever—even when disguised in religious language and framed as "doctrine"—doesn't make anything right; it's simply the product of a sadist's imagination.

Gladly, some ancient theologians, like St. Isaac the Syrian, grasped this truth: *"Those who are tormented in hell are tormented by the invasion of love... It is absurd to assume that the sinners in hell are deprived of God's love."* [138]

Early Church Fathers of the first and second centuries—among them the theologian, St. Clement of Alexandria—held that because the image of God is present in every human being, all people will ultimately be restored to God. This restoration, however, was not imagined as cheap or automatic; it involved a purifying process by which sin is stripped away from what God created good.

This hopeful view of universal restoration prevailed throughout the first three centuries, lasting until the time of Augustine. The belief was that God's redemptive work in Christ would ultimately heal, restore, and reconcile all people, bringing the entire creation back into harmony with God like it was before the fall.

To deny such a hope would imply that God condemns His own image—that He consigns to endless ruin what bears His likeness. In other words, it would mean God condemns, forever, something of Himself that He placed within every person.

Conclusion

In the end, the question is not how far God is willing to punish, but how far His love is willing to go. The God revealed in Jesus does not save by fear, nor rule by terror, but heals by truth, patience, and mercy that refuses to let go. Hope is not naïve—it is faithful to the character of God. And if love is stronger than death, wiser than wrath, and more enduring than sin, then the story of humanity does not end in despair and torment, but in restoration, light, and a grace vast enough to bring every lost soul home.

If free will is exercised under the threat of unending torment, then it is not free at all. A choice made under existential fear is a forced choice, no different from someone pressing a gun to your head and ordering you to your knees—or an abuser telling their captive, "If you don't love me, I'll burn you—but it's your choice."

Is God Like a Father Warning His Child of the Danger on the Highway?

Then I also often heard Eternal Conscious Torment defended with an analogy like this: we are toddlers playing on a busy highway, and our Father lovingly warns us not to run into traffic because we will be hit. God gives the warning, but ultimately leaves the choice to us—free will.

But let's press into that fable a little further: What kind of parent lets toddlers play next to a highway in the first place? Any decent, loving parent would build a fence, lock the doors, hold their child's hand, or remove the danger entirely—not step back, warn them once, and then say, "If you get hit, that's on you!"

If God is truly loving and all-powerful, then placing "spiritually helpless children" near a deadly, infinite consequence—and then holding them responsible for not avoiding it—isn't justice. It's negligence at best, cruelty at worst.

Millions die without ever reading the Bible, understanding the Gospel, or even hearing the name Jesus in any meaningful way. Are they still toddlers playing on highways? And if so, who put them there?

The False Choice: Love or Infinite Suffering

What kind of loving parent would hurl their child into a fire pit or strap them to an eternal torture rack for failing a theology exam? If even flawed, broken humans recoil in horror at such cruelty, how dare we project it onto a perfect Father and call it "holiness"? A god who does that isn't loving—he's monstrous—and he bears no resemblance to the Father Jesus revealed.

Imagine a person being forced to sign a contract with a knife to their throat. Can we honestly say they made a "free" choice? No, they made a choice to avoid suffering. Love has nothing to do with it. That's exactly what the monstrous doctrine of ECT does—it places a gun to the soul and calls it "free will."

If rejecting God means unending torment, then there is no real alternative—only forced submission. It makes no actual sense to say that God lets people destroy themselves out of respect for their free will. If God truly loves us, He wouldn't just watch us destroy ourselves forever in the name of "free will." Just as a good parent wouldn't let their hurting child walk into fire without stopping her, real love doesn't abandon—it rescues.

Or worse, imagine a parent saying to their child, "Love me, or I'll make sure you fall into a pit of fire where you will scream in agony forever." Would we call that parent loving? Would we say the child has genuine free will? Of course not. Because love, by definition, must be freely and unconditionally given—not extorted through terror.

If your theology portrays God as less loving or caring than the parent you aspire to be, it's time to rethink that theology.

Love me, or else...

Yet, fundamentalist theology tells us that God, the supposed source of perfect love, presents humanity with the very same ultimatum: "Worship me, or I'll burn you forever!" The mere fact that rejecting God comes with

such a threat makes the choice fundamentally illegitimate, morally absurd. It's the very definition of a fear-based religion.

No religious faith that relies on fear of unending punishment can be called just or loving. A choice made under the threat of permanent suffering is not a choice—it's coercion.

> Love is not something you can force. It must be freely given.[139]
>
> (C. S. Lewis)

Fear-Based Love Is Not Love At All

The Bible repeatedly tells us that *"perfect love casts out fear"* (1 John 4:18). Yet, Eternal Conscious Torment depends and thrives on fear. The entire premise of hellfire theology is rooted in existential terror, not love.

What kind of love demands threats of perpetual torture? If God truly desires a loving relationship with us, why would He construct a system where fear is the primary motivator? An affection given under the threat of hellfire is not love at all—it's survival at best.

Free will without true alternatives is meaningless.

Even in the Torah, Punishment Was Never Without End

Even within the supposedly "legalistic" Law of the Old Testament—where consequences are stated plainly and choice is taken seriously (e.g., Deuteronomy 11:26)—the harshest penalty for the most severe crimes was death, not perpetual torture. When execution was prescribed, it marked an end in this life, not the beginning of endless torment in the next. It was "game over" in this world—not infinite suffering in another.

If torment were truly the highest expression of justice, one would expect God to mention it in the Old Testament Law. But He does not. Instead, we find a legal system marked by restraint, proportionality, and mercy—one so cautious that executions were rare, surrounded by safeguards, and never meant to be cruel. Even when death was required, it was to be swift, not sadistically dragged out for years. Prolonged torture was

the hallmark of pagan nations, not Israel. And nowhere in the Law of Moses is there a threat of eternal suffering after death. Not once.

What makes this even more striking is Scripture's own testimony. Some of the Bible's most revered figures committed crimes that, under the Law, deserved death—murder, idolatry, adultery, conspiracy, persecution. Yet they were not discarded. They were confronted, corrected, transformed, and ultimately redeemed. If God's justice in this life could allow King David's restoration after committing adultery with Bathsheba and orchestrating the death of her husband Uriah, why would He suddenly be more merciless and unforgiving in the next life?

Human free will—our stubbornness, ignorance, and self-destructive choices—is not a justification for Eternal Conscious Torment. It is the very reason transformation is necessary. A God who understands human weakness does not respond with infinite cruelty, but with patient, redemptive power aimed not at destroying the sinner, but at healing their brokenness.

How Free Is Our Mind, Anyway?

Now, let's be honest. To justify God tormenting us forever, our minds would have to be totally and genuinely free—unbiased, unclouded, unaffected by anything or anyone. But that is impossible for us. We are shaped by every experience, every influence, every wound, every fear, every voice that has ever spoken into our lives—even demonic ones. Human beings cannot achieve perfect objectivity or perfect clarity. Only God can.

We live in an era where ideas are traded like currency—endless controversial paragraphs scrolling through social media feeds and podcasts. Culture encourages us to "think out loud," to share reactions freely and boldly, to broadcast interpretations and flood the world with personal and collective opinions. Yet how many of these thoughts and feelings truly belong to us? Psychologist Jordan Peterson often cites psychiatrist Carl Jung's observation: "People don't have ideas—ideas have people." According to Peterson, 95% of what we think and say doesn't originate from our true selves. Most of what runs through our minds comes from thought and emotional patterns implanted from the outside. It's the voice of the world—not our own. When we think, feel, or say "we," it's often someone else's voice speaking through us:

> Most of what you think and most of what you say are the opinions of other people. There are things you've read and things people have told you. That's a benefit in some ways because you get all those thoughts that other people have spent a long time formulating, but it's a disadvantage in that it's not exactly you.[140]
>
> (Jordan Peterson)

If human judgment is this fragile—shaped by wounds we didn't choose, fears we never asked for, malevolent spiritual forces we cannot control, cultures we didn't design, ideas that often "have us" more than we have them—then for God to punish anyone with infinite torment would be monstrously unjust. How could a perfectly good God condemn people forever for a will—thoughts and choices—that was never *fully* their own? For reactions formed by trauma? For beliefs shaped by upbringing, genetics, personality, pressures, or the thousand invisible influences that make us who we are? If our minds are not free in the fullest sense, then no verdict of infinite punishment could ever be fair. Everlasting hellfire would require perfect clarity, perfect freedom, perfect objectivity—and we do not possess these. Only God does.

In other words, we *do* have free will—but it is not "free" in the sense of pure objectivity or neutrality. Therefore, if God is truly just, He cannot hold finite, conditioned creatures accountable forever for decisions made with limited knowledge, limited understanding, limited freedom, and limited agency. The logic is inescapable: a God of perfect justice could not—would not—burn confused, wounded, influence-shaped humans forever.

Eternal Conscious Torment Diminishes the Gospel

If God is truly love, if He is truly merciful and full of grace, then His actions should reflect a love greater than human love—not less.

A truly loving God would:

- Offer endless opportunities for reconciliation (Matthew 18:21–22), even in the age-to-come.
- Bring healing, not inflict endless pain (Luke 5:31–32).
- Aim at the restoration of people and the world—not their destruction (2 Corinthians 5:18-19).
- Desire genuine love, not forced compliance (Romans 8:38–39).
- Never create a religious system based on terror, coercion, and perpetual suffering (Lamentations 3:31-32).

Telling someone they will burn in hell unless they believe X is the very definition of coercion—and coercion stands in direct opposition to love, because love cannot be forced. For that reason, any "gospel" that adds a term or condition to God's forgiveness is not the gospel at all. Anything that sounds like, *"God has forgiven you in Christ, **but only if**..."* or *"You are forgiven **if**..."* is a lie.

The salvific heart of the gospel is this: through Christ, God has *"taken away the sin of the world"* (John 1:29). No ifs. No buts. Just a period.

He is the atoning sacrifice for our sins, and not only for ours but also for the sins of the whole world.

(1 John 2:2)

God, who reconciled us to himself through Christ and gave us the ministry of reconciliation: that God was reconciling the world to himself in Christ, not counting people's sins against them. And he has committed to us the message of reconciliation.

(2 Corinthians 5:18-19)

Conclusion

If Christianity is to reflect the God of love, it must abandon the abusive framework of Augustinian hellfire and

return to the true God of Israel revealed through Jesus' transforming grace. God forces no one into submission; He is wise and loving enough that, in the end, every person will come freely. For now, we see only fragments—but when the whole truth is unveiled, no knee will remain unbowed.

Jesus will ultimately gather every prodigal soul, no matter how far they've wandered or how deeply they've fallen into fear, pain, or resistance. Through Christ, God finds, binds wounds, and leads us home—even through seasons of regret, "gnashing of teeth," and long nights of refusal. Some will resist the rescue, clinging to bitterness or confusion, but no heart can withstand the steady fire of perfect love forever.

When illusions fade and every wound is healed, all will awaken to the same truth: Jesus Christ is God's relentless love reaching for us. No fall is too deep. No detour beyond His reach. In the end—only God knows how—all will find themselves, scarred yet cherished, gathered into His embrace.

Before moving to Israel, she grew up in Eastern Europe and endured intense antisemitism from the surrounding Christians, who made sure she knew she was being mocked and bullied solely because she was Jewish.

And if that wasn't enough, when she later met Messianic believers in Israel, they told her that the same god in whose name her family had been persecuted—the one she was supposed to trust—was now also cruelly burning them in hellfire, just like Hitler did to them, only this time for good.

Will God Ignore Christian Antisemitism in His Judgement of the Jewish People?

When so-called Christian public figures like Candace Owens spread antisemitism day after day—doing so beneath a visible cross and while calling themselves Christian—what do you think Jewish people conclude about Christianity? About Christ Himself? The message they receive is not love, mercy, or truth, but hostility baptized in religious symbols. Once again, the name of Jesus is dragged through the mud by those who claim to represent Him.

Now consider the harder question: is God really so narrow-minded, so limited, so lacking in understanding, empathy, and love, that He would turn away Jews like my mother simply because the only "Jesus" they ever knew was a twisted counterfeit—distorted, hateful, and used as a weapon against them? What kind of justice is that? What sort of ruthless judge does that portray God to be? Where, then, are the mercy, patience, and grace so often preached from pulpits and sung in worship songs? Are they real—or merely rhetorical?

The idea that a God of infinite wisdom, justice, love, power, and understanding would fail to save most of humanity—and instead condemn creatures of limited rationality and overwhelming emotion to Eternal Conscious Torment—is not merely disturbing; it is incoherent. To suggest that God allows people to damn themselves because of misunderstanding, deception, trauma, fear, pain, or inherited hatred—conditions bound up with the very fabric of human existence—is to portray Him as distant, indifferent, and blind to the human condition.

Such a god does not truly see us. He does not understand us. And he bears little resemblance to the God revealed in Jesus Christ.

Does God Ignore Christian Bigotry and Sectarianism?

What the Jewish people experienced is not an isolated case.

Consider the British Empire. Its leadership was almost entirely Christian, and Christianity—explicitly and implicitly—helped shape its moral imagination and imperial vision. India lived under British rule for nearly two centuries. And while colonial rule is not in itself evil, the reality on the ground was often oppressive, violent, and merciless toward native populations.

Now ask yourself what impression that legacy has left on the minds of over a billion Hindus. For generations, Christianity was not encountered as good news, but as the religion of the occupier—the faith associated with domination, humiliation, and injustice. When a so-called "Christian nation" ruled with cruelty, how would the average Hindu come to imagine the Christian God? Almost certainly not as a God of mercy, compassion, and love. Would they feel drawn to a Western religion under those conditions? Highly unlikely.

Now narrow the lens further. Imagine a fifteen-year-old Hindu girl in the 1800s who dies "without Christ"—having never encountered Jesus except as a symbol tied to the suffering and subjugation of her people. Would

a just and loving God ignore her entire life context and cast her into Eternal Conscious Torment simply because she did not believe correctly?

If that were the case, then God would not be a righteous judge at all—a good judge always seeks understanding. He considers context. He weighs motive, background, trauma, and exposure. He understands how culture shapes belief, how history distorts truth, and how human hearts are formed long before conscious choices are made.

To ignore all of that would be to render judgment without mercy and justice without wisdom—something no good judge ever does. And the God revealed in Jesus is not a careless executioner of souls, but a discerning, compassionate, and infinitely just Father who sees the whole story before He renders a verdict.

And God is not just a good judge—He is the perfect and most merciful judge:

> *Therefore the Lord waits to be gracious to you; therefore he will rise up to show mercy to you. For the Lord is a God of justice; blessed are all those who wait for him.*
>
> (Isaiah 30:18)

Who Are Unbelievers Truly Rejecting?

We are all shaped by extremely limited knowledge, flawed understanding, emotional wounds, cultural conditioning, religious distortion, and environmental influence. A child born in North Korea or a teen raised in a spiritually abusive Christian household aren't necessarily rejecting God—they're rejecting what they've been told He is. They may be rejecting a god of terror, control, tribalism, hypocrisy, or injustice. But the true and living God—the Father revealed in Jesus—is often hidden from them. So, is it really rejection if they've never truly encountered *Him*, understood Him, grasped His message, or known Him? Remember, the very reason Jesus asked the Father to forgive His enemies was because *"they **know not** what they do"* (Luke 23:34).

Humanity is ignorant of its own sin because human consciousness is limited, conditioned, shaped, and often distorted—and it's in that very gap where the grace of God is needed and where it appears, not to condemn, but to forgive.

We are all still in the fog, still sorting through shadows, lies, traumas, and half-truths. Many Christians project a smug sense of certainty, as if they alone—unlike the other 48,999 views—have finally "figured it all out." But once pressed, even the most respected theologians, priests, rabbis, and mystics have admitted to me in countless theological discussions that their understanding is incomplete on so many topics. My experience includes many messianic pastors, several seminary professors at Dallas Theological Seminary, and even a Catholic cardinal.

Even the apostle Paul—who experienced visions and revelations—said, *"Now we see through a glass, dimly… now I know in part"* (1 Corinthians 13:12). If that was true for Paul, how much more so for the rest of us?

And if salvation is to come to the knowledge of Him, then that knowledge—by Paul's own admission—is still partial, indirect, and incomplete: seen "through a glass," and only "dimly." Thus, it could be argued that rejection based on a partial or distorted understanding isn't rebellion—it's confusion. And God understands it.

I believe this logic applies both to those who pervert His name and image and those who "willfully" reject Him. But when they finally understand, when the veil is lifted and the truth of God's goodness is fully revealed, awe and surrender will be the only natural response. Every knee will bow.

Conclusion

When the blinders are gone, when the distortions are burned away by perfect love, then—and only then—will the human soul truly be able to choose. When that soul sees God for who He really is, it will not walk away.

This is why all rejection of God must be temporary. This is why Hell—however one defines it—must also be temporary. Because the rejection is not of God Himself, but of a false image—a distortion. God's plan is not to punish the confused, the brainwashed by the devil, the indoctrinated by sin, but to enlighten them. And once they are enlightened—truly, fully, gloriously—they will fall to their knees, not in shame or fear, but in praise.

Every knee will bow when every mind truly understands.

Chapter 43

God Understands Evil—and the Way It Shapes Us

No child is born a hater; no baby longs to murder. Even the most destructive personalities—narcissists included—are largely shaped by the wounds, neglect, and environments that formed them. It is mostly through trauma and indoctrination in hatred that innocent hearts are twisted into instruments of violence.

Boy Named Ahmed—An Illustration

From the moment Ahmed was born, his world was filled with the passionate voices of the muezzins echoing from loudspeakers. Before he could walk the streets of Gaza, his ears had already absorbed words heavy with meaning: Shahid, Jihad, evil Zionists, martyrdom, and being told Allah is the God of revenge.

At three years old, Ahmed was already chanting hateful phrases he didn't understand but was praised for saying. His uncle placed a toy gun in his hand and told him he was Allah's lion against the Jews. "Allah will reward you. One day, you will bring honor to your family," he said.

His picture books weren't like those of Western children. They were filled with tales of young boys who died fighting the so-called "enemy"—Jews portrayed not as individuals, but as one cursed people, dehumanized and imagined with horns. In one story, a Jewish man betrayed the Prophet Muhammad and was justly punished. In another, a teenager's soul was lifted to paradise because he threw a stone at a Jew and was killed. Ahmed learned that paradise was closest to the brave, and bravery meant resistance, and resistance meant bloodshed.

At five, Ahmed sat cross-legged in the mosque, where the imam taught that to fight the Zionists was not only political—it was divine will. The Quran was quoted to him in fragments, always ending in certainty: "You, little one, are chosen by Allah to resist. To fight is to believe."

By age seven, Ahmed was playing "ambush" with his cousins in alleyways, pretending to sneak up on Jews made of cardboard. He practiced knife grips, praised by his older brother, who had photos of armed martyrs on his bedroom wall. At family dinners, the name of an uncle who had blown himself up at a Jerusalem bakery was mentioned with pride. "He is in paradise," his aunt said, "and now his whole family is honored."

Ahmed didn't learn Hebrew. He didn't meet Jewish children. He didn't hear stories about peace or shared pain. He only knew what he had been indoctrinated with: fear, resistance, and the promise that Allah's favor would rest on him if he fought unto death.

By thirteen, driven by sexual desire and swayed by warped beliefs, he was led to believe he'd be rewarded with 72 virgins if he died committing violence against the infidels.

By fifteen, Ahmed was ready. He no longer smiled when he played. His play had become preparation. When a recruiter from a militant group noticed him at the mosque, he praised his knowledge, his devotion, and his seriousness. "You are pure," the man said. "The world hasn't corrupted you. You are now ready. You will make Allah proud!" Ahmed believed him.

The boy who once held a toy gun now held a real one. He no longer saw the world in shades—only in black and white. Us and them. Allah and the cursed Jews. He was told that if he died fighting, he would awaken immediately after in the gardens of paradise, with angels and virgin girls attending to him, and countless heavenly rewards awaiting.

He didn't know the faces of the people he was taught to hate. He never met them. He only knew the story he had been brainwashed with, over and over again, in the name of Allah. He didn't know better.

This story might sound like fiction to a Western "enlightened" ear, but it's an everyday reality in parts of the Middle East and Africa, where Groups such as Hamas, Hezbollah, ISIS, Boko Haram, and Islamic Jihad have repeatedly weaponized children—brainwashing them into soldiers and then exploiting their deaths to manufacture sympathy and outrage among naïve Western audiences.

Child soldiering is evil in its most distilled form (Matthew 18:6). These children were never truly given a chance—never afforded the freedom, safety, education, or moral formation that Western Christians often take for granted. To equate the "choices" of Muslim children in Gaza with those of a pastor's child raised in a comfortable Christian home in Texas is not just ignorant; it is morally obscene. Any theology that pretends these lives begin on equal footing is blind to reality—and any judgment that ignores such disparity is not justice, but cruelty masquerading as righteousness.

But I believe God sees everything. He understands how deeply evil shapes, wounds, and distorts His children, and He takes all of that into account in His just and merciful judgment.

We Don't Realize What We Don't Know

By definition, the human mind is incapable of grasping all truth, because we are not all-knowing. From birth, we are slowly formed—mostly unconsciously—by inherited narratives. We do choose freely, but our freedom is never absolute; it is always heavily conditioned.

And this is where I believe God's understanding and mercy come into play. I'm not suggesting young terrorists are in for a garden of roses, but God is not binary. Divine justice isn't a simple equation of bliss versus endless torment.

Being refined and purified by *fire* is hardly a metaphor for a pleasant experience, but losing reward or facing consequences for wrongdoing doesn't have to mean endless torment in hell, as some Christian (and Islamic) traditions claim. Besides, if all will ultimately be restored, then even the most tragic and violent deaths are not

the final word. Every person—whether lost traumatically or naturally—will be resurrected and restored again. In that light, even the worst death becomes a temporary condition, not an everlasting one.

If God's grace isn't bigger than our own, then it's not really divine grace at all.

We Wrestle Not Against Flesh and Blood

And here is a crucial point that is often overlooked: many people are shaped not only by culture, but by a dimension of evil that runs far deeper—one reflected in struggles like Ahmed's. This is something God understands far more profoundly than we do and fully takes into account in His judgment. Human beings are not formed in a vacuum. Spiritual forces are at work as well, and fragile, impressionable creatures that we are, we are profoundly susceptible to their influence and damage.

Scripture is unambiguous on this point: *"We wrestle not against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this world, against spiritual wickedness in high places"* (Ephesians 6:12). Our struggle, at its core, is not merely human—it is spiritual. Behind every terrorist

organization, every murderer, every system of brutality, there are dark powers at work, pulling strings like marionettes—sometimes metaphorically, and at times perhaps quite literally through demonic possession.

These forces do not merely influence individuals; they shape entire systems, cultures, and histories. And they do not spare the Church. Satan assaults Christian belief itself—its doctrines, its translations, its commentaries, its teaching. How else can we account for the staggering fragmentation of Christian theology, or for portrayals of God so grotesque and cruel that they bear no resemblance to the Father revealed in Jesus? Theological distortions—such as Eternal Conscious Torment—do not arise from divine truth, but from spiritual deception.

All of creation is caught up in a cosmic conflict. Most human beings are barely aware that they are participants in it. And if the struggle is spiritual in nature and universal in scope, then the solution—the salvation and redemption of humanity—must also be universal. A conflict that engulfs all creation demands a redemption that reaches just as far. Anything less would leave evil partially victorious and God's saving purpose unfinished.

If the primary battle is truly between spiritual powers far stronger than we are, then human beings are not monsters by nature, but image-bearers under assault—wounded, manipulated, and distorted by forces beyond their control. In that case, God's aim is not to annihilate sinners, but to destroy sin itself—and the powers of evil. Thus, His victory must look like healing a disease—not killing the patient, but eradicating the infection.

And if Christ truly accomplished that—atoning for the world so that, in the end, all are saved—then what we witness is a complete and decisive triumph over the powers of darkness. Nothing is left in their grasp. No victim is abandoned. No life is written off as collateral damage. God's love and power prove so vast, so relentless, and so victorious that they redeem not merely a few survivors, but all of creation—leaving evil empty-handed and defeated at last.

Conclusion

Just as evil and death do not discriminate in their reach, neither does God's grace and salvation. His redemptive love encompasses *all*, ensuring that every soul is eventually restored. This reflects the character of a God who does not abandon His creation to ruin, but rescues it fully—revealing both His supreme authority and power, and His limitless mercy.

When we finally see the story as God sees it—when we understand that evil is deeper than individuals and salvation wider than our categories—we discover that God's answer to darkness is not abandonment or torment, but redemption. His justice does not end in exclusion, but in healing; not in destruction, but in

restoration. Sin and evil are confronted, judged, and undone, yet the image-bearer is never discarded. This is the triumph of the gospel: not that a few escape while the rest are lost, but that light overcomes darkness, truth dispels deception, and love outlasts every distortion. A world apart from God fractures and decays. But in Christ, what was lost is being found, what was broken is being restored, and what was condemned is being redeemed. The world is not being thrown away—it is being saved!

Chapter 44

Love, Fear, and the Conditional "If"—Why the Gospel Cannot Be Rooted in Terror

In religious discussions, few words carry as much weight as *"if."* At the center of much Christian theology stand conditional statements: "*If* you do or believe X, then Y will happen." Depending on how that *if* is understood, it can either open the door to a living, transformative experience with God—or warp faith into a system of anxiety, insecurity, and fear.

The meaning of that "if" depends entirely on the framework through which we read it. And here, two very different theological paradigms emerge:

1. Existential Condition (Fear-Based Theology):

"*If* you don't intellectually believe the right doctrine or behave a certain way, you'll suffer Eternal Conscious Torment in hell."

This view dominates much of Western theology. It places salvation on a razor's edge, dependent on intellectual or moral precision. In other words, this "if" is a fear-driven faith.

I'm very familiar with the verses that speak about "fear of God" (e.g., Proverbs 9:10; 19:23; Matthew 10:28; 2 Corinthians 7:1). However, the commonly translated biblical term "fear," particularly the Hebrew *yir* and the Greek *phobos*, does not equate to the modern English understanding of terror or fright, but instead primarily signifies awe, reverence, and profound respect toward God. Distinct Hebrew words exist for the feeling of terror or dread, such as *pachad* and *eimah*. If you want to explore this further, especially how misunderstanding this

word has shaped Western doctrines of God's character, I discuss it extensively in my book ***Lost in Translation: 15 Hebrew Words to Transform Your Christian Faith.***

2. Relational/Consequential Condition (Love-Based Theology):

If my son misbehaved and refused to repent, I might deny him ice cream—a temporary consequence that affects our relationship. But I would never even consider taking his life simply because he refused to repent. In other words, the "if" shapes the *quality* of the relationship and the consequences within it—not the child's existence or ultimate destiny.

This understanding—deeply rooted in Jewish thought—views God not as a tyrant seeking perpetual punishment, but as a loving Father who disciplines yet never abandons. This is the consistent pattern of God's relationship with Israel throughout the Hebrew Scriptures.

When God Corrects, Not Forsakes: Israel as the Covenant Example

> *See, I am setting before you today a blessing and a curse—the blessing* ***if*** *you obey the commands of the Lord your God that I am giving you today; the curse* ***if*** *you disobey the commands of the Lord your God and turn from the way that I command you today by following other gods, which you have not known.*
>
> (Deuteronomy 11:26-28)

Yet even at Israel's lowest moments—idolatry, rebellion, exile—God's promise remained unwavering:

> *I will not reject them or abhor them so as to destroy them utterly and break my covenant with them; for I am the Lord their God.*

(Leviticus 26:44–45)

> *This is what the Lord says, he who appoints the sun to shine by day, who decrees the moon and stars to shine by night, who stirs up the sea so that its waves roar—the Lord Almighty is his name: "Only if these decrees vanish from my sight," declares the Lord, "will Israel ever cease being a nation before me."*
>
> (Jeremiah 31:35–36)

Even *"following other gods"* did not cause God to abandon Israel.

Even today—despite her spiritual rebellion and the rejection of Christ—Israel stands as living proof that God does not break His promises.

If this is God's love toward a rebellious, "stiff-necked" (Exodus 32:9; Deuteronomy 9:6, 13) and chronically unfaithful (Jeremiah 3:20; 32:33) nation, does it not apply to us as well?

These verses echo a central biblical truth: God corrects, but He does not cast off forever. His judgments are restorative, not annihilating. He doesn't engage in cancel culture because His steadfast love remains constant, even when His people fall short.

The God who refused to forsake Israel in her rebellion will not forsake us either. His love for His creation endures even when ours does not, and His faithfulness remains even when ours falters.

The gospel is not a fragile contract that collapses at the first sign of human weakness. It is a relationship—covenantal, parental, rooted in fidelity rather than fear. God disciplines to heal, not to destroy; to guide, not to damn.

If our motivation to believe is rooted in existential fear rather than love, insecurity and anxiety inevitably take hold. We can never rest, because we are never truly certain that God will not punish us forever for believing the wrong thing or failing to behave in the right way.

When "If" Becomes a Threat Instead of an Invitation

If unending torture is held out as a conditional threat—based on performance or possessing the "right" faith—

then the gospel is reduced to a transaction. Fear becomes the engine. Obedience is no longer born of love, but of terror. "Okay! I'll believe! Just promise You won't torture me forever!"

Unless one is Hannibal Lecter or the bogeyman, by any honest standard of logic, that is not love. It is coercion.

This is why the apostle John wrote:

> *There is no fear in love. But perfect love casts out fear, because fear has to do with punishment.*
>
> (1 John 4:18)

A relationship with God built on fear cannot be intimate. You cannot draw near to someone you're afraid might destroy you for one reason or another. The soul becomes obsessed with getting the formula right—never resting, never sure, never free.

In fact, research shows that Scrupulosity and OCD are disproportionately high among fundamentalist Christians. A 2019 study, for example, found that the severity of OCD symptoms linked to scrupulosity differed between religious groups, with conservative Catholics and Protestants reporting the highest levels.[141]

If you're part of this group, please let me encourage you: No matter how far you fall, you cannot outpace the love of God. No matter how badly you stumble, you can never outdo God in love or forgiveness. You will never be better at sinning than He is at redeeming.

If God truly never changes, then neither do His mercy and grace. By definition, our capacity to sin can never exceed His power to redeem. To believe otherwise is to imagine that human failure can overpower divine compassion—to claim that sin is stronger than grace. That is an impossibility. No matter how deep the fall, His forgiveness always reaches deeper still.

The "if" of Divine Love

A faith rooted in love looks very different from one rooted in fear. Love leads to intimacy, joy, and a life of gratitude. Fear leads to anxiety, legalism, and performance-driven spirituality. When we fear God's rejection, we become actors on a stage, hoping our performance will earn divine applause. But when we trust God's acceptance, we become children in the arms of a Father—free to grow, learn, stumble, and rise again.

God's "if" isn't about whether you'll be endlessly forgiven or endlessly tormented, but about the consequences and rewards—blessings and curses—that flow from how you live your life.

Scripture is full of consequences—not Eternal Conscious Torment, but consequences nonetheless. Paul says:

> *Each one's work will become manifest… and the fire will test what sort of work each one has done.*
>
> (1 Corinthians 3:13)

> *We must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ… to receive what is due for what he has done in the body.*
>
> (2 Corinthians 5:10)

In this light, the "if" is no longer existential—it mainly shapes the status and rewards in the age to come. The judgment is not about sadistic wrath or punishment for its own sake, but refinement and purification. Just as

a loving parent might discipline a child without ever withdrawing love or identity, so too God punishes for the sake of correction.

The outcome? Not annihilation. Not everlasting hellfire. But loss—or gain—of reward, honor, and role in God's coming Kingdom. Just like a good parent disciplines but never disowns, God corrects without rejecting (Hebrews 12:6).

This distinction is crucial. If the "if" relates to our identity, inclusion, or immortality itself, then we live in constant dread. But if it relates to our calling, responsibility, and future reward, then it becomes a path to growth.

That's the Gospel. Not "God threatened us into heaven," but "God loved us into transformation."

God still disciplines. There are still stakes. But God's corrections are born of love, not hate. Like a physician cutting out disease—not to punish, but to heal. Like a fire that refines gold—not to destroy, but to purify.

Reclaiming the "If" as a Blessing

When we see the "if" in the right light, it turns into a medal, a trophy, a bouquet, a promise—not an existential

threat. It calls us not to fear never-ending damnation, but to live with purpose. To win heavenly rewards. To reflect God. To steward our gifts. To store up treasures in heaven. To become Christlike. Every act of love, every sacrifice, every act of mercy—none of it is forgotten.

In this light, the "if" becomes a potential blessing, not a burden of existential threat. It challenges us, but never threatens what Christ did for us. It corrects us, but never condemns us. It sharpens our purpose without undermining our identity.

Any discipline that proceeds from a loving source must serve a loving purpose. By simple logic, that purpose can only be restorative. God's judgment, then, is not vindictive fury but the fierce fire of His love—burning away what destroys, cleansing what corrupts, purging what enslaves.

Judgement that comes to an end implies that something has been achieved: purification, transformation, repentance. And if repentance is reached, then restoration necessarily follows.

Conclusion

Let us, then, walk not in existential fear, but in awe of the grace that welcomes us. Let us believe not for the

sake of escaping, but to reflect the One who saves us in every way. For perfect love drives out fear—and draws us deeper into the joy of the Father's heart.

Let us reject the existential dread masquerading as theology, and embrace the love that drives out fear. Let us obey not because we are terrified, but because we are loved. Let us remember: We are not being threatened into faith. We are being invited into glory.

The retributive vision of Eternal Conscious Torment portrays God as fragile, wounded, capricious, and vindictive—seeking to pacify Himself through the suffering of others. It imagines an offended ruler who lashes out, rather than a healer who restores. But if God truly is love, then His response must be compassion: to heal, not to harm; to restore, not to destroy. Eternal Conscious Torment is irreconcilable with a God who is love—good, perfect, self-sufficient, and complete in Himself.

Chapter 45

God Is Not a Nazi

If only born-again Christians go to heaven, then the piles of suitcases and bags of human hair displayed at the Holocaust Museum represent thousands upon thousands of men, women, and children suffering eternal agony at the hands of an angry God.[142]

(Rachel Held Evans)

I'm often amazed at how some Christians use Hitler as the ultimate example of evil—and rightly so, given that he burned countless people alive—yet simultaneously attribute to God the very same actions and character they condemn in Hitler.

The logic used to defend Eternal Conscious Torment for someone like Hitler does not stop with him. It inevitably extends to the six million Jewish men, women, and children he murdered—most of whom were not believers in Jesus—and condemns them to the very same fate. Under this framework, victims and perpetrators alike—the murdered and the Nazi murderers—end up suffering Eternal Conscious Torment.

That conclusion alone exposes the moral bankruptcy of the system.

Think about how absurd this is: under the ECT view, some of the kindest people who ever lived would endure endless torment just like the most monstrous figures in history, often the very people who killed them. And that, so we are told, is God's justice.

Preaching God's Name in Vain

> Someone has said that no theology is worth believing that cannot be preached standing in front of the gates of Auschwitz. I, for one, could not stand at those gates and preach a version of God's sovereignty that makes the extermination of six million Jews, including many children, a part of the will and plan of God such that God foreordained and rendered it certain.[143]
>
> (Roger Olson, PhD in Theology)

If a "gospel" becomes morally grotesque and collapses into incoherence in the face of atrocities like the Holocaust, then it is not the *"good news of great joy for all people"* (Luke 2:10). It is a theological system in desperate need of reexamination.

A true gospel—if it is truly good—must be able to speak meaningfully into humanity's darkest hours, offering a hope deeper than despair and a compassion strong enough to touch the wounds of history. There is hope in knowing we will see the six million—or anyone else, for that matter—again. There is no hope at all, only despair, in believing they are being tormented forever in hellfire.

If our theology becomes useless, or even cruel, when placed beside the worst horrors humanity has endured, then perhaps the problem is not with God—but with the way we have come to understand Him.

Hitler's Final Moments

It's one thing for people to have never heard of Jesus or to have only encountered a distorted image of Him, but what about those who are truly evil? What name comes to mind when you think of someone you could never imagine in heaven? For me, growing up as a descendant of Holocaust survivors, that name was Hitler—the monstrous German dictator responsible for millions of deaths, including members of my own Jewish family. Adolf Hitler, who ended his life by gunshot on April 30, 1945, in his Führerbunker in Berlin, embodied for many the very definition of irredeemable evil.

But there's an overlooked part of Hitler's story that turns our assumptions on their head.

During Hitler's meteoric rise to power, a German theologian named Dietrich Bonhoeffer became one of his fiercest critics—eventually participating in a plot to overthrow the Nazi regime. For this, Bonhoeffer was arrested, imprisoned, and finally executed in April 1945, just days before Germany's defeat. His letters and papers from prison, published posthumously, remain one of the most profound testimonies to Christian conviction under tyranny.

According to a report online, a letter was found hidden deep within the ruins of Hitler's bunker. This letter, allegedly written shortly before his suicide, revealed something shocking: Hitler had been haunted by Bonhoeffer's teachings in the final days of the war. The words he had once dismissed as weakness now gnawed at him. His letter records overwhelming remorse for his crimes, particularly against the Jewish people. It describes a desperate cry for God's mercy—a confession, a plea.

The Soviet propaganda machine, it is said, suppressed the letter. Allowing Hitler even the possibility of redemption would have undermined the black-and-white narrative. Hitler, in their view, could only be seen as monstrous and damned—not complex, not broken, not redeemable.

And yet, this possibility forces us to ask a deeper question:

What if he did repent? What if, in the last moments of his life, Adolf Hitler sincerely sought forgiveness from Christ?

Most Christians see no serious theological problem with granting salvation to someone evil—even Hitler—provided he repented before death, much like the thief crucified beside Jesus. In this framework, a sincere last-second prayer or "inviting Jesus into one's heart" is enough to secure salvation, regardless of a lifetime of atrocities.

The irony is chilling. Under this logic, the six million Jews Hitler murdered would suffer Eternal Conscious Torment, while Hitler himself would walk free.

Think about that for a moment.

According to this belief, the murderer is embraced while the murdered are forever tortured.

The abuser finds peace while those he abused find everlasting agony.

The "born-again" oppressor is granted heaven, while his victims suffer permanent torment in hellfire.

But strangely, these same Christians erupt into spiritual outrage at even the possibility that repentance could be accepted and salvation granted if it occurred five seconds *after* death—when a soul finally sees undiluted reality face-to-face. In that case, they declare, it is "too late"—grace is cut off, God becomes a cosmic executioner, and the door to heaven is slammed forever.

How strange—how different the outcome, all because of ten seconds. Had Hitler whispered a prayer for mercy five seconds before death, many would eagerly welcome him into heaven. But had that same repentance occurred five seconds after his final breath—after facing pure truth—most would declare it impossible. As if

the ticking of a clock, not the sincerity of the heart, determines the fate of an eternal soul. How fragile, how arbitrary, Western theology can be.

If this strikes you as not just logically contradictory but also morally disturbing, you're definitely not alone.

The theology that flows from Augustine and Calvin, with its binary afterlife of instant heaven or hell, demands such contradictions. It forces you to celebrate Hitler's "salvation" (if he repented) while condemning Anne Frank to endless burning—because inherited belief systems, not moral sanity, is running the show.

And yet, Scripture reveals a better, more coherent story—a story of justice that restores, not simply punishes; of mercy that outlasts death; of love that never fails.

The story of Hitler's letter has been floating around the internet for years, though it's never been proven real. Still, whether it's genuine or not doesn't really matter—it works as a fascinating mental exercise. It's a way to explore how profoundly the Gospel pushes us to rethink our ideas about justice, mercy, and the value of every human life.

Which scenario really makes sense? That someone as monstrous as Hitler could mumble a last-minute confession and be instantly welcomed into heaven without any consequence or reckoning? Or that such a person would have to pass through a refining fire, fully face the evil they committed, and be transformed by it —regardless of their beliefs—before entering God's presence?

One scenario is moral absurdity. The other is justice healed by mercy.

"Where Sin Increased, Grace Increased All the More" (Romans 5:20)

Salvation is not an on–off switch. It is not a mechanical transaction triggered by intellectual belief or the correct words spoken. And though it is not easy for me to say this as a Jew, I believe God's mercy and compassion are far greater than my own. His love extends even to my greatest enemies.

In other words, I'd prefer to see Hitler—and anyone else deeply wicked—come to understand the truth, repent, bow in humility, and confess Jesus Christ as Lord, rather than be subjected to endless torture with no redemptive purpose. Eternal torment achieves nothing, but repentance changes everything.

Yes, even a soul as dark and grotesquely deformed as Hitler's could, through a hell-like process of judgment and purification, be brought to genuine repentance and ultimately restored. Not to earn salvation, but to undergo a true transformation of heart and vision.

This does not trivialize evil in the slightest. It does the opposite. It declares that evil does not get the last word, that even the most corrupted will not eternally rival God's goodness. It proclaims God's final and

complete victory over evil, not by endlessly sustaining it through punishment, but by overcoming it through judgment that heals, exposes, and ultimately redeems.

But not cheaply. Not instantly. And certainly not without facing the full, crushing horror of what was done. Restoration is never about excusing evil or sweeping it under the rug. That would be cheap grace—as obscene as the idea that Hitler could stroll into heaven simply for muttering the correct prayer seconds before death. That is not grace—it is moral absurdity.

True restoration is costly. It confronts evil head-on. It breaks the sinner under the unbearable weight of truth. It allows grace—slow, severe, and purifying grace—to do its work where nothing else can. For someone like Hitler, that would mean first passing through hell: not as sadistic vengeance, but as the full, unfiltered encounter with reality.

What that hell looks like, I do not pretend to define. But I imagine it as an encounter with truth so devastating it can no longer be avoided—seeing every act as it truly was, not from the safety of distance or ideology, but from within the suffering inflicted on others. Feeling the pain not abstractly, but personally. Bearing the moral weight in the depths of the soul until denial collapses, self-deception shatters, and repentance becomes unavoidable.

That is not cheap grace. That is justice fulfilled. And only a God whose love is stronger than evil could dare to bring even such a soul through fire and out the other side—not to excuse the crime, but to finally, completely, and forever purge sin.

Such repentance would not erase what had been done. It would transform the person who did it. They would not emerge honored or exalted. If anything, they would be *"least in the kingdom."* Their honor would be stripped away, their rewards forfeited, their former power undone—exchanged for humility, service, and a long apprenticeship in love.

But restoration does not mean denial. Restoration means healing after justice has been satisfied—not human revenge, but God's perfect justice that disciplines to restore, not destroy.

In the end, if Hitler ends up in heaven, it will not be because his crimes were forgotten. Yesterday was Yom HaShoa—Israel's Holocaust Remembrance Day—and like every year, a nationwide loud siren screamed for two minutes while everyone stood still. We still remember. We still grieve. But no amount of vengeance can bring back our loved ones. And it's okay, because I know they, too, will see God, will meet Jesus, and will come to accept Him. If they too are to be saved, then all the harm done to them by evil Hitlers was only temporary.

Conclusion

In the end, if Hitler is in heaven, it will be because God's mercy is wider than we dared imagine—and because God's justice is not a mirror of human wrathful vengeance, but a fire that purifies even the worst among us. A fire that burns away the impure and forges what's left into precious gold.

If that scandalizes you, remember: It is not Hitler who defines the limits of God's grace. It is Jesus—the One who said, *"Father, forgive them, for they know not what they do."* (Luke 23:34). God's love for humanity is revealed most clearly at the cross. Even as humanity crucified Him, He pleaded for forgiveness—*"because love covers over a multitude of sins"* (1 Peter 4:8).

And if Jesus could pray that prayer for the very men nailing Him to the cross, then maybe the scandal of grace is exactly what we need to be confronted with—and transformed by.

Chapter 46

Life's Purpose Isn't Escapism

Conclusion

It feels almost unthinkable to imagine offering forgiveness to the very people who mocked, hammered nails into flesh, spat on, and ultimately crucified Christ.

But what seems offensive and unthinkable to us was not unthinkable to Jesus.

From the cross—bleeding, suffocating, surrounded by hatred—in those final moments between life and death, He cried out:

"Father, forgive them!" (Luke 23:34)

Some might say there's no forgiveness for those who turn away from Christ. But if Christ could ask the Father to forgive those who committed the very act of killing Him, then surely His love atones for every human heart, no matter how resistant or broken.

God's love is not small.

It is not finite or bound by time.

It is not limited by resistance or human rebellion.

His love is boundless, relentless, and eternal—because He is.

The Gospel was never meant to terrify people into belief.

It was never designed to be a cosmic threat hanging over humanity's head.

The Gospel is a proclamation of forgiveness and an invitation into something—into love, healing, transformation, truth, and life.

It is the announcement that God's goodness is stronger than our darkest failures, that His mercy outlasts our stubbornness, and that His desire and ability to save are far greater than our ability to resist Him.

Hell's "Fire" Meant for Refinement, Cleansing, and Purification

In the ancient world, fire and sulfur were closely associated with the refining of metals, especially gold. Sulfur, often called brimstone, was used in the purification process. When added to molten metal in a crucible, it helped bind with impurities, forming sulfides that would react, smoke, and separate, allowing the purer metal to settle at the bottom. This method increased the purity and value of the metal.

Within this historical context, the biblical imagery of fire and sulfur points naturally to refinement and purification, not to endless sadistic torment. Just as a refiner's fire burns away impurities to reveal pure gold, biblical language about fire often depicts a process that exposes, cleanses, and restores rather than one that exists merely to inflict pain without end.

Thus, perhaps the true purpose of what we call "hell"—understood metaphorically and biblically—is what several early Church Fathers actually taught: an encounter with God's purifying fire. Not retribution for its own

sake, but a refining, healing process. Origen of Alexandria, Gregory of Nyssa, Clement of Alexandria, Didymus the Blind, Theodore of Mopsuestia, Isaac of Nineveh, and others, all spoke of divine judgment not as endless revenge, but as corrective, medicinal, and ultimately restorative—fire that burns away corruption so that what God created good may finally be made whole.

As I said previously, I do not pretend to know exactly what this looks like. But I can imagine that it may involve facing, with full awareness, the sorrow and pain we have inflicted on others throughout our lives. Not as vengeance, but as transformation. Truth encountered without escape. Reality felt without denial. A reckoning that breaks self-deception and gives birth to genuine repentance.

> *For everyone will be salted with fire.*
>
> (Mark 9:49)

Such fire does not exist to destroy the person, but to destroy what dehumanizes them. And it is this process —costly, honest, and purifying—that leads to the day Scripture promises: when every knee will bow and every

tongue will confess allegiance to Jesus. Not coerced by terror, but won by truth. Not crushed into submission, but healed into worship.

> *God disciplines us for our good, that we may share in His holiness. No discipline seems pleasant at the time, but painful. Later on, however, it produces a harvest of righteousness and peace for those who have been trained by it.*
>
> (Hebrews 12:10–11)

The teachings of the Lord are given so that we might repent *now*—freely, joyfully, and with open hearts—rather than learning the hard way through painful consequences. Repentance offered today is a gift; delaying it may only mean unnecessary suffering on the path to the same eventual restoration.

Repentance is not merely spoken words or crying eyes—it's a realignment of our will, our values, and our moral behavior with the heart and character of God.

Think of it like this: a loving parent warns their child about the consequences of reckless choices. The wise child listens—and is spared the pain that follows rebellion. But sometimes, despite all the warnings, the child

chooses their own path. When the consequences arrive—like a visit from the authorities or imprisonment—they become the teacher. Suffering opens the door to understanding. And from there, repentance flows.

Christ invites us to skip the needless pain. To follow Him *now*. To embrace His wisdom and walk the path of repentance—not as punishment, but as the way to true freedom, healing, and joy.

Preaching a Different Gospel

If today's gospel focuses on escaping endless hellfire torment instead of the early message from the first two centuries about stepping into the life, light, and love of God through Christ, it raises the question: Who altered the biblical message, and for what reason?

The answer is straightforward: if Satan used Scripture in an attempt to tempt and deceive Jesus—if he dared to twist the Bible against Christ Himself—then we can be certain he employs the very same tactic to mislead the Church.

It only makes sense that one of the most effective ways for Satan to distort the Gospel is by using the Bible itself. He convinces well-meaning Christians they are being "biblical"—when in reality, they are cherry-picking verses out of context to support their own agendas and theological biases.

And tragically, this kind of selective misuse of Scripture leads people to believe they are preaching the Gospel, when in fact, they are driving others away from it.

If this is true—and given how Satan operates, it likely is—then some of the people most in need of salvation are already inside the church.

They need salvation from a distorted image of God—a frightening, wrathful, and condemning figure created by well-meaning Christians who truly believe they are honoring the Bible. They need saving from anxiety and depression, and a path into life.

Sometimes, the greatest deception isn't outside the church. It's inside—dressed in religious language, backed by isolated verses, and preached with the best of intentions, but far from the heart of Christ.

"But Eitan," you might ask, "what about all those verses—being erased from the Book of Life, the Lake of Fire, outer darkness, weeping and gnashing of teeth, Lazarus and the Rich Man, the Sheep and the Goats, and so on?"

That's a fair question. And it deserves a careful, honest answer—not soundbites, not fear-driven assumptions, and not readings torn from their historical and Jewish context.

If you genuinely want to understand what the so-called "hellfire verses" are actually saying—how they were heard by their original audiences, what metaphors they employ, and how later theology reshaped them—I invite you to continue this journey with me in my book ***HELL: A Jewish Perspective on a Christian Doctrine.*** There, we walk patiently through every difficult passage, refusing both denial and distortion, allowing Scripture to speak on its own terms.

I promise you this: it will challenge assumptions, dismantle fear-based readings, and open a far richer, more faithful vision of God's justice and mercy. You won't walk away unchanged.

Part VI: Your Life as an Audition

Introduction: So, Now What?

If the gospel is true—and if Jesus truly is the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the *world*—then a staggering conclusion follows: Christ died for every human being, not merely for those who articulate the right theology, grasp the correct concepts, or arrive at proper doctrinal formulations. His love reached us long before we ever reached for Him. His mercy embraced humanity before humanity could even respond. That much is clear.

But this inevitably raises the question people fear to ask: **if God has already acted decisively for us, then what is the meaning of our lives?** What is the point of Christian existence? What is our role in this story? What is the purpose of judgment? Why this long, difficult journey on earth at all?

The answer is far deeper—and far more practical—than most expect.

Yes, Christ died for all. Yes, His love is universal. Yes, His mission is the reconciliation of all things. But that does not render this life meaningless. It does the opposite. It makes this life infinitely more meaningful. Because while redemption has already been accomplished, *transformation* has not yet been completed—and transformation is precisely where your life matters.

Scripture never teaches that God is testing our theological accuracy. Jesus never said, "Blessed are those who checked the correct doctrinal boxes." What He did teach—again and again—is that every human being is living through a divine examination. Not an exam of intellectual mastery or doctrinal precision, but an examination of life itself (e.g., Matthew 7:24–27; 22:37–40; John 13:34–35; James 1:22–27; Romans 2:6–7; 2 Corinthians 5:10).

Each of us is given a span of years—long for some, painfully short for others—and within that time God watches what we do with what we have been given: our compassion, our generosity, our integrity, our willingness to forgive, our pursuit of justice, our love for neighbor and enemy alike. The test is not what we know. It is who we become.

This is why Jesus spoke so often about reward. Not as bribery. Not as fear management. But as the natural outflow of a life aligned with God. *"The Son of Man will repay each person according to what they have done." "Great is your reward in heaven." "Store up treasures in heaven."* These are not coded threats about avoiding flames. They are promises of honor, joy, reward, and responsibility in God's restored world.

If Christ died for all—and He did—then the central question of faith is no longer, "How do I avoid hell?" The question becomes, "How do I live in a way worthy of the life I've been given?" "How do I live so that when I stand before the King, my deeds, my choices, and my loves testify that I embraced His way?"

Some—perhaps all of us—will need to be *salted with fire* before entering the Kingdom, because nothing distorted can enter a realm built on love. Fire, here, is not rejection but refinement. Those who lived with mercy, generosity, and justice will shine like the brightness of the heavens—not because they earned salvation, but because they lived faithfully within the time entrusted to them.

Life, then, is not a waiting room before heaven or a trapdoor above hell. It is the arena where character is revealed. It is the proving ground where God sees not what we claimed to believe, but how we lived, how we loved, how we forgave, how we treated the least of these.

Judgment is not the threat of endless torture. It is the unveiling of truth. It is the moment when the life we lived becomes the life we receive. And because Christ has already reconciled the world, judgment is not about

deciding who gets in. It is about determining what each person enters with—shame or glory, emptiness or fullness, ashes of wasted years or the treasure of a life well lived.

This is the invitation Jesus offers: not fear-driven compliance, but the dignity of a life examined by God and honored accordingly.

> *Do not marvel at this, for an hour is coming when all who are in the tombs will hear his voice and come out, those who have done good to the* ***resurrection of life****, and those who have done evil to the* ***resurrection of judgment****.*
>
> (John 5:28–29)

Notice that *both* groups—the righteous and the unrighteous—are resurrected. The difference lies not in whether one group is made alive again, but in the *nature* of that resurrection: *life* or *judgment*.

Resurrection of Life

The Bible isn't a biology textbook, so here "life" isn't about biology, especially since both have been resurrected.

Remember, *life* in the biblical sense never meant merely continuing to breathe. It meant blessing and joy, wholeness and peace, purpose, flourishing, and harmony with God. To *live* was to participate in the fullness of

divine life—not merely to exist. Life was never defined by quantity or duration, but by quality: a life filled with meaning, joy, blessing, and flourishing in God's presence.

Thus, *"resurrection of **life**"* signifies reward, honor, and greatness—what Jesus elsewhere calls being *great in the kingdom* (Matthew 5:19). The New Testament describes this kind of "life" in multiple ways: *storing treasure* (Matthew 6:20), *winning the race* (1 Corinthians 9:24), *receiving rewards* (1 Corinthians 3:14), *inheriting the kingdom* (Matthew 25:34), *entering the kingdom* (Matthew 7:21), *receiving the crown of life* (James 1:12), or *walking the narrow path that leads to life* (Matthew 7:14). These and others are biblical idioms and Jewish expressions that speak of spiritual blessings and achievements—depicting not those who merely intellectually accepted Christ but also lived out His way with faithfulness and love.[144]

Resurrection of Judgment

By contrast, the *"resurrection of **judgment**"* implies shame, regret, chastisement, and sanction. There's a big difference between feeling the sting of shame and condemnation when your sins come to light and suffering Eternal Conscious Torment in hellfire.

Imagine a Christian family with two young siblings returning home from summer camp. One behaved well, and everyone has nothing but praise for them; the other behaved terribly. When they walk through the door, one is met with warmth and celebration, while the other faces correction and discipline. Yet no one imagines that the parents would throw the misbehaving child into a fiery pit in the backyard.

When the child of a loving parent is punished for wrongdoing and feels "damned," it does not mean they are cast away or destroyed. It means they are being corrected within a relationship of love. If that's true about a loving parent, then why would we believe that a God who IS love (1 John 4:8, 16) would behave in a way that only an abusive, psychopathic parent would?

The *resurrection of judgment* represents those who failed to live according to God's ways—not a sentence to unending torture, but a form of loss. Jesus described it using culturally understood symbols like *"weeping and gnashing of teeth"* (Luke 13:28), a known Jewish/biblical idiom expressing deep remorse or jealousy (e.g., Psalm 35:16, 37:12, 112:10), much like the modern feeling of FOMO (Fear of Missing Out). Other terms like *"outer darkness"* (Matthew 22:13) or *"will not inherit the kingdom"* (1 Corinthians 6:9–10) don't refer to annihilation or hellfire, but to missing out on the great honor, reward, and joy of being close to God in His kingdom.

In the ancient world, living inside a kingdom's walls was a privilege reserved for the wealthy, the inheritors, and those honored by the king. Those not granted entry would remain outside after dark, missing out on the

safety, light, and feasting within. *"Outer darkness"* was a Jewish metaphor for missing out on blessings (e.g., Deuteronomy 28:29) or being left outside the celebration—not executed or tortured, but distanced.

Likewise, Paul writes about those who will be spared, *"but only as through fire"* (1 Corinthians 3:15)—they suffer loss, but are not condemned forever. They are still alive, yet without honor, reward, or inheritance.

The final judgment, then, is not simply a binary verdict of paradise or inferno, but a revelation of the quality of each life—its fruit, its faithfulness, its alignment with God's love. Resurrection is God's free gift to all, but reward is to be earned and based on how we lived.

Gaining Rewards in Heaven

> *Who, then, is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?*
>
> (Matthew 18:1)

Knowledge of the Bible is crucial, yet countless Christians can quote verses, recite creeds, and defend doctrine with the speed of a trained lawyer—yet their lives remain anxious, angry, judgmental, fearful, or spiritually dry. But from time to time, you get to meet Christians with very little theological knowledge whose lives radiate peace, kindness, mercy, courage, and generosity. Here is a simple truth: God is far more interested in the kind of person you are becoming than in the amount of religious information you can memorize and recite. Biblical faith was never meant to be a trivia contest. Faith is a way of living, a way of becoming whole and one with God. That's exactly what God is looking for in His followers. The point is transformation, not information.

In Second Temple Judaism, the role of a rabbi was not simply to accumulate knowledge or deliver theoretical teachings. His role was to embody divine truth—to live it out so fully that his own life became the lesson. That's why ancient rabbis didn't hide away in ivory towers and only appear once a week behind a pulpit for a 45-minute sermon. They *lived* with their disciples. They walked, ate, traveled, prayed, debated, and experienced the world alongside them. The goal was formation, not information—shaping not just minds, but entire lives. Of course, some rabbis did better (Acts 5:34–40), while others did worse (Matthew 23:13–37).

Yeshua—the Jewish rabbi from Nazareth—fulfilled this calling more perfectly than anyone in history. He didn't simply preach truth; He incarnated it. His disciples didn't attend His weekly lectures; they followed Him everywhere for years. They watched how He spoke to the broken, how He challenged the proud, how He healed the wounded, and how He lived every moment before God.

Jesus didn't merely teach the way of God. He *was* the way of God—embodied, lived, breathed, and shared in real time with those who walked beside Him.

And it was the mission of His disciples—and ours today—to learn and reflect that kind of faith. This is what God is testing us for: a faith that isn't just theoretical or abstract, but lived out in every part of life. When we follow Christ's way—with generosity, peace, kindness, patience, humility, forgiveness, mercy, courage, and compassion—we enter into the kind of life God loves to bless.

A life shaped by such faith has no need to fear judgment or condemnation, because it already participates in the very life of the Kingdom. This is the faith Jesus modeled, the faith the apostles practiced, and the faith we are called to embody; not a checklist of doctrines, but a way of being in the world that reflects the heart of God.

Only then does Paul's famous line about "no condemnation" begin to make sense.

No Condemnation to Them Which Are in Christ Jesus

> *There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus*

(Romans 8:1a)

Contrary to how this verse is often quoted, Paul isn't talking about someone who simply agrees intellectually with a doctrinal statement of belief. He speaks of those who *live* in alignment with Christ—whose *lives* reflect His Spirit, His values, and His way of love.

"*In* Christ" isn't about reciting a prayer from a pamphlet, but about embracing an active way of living.

How do I know? Because of the second part of the verse that's so often left out:

> *There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus,* ***who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit.***
>
> (Romans 8:1)

In Scripture, "flesh" refers to *selfishness*. Those who live "according to the flesh" focus inward on themselves, while those who live "according to the Spirit" show love outward toward others (Galatians 5:14, 22–23). Living in a Christlike way is what truly brings blessing and keeps us from condemnation. Condemnation

rests on selfishness, not on those who walk in love. Selfish people often steal, lie, exploit, and abuse, which is why selfishness itself is met with condemnation—sometimes in very real ways, like penalties, fines, or imprisonment.

However, *Condemnation* does not mean "In the future after you die, you'll burn in hellfire forever!" but rather to live under the weight of guilt, shame, judgment, sanction, alienation, fear, and spiritual drought—the condition of estrangement from God's blessings and peace.

I've met both Christians and non-Christians who embody divine values, living lives that mirror the compassion and truth of Jesus. Yet it is expected of Christians—those who profess to follow Him—to hold themselves to a higher standard of love, the kind of love Jesus Himself demonstrated (James 3:1, Luke 12:48). Sadly, that is not always the case. And I'm not here to cast stones—lest I be found guilty as well.

True Faith Loves

There are few passages in the New Testament as blunt, as piercing, and as disruptive to comfortable religion as the second chapter of James. This is not theology in a seminar. This is theology in the street. In the hospital. In

the prison. In the eyes of the one begging at your feet.

James begins with a question that should shake every modern believer:

> *What good is it, my brothers and sisters, if someone claims to have faith but has no deeds?*
>
> (James 2:14)

On judgment day, God will not ask for your statement of faith—what you believed—He will ask what your belief produced. He tests your heart, not your knowledge.

Faith, in this passage, is not a mental checklist. It is a living force that manifests itself in love. Anything less is counterfeit. James offers a concrete example:

> *Suppose a brother or a sister is without clothes and daily food. If one of you says to them, "Go in peace; keep warm and well fed," but does nothing about their physical needs, what good is it?*
>
> (James 2:15-16)

Here, faith and salvation come together in real life. Both are real and practical. Salvation means being rescued from a terrible situation, and faith is the action behind it, not just mentally agreeing in your head. James paints a striking picture: someone offering kind words, prayers, blessings, even spiritual-sounding comfort—yet doing nothing to actually help the person in need. That's not just weak faith. It's empty. Pointless. James calls it what it is:

> *Faith by itself, if it is not accompanied by action, is dead.*
>
> (James 2:17)

And then comes the challenge, sharp as a sword:

> *Show me your faith without deeds, and I will show you my faith by what I do.*
>
> (James 2:18)

Here lies the heart of the matter. Faith, if real, must be visible. It must incarnate itself. It must walk and weep and wash feet. You can't preach Christ crucified while ignoring the suffering of the poor right in front of you.

Evangelism, in this sense, is not about handing out tracts or shouting through a megaphone. Evangelism is feeding the hungry, visiting the imprisoned, forgiving your enemy, and loving your neighbor.

James goes on to draw from the stories of Abraham and Rahab—two people whose righteousness was not a private intellectual thought but a risk-taking, sacrificial response to God's call. Abraham was willing to offer even his son. Rahab—a prostitute—protected spies at the risk of her own life. Their faith was not just declared—it was demonstrated.

Not What You Know, But What You Do

> *As the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without deeds is dead.*
>
> (James 2:26)

This isn't about works-based salvation. It's the contrast between lifeless doctrine—mere intellectual belief—and the kind of biblical faith that breathes, moves, and nourishes.

To say you follow Jesus, and yet turn away from the person in need, the hungry, the hurting, and the forgotten, is not just a contradiction. According to James—it is a corpse.

Genuine faith—the kind Jesus spoke of—naturally produces love. James makes this unmistakably clear: a "faith" that utters pious words to the poor while refusing to lift a finger to help is no faith at all—it's just Gnosticism. The proof of living faith is not theological sharpness, not isolation from the world, not winning arguments on social media—but concrete acts of love!

> *The only thing that counts is faith expressing itself through love.*
>
> (Galatians 5:6)

Yes, acts of love are what God is after. God has never been impressed by ceremonial precision or doctrinal correctness. Through Isaiah, He bluntly declared that He hates empty rituals divorced from justice, mercy, and compassion (Isaiah 1:13–17; 58:5–7).

The New Testament makes it clear that faith is shown through love (Galatians 5:6). When love fades, any intellectual defense of any "salvation" doctrine has already missed the point.

The Illusion of Control

Jesus of Nazareth was not merely a moral teacher or mystic; He was a first-century Jewish rabbi who perfectly embodied the unity between heaven and earth—between God's transcendent domain and our human condition. As such, He exposed the fundamental obstacle that keeps us from experiencing that divine unity: the ego. The self-centered drive to secure *our* future by accumulating wealth, status, and control is what distances us from inheriting the Kingdom.

That's why Jesus said:

Do not store up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moth and rust consume and where thieves break in and steal. But store up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where neither moth nor rust consumes and where thieves do not break in and steal.

(Matthew 6:19–20)

Everyone accumulates something. We gather possessions, build savings, chase influence—not because we're evil and greedy, but because these things offer a seductive illusion—a sense of security that we are safe, strong, and in control. Yet Jesus shatters this illusion. Earthly treasure, He warns, is fragile. It decays, disappears, and ultimately disappoints. As you came naked from your mother's womb, so you will depart, taking nothing with you (Job 1:21).

Treasure in heaven is not stored by amassing wealth on earth, nor by memorizing Bible verses. It is stored by self-giving—by how much of yourself you pour out for the sake of others. He tests your heart, not your knowledge.

Conclusion

Jesus invites us into an economy radically unlike the one we know—an eternal economy where love is the currency, mercy is the measure, and faithfulness is the true wealth. "Store up treasures in heaven," He says, not because heaven is far away, but because this way of living aligns us with what endures. Everything else fades. Possessions rust. Status dissolves. Control slips through our fingers. But love—lived, practiced, given away—remains.

The Kingdom of God is not secured by fear, nor entered by intellectual mastery. It is revealed in lives poured out for others. Treasure is gathered not by what we accumulate, but by what we surrender. Not by what we know, but by how deeply we love. This is why Jesus ties judgment to fruit, reward to faithfulness, and life to self-giving. Resurrection awaits all, but the quality of that resurrection—the joy, the honor, the nearness—will reflect the kind of life we chose to live.

What we have loved, whom we have served, how we have walked—these are the only things that follow us.

True faith, according to James, is expressed in acts of love. We are "saved" because God has saved humanity through Christ. But it is through faith—not intellectual assent, but the lived, embodied faith James describes—that we store up treasure and inherit the Kingdom of God.

This is the paradox of the Kingdom. To lose is to gain. To give is to receive. To surrender is to be secure. And when we live this way—walking in love, justice, humility, and compassion—we discover that the life to come has already begun, and the treasures of heaven are being stored even now.

Chapter 48

The Path to Kingdom Greatness

Israel's prophets longed and prophesied for the day when God would bring about the world's final restoration. Isaiah's hope was not for escape, but for a healed world (Isaiah 11:6–9, 65:17–25, 66:22–23)—the reality known as *"Tikkun Olam."* A time when swords would be beaten into plowshares and *"nation shall not take up sword against nation, nor will they train for war anymore"* (Isaiah 2:4).

Here's something easy to miss: if nations will no longer fight, it means they still exist in the age to come. God's future isn't about wiping out diversity but about reconciling all peoples—a world made new, not erased. The existence of nations suggests there will still be structure and roles.

Likewise, when Jesus and Paul spoke of the world to come, they too described a reality with roles, responsibilities, and authority (see, for example: Luke 19:17–19; 1 Corinthians 6:2–3; Revelation 21:24–26). The New Creation—the New Jerusalem, the age that follows—will be much like this one but finally healed and set right. Nations, cultures, function, purpose, and community will remain.

But the Kingdom of God is truly "upside-down"—those who are last today might be first tomorrow, because greatness is measured by faithfulness, humility, and love—attributes that can be demonstrated no matter what condition your life is in right now. That's why this present life is not a meaningless prelude, but a holy preparation—a kind of audition for the age to come. Every moment, every choice, and every act of love or sacrifice shapes your path toward your heavenly calling. But take heart: to qualify for this "job," you don't need a suit or seminary degree. God isn't looking for resumes or accolades—He's searching for hearts that are humble, merciful, and faithful.

This life is not only an audition but also your training ground. Let every day prepare you—not with ambition or anxiety, but with hope, integrity, and love. For in God's kingdom, the qualities that matter most are the ones the world often cares about least.

It's Not About Your Religious Affiliation

Your faith and actions do not determine whether you will be resurrected—that is something God has already secured. But they do shape the quality of your life, both now and, perhaps even more importantly, in the age to come. This life, then, is not an audition for whether you get to live again, but for how deeply you will experience that life.

Make no mistake: you are not judged by the denomination you belong to. In fact, Jesus did not come to establish a new religion. He showed little interest in religious systems for their own sake; to Him, they were secondary—seasoning, not the meal itself. What He came to bring was something far greater: the Way, the Truth, and the Life—familiar Jewish and biblical expressions that described a way of living aligned with the heart of God (cf. Psalm 1:6; Jeremiah 6:16).

Religion so often fixates on appearances—rules, rituals, regulations, penalties, and outward conformity. Jesus, by contrast, came to redeem what lies beneath the surface. He came to heal hearts, renew minds, and restore the broken places within us that no external system of control or discipline could ever reach.

In other words: you do not glorify God by merely attending a weekly gathering, singing songs, and listening to a lecture. That, by itself, does not move His heart. Christ showed us what true worship looks like: forgiving those who wrong us, loving our enemies, defending the vulnerable, and caring for the poor, the orphan, and the widow. That is holiness. That is worship. That is the Kingdom of God made visible.

And here is the liberating truth: you do not need a religion, a denomination, or an institution to live this way. You can live this out even if you're on a remote island or in prison with nothing but fellow inmates around you. You need only to walk the path Jesus revealed—loving kindness, justice, and faithfulness—because this is what truly honors God.

If you are part of a faith community—and you should be, as Hebrews 10:25 encourages—make sure it is a healthy one: a place where you can both give and receive, grow and heal, serve and be cared for, and where you would feel at peace inviting others to encounter the beauty of God's Kingdom.

And if you are not yet part of such a community, choose wisely. Not every smiling, energetic, "spirit-filled" environment is healthy. Some of the most toxic, manipulative, abusive, and spiritually damaging communities hide behind friendly faces, polished worship, dramatic lighting, pretty websites, striking newsletters, dramatic video clips, and impressive branding. And I say this from personal experience. [145]

A true community of faith cultivates freedom, not control; healing, not fear; love, not judgment.

Don't Waste Your Life

Don't spend your life trapped in hollow religion that leads only to anxiety, isolation, fear, depression, and emptiness.

Since there are over 49,000 Christian church groups in the world, then there are, in practice, 49,000 variations of the Gospel—each with its own emphasis, culture, theology, and traditions. Some are compassionate; others are controlling. Some reflect the humility of Christ; others, the pride of man. So how can you tell whether the version of the gospel being preached to you is anywhere close to the real thing?

Well, I hope my book offered you at least a few clues. But there is an even simpler test: *test the fruit.*

Does it produce love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control (Galatians 5:22–23)?

Does it set the oppressed free, lift up the brokenhearted, heal the soul, and reconcile enemies?

Does it draw you closer to a loving Father?

Or does it breed fear, shame, and religious anxiety?

Does it bind consciences, crush the wounded, harden hearts, and divide people from one another?

Does it push you away from God—into dread, self-loathing, and a god you cannot fully trust or love?

The true gospel leads to life. Life means blessings and transformation—not just of intellect, but of heart, character, and relationships. If what you're hearing doesn't sound like good news to the weary, the wounded, and the wandering, then it's not the Gospel He preached.

It's not rare to meet someone who speaks eloquently about Jesus, defends every line of doctrine, and claims unwavering piety—yet whose life shows no sign of Christ's Spirit. They may win debates, quote Scripture, and defend orthodoxy with zeal. But if their hearts are ruled by pride, their tone by condescension, their character by unkindness and lack of compassion, and their actions by fear, control, anxiety, or cruelty—then let us not be deceived: they may speak about Christ, they may even wear a cross on their neck, but they are not walking with Him.

For the true mark of the Holy Spirit is not merely intellectual accuracy—it is the transformation of the heart. Yes, a wrong understanding can certainly shape distorted ideas about God's will and nature. But wherever the Spirit is genuinely at work, the character of Jesus begins to take root and grow within a person.

Even if you're a new believer who hasn't even read the Bible yet, you can still recognize whether the "gospel" you hear is truly from God and whether a faith community you're considering genuinely reflects Christ. The Spirit reveals this through character:

Humility replaces arrogance.

Gentleness disarms harshness.

Peace quiets fear.

Love casts out judgment.

Compassion crosses boundaries.

Patience softens impatience.

Kindness overtakes cruelty.

These aren't just spiritual accessories or decorative touches; they're the proof of true biblical faith. Where these fruits show up, the Spirit is there. And when they're missing—no matter what beliefs are spoken or how "theologically correct" someone appears—the Spirit isn't at work.

Let's be honest: a gospel that leads to hard hearts, judgmental spirits, and a condescending attitude isn't the gospel of Jesus. A "truth" that makes someone more self-righteous, more divisive, more fearful and controlling —is not the good news that sets us free.

Conclusion

The greatest miracle of the Spirit is not speaking in tongues or memorizing complete chapters—it is loving your enemy. Forgiving your betrayer. Embracing the outcast. Because following in the footsteps of our Rabbi-Messiah means more than admiring Him from a distance or with your tongue; it means *becoming* like Him.

This is the Spirit's purpose: to transform people and form communities where heaven's love touches earth's wounds, where people don't just believe in God intellectually but embody Him. A people who make the invisible God visible.

Let's not measure our faith by how loudly we declare it, but by how profoundly it transforms us. In the end, God won't ask how many verses we could recite or tracts we passed out, but who we became and whose lives we touched. Those whose hearts and lives reflect the Spirit of the Son will be richly rewarded.

Chapter 49

God's Kingdom is Upside-Down

The Jewish disciples of Jesus argued often—but never about who would "get saved" and who would burn forever. That question simply was not on their radar. Their debates revolved around something entirely different: Who is the *greatest* in the kingdom?

For them, reality was not a binary system of insiders and outsiders, heaven and hellfire. It was a spectrum—a question of rank, honor, and responsibility within God's reign. These young Jewish men had no formal "Doctrine of Soteriology," nor did they imagine salvation as rescue from an angry God or from a cosmic furnace

designed to melt their skin for eternity. Such ideas appear nowhere in their Hebrew Torah and played no role in their spiritual imagination.

Instead, they were preoccupied with how to please God, how to live faithfully, and how to rise in status within His coming kingdom. Their concern was not whether they belonged, but *how* they would belong—what kind of people they would become, and what place they would hold when God set the world right:

> *At that time the disciples came to Jesus, saying, "Who is the **greatest** in the kingdom of heaven?" And calling to him a child, he put him in the midst of them and said, "Truly, I say to you, unless you turn and **become like children**, you will never **enter** the kingdom of heaven. Whoever humbles himself like this child is the **greatest** in the kingdom of heaven."*
>
> (Matthew 18:1-4)

Jesus often taught using antithesis—placing contrasting ideas side by side to sharpen their meaning. In this framework, *"**entering** the kingdom"* corresponds to being *"**great** in the kingdom,"* while not entering

corresponds to being least in the kingdom. The contrast is not between heaven and hellfire, but between honor and loss, participation and exclusion, fullness and forfeiture.

In other words, the opposite of greatness in the kingdom is not Eternal Conscious Torment—it is missing out. It is being outside the celebration, away from the banquet table, beyond the walls when night falls. It is the grief of exclusion, not the agony of flames. Jesus' imagery consistently points to loss of reward, status, and joy—not unending punishment. The faithful receive crowns, medals, and honors (1 Corinthians 9:24–25; 2 Timothy 4:7–8; James 1:12; 1 Peter 5:4; Revelation 2:10; Revelation 3:11); the unfaithful forfeit them.

To grasp this, Jesus insists we must become like children. Children do not live in terror that their parents will burn or kill them. But they do long to please them. They want to be praised, affirmed, and embraced. They strive—not out of fear—but out of trust, affection, and desire for approval.

By calling His disciples to become like children, Jesus exposes the true nature of kingdom motivation. Greatness is not achieved through power, status, theological sophistication, or self-sufficiency. It flows from humility, dependence, trust, and an open, teachable heart. Adults cling to control and hierarchy; children know they need guidance. Adults posture; children receive.

Jesus' message is clear: the kingdom is not governed by terror but by love, not by threat but by invitation. True greatness is not earned through dominance or fear-driven obedience, but through humble faith—and the joyful desire to live in a way that delights the Father.

To Be Called Great in the Kingdom of Heaven

> *Therefore whoever relaxes one of the least of these commandments and teaches others to do the same will be called* ***least*** *in the kingdom of heaven, but whoever does them and teaches them will be called* ***great*** *in the kingdom of heaven.*
>
> (Matthew 5:19)

Want to be *great* in the kingdom? Then follow Jesus' commandments. But what were they? Was it waking up at 5 a.m. every morning to pray and read a devotional? Never missing church on Sunday? Shutting yourself away from the "evil" world? No.

Instead of complicated theological language, Christ spoke in a simple, straightforward way—like explaining something to a child—laying out His commandments over three chapters:

— Always reconcile with people. (Matthew 5:24).

— Settle matters quickly with your adversary. (Matthew 5:25).

— Speak the truth. (Matthew 5:37).

— Don't take revenge. (Matthew 5:39).

— Be generous. (Matthew 5:42).

— Love your enemy. (Matthew 5:44).

— Stay humble. (Matthew 6:1).

— Give to the needy. (Matthew 6:4).

— Pray and seek justice. (Matthew 6:9-10).

— Abstain from evil. (Matthew 6:23).

— Do not worry. (Matthew 6:25).

— Do not be judgmental. (Matthew 7:1).

— Do not settle for shallow, empty religion. (Matthew 7:7-8).

And so on...

That's how one becomes great in His kingdom, and this is why Jesus summarized the Law and prophets as loving God with all your heart—and explained that you love Him by loving your neighbor. Then, Jesus redefined "neighbor" to include everyone, even your enemy (e.g., The Parable of the Good Samaritan—Luke 10:25-37).

Jesus wasn't a woke activist—He was a strong Jewish rabbi. For Him, love was never a sentimental "yippie" feeling or a fleeting emotion. Love was concrete. It was expressed through real acts of sacrifice, care, kindness, truth, justice, and compassion toward all people—even those who did not deserve it.

Love is what impresses God and moves His heart; thus, the ability to love is what makes someone truly great in the kingdom (Matthew 22:37–39, John 13:34–35, 1 Corinthians 13:13, Galatians 5:14, and 1 John 4:7–8).

It is Grace that will resurrect you, but how you *love* determines the reward and joy you'll carry into the next life.

Not Just Blessings and Rewards—But Roles and Responsibilities

Kingdom greatness is not merely about receiving rewards and blessings in the age to come. God is preparing—and selecting—people for leadership. Life, in a very real sense, is an audition. God is choosing those who will govern, serve, and steward His future kingdom—not on the basis of religious titles, wealth, influence, or earthly power, but on the basis of Christlike character.

Jesus promised His faithful disciples that they would "sit on thrones" and even "judge angels." Authority, then, is part of the coming kingdom. But the decisive question is this: what kind of people will God trust with authority?

The qualities that matter to God are the very qualities Jesus embodied—humility, courage, compassion, integrity, generosity, steadfast love, justice, and mercy. These are the traits God looks for in those He entrusts with responsibility, both now and in the world to come.

Ask yourself honestly: if you were God, who would you trust to wield authority in your kingdom? Who would you appoint as leaders, judges, counselors, and caretakers of creation? Not the proud or the oppressive. Not the ruthless or the self-promoting. But the teachable, the gentle, the compassionate, the just, and the merciful—those who reflect the heart of Jesus.

The disciples once argued among themselves about who was the greatest. Jesus did not rank them or settle the debate with hierarchy. Instead, He wrapped a towel around His waist and washed their feet. In that single act, He redefined greatness forever. In God's economy, greatness is not dominance but servanthood. It is not intellect, status, or force—but humility expressed through love.

Christ's kingdom is not a continuation of the beastly empires of this world. It is their complete reversal. That is why Jesus declared, "The last will be first, and the first will be last." The CEOs, presidents, generals,

and celebrities of this age may find themselves far from the front of the line, while unseen caregivers, quiet peacemakers, and faithful servants are crowned with honor and entrusted with leadership.

The world promotes the loudest, the strongest, and the richest. God looks for those who love deeply, serve quietly, and lead with grace.

That is why the Kingdom of God has always been—and will always be—the upside-down kingdom.

Faith Is a Calling—Not to Privilege

The more light you receive, the more responsibility you bear. Scripture is explicit: we are judged according to the light given to us (Luke 12:47–48; James 4:17). A child raised in North Korea is not held to the same standard as a pastor raised in a Christian home in America, surrounded by Scripture, teaching, and freedom. A Christian—one who claims allegiance to the crucified Lord—cannot plead ignorance. The better you know Christ, the more you are called to reflect Him.

And what did He reveal? Radical compassion. Relentless forgiveness. Abundant mercy. Courageous truth-telling. A life poured out for the poor, the outcast, and the oppressed.

Greater knowledge brings greater accountability. If you know what Jesus taught—if you know you are called to love, including your enemies; to care for the poor, the wounded, and the forgotten—but choose not to live it, Scripture does not threaten you with Eternal Conscious Torment. It warns you of real loss: forfeited reward, diminished glory, squandered vocation in the age to come.

To walk with Jesus is not an elevation to privilege; it is an invitation to responsibility. In the Kingdom of God, greatness is not measured by doctrinal mastery but by love embodied. Not by how refined your theology sounds, but by how worn your hands are from serving others. Revelation always increases accountability. This is a consistent biblical pattern: *"From everyone who has been given much, much will be required."* (Luke 12:48).

With revelation comes responsibility. If you claim His name while neglecting the poor, marginalizing the broken, or weaponizing religion to spread fear and division, you have missed the heart of the Gospel. Worse still, you may lose what you were meant to gain. Knowledge without love, as Paul warned, is nothing but noise (1 Corinthians 13:1). In God's Kingdom, theology without mercy is spiritually bankrupt.

True Greatness Redefined

In Matthew 20:20–28, when the mother of James and John requests thrones of glory for her sons, Jesus gently corrects her. The path to glory, He says, is paved with sacrifice and service. *"Whoever would be great among you must be your servant."*

In Luke 22:24–30, when His disciples argue over status, Jesus reverses the logic of the world: *"Let the greatest among you become as the least, and the leader as one who serves."* Leadership in the Kingdom is not about control but self-giving love.

In Matthew 5:12, Jesus comforts those persecuted for righteousness, not with escape, but with reward: *"Rejoice and be glad, for your reward is great in heaven."* Kingdom reward is not for the comfortable, but for the courageous. Don't allow fear to become your glass ceiling.

As Paul neared death, he wrote with confidence: *"I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race... there is laid up for me the crown of righteousness"* (2 Timothy 4:7–8). Not because he was perfect, but because he endured in love.

In Revelation 2:26, Jesus promises that those who remain faithful will share in His authority—*"to the one who conquers, I will give authority over the nations."* And in Revelation 22:12, His final promise is also a warning: *"Behold, I am coming soon, bringing my recompense with me, to repay each one for what he has done."*

The New Testament's idea of reward and greatness isn't about earning a place in heaven, but about reflecting its values here and now. Sacrificial love is the currency of the Kingdom. It's how we store treasure in heaven—not by stockpiling religious rituals or moral superiority, but by embodying the same self-giving love that Christ demonstrated.

Conclusion

So, who will be *great* in the Kingdom?

Not the ones who mastered theology, won debates, or never missed church service—but those who fed the hungry, clothed the naked, visited the imprisoned, forgave the undeserving, and embraced the broken. Those who truly lived like the King.

In the end, the places of greatest honor in the Kingdom do not belong to those who merely believed the right things, but to those who became most like Him.

Chapter 50

Then What's the Point in Evangelizing?

A common objection is raised: "If everyone will eventually be redeemed, then why evangelize at all?"

During an Iranian missile attack on Israel in June 2025, sirens tore through the air and panic erupted. My wife and I, along with the rest of the crowd, hurried frantically to find safety. With us, those caught outside rushed into the nearest bomb shelter across from us, desperate to survive. In the midst of the chaos, one family —ironically a Christian family—became visibly agitated. They insisted that only residents of nearby buildings

should be allowed inside, not random people from the street. They demanded that the doors be shut and locked against "outsiders."

Later, I sat with one of them. He was still shaken from the situation and also angry that strangers had sought refuge in what he perceived as *their* shelter. I told him I understood practical limits; sometimes shelters truly do become overcrowded and unsafe. But this one wasn't full. There was still room. What I sensed wasn't logistics—it was an emotional barricade.

So I asked him gently, "Don't you care about those people? If the door had been closed and they were killed by the missile, how would you feel?"

He answered flatly, almost hollowly, ***"I don't feel anything anymore."***

I paused, then asked, *"Why? Something must have happened to you."*

His eyes immediately filled with tears. *"I did something terrible when I was young and stupid,"* he said. *"Since then, I don't feel anything. I stopped caring."*

Now return to the question: Why preach the gospel if every knee will eventually bow?

Like a good Jew, I'll answer the question with another: Does the gospel still matter to someone like my neighbor across the street?

Does it matter to a soul that feels shattered, numb, almost dead inside? Can the Good News—*that he is already forgiven in Christ, without conditions*—begin to thaw a heart frozen by shame and self-loathing? Can

the gospel breathe life into someone who feels like a walking corpse? Or is it merely a message about where you go after you die?

And what about the Jewish mothers whose children were kidnapped and murdered on October 7, 2023? Or the Palestinian mothers who buried their babies? Does the gospel matter to them? Can the proclamation that death will not have the final word—that all will be raised and live again—restore even a fragment of hope to hearts crushed by grief? Does the promise of reunion matter? Does it heal? Does it sustain?

This is why we evangelize: so *"that they may have life, and that they may have it more abundantly."* (John 10:10).

Not to scare people into heaven, but to awaken the dead now. Not to threaten with Eternal Conscious Torment, but to announce life. The gospel is not a message reserved for the afterlife; it is a medicine for the present. It tells the numb they are not beyond healing, the guilty they are not beyond forgiveness, and the grieving that love has not been erased by death.

If the gospel is true, then it is not merely about where we end up—it is about who we are becoming. And that makes all the difference in the world.

Is God truly so narrow and selective that the gospel belongs only to a small, enlightened elite—as so many assume—or is the Good News actually *good news for all*, especially for the grieving, the traumatized, the lost, the searching, and the broken?

If the gospel is nothing more than a ticket out of hell in the afterlife, then it is useless to those who are already living in hell now. And yet, those are precisely the people Christ came for. Listen to Isaiah's vision of the Messiah:

> *The Spirit of the Sovereign LORD is upon me, for the LORD has anointed me to bring* ***good news to the poor****; He has sent me to* ***bind up the brokenhearted****, to proclaim* ***freedom to the captives and release from darkness to the prisoners****, to announce the year of the LORD's favor and the day of His justice,* ***to comfort all who mourn*** *and to* ***provide for those who grieve*** *in Zion—****bestowing on them a crown of beauty instead of ashes, the oil of joy instead of mourning****, and a* ***garment of praise instead of a spirit of despair****; they will be called oaks of righteousness, a planting of the LORD, for the display of His splendor.*
>
> (Isaiah 61:1-3)

When the Very Question Exposes the Misunderstanding

But the very fact that we wrestle with this objection at all exposes how far the Western gospel has drifted from its first-century roots. The questions we instinctively ask betray a deep disconnect between the life-giving, present-tense gospel proclaimed by Jesus and His apostles and the diminished version many have inherited—a subtly gnostic gospel fixated on escapism and the afterlife rather than transformation here and now.

The point of sharing the gospel was never to "save" people from falling into a cosmic fire pit after death. The gospel exists to rescue people from the hell in which they are already living. It is about offering real hope to the hurting, direction to the lost, and healing to the broken. It awakens compassion where numbness has taken over and breathes life where the soul has gone cold.

The gospel is not merely a promise deferred to the future; it is an invitation into wholeness now—to stand upright, to breathe again, to live as we were created to live. That is why we proclaim it, even if God's mercy ultimately reaches everyone: because people need to be saved from the hell that grips them today.

So Why Should You Evangelize?

You evangelize because you want people to truly live and live abundantly.

You evangelize because healed hearts heal others.

You evangelize because forgiven people forgive.

You evangelize because the Prince of Peace has come into the world—and through Him peace can be made even with enemies.

You evangelize because to know Jesus is to overflow with the life He gives—a life that cannot help but spill outward.

You evangelize because you love, and love cannot sit still.

Evangelism is not recruitment into a cosmic survival bunker. It's an invitation into the healing flood of God's restoration.

We evangelize because we have tasted something beautiful—and beauty demands to be shared.

We evangelize because we have seen the face of love—and love demands to be reflected.

We evangelize because the Kingdom of God is not just something we wait for—it is something we build, one act of kindness, one word of truth, one spark of mercy at a time.

Evangelizing for a Better Society

The beauty of the gospel is that it was never meant to stop at the level of private belief or individual spirituality. From the beginning, its horizon has been public, communal, and even cosmic. Jesus spoke of a kingdom—not merely a personal rescue plan—and Acts tells us that this message was meant to spread outward, reshaping lives, communities, and nations (e.g., Matthew 28:19–20, Mark 16:15, Acts 1:8). Wherever the gospel has taken root in its fullness, it has carried with it a vision of human dignity, moral responsibility, justice tempered by mercy, and the worth of every person made in the image of God.

Now consider the world beyond the West. Have you ever been to Syria, Afghanistan, North Korea, Sudan, Iran, Gaza, or Yemen? These are places scarred by tyranny, endless cycles of violence, suppression of conscience, and the crushing of the weak. This is not a matter of cultural superiority, but of moral contrast. Societies shaped by Judeo-Christian values—however imperfectly—have tended to cultivate ideas that many now take for granted:

the sanctity of human life, limits on state power, care for the poor, the dignity of women and children, and the idea that rulers themselves are accountable to a higher moral law.

The gospel challenges injustice not only in hearts but in systems. It confronts cruelty, tribalism, and oppression wherever they appear. It insists that power exists to serve, not to dominate; that truth matters; that love of neighbor is not optional; and that the strong are responsible for the weak. These ideas did not arise naturally in human history—they were seeded, slowly and often painfully, by a worldview rooted in the Hebrew Scriptures and embodied in the life of Jesus.

To say that the gospel is only about personal salvation is to shrink it far below its biblical scope. It is not merely about where an individual goes after death; it is about what happens to the world while we are alive. It is a message meant to humanize societies, restrain evil, inspire compassion, and cultivate justice. When received rightly, it does not erase cultures, but heals them—calling every nation to become more humane, more just, and more aligned with the goodness for which humanity was created.

The gospel, at its best, is not an escape from the world. It is God's invitation to remake it.

But Wouldn't People "Backslide" Without the Threat of Endless Hellfire?

Some would argue that preaching hellfire is necessary to demonstrate God's justice. But in the apostolic era, God's justice was demonstrated in Christ's victory over sin, death, and evil—not in the perpetual torment and suffering of souls. God's justice was about setting things right, healing creation, and *"reconciling the world to Himself"* (2 Corinthians 5:19).

Discipline, loss of rewards, and correction are still unpleasant, even if the punishment is only temporary. But the idea that Christians would "backslide" into terrible behavior without the looming threat of burning forever not only paints a grim picture of God but is also both logically and morally flawed.

If the only thing preventing someone from committing evil is the fear of Eternal Conscious Torment, then we're not talking about righteousness—we're talking about restraint. That's not transformation; it's just wickedness kept on a leash. Is that what Christianity is all about?

The God of the Hebrew Scriptures doesn't manipulate with terror—He draws with *chesed* (lovingkindness). Grounding morality in existential fear undermines the very heart of the Gospel. The teachings and life of Jesus embody this: not a religion of fear, but a way of life rooted in mercy, truth, justice, and love.

Genuine faith is not driven by fear but by love, compassion, and a desire to do what is right. A relationship with God grounded in terror does not foster trust, growth, or genuine devotion. Fear may produce temporary compliance, but it cannot produce love—and love is exactly what God asks of us: *"Love the Lord your God… and love your neighbor as yourself"* (Deuteronomy 6:5; Leviticus 19:18; see also Matthew 22:37–39).

Religion Motivated by Fear vs. Faith Inspired by Love

Take my Jewish friends—religious and secular alike—as a living example. Many of them follow a rigorous moral vision shaped by Jewish ethics. They give generously, often to complete strangers. They sacrifice for the sake of others. They work toward justice and peace—not because they fear hellfire, but because it is the right thing to do. Their lives alone dismantle the claim that morality depends on the threat of Eternal Conscious Torment.

If your moral behavior requires the menace of unending punishment to keep you in line, then love is not what motivates you—fear is. At that point, morality is not transformed character but external control. Strip away the threat, and the virtue collapses. That is not faith; it is coercion. It is obedience on a leash.

Genuine faith has never been about avoiding punishment. It is about becoming like the One who forgives, heals, restores, and loves to the very end. It is about internal transformation, not external terror.

As we saw at the beginning of this book, the apostles did not evangelize by threatening people with flames. They proclaimed Jesus—His resurrection, His fulfillment of Israel's hope, His call to turn from idols, His offer of forgiveness and blessing, and His promise of honor and life in God's restored world for those who are faithful. They appealed to hope, not horror; to life, not fear; to transformation, not terror.

Fear may restrain behavior. Only love can redeem a soul.

Conclusion

Evangelism, then, is not about scaring people into heaven. It is about proclaiming the goodness of God, the beauty of Christ, the power of His resurrection, and the hope of transformation. It is about inviting all people to

step into the abundant life God offers here and now—and in the world to come. It's about proclaiming life over death, healing over brokenness, light over darkness. It's about inviting people to live the life they were created for—now and forever.

Hellfire was never the driving force of Apostolic evangelism. Life was. And it still should be today.

Chapter 51

Becoming an Ambassador of God's Kingdom

If you consider yourself a true disciple of Christ, it's also your responsibility to help care for God's flock. Just like in Jesus' time, some may be stubborn, irritating, or even outright foolish, but you're called to shepherd them with love. To follow Christ is not merely to confess His name. It is to carry His heart—and take up His cross.

Taking up your cross is not accomplished by defending doctrine on social media. It is about love in action. It's about aligning your life with the sacrifice, compassion, justice, and mercy of Jesus. And you cannot do that while walking past the poor, the hurting, the oppressed, and the forgotten.

In Matthew 25, Jesus gives us a startling glimpse into what final judgment looks like—and it's not based on how well we articulated a statement of faith, but on how we treated "the least of these":

> *"For I was hungry and you gave me something to eat, I was thirsty and you gave me something to drink, I was a stranger and you invited me in, I needed clothes and you clothed me, I was sick and you looked after me, I was in prison and you came to visit me." Then the righteous will answer him, "Lord, when did we see you hungry and feed you...?" And the King will reply, "Truly I tell you, whatever you did for one of the least of these brothers and sisters of mine, you did for me."*
>
> (Matthew 25:35–40)

These words strip Christianity down to its core: Love. Kindness. Compassion. They leave no room for performative religion or self-righteous faith. Jesus doesn't ask if we accepted Him into our hearts or recited the sinner's prayer. He asks if we saw Him in the faces of the broken, the invisible, and the outcast, and responded with love.

To ignore “the least of these” is, according to Jesus, to ignore Him. To love them is to love Him.

Thus, taking up the cross means living in a way that mirrors His own sacrificial love. It means showing mercy to those the world forgets, welcoming the outcast, feeding the hungry, visiting the prisoner, and giving dignity to the downtrodden.

This is the gospel. Not just preached—but lived.

The Danger of Outsourcing Compassion

We live in a world of outsourcing. We outsource our meals to delivery apps. Our learning to TikTok videos. Our friendships to digital platforms. And—without realizing it—we’ve begun outsourcing our compassion.

"I give a tithe at church."

“I pay my taxes.”

“I give to charity.”

“There are social services for that.”

These phrases may sound responsible. But they often function as spiritual escape hatches—ways to quiet the conscience without engaging the heart. But Jesus never outsourced compassion. He didn't send angels to bind the wounds of the bleeding and the sick.

In His parable about the Samaritan—someone viewed as theologically impure, ethnically inferior, and socially suspect—it was the Samaritan, not the passing religious elite, who became the true reflection of God's heart.

Institutional help has its place. But it is often cold, bureaucratic, and transactional. It does not look someone in the eye. It does not sit with them in their pain. It does not call them by their first names.

And here is the tragedy: when we outsource compassion, we don't just rob them of love—we rob ourselves of transformation.

The shepherd isn't simply a role; it's a refining fire. It is only when we touch the wounds of another that we begin to be healed of our own indifference.

Caring for His sheep is not a task we perform once we've "mastered theology." It is theology in motion. It is faith with hands. It is Christ made visible not through sermons but through service.

Because the scariest danger isn't that we'll deny Christ with our words; It's that we'll deny Him with our inaction.

I'm not speaking of dropping coins into an addict's plastic cup to quietly fund their chains and enable their addiction. I'm speaking of offering a meal, a seat at the table, and a listening heart for their pain and struggle. If Jesus is absent from your actions, no pamphlet will make Him visible.

Why It Matters for You

This call to care for His underprivileged sheep isn't just for their sake. It's for yours.

Modern faith often assumes a dangerous lie: that obedience is a burden and love is a sacrifice made at our own expense. But the truth is more mysterious and beautiful: when we give ourselves to others, we are also given back to—renewed, expanded, awakened.

Acts of compassion are scientifically proven to reduce anxiety and depression, thus boost the immune system, and increase feelings of joy and purpose.[146, 147] Generosity activates pleasure centers in the brain. Helping others literally makes us happier. Better. Christ-like.

But beyond the neuroscience lies something deeper, something ancient: when we serve others, we are drawn closer to the heart of God. Helping the poor cultivates empathy—it stretches your soul to include another's pain. It nurtures gratitude—suddenly, the small becomes sacred.

It births humility—you realize how little separates you from the one in need. It grows faith—you begin to see God not in church buildings, but in broken people. In the cracks of society.

Jesus said, *"It is more blessed to give than to receive."* (Acts 20:35). This wasn't just poetic idealism. It was a blueprint for spiritual transformation.

You were not made to be a spectator of holiness. You were made to carry it. To touch others with it. And in doing so, you will find the Kingdom of God breaking forth not just in them, but in you.

Why It Matters for Them

We often think of poverty in material terms—lack of food, shelter, income. But poverty wears many faces. It is hunger, yes, but it is also loneliness. Abandonment. Shame. Guilt. Feeling unseen and unloved in a world that moves too fast to notice.

Institutions can feed a stomach. But only love can feed a soul.

A government agency may give food stamps. A church program may deliver groceries. But when you look someone in the eyes, smile at them, hug them, and choose to sit beside them rather than shy away from them—that is when dignity is restored. That is when someone begins to believe, maybe for the first time, that they are loved. They get to see Christ through you.

Not because they cleaned up. Not because they repented first. Not because they got their act together. But because there's a God who loves them so deeply, He sent someone like you to extend that love to them.

When you show up in someone's story—not as a superhero, but as a servant or friend—you become a living parable of grace. You become the whisper of God's compassion made flesh.

Many who have been helped by systems remain emotionally and spiritually untouched. But those who have been loved by a person—with consistency, humility, and kindness—are forever changed.

Because when you love someone personally, they stop being a "need" and start being a name. And in that place where heaven and earth meet, they encounter the Shepherd—not in theory, but through your hands.

Why It Matters for Society

We tend to treat compassion as something private—a personal virtue, a matter of individual character rather than a force capable of reshaping the world. History tells a very different story.

Every time compassion has moved from the margins to the center, societies have changed. Mountains have shifted. Entire civilizations have been redefined by people who chose love over indifference, presence over policy, neighborliness over nationalism. Yes, group identity matters. Laws and policies matter too—but only because they are meant to protect and serve human beings. The moment systems eclipse the people they exist for, they lose their moral legitimacy.

When Jesus called His followers to feed the hungry, clothe the naked, visit the imprisoned, and care for the sick, He was not offering a checklist for private piety. He was planting the seeds of a new world—the arrival of a kingdom where justice streams like a river and mercy falls gently like spring rain.

And this kind of world does not begin with politicians. It does not start with institutions or systems. It begins with people—fishermen, tax collectors, laborers, mothers, neighbors—ordinary individuals who see a stranger and choose to treat them as family. Because love, when practiced publicly, becomes contagious.

Children raised in homes where generosity is normal grow into adults who lead with kindness.

Churches that go out to serve rather than condemn become refuges for the wounded—not museums for the flawless.

Communities that value compassion over competition cultivate trust, safety, and resilience.

We live in a moment when society feels stretched to the breaking point—fractured by politics, fear, tribalism, and apathy. But imagine what could change if even a small number of people began living as though every human life truly mattered.

What would happen if we treated every person—friend, stranger, even enemy—as someone bearing the image of God, worthy of dignity, patience, and care?

That shift, even in a handful of lives, could begin to heal what feels irreparably broken. It could soften hardened spaces in our culture and ignite a quiet revolution of love in a world starving for it.

What if we stopped asking, "What do they deserve?"

And started asking, "How can I love them the way Christ loved me?" "How can I love my enemies the way Christ loved His?"

What would follow would not be a revival of louder hymns or grander religious events, but of life itself—flowing back into forgotten neighborhoods, wounded families, and neglected souls. That's what true revival looks like.

Jesus did not gather kings or elites around Him. He chose poor Galileans, the overlooked, the wounded—people broken enough to know they needed transformation.

That was the spirit. That was the force. That was the gospel before it became a Western institution—when it was lived openly, breathed daily, and practiced publicly by ordinary Jewish people and gentiles who joined them, transformed by an extraordinary Love.

> *All the believers were together and had everything in common. They sold property and possessions to give to anyone who had need. Every day they continued to meet together in the temple courts. They broke bread in their homes and ate together with glad and sincere hearts, praising God and enjoying the favor of all the people. And the Lord added to their number daily those who were being saved.*
>
> (Acts 2:42-27)

The Gospel has never changed, but the way *we* understand and practice it has. We just need to reconstruct and reclaim the ancient Spirit behind it.

Don't Just Preach It. Live It.

In the end, the question is painfully simple: Can you truly claim to follow Jesus if you walk past the people He would have stopped for? He never said, "They will know you are my disciples by your perfect doctrine." He said, *"They will know you are my disciples by your **love**."* (John 13:35).

And love, real love, is never abstract. It breaks bread. It binds wounds. It gets interrupted. It gets involved. It feeds both stomachs and souls.

Before you stand on a street corner soapbox, love. Before you quote, care. Before you proselytize, empathize.

The world is not waiting for another sermon on end-times tribulation. It is starving for the kind of people who are a sermon. Not with clever words, but with consistent love. Not with megaphones, but with open hands.

Because faith—real faith—is not merely something you say or believe. It is how you love.

Conclusion

You've just discovered one of the deepest secrets of life: God designed us so that true joy is often found on the other side of sacrificial love. Lasting joy and healing don't come from personal comfort or momentary pleasure—they spring from the love and purpose of giving ourselves to others.

To love means choosing someone else before yourself, letting go of ego and ease, and pursuing something greater than your own preferences. And it's precisely there—in loving others—that we not only find divine purpose and fulfilling joy but also a place where our own wounded hearts heal the most.

In the end, it is love that gives life its deepest meaning—not by pressuring people into intellectual agreement, but by reaching into suffering and pulling people out of the hell they are living in here and now. And from that kind of meaning, real joy begins to rise—quietly, steadily, and unmistakably.

If you want to explore this vision of love more deeply, I invite you to read my book ***The Theology of Love: Christianity's Most Underrated Doctrine.*** I truly believe it has the power not just to inform your mind, but to soften and transform your heart.

Final Conclusion

The gospel no longer needs to sound like this: "God is furious with you—but if you manage to hold the correct intellectual beliefs, then and only then He will refrain from burning and tormenting you forever." That is not good news; it is fear dressed up as theology.

The gospel can finally sound like what it always was meant to be:

God loves you—before you understand, before you believe correctly, before you get anything right. You are not an object of divine rage, but the object of relentless mercy. God has already acted for you in Christ, not to

threaten you with fire, but to rescue you from death, heal what is broken, and restore you to life. You are invited —not coerced—into a way of living that leads to wholeness, joy, peace, and purpose. This is not about passing a theology exam or escaping punishment, but about becoming fully alive, learning to love, and participating in the renewal of the world.

That is the Gospel: not fear of God, but trust in Him; not terror of judgment, but hope of restoration; not survival after death, but life—real life—beginning now.

Final Conclusion in Theological Language

The earliest believers proclaimed a gospel centered not on the individual escaping to a distant heavenly realm, but on collective resurrection—bodily, earthly, tangible resurrection—because that is what they saw happened to Jesus. Christ rose here, on this earth, in a transformed yet physical body (Luke 24:39–43; John 20:27–28). His resurrection was not a symbolic event, nor a spiritual metaphor, but—as Paul insisted—*"the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep"* (1 Corinthians 15:20). Messiah was the first among many; what happened to Him will happen to *all* of us.

For the first followers of Christ, this was the core logic of salvation and the gospel they preached:

Death entered through Adam and affected us all; *resurrection* overcame it through Christ for the sake of us all (1 Corinthians 15:21–22).

Sin brought *mortality*; God's remedy is *immortality* (2 Timothy 1:10), not disembodied escape.

This is why the Bible consistently frames 'salvation' in terms of *the resurrection of the dead* (e.g., John 5:28–29; Acts 24:15), not as a postmortem relocation to some distant realm opposite hell. "Heaven"—whatever nuances the term carries—was never imagined as a galaxy far away where souls escape the earth.

The biblical hope moves in the opposite direction. The New Jerusalem comes down to earth (Revelation 21:2). God does not abandon creation; He returns to it. He makes His dwelling among humanity, here—not elsewhere (Revelation 21:3). *Salvation* is not escape from the world, but the resurrection and renewal of it.

In both Jewish and early Christian tradition, the Garden of Eden in Genesis 2–3 is understood as an earthly location—a real place where Adam and Eve lived and walked with God. The text itself places Eden *"in the east"* (Genesis 2:8), with rivers flowing out from it and through recognizable regions such as Cush and Assyria (Genesis 2:10–14). Nothing in the biblical narrative suggests a celestial, non-physical realm. Eden is grounded, earthy, geographic. In the Bible's own worldview, Eden was on earth.

In Second Temple Judaism, "heaven" (*shamayim* in Hebrew—literally "the skies") was understood primarily as God's dwelling place, not as an afterlife reward destination. The dominant Jewish hope was resurrection.

Put simply: God and the angels dwelt in heaven (the skies) above, humans lived on the earth, and the dead went down—awaiting resurrection. Salvation was never about escaping the world but about the three dimensions merging—a return to Eden—which was not "up there." It was here. And God walked with us here.

The Underworld

After humanity's exile from Eden, death enters the story (Genesis 3:19). And once death became part of the human experience, ancient people naturally imagined the dead as going downward—to the underworld—because that is precisely where bodies were laid. The Bible calls this realm *"Sheol"* or *"Hades"* (Psalm 139:8; Acts 2:27)—often translated to "hell" in English—the shadowy place beneath the earth where all the dead—righteous and wicked alike—went (Genesis 37:35; Job 7:9; Ecclesiastes 9:10).

Jacob expected to go to *Sheol* when he died (Genesis 37:35).

Job described *Sheol* as darkness and stillness, not torment (Job 10:21–22).

The Psalmist said, *"The dead… go down to silence"* (Psalm 115:17).

No flames. No Eternal Conscious Torment. Just the grave beneath us.

Heaven

Above the earth lay the realm of the heavens—*shamayim*—believed to be inhabited by celestial beings.

- the *Malachim* (angels),
- the host of heaven (1 Kings 22:19),
- the "sons of God" (Job 1:6),
- and the divine council (Psalm 82:1).

And above them all, as Israel testified, stood the Lord of lords, the Maker of heaven and earth (Deuteronomy 10:17; Psalm 115:15)—Yahweh, the Holy One of Israel.

This three-tiered worldview—heavens above, earth here, Sheol below—shaped the imagination of the biblical authors, the ancient Israelites, and the earliest followers of Jesus. Their hope was never escape from

this structure, but its healing. Salvation meant the reunion of what had been fractured—the restoration of heaven and earth back into harmony, as it was in Eden, back when God still walked the earth (Genesis 3:8).

This is precisely why Jesus ascends into heaven. His ascension is not an exit strategy from the world, but a declaration of its destiny. Heaven and earth are not meant to remain separated; they are moving toward reunion. And the way that reunion happens is not through domination, conquest, or force—but through self-giving love. In ascending, Jesus reveals that sacrificial love is the true bridge between heaven and earth, the path by which humanity is lifted and creation is restored.

The "New Jerusalem" does not float believers away to heaven; instead, heaven descends to earth (Revelation 21:2).

The movement is always the same: the dead are raised back here and God comes down here, not us escaping elsewhere. He came to Eden. He came again as Jesus. He will bring down the New Jerusalem. It's all here.

This ancient pattern—Eden on earth, the grave below, the heavens above—set the stage for the earliest Christian proclamation: That Christ rose from the dead—here on earth—and therefore we will too (1 Corinthians 15:20–23). That was the gospel: world restoration. *Tikkun Olam*.

Paul's entire argument in 1 Corinthians 15 hinges on this:

Since Christ was raised bodily, then all of us, too, will be raised bodily—not to float away, but to live renewed in God's restored creation.

The Hebrew prophets envisioned the same hope:

"Your dead shall live; their bodies shall rise" (Isaiah 26:19, see also Daniel 12:2).

Early Christians carried on this same hope—not of escape, but of resurrection.

Thus, in the first and second centuries, the Gospel sounded like this:

"The wages of sin is death" (Romans 6:23), not afterlife torment.

Death is the enemy. (1 Cor. 15:26)

We have all been dying since Adam. (1 Cor. 15:22)

But we will all be made alive because of Christ. (1 Cor. 15:22)

Heaven comes here. (Revelation 21:2)

Christ resurrected here. (Matthew 28:6)

Thus, our resurrection happens here.

Hell—at least in the later medieval sense of endless fiery torment—was not part of this picture. The earliest Christian preaching centered on life from the dead, not an escape from Eternal Conscious Torment.

The Gospel is simple:

Because Christ rose, we will rise.

Because He lives, death will die.

And the world that began in an earthly garden will be restored in a renewed creation—*"a new heaven and a new earth"* (Isaiah 65:17; Revelation 21:1).

The earliest Church Fathers echoed this earthy, concrete hope:

Ignatius of Antioch (early 2nd century) wrote that we *"shall rise again in the flesh, even as Christ has risen."* [148]

Justin Martyr insisted that the Christian hope is *"the resurrection of the body,"* rejecting the notion of purely spiritual salvation as a distortion influenced by Gnosticism. [149]

Irenaeus, representing the mainstream second-century church, taught that God intends to *"renew creation itself,"* and that resurrection means inheriting a restored earth, not fleeing it. [150]

In this worldview, the problem was death—*"the last enemy."* The solution was life—immortal, resurrected, restored, eternal life that no illness or disease could destroy.

The gospel is so simple that even children can understand it:

Christ died and rose again, and so we too will die and rise again.

And when He returns, God will restore all things (Acts 3:21).

Heaven does not whisk us away; heaven comes down (Revelation 21:2).

God does not abandon creation; He renews it (Romans 8:19–21).

Each of us will be judged and rewarded based on our past on Earth (Matthew 16:27, Romans 2:6, 2 Corinthians 5:10, Revelation 20:12).

Hellfire—as later imagined in Western medieval theology—was simply not part of the original message.

Final Conclusion in My Own Words

You are not saved because of your theological precision. You are saved because Christ saved the world you are part of. Salvation rests on what He has done, not on how accurately your brain manage to understand it.

Jesus is not owned by the Baptists.

Jesus does not belong to the Pentecostals.

Jesus is not the property of Calvinists or the Arminians.

He isn't Catholic nor Orthodox.

He does not belong to any church, any system, any theological institution.

You will not find Him behind a pulpit wearing a suit, nor teaching systematic theology at a seminary.

And yet—Jesus is near. Closer than breath.

He meets people. All kinds of people. In all kinds of places. At all hours of the day and night.

He meets the poor in spirit.

He meets those who mourn.

He meets those who hunger and thirst for righteousness.

He meets the merciful.

He meets the pure of heart.

He meets the peacemakers.

He meets the persecuted—those who suffer for the sake of justice and truth.

This is where He walks.

Not in the corridors of power, but on the dusty roads of longing hearts.

Not in religious ivory towers, but with broken people.

Not in echo chambers of doctrine, but in the silence of those who ache.

So if you wish to truly meet Jesus in the deepest way—you may have to leave your theological tribe.

You may have to unlearn your inherited system.

You may have to deconstruct man-made doctrine.

You may have to let go of the illusion that your church denomination has a monopoly on the Messiah.

Because He is not owned. He is not contained.

He is given—to the world.

And He walks freely among those who are open, humble, hurting, and hungry.

This is where the Son of Man still walks today.

And you don't have to earn Jesus or His forgiveness through intellectual knowledge or religious deeds.

You've already been forgiven.

That is not a possibility.

Not a wish.

Not a future condition.

It is a fact sealed in history.

When Jesus declared, *"It is finished"* (John 19:30), something cosmic closed forever: the effect of sin, the record of debt, the lie that God's love must be earned, the fear that we must twist His arm through rituals, guilt, or begging for forgiveness.

Christ did not go to the cross to change God's mind about you.

He went to the cross to change your mind about God.

But forgiveness of sins is not the end of the story.

It is the beginning of a new one—yours!

Now comes response.

Now comes invitation.

Not to crawl under the weight of guilt, but to rise under the lift of grace.

Not to tremble in fear, but to walk fueled by love.

True repentance is not groveling, self-flagellation, or dutiful box-checking. It is turning—toward home, toward healing, toward a truer way of being. It is choosing the road Jesus walked: the narrow path of mercy, humility, courage, and self-giving love.

Jesus came not only to forgive, but to show us how to live forgiveness.

He didn't just teach "love your enemies"—He gave His life for His enemies and prayed for their forgiveness even as they killed Him, so they too could be resurrected.

That is salvation. Not escapism, but becoming whole.

Not fleeing everlasting hellfire torment, but entering eternal, divine life.

Not earning afterlife heaven, but participating in His kingdom here and now—in the dust, the pain, the beauty of earth.

You just need to tap into *eternal life*—not endless duration, but cup overflowing.

It's about a divine quality—a life that's radiant, abundant, and deeply rooted in God's very essence.

And it begins now.

"This is eternal life: that they know You…" (John 17:3).

Not a theological exam—a relationship so transformative that love begins to take on flesh in us.

The Gospel is not an evacuation plan.

It is creation remade.

It is God putting all things right.

Yes, sin still matters.

It fractures us.

It blocks blessing.

It destroys lives and relationships.

It poisons the soul.

But forgiveness is medicine.

Healing begins when we receive it—when we let grace seep into the bones and reshape how we think, act, and live.

Grace is not passive or an abstract idea.

Grace is power. The motivation to forgive others.

Salvation awakens the heart, renews the mind, and spills outward in action.

It feeds the hungry.

Clothes the naked.

Forgives the guilty.

Welcomes the outsider.

This is the Kingdom of God—not a future address, but a present revolution of love.

And yes, choices have consequences.

Those who cling to hatred, deception, pride, and cruelty will taste the bitter fruit of those choices.

Not because God delights in punishment, but because rejecting love is its own collapse. Because sin needs to be purged from the sinner.

Sin brings death—not by divine sadism but by spiritual gravity.

Yet even judgment is medicinal at its core: not to destroy, but to restore.

Every road of suffering is a road that leads back home.

The resurrection was not just one man rising. It was the first light of a world being remade. A promise that what happened to Him will happen to humanity—to those who you loved and are gone.

So we evangelize so *"that they may have life, and have it abundantly."* (John 10:10)

Because we are not here to frighten people out of hell—we are here to awaken them to Love.

Because love must share itself.

Because we want to expand God's kingdom.

Because following Jesus means becoming a doorway through which others glimpse the Kingdom.

To follow Christ is to feed His sheep, to carry your cross, to choose love when it hurts, peace when it costs, and compassion when it's inconvenient.

It means you don't just believe the Gospel—you become it.

You become good news in human form—an ambassador.

In the end, salvation is not about passing a final exam or sneaking into heaven before the gates close.

It is about becoming fully human—fully alive—fully like Christ.

And that journey does not begin at death.

It begins now.

So come.

Step into the life of God.

Let grace be your breath.

Let love be your legacy.

Because the world does not need more doctrine, more labels, or more conflict.

It needs more Jesus.

And the only Jesus it may ever see—is the one it sees in you.

Afterword

I have a small favor to ask before you close this book (or turn off your e-reader). I've dedicated significant time and effort to creating this book (in a language not native to me). However, it has been my sad experience that Calvinists leave negative—sometimes outright malicious—reviews on my books without even bothering to read them first. Therefore, if you have found enjoyment and education in the book—and it's completely fine if we don't see eye-to-eye on every detail—please consider expressing your appreciation by sparing a few seconds to rate it on Amazon and/or Goodreads. If you also have two minutes to spare, leaving a short review

would mean the world to me! As an indie-author I make it a point to read every review. If you want to go the extra mile, then feel free to post a photo of the book and recommend it on social media, or even get copies for friends!

Thank you so much for your attention and consideration, and please don't forget to check out my other books!

Dr. Eitan Bar

P.S. If you'd like to help me spread this grace-based restorative gospel of universal reconciliation—especially among the Jewish people in Hebrew/Israel (because no one else does!)—please visit ***www.eitan.bar/give*** or feel free to get in touch.

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46. "Mount of Olives Jerusalem – the Oldest Cemetery," City of David website, accessed December 16, 2025.
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54. George MacDonald — Unspoken Sermons, Series Three (1889). Sermon title: "Justice."

55. Jonathan Edwards, SECT. II.m How fearfulness will hereafter surprise sinners in Zion.

56. John MacArthur, "Sin Didn't Kill Jesus, God Did," Crossway, 28 March 2018.

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62. Dr. Michael Heiser, Some Random Thoughts About Substitutionary Atonement, July 7, 2018. (drmsh.com)

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64. If you're curious about who wrote the Letter to the Hebrews, check out my short book, **"Unmasking Hebrews' Secret Author: And the Rabbi Who Saved Christianity."**

65. The Emphasized Bible by Joseph B. Rotherham.

66. Concordant Literal New Testament.

67. 2001 Translation – An American English Bible.

68. E.W. Bullinger's Lexicon.

69. Historians estimate that between 11–15 million people died in the major Catholic-Protestant conflicts of early modern Europe, including the French Wars of Religion (1562–1598), the Eighty Years' War (1568–1648), the Thirty Years' War (1618–1648), and the English Civil Wars (1642–1651). See Mark Greengrass, The French Wars of Religion, 1562–1629 (London: Routledge, 1996); Geoffrey Parker, Global Crisis: War, Climate Change and Catastrophe in the Seventeenth Century (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2013); and Peter H. Wilson, The Thirty Years War: Europe's Tragedy (London: Allen Lane, 2009).

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145. In Israel, the Messianic movement I was part of for twenty years is widely regarded by the general Israeli public as a dangerous cult—not because of its faith in Jesus, but because of what goes on behind the scenes. Some of it becomes public, much of it doesn't: cases of murder, sexual abuse by elders and ministry leaders, financial exploitation, and patterns of manipulation and control. These realities are largely hidden from international supporters, who only see the polished surface (websites, YouTube videos, newsletters, etc.). But that is a topic for another book.

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